

AN ADULT EPIC FANTASY NOVEL

THE FEAST OF A HUNDRED FIRES

No hidden seat. No borrowed wound.



T. K. ARVEN

The Feast of a Hundred Fires

An original adult fantasy novel

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Part I

Chapter 1 — The Refugee Kitchen

Savra cut the burned skin from an onion while the ration line argued itself awake.

Forty-three people waited beneath the patched awning, though the slate beside the oven promised breakfast for thirty-six. The first seven had come before dawn and marked their places with sandals, baskets, or sleeping children. Those arriving later disputed the custom. Rain from the night storm had found every tear in the canvas. It dripped into bowls, flattened charcoal dust on the paving stones, and made the younger children press close to the oven wall for warmth.

"Thin it again," Dima Orr said from the kneading board.

Savra looked into the copper pot. Chickpeas had cooked down to a velvet thick enough to carry oil. Another pitcher of water would turn breakfast into an apology.

"Seven more mouths," Dima added. "Unless you've learned to feed sandals."

"Sandals complain less." Savra poured the water.

She worked under the name Veyra in the refugee kitchen, slept above the old spice store with three widows and a roof rat, and accepted no task involving seals. The arrangement had held for eleven months. Dima knew she could judge grain by touch and sharpen a warped knife so it cut straight. He did not ask how a woman with a field cook's scar on her left forearm had learned either skill. Kelar received people who had survived questions; good manners required no repetition.

At the back hearth, a boy fed broken packing slats between bricks. Their own ember jar had gone dark during the rain. Someone from the night shift had borrowed coals from the market ovens, and the flames burned with an uneven blue tongue Savra disliked. She crouched, caught the boy's wrist before he added a painted board, and smelled the smoke.

"Where did these coals come from?"

"Bread row. Or the soldiers' cookcart." He pulled against her grip. "Hessa gave me the scoop."

"Hessa has three opinions before sunrise and none after."

The boy grinned. His name was Piri, ten years old if the ration register told the truth, with close-cropped hair and a gap where his left canine should have been. Savra let him go and separated the blue-burning coal with her tongs. Rain had washed most ash signatures to mud, yet one ember carried a lacquered sheen. Oil, perhaps. Military kitchens used pressed sesame waste to keep cart fires alive.

A bell sounded beyond the eastern roofs.

Not a temple bell. The note came low and blunt, struck from iron rather than bronze. One peal, then two close together. Army meal signal. Kelar's occupying

garrison kept its barracks uphill, far enough away that a cook in the market ought to hear only the largest watches.

Savra lifted her knife and scored three lines into the chickpea cakes. No seal, no binding, only a baker's habit to help them break evenly. She made herself breathe.

Dima ladled bitter fenugreek into the pot. The broth took on its morning sharpness, medicinal at first, then warmer as smoked onion oil spread across the surface. Savra tasted from the wooden spoon. Fenugreek, onion, old chickpeas, iron from the pot. Beneath those sat a faint clean numbness, like salt held too long against a cut.

"Stop service," she said.

Dima had already filled four bowls. "On what grounds?"

"Bad ember."

"Bad how?"

Savra searched for an answer that belonged to Veyra. Wet fuel. Paint smoke. Spoiled oil. None explained the numbness gathering at the back of her tongue.

Piri took a cake from the cooling cloth.

The second bell struck.

His right hand snapped backward.

No one touched him. The wrist bent with a dry sound, fingers driven toward his forearm as if a horse had stepped on the palm. Piri stared at the wrong angle. For one suspended breath he made no noise. Then the scream tore through the awning.

Dima crossed the kitchen before the wooden spoon hit the ground. He caught the boy by the elbow, supported the hand, and shouted for splints. Two people in line lurched at once. An old man clutched his ribs. A nursing mother dropped to one knee with blood starting from her nose. Near the awning post, a girl named Seli cried that something had gone through her thigh, though her skirt showed no tear.

Savra swept the four filled bowls from the serving ledge. Pottery broke on the stones. Hot broth ran around bare feet and sent the line scattering.

"No one eats," she said. "Spit out what's in your mouth."

A bearded cooper grabbed her shoulder. "My daughters waited since dark."

"Then let them wait alive."

He heard the certainty and released her.

Dima set Piri's wrist between slats while the boy bit on folded leather. "There's no impact wound. No fall."

"There was an impact," Savra said. "It happened elsewhere."

His hands paused for less than a heartbeat. The kitchen noise filled the gap:

children crying, a pot lid rattling under someone's heel, rainwater ticking from canvas. Dima tied the splint tighter.

Another meal bell rolled over the roofs.

Pain entered Savra beneath the collarbone, narrow and hot. A spear point, she thought, driven through leather at a rising angle. Her body carried no puncture. Breath still came. Across the yard, three diners folded around the same invisible thrust.

Wounds without battle. She had heard villagers use that phrase years ago, before officials replaced their testimony with clean numbers. A person woke with an archer's shoulder after no bow work. A child limped on a cavalry fracture. A woman bled into her lungs while the nearest fighting lay four days away. Hall clerks called the reports ration hysteria. Savra had helped prepare the tables those clerks defended.

She seized the back-hearth shovel. "Dima, get everyone beyond the awning. Those who swallowed broth go first. Keep them together."

"What are you doing?"

"Finding the seat list."

His stare sharpened. Veyra should not have known that term.

Savra overturned the ember basket onto wet flagstones. Ordinary charcoal hissed and went black. Three live coals held their color. She separated them with the shovel and saw pale ash clinging underneath in deliberate crescents. Not a complete seal. Someone had scraped an imperial hearthstamp against the cookcart grate, then emptied waste coals into a common market bin. Rain joined signatures that dry handling would have kept apart.

No binding should have survived such neglect. Yet the chickpea flour came from imperial ration sacks, donated after the west granary inspection. Grain oath and ember signature had found each other. Food remembered no intent. It carried only preparation.

Savra dragged the copper pot off its stones. Heat blistered her palms through the cloth. The linked diners groaned when the broth sloshed, their pain rising with the disturbed oil.

"Leave it still," she ordered herself.

The words brought back a tiled testing room in Namarra, Rován's hand steady above a silver spoon, his voice patient: agitation changes distribution before it changes flavor. She forced the memory shut.

Dima moved the line into the rain. Fourteen people had eaten, perhaps sixteen if children had shared cakes. Piri had swallowed half a mouthful. The broken wrist belonged to some cavalryman receiving treatment while his portion traveled outward. A spear wound had dispersed among at least four adults. Smaller burdens showed themselves now: saddle chafing across a widow's thighs, exhaustion in a

mason's back, the bitten tongue of a rider thrown hard against his teeth.

Someone had weighted the military seats light and every concealed civilian seat heavy. The kitchen had not joined by chance alone. Chance had supplied contact. Design had supplied the bias.

Savra took a clean cup, skimmed broth from beneath the oil, and added vinegar from Dima's medicine shelf. Sourness accelerated a bond. If she tasted now, the table would pull her into its active structure quickly enough to read the weighting through her own body. It might also hand her a soldier's dying.

Dima saw the cup. "No."

"Can you tell me how many are bound?"

"No."

"Then hold Piri's arm."

"You know what this is."

"I know enough to stop it."

His mouth tightened. Dima had the heavy forearms of a flour porter and the precise fingers of someone who had stitched too many wounds with poor light. He could have knocked the cup away. Instead he returned to Piri and braced the splint.

Savra drank.

The vinegar struck first. Bitter seed followed, harsher than it should have tasted. Then bodies opened around her, not minds or memories, only a field of exertion. Horse muscles labored in borrowed rhythm. A rider's left knee burned. Someone shivered under blood loss while three distant bodies took the warmth away. The kitchen diners appeared as deep wells into which every burden ran. Their shares did not carry names in language, but position had its own grammar: near seats, declared seats, reserve seats hidden beneath the salt stroke.

One place in the structure pulled harder than all the others. Piri.

Children weighed efficiently because officials counted small bodies as fractions while recipes could invert the fraction. The boy's grain-oath mark had likely entered the register when soldiers issued his family displacement flour. His half mouthful now carried more of the cavalry table than a full-grown rider's bowl.

Savra gripped the ledge as another force drove through her left thigh. Her leg remained whole. Pain insisted otherwise.

"Blacken the broth," she said.

Dima looked up from Piri. "With what?"

"Soot. Ash. Anything that makes it inedible. We have to stop anyone taking another bite."

A woman poured stove ash into the pot. Another emptied a bucket of wash water over the chickpea cakes. The acts offended every hungry person watching.

Their anger had shape and justice. Savra accepted it because spoiled food could be replaced and a shattered child could not.

Severance offered three routes. Break the seal, kill the origin ember, or wait for digestion. Waiting meant hours. The seal remained elsewhere, perhaps on a field-kitchen cauldron. That left fire.

She studied the three stubborn coals. Extinguishing local embers might cut only Kelar's accidental branch. If the military origin still burned, recoil would strike the remaining civilian seats. She needed to weaken the local share before breaking it.

"Bring salt," Savra told Dima. "Not market gray. White preserving salt."

"We have half a jar."

"All of it."

He fetched the jar without asking why. That obedience frightened her more than suspicion.

Savra drew a circle on the wet stones around the live coals, then divided it with four straight salt lines. She could not create open seats or remove hidden names. Those refinements required a complete seal. She could, however, obstruct the accidental branch and spread its recoil through the food already ruined. Broth, ash, cakes, spilled oil: all had touched the ember. Matter could carry a share until cooling ended it.

The riders' pain surged again. Piri's splinted hand jerked. Savra tasted blood where she had bitten her cheek.

"On my word, pour the pot over the fire."

Dima lifted one handle. The cooper took the other. Savra placed herself inside the salt circle. A cook who severed from outside could mistake escape for success. If the recoil needed flesh, hers should answer before the diners' did.

She cut the first salt line with her knife.

Heat crowded under her skin. The second line gave her the cavalryman's crushed wrist, not as damage but as an instruction every nerve believed. Her knife fell from fingers that no longer trusted themselves. At the third, fourteen heart rhythms stumbled into rough accord. The last line remained between the kitchen and the origin fire.

"Now."

Dima and the cooper tipped the pot.

Ash-thick broth smothered the coals. Steam burst upward. Savra broke the final line with her heel.

Recoil struck her spine and threw her onto both knees. Around the awning, bound diners cried out once. Piri fainted. For a terrible moment Savra felt the whole cavalry table searching for somewhere to set its weight. Then the wet ash took the heat, the scattered cakes took a pulse of bitterness, and the connection

collapsed as the last lacquered ember went dark.

Rain returned to being rain.

Dima checked Piri first. The wrist remained broken. Severance could not undo an injury already transferred; nothing in a hearth returned what it had consumed. Yet no new bruises rose on the boy's arms. The mother's nosebleed slowed. The old man drew a shallow breath without the spear pain tightening it.

Savra stayed kneeling until her own nerves released the borrowed crush. Her palms had blistered for real where the pot cloth failed. She wrapped them in a strip torn from her apron.

Beyond the awning, iron-shod boots entered the market.

Soldiers lowered smoke shutters across both ends of the lane. Their officer read from a wax tablet while pairs of infantry inspected ovens, ember jars, and ration sacks. Someone had noticed the broken branch. A field tablewright would feel the sudden recoil even if no clerk knew where it had gone.

Market people understood a closure more quickly than any proclamation. Spice sellers pulled reed mats over their fenugreek, cumin, and dried lime. Bakers buried live coals beneath cold ash, though hidden heat left a wavering stain above each brazier. A butcher tipped blood from his gutter and turned his block facedown. These acts did not make the lane innocent. They made every stall equally difficult to accuse.

Savra counted six soldiers at the east shutter and four at the canal end. Two more moved door to door with long-handled ember spoons. The spoons carried white clay cups at their tips so inspectors could lift a coal without joining its signature to their own equipment. Proper field practice. The officer had not brought clerks or healers, only men trained to preserve evidence and close exits. Whoever commanded the cavalry kitchen valued the broken bond more than the people it had injured.

"Wash the ladle," Savra said to the woman nearest her. "Use sand first, then water. Put every ration sack on the north wall with the oath marks facing inward."

The woman obeyed until Dima said, "No. Marks outward."

Savra looked at him.

"If we hide them, they search longer," he said. "If they see donated flour, they blame their own storehouse before us."

He had read the danger correctly without knowing the craft. Savra turned the sacks herself. Black registry strokes crossed the coarse cloth: WEST KELAR RELIEF, third measure, issued under the Hall's winter oath. The flour had entered the kitchen as charity after inspectors seized better grain for the garrison. Every cake served this morning had therefore carried an imperial claim inside it.

That realization hurt differently from the borrowed spear. The empire had not needed a tablewright in every alley. It needed grain made official once, embers

allowed to travel, and hunger strong enough to prevent questions about the source. A refugee kitchen assembled those pieces every dawn.

At the neighboring bakery, a soldier plunged his spoon into a banked fire. The baker objected. An infantryman pinned him against the oven with one arm while the inspector held the recovered coal to a tablet striped in wax. Nothing answered. They dropped it into a lidded jar and moved on.

Savra rubbed ash into the wet stones around their own dead hearth. The broken salt lines still showed pale against the flagging. She smeared them with her heel, then mixed spilled chickpea mash through the marks until they resembled clumsy cleaning. Her blistered palms protested each time she leaned on the shovel. Real injuries had evidentiary value. If questioned, she had burned herself saving breakfast from an overturned pot.

Piri woke on the door litter. "Did the horse get away?"

"No horse here," his sister said.

"I felt it fall."

Savra met Dima's eyes. The boy had received exertion and injury, not a rider's memory. A falling body could teach the nerves a shape that the mind later supplied with the nearest explanation. She needed Dima to keep that distinction clear if soldiers asked. Claims of visions would help officials dismiss everything as panic.

"Tell him what happened to his wrist," Savra said quietly. "No more and no less."

Dima checked the splint again. "And what did happen?"

"A burden reached him through breakfast. It came from a fighting table. That is all we can prove."

"Can we prove even that?"

Savra felt the hidden seal press against her palm bandage. "We can if I keep what came out of the ash."

Dima helped Piri onto a door used as a litter. "They'll search this kitchen."

"They'll search every fire that borrowed market coal."

"You sound certain again."

Savra picked up her fallen knife. The asymmetrical edge had chipped against stone. Eleven months of hiding had depended on no one recognizing how she held it.

"Take the injured through the dye stalls," she said. "The south lane has no oven smoke. Tell the inspectors breakfast burned."

A girl crouched beside the dead coals and pointed. "There's copper."

Savra moved the ash with her shovel. Beneath the slurry lay an oval ceramic tag no longer than her thumb, its glazed face stamped around a copper eye. The

market coals had carried it from the military cart. Ordinary hearthseals named authorized companies with radial marks. This seal carried those marks in the outer ring, but the inner clay held dozens of pinpricks, each impressed after firing with a civilian ration punch.

Some matched Kelar district signs. Savra recognized the hooked well of the west refugees, the split roof of the burned dyers' quarter, and the small open square used for unregistered children.

The seal had not merely found civilians. Someone had prepared places for them.

Dima watched her turn it over. "Can you read that?"

"Enough."

"Enough to run?"

Boots struck the lane gate. The officer demanded entry to the refugee kitchen.

Savra thought of her upstairs bundle: one spare shift, whetstone, two silver measures she had never spent, and a road token under the floorboard. She could cross the canal before soldiers finished the ovens. By sunset she might become another cook under another shortened name.

Piri whimpered on the litter. His sister held the unbroken hand. Behind them stood people who had lost breakfast, trust, and pieces of a battle they had never seen.

Savra slipped the hearthseal beneath the bandage at her blistered palm.

"Dima, open the gate," she said. "I'm staying with the pot."

Chapter 2 — Wounds Without Battles

The rear axle split nine miles short of Kelar, under three hundredweight of grain they had no spare wagon to carry.

Teren Avo heard the crack through the rain and felt the cart settle before the driver called out. He raised one fist. Four wagons stopped along the canal road, mules tossing their heads as harness chains slackened. The escort behind them vanished into roadside tamarisk and watched the western rise. Imperial requisition riders had crossed that rise before noon yesterday. If the road remained dry, riders could cover the distance in half the time a grain convoy needed.

“Unload eight sacks,” Teren said. “Not the barley. Rice first.”

Noro, the axlewright, crawled beneath the tilted bed and swore. “Unload twelve if you want the wheel square.”

“Eight gives you a handspan.”

“Twelve gives me fingers afterward.”

“Ten.”

The bargain cost one breath. Teren assigned six carriers, two to each side and two at the tail, so no one wasted strength pulling against another person. Free Granary marks had been painted over the wagon boards with river mud, but wet weather exposed the blue sheaf beneath. From fifty paces the convoy looked like another merchant train caught by an ambitious load. Up close it announced grain withheld from the empire.

Teren carried the first sack himself. Red canal rice shifted against his shoulder. His old left ankle held until he stepped off the paving, then sent a familiar blunt warning through his calf. The joint had been crushed between barges eleven years earlier. It tolerated roads, ladders, and most weather. It objected to mud with arithmetic precision.

“Captain,” a lookout called from the tamarisk. “One runner east.”

“Uniform?”

“No. Barefoot.”

The runner reached them bent nearly double, a girl of perhaps fifteen with mud to her knees and one hand clamped beneath her opposite arm. She wore a reedworker’s short coat. No weapon, no village badge, no shoes. Teren took her weight before she hit the road.

“Water,” he said.

She drank twice and pushed the cup away. “Ruva needs a healer.”

“We have bandage linen.” Free Granary convoys carried no healer on runs this close to occupied towns. “What happened?”

"Spears."

The escorts stirred in cover.

Teren looked east. The canal road ran straight for more than a mile, empty except for two goat carts and a man dredging weed from an irrigation cut. "How many soldiers?"

"None."

"Who used the spears?"

"Nobody. That's why you have to come."

Noro struck out the broken axle pin. "Riders won't care why we stopped."

Teren measured what delay could buy and what it could cost. Ten sacks lay on oiled cloth. An axle scarf needed half an hour if the split remained clean, longer if the iron collar had warped. Ruva sat less than a mile north of the canal, according to the marker stones. A detour there and back would add another hour. Imperial riders, if already moving, could close nine miles in less.

The girl showed him her hidden hand. Purple swelling crossed the palm below the thumb. The skin held no cut, but two parallel grooves pressed deep into the flesh as if reins had burned through it.

"Do you ride?" Teren asked.

"We own one ox. He doesn't use reins."

"Did you eat this morning?"

Her face tightened with impatience. "Millet porridge. Half the village did. Then Nima took a spear under his ribs while he sat by the oven. Come see."

Teren turned to his second, Haro Sen. "You own the repair. If riders appear, send two wagons toward the canal ferry and hide the grain from this one in the drainage culvert. I'll take four people."

"You'll take six," Haro said. "That ankle makes you worth half on wet ground."

"Six, then."

Ruva held forty-three houses around a communal oven and two reed sheds. No blood marked the central yard, though eight people lay on doors beneath an eave. Teren checked every lane before he accepted the emptiness. Cooking smoke, tethered animals, children peering from roofs. No broken gate. No hoof marks newer than the rain. No place for an armed party to hide.

A gray-haired potter named Nima breathed in shallow measures. He had lifted his shirt to reveal unbroken skin above his right hip. Each inhalation stopped at the same point.

"Feels like iron went in here," he said. "Came out my back. My wife put a mirror there. Nothing."

Teren knelt without flexing the bad ankle. "When?"

“First sun.”

“How long after breakfast?”

“Not long. We ate when the canal watch struck.”

Nearby, a woman’s left shoulder had swollen around no visible injury. Another villager could not put weight on his right knee. Three children slept with the heavy stillness of people who had marched all night. Their pulses ran steady. Their feet carried no blisters.

Teren asked the same questions in the same order: food, time, work, visitors, soldiers, shared water, new grain. Answers meant little until arranged. The village had eaten red millet from an imperial relief sack issued five days earlier. Their oven had burned local tamarisk. No one had used an official feastwright’s seal. Pain began after the canal watch sounded two long notes and a short one.

The runner, Eda, followed him from patient to patient. “Can your grain fix them?”

“Food fixes hunger. This needs a cause.”

“You’re Free Granary.” She said the name as children said floodwall, a thing built to keep consequences outside.

Teren did not correct her. He ordered two sacks of rice left at Ruva because injured people could not grind millet, and rice could boil with less labor. He assigned one escort to record names, symptoms, handedness, and precise times on the back of a toll invoice. If imperial riders found it, they would see arithmetic and no accusation.

A bell carried faintly from the south.

Two notes, a pause, then one.

Nima arched against the door. Eda’s rein burns reddened. Teren felt a sudden pressure around his chest, not pain exactly, but the exhaustion of a body pulling air at the end of a charge. His own breath answered before he could refuse it.

Every patient had eaten. So had Teren, though his breakfast came from convoy flatbread baked yesterday at Penrill storehouse. The pressure eased within seconds.

“Did anyone hear that earlier?” he asked.

Nima’s wife nodded. “Same ringing before the hurts.”

The canal watch used a wooden clapper. Those iron notes came from farther away.

Teren returned to the road at a pace his ankle disliked. Noro had fitted a green elm scarf around the broken axle and bound it with the old iron collar. The repair would hold to Kelar if they moved six sacks forward and kept the rear wagon off ruts. Haro had bad news waiting.

“Smoke west. Two miles, perhaps three. Mounted.”

“How many?”

“Road dust says twelve to twenty.”

Teren pointed to the ten unloaded sacks. “Two stay at Ruva. Put four each on the front wagons. What’s the next village east?”

Noro looked at him as though he had proposed reversing the canal. “Kelar lies south.”

“I asked for the next village.”

“Daret Ford. Mile and a half beyond the sluice.”

They moved before the repaired axle cooled. Teren put the slow wagon second so a fresh axle failure would not trap the whole train. Four escorts remained in roadside cover to show false tracks toward the ferry. Two rode empty mules ahead, not fast enough to advertise fear. The convoy left twelve minutes after the first hammer blow.

At the sluice, Daret Ford’s meal yard looked like a skirmish after everyone had removed the weapons. A miller rolled on packed earth holding his thigh. Two women braced a clothworker whose jaw had dislocated. Children carried water to adults who seemed too tired to stand. On the road verge, an old draft ox cropped grass without concern.

Teren did not stop the wagons. He walked beside them while Haro gathered answers from the mill keeper. Imperial barley had entered Daret seven days ago. Local hearth, common breakfast, symptoms at first sun. Two-one bell sequence heard across the fields. No soldiers sighted in nineteen days.

“Second place,” Haro said.

“Third report,” Teren corrected. “Eda’s hand counts apart from Ruva’s yard.”

“Three people don’t make a village.”

“No, but a rein injury in a reed settlement makes a route.”

He left another sack. The choice reduced their reserve below the amount required to bribe Kelar’s south-gate weighers. Haro marked the loss in charcoal on the wagon rail and did not argue. Free Granary rules gave a captain authority over emergency distribution. They did not make replacement grain appear.

Beyond Daret, the road divided. The paved branch bent south toward Kelar. A towpath continued east to Iskar Fen, where thirty households harvested lotus root and sent nothing to the garrison except canal tax. Teren saw people gathered at the fen oven and ordered the convoy onto the towpath.

Noro spat into the water. “That scarf lasts to Kelar, not through every hungry hamlet in the basin.”

“We’re checking one.”

“We checked two.”

“We found two.”

Iskar Fen supplied the pattern its missing quantity. Three unwounded villages had eaten from different sacks, cooked different grains, and burned local fuel. Ruva used red millet, Daret barley mash, Iskar rice crust softened with goat milk. Each village had received imperial grain under the same district oath. Each reported injuries after identical distant bells. No road connected them in an order cavalry could have ridden before breakfast.

At Iskar, six lotus cutters carried the ache of saddle work in their hips. One man had a shallow cut appear across his brow while he repaired a net, though no blade touched him. A pregnant woman suffered repeated cramps timed with the bells. Teren made her the first recipient of the clean rice they carried, then stopped himself before promising it would help.

Food could carry the problem. More food did not necessarily carry a cure.

He asked to see the ration seals. The village head brought broken ceramic tags from three sacks, kept because official collectors sometimes demanded proof of lawful use. Teren laid them on a fish-drying rack beside a tag from Ruva and Haro's charcoal rubbing from Daret.

Outer symbols differed by grain measure and issuing clerk. The inner hook repeated on all three: a narrow bend crossed by two dots. Teren had seen similar marks on military requisition inventories, though never inside a civilian issue ring.

"What does it say?" the village head asked.

"I don't know."

"Then why are you looking at it like a confession?"

"Because someone took the trouble to put it there."

Teren wrapped one Iskar fragment in cloth. He had handled manifests, toll exemptions, false guild stamps, canal-duty waivers, and enough forged measures to know when a mark exceeded its stated work. Reading hearthseal notation required a feastwright. Most served the Hall of Measures. One did not.

Years ago, before the Free Granary had a name, a deserter from the imperial kitchens had sent river towns a warning about flour oaths. Savra Kel's letter contained no apology and no request for shelter, only seven ways to prevent requisition grain from retaining a military signature. Teren had copied those instructions by hand. He had never met her. Three separate informants placed her in the western basin under different names; the most recent pointed to Kelar.

A rider arrived from the paved road. Haro's rear scout slid from the mule before it stopped.

"Imperials found the false ferry track. They're turning east."

"Number?"

"Fourteen. One officer."

Teren looked at the towpath. Water on one side, reed beds on the other, no room for wagons to turn. The nearest bridge stood behind the riders. Ahead, Iskar's

grain sheds had raised stone floors and doors too narrow for sacks to pass quickly.

“Cut the third wagon loose,” he said. “Put its mule teams on the others. We cache its load under the drying racks.”

Noro swore again, this time with admiration or despair.

They shifted twenty-four sacks in nine minutes. Iskar’s lotus cutters formed a line without being asked. Each person carried one sack from wagon to rack, stepped through the water beneath, and passed it upward through a loosened floor panel. The pregnant woman counted loads from a stool. Teren left six sacks visible in the abandoned wagon, enough to support the appearance of a merchant loss without giving the riders reason to dismantle the village.

His ankle failed on load seventeen. The foot folded inward. Haro caught the sack before it pulled Teren down.

“You’re done lifting.”

“Three loads remain.”

“Two remain. One’s on my shoulder.”

Teren accepted the correction because command did not alter weight. He bound his ankle over the boot and positioned the disabled wagon sideways where the towpath narrowed. When imperial riders reached it, they would have to dismount or push it into the canal.

The convoy departed through the reed beds on a fishermen’s maintenance path. Wheels sank to the hubs twice. Mud stripped the paint from one board and exposed the Free Granary sheaf fully, but no one had time to conceal it again. Behind them, men shouted at the blockade wagon.

At the second mire, Teren ordered the rice sacks moved by hand before anyone tried the wheel. Wet grain could gain a tenth of its weight through cloth, enough to turn a manageable rut into a broken hub. Iskar’s cutters laid split reeds beneath the rim while Noro levered from the axle. No one pulled until Teren counted. On four, the paired mules leaned together, six people lifted, and the wheel climbed onto the reed mat without twisting. The method cost three minutes and spared another wagon. Teren marked both facts against the margin in his head. Delay mattered. So did arriving with something left to unload.

A new series of bells sounded near midday.

This time Teren counted before pain arrived. One long peal. Two quick. A pause sufficient for serving bowls. Then three strokes.

The lotus cutters behind them cried out in scattered sequence. Haro grabbed his left arm as if a shield strap had torn the shoulder. One mule stumbled under a burst of fatigue that came from no exertion of its own; animals could occupy declared ration seats when grain oaths named a transport team, but this mule had eaten only roadside grass. The effect passed around it, not through it.

Teren took out the toll invoice covered with symptoms. He wrote bell patterns

beside every time. First sun at Ruva: two-one. Daret: same. Iskar: same. Midday: one-two-three. Those patterns matched meal calls used by field companies, not temple hours or canal watches. Breakfast sounded once for first line and twice for second. Midday separated mounted units from infantry by serving order.

The injuries followed meal bells, not roads.

That conclusion reduced a wilderness of possibilities to one dangerous route. Soldiers ate. Villagers hurt. Grain seals joined them across distance. If the garrison controlled the meal schedule, every ration line in its issue district could become a hidden part of military provisioning.

Teren folded the invoice into his document pouch beside the Iskar seal fragment.

"We're still carrying twenty-eight sacks," Haro said. "Kelar was promised forty-two."

"Leave four at the east safehouse. Send six back to these villages by fishing skiff tonight."

"That puts Kelar at eighteen."

"Twenty-four. The wagon bait held six, and the promise already lost those."

Haro gave him the look reserved for commanders who used correctness to make bad news sound manageable. Teren knew the habit and disliked it more when another person noticed.

"Twenty-four, then," Haro said. "What buys the shortfall?"

"Evidence."

"Evidence doesn't boil."

"No. It tells us why people fall before the pot does."

At the final rise, Kelar's walls appeared through rain haze. Smoke shutters darkened the market quarter. The east barracks signal tower stood above them, its iron meal bell visible beneath a tiled hood. Two companies lined the south road, stopping carts and opening ember jars.

A Free Granary contact waited in an abandoned lime kiln outside the canal gate. He had arrived with word of a morning disaster: refugees injured over breakfast, a cook who ruined the pot, inspectors searching market fires. He did not know the cook's true name. He knew she had ordered salt placed like a trained tablewright and had stayed when escape remained possible.

Teren gave him Savra Kel's old description: compact build, scar along the left forearm, forty years or more, knives sharpened unevenly.

The contact nodded at the scar. "Could be her."

"Could be anyone who worked an oven."

"You came nine miles on a broken axle for anyone?"

Teren looked back at his remaining wagons. Twenty-four sacks for a district

expecting forty-two. Fourteen riders somewhere behind them. Three villages carrying a garrison's morning injuries, with another meal due before sunset.

"Get the grain through the canal store," he told Haro. "No common ovens. Sell from sealed jars until I return."

Haro glanced toward the closed market. "And you?"

Teren tightened the binding around his left ankle and put the wrapped seal fragment in the inner pocket of his coat.

"I'm going to find the cook before the next bell."

Chapter 3 — The First Taster

Issen touched the white loaf to their lower lip and waited for the hall to become silent.

Silence never arrived all at once in the Hall of Measures. Bronze weights ceased ringing first. Petitioners along the east wall quieted next, followed by grain clerks at their stepped desks. The provincial assessors took longest because rank allowed them an extra breath of conversation. When the last whisper ended, Issen bit through the scored crust.

The loaf carried Namarra's public standard: sifted wheat, one part old grain to nine new, city-cistern water, sesame oil at the permitted minimum. Its underside held a dusting of pale ash from the civic ovens. No sourness, no mold, no narcotic seed, no unregistered hearth signature. Issen chewed twelve times and swallowed.

"Fit for the common measure," they said.

A clerk struck the approval tablet. Two hundred loaves passed from inspection tables to blue-robed distributors. Petitioners watched the bread leave by a door they could not use. The morning ceremony certified that the capital's grain met its own standard; it did not require the loaves to reach everyone present.

Issen lifted the next cup.

Their silver tasting chain hung from neck to belt in seven graduated links. Each link represented a class of danger the office had once claimed authority to reject: rot, adulteration, poison, oath defect, hearth contamination, hostile weighting, and unnamed seats. During Issen's eleven years as First Taster, officials had narrowed the last two into ceremonial questions. They might ask whether a table held hostile intent. No document defined who got to decide hostility.

The cup contained lentil broth from a barracks allotment. Cumin had scorched against the pot before the cook diluted it. Issen found iron residue at the rim and a trace of sleep-poppy too weak to violate soldiers' regulation. They approved it with a condition that the pot be sanded.

Three more samples followed. Canal rice. A salt-cured fish paste. Oil from the west presses, rancid beneath clove meant to hide it. Issen refused the oil. The presiding clerk grimaced because refusal required paperwork, but the barrels would not enter hospital kitchens that afternoon.

Small protections kept an office habitable.

The refused oil required a witness procedure. Issen poured the sample into a narrow glass tube, stoppered it with red wax, and pressed the sixth link of their chain into the seal. A junior clerk copied barrel marks while an assessor from the west presses objected that cloves naturally darkened storage oil.

"Clove darkens the color," Issen said. "It does not produce the wax taste at the back of the tongue."

"The barrels passed at the canal gate."

"Then the gate taster may join me for a comparison."

"He has other duties."

"So do the hospital patients."

The assessor withdrew his objection rather than summon a colleague whose approval would become part of the record. Issen watched the clerk add the withdrawal in smaller script. Official truth often depended less on what a mouth detected than on which person could be forced to taste beside it.

At the east wall, a petitioner raised both hands. "Taster Mar, my district received that oil yesterday."

The presiding clerk ordered silence.

Issen should have let the guard remove the speaker. The tasting office certified samples placed on its table, not shipments already distributed. Jurisdiction again. Instead they asked, "Which district?"

"Lower Potters. Four infirm jars. Same barrel stamp, west crescent with two reeds."

The junior clerk's stylus stopped. Marks on the refused sample showed one reed crossed by a press line. Similar enough for merchants to confuse, different enough for a Hall advocate to deny.

"Bring one sealed jar before sunset," Issen said. "Do not open it."

The presiding clerk leaned close. "That instruction exceeds the docket."

"Then place it on tomorrow's docket."

"Tomorrow holds military allotments."

"Rancid oil keeps."

A few petitioners laughed before remembering where they stood. The clerk colored. Issen returned the sealed tube to the evidence rack and made certain its slot number entered two ledgers. One copy could disappear. Two required coordination.

For eleven years, such maneuvers had persuaded them that the chain retained substance. They had stopped adulterated vinegar, flour cut with kiln chalk, fish paste tainted by a cracked lead glaze, and sleep-poppy added to workhouse porridge. Each refusal saved bodies that could be counted. Yet no link granted access to the grain-oath room, where clerks assigned villages to supply districts. No taster saw military seat lists. When a laborer ate lawful bread and woke carrying lawful pain, every ingredient could pass inspection.

The office protected mouths from what policy admitted food might contain.

What policy refused to name passed under a covered lid.

At the seventh tasting, doors behind the weighing dais opened. Four Hall attendants entered carrying a covered ceramic vessel between them. Their gloves

reached above the elbow. No sample card hung from the handles. Grand Provisioner Rován Dast walked behind them in an undecorated gray robe, his only badge a square of black bronze at the throat.

Provincial assessors stood. Petitioners knelt because everyone else had.

Issen remained seated. Ceremony required the First Taster to meet all food at mouth height, regardless of who sent it.

Rovan stopped beside their table. At sixty-one he had the composed face of a man who slept enough because other people were paid not to. Gray threaded his beard. Steam dampened one cuff where he had steadied the vessel himself.

"An unscheduled measure," he said.

"Then it lacks a lawful place in the public sequence."

"It has a private one."

Issen glanced at the covered vessel. Heat still moved beneath its lid. "Private food needs no public mouth."

"Today it needs yours."

He never raised his voice. That habit made refusal sound like an administrative error rather than a possibility.

The presiding clerk dismissed the hall for a recess. Petitioners protested as distributors carried away the remaining bread. Bronze doors closed on their voices. Rován's attendants turned toward a narrow stair behind the grain standards.

Issen wiped their spoon in salt, rinsed it, and fastened it to the lowest link of the chain. "I will need the seat declaration."

"You will have what the test requires," Rován said.

"That answer has no flavor, Provisioner."

"Come taste before the broth cools."

The stair descended farther than public plans acknowledged. Hall kitchens occupied the first underground level, where bakers prepared inspection loaves and clerks ate at different bells according to rank. Rován led Issen through those rooms and down another flight cut into older stone. The air grew dry. Ventilation shafts carried smoke upward without sharing the smells of cooking.

At the bottom stood a kitchen with one door, two tables, and a circular hearth sunk into the floor. White tiles reflected firelight. Copper pipes entered the wall from four directions, each terminating above a lidded ember cup. Ninety-nine cups sat around the hearth rim, small enough to fit in a closed hand. One larger brazier occupied the northern point.

Issen counted twice.

"One hundred fires," Rován said. "In representation."

"Representation by what?"

“Provincial signatures entrusted to the Hall.”

Several cups carried no live coal, only ash sealed beneath mica. Others showed pinpricks of orange. The northern brazier burned steadily under a cage of blackened bronze. Issen recognized it from civic processions as the capital’s oldest maintained ember, though they had never seen the vessel without flower garlands and a guard of children.

A cook waited beyond the salt line. She wore no Hall insignia and kept both hands visible. On the preparation table lay pale barley, rendered lamb fat, dried mint, sour plum, and a shallow horn dish filled with coarse black crystals.

Issen pointed with their clean spoon. “That salt has no registry color.”

“Not a market article,” Rován said. “A hearth instrument.”

The cook’s face did not change, but her left thumb pressed hard against her forefinger.

Issen moved close enough to inspect without crossing the floor line. Each crystal had a dull center and glassy edges. Ordinary salt fractured white. These grains held ash inside their structure, fused by heat or long contact with a concentrated ember signature.

“Black hearth-salt,” Rován said. “It lets the primary fire keep order among lesser arrangements.”

“Whose order?”

“The recipe’s.”

That answer carried enough truth to evade correction.

The attendants uncovered the vessel. Barley broth released lamb fat and mint into the room. Sour plum sharpened the steam. Nothing about the smell suggested poison. Beneath the surface, an oil spiral divided into many narrow arms. Each arm touched the bowl’s rim at a scored point.

Issen counted visible scores. There were twenty-five, each quartered by hairline cuts. One hundred places compressed into a ceremonial cup.

“Seat list,” they said.

Rován gestured toward the hearth. “The represented fires.”

“Fires do not have wrists or stomachs.”

“The populations attached to their lawful grain oaths provide the tested field.”

“How many people?”

“This measure concerns reach, not census.”

“Then you have not answered.”

Rován’s attention rested on them with what others might mistake for patience. “The office of First Taster exists because no list can name every mouth affected by provisioning. You stand for those mouths.”

"I eat before them. I do not become them."

"Today we may learn whether the distinction can be made useful."

An attendant placed a thumb-sized cup before Issen. The cook stirred the vessel once, clockwise, without scraping the bottom. She filled the cup from beneath the oil and added one black crystal with bronze pincers.

Source fire: the old capital brazier, carrying lesser signatures. Food: barley and fat, souring to accelerate. Seat declaration: provincial grain oaths treated as populations. Weighting remained unstated. Duration likely followed digestion unless the hearth went out.

"Severance?" Issen asked.

Rovan indicated a hood above the northern brazier. "The primary ember can be smothered."

"By whom?"

"The supervising tablewright."

The cook's eyes stayed lowered.

No personal route. No independent witness. No authority in Issen's hands despite the chain that said otherwise.

They could refuse. The public record would show an incomplete safety test. Rovan would select another mouth, perhaps one less practiced at distinguishing pain from damage. Refusal would protect Issen's body and leave the measure untouched.

"Record my objection," they told the attendant holding the test slate. "Seat identities withheld. Weighting withheld. Taster lacks severance."

The attendant looked to Rovan.

"Record it," he said.

The stylus scratched wax.

Issen raised the cup. Barley touched their tongue first, cooked until its husks opened. Lamb fat carried heat along the palate. Mint arrived stale. Sour plum cut through everything, and the black grain dissolved without saltiness.

They swallowed.

A hundred ember signatures unfolded across their body.

The experience contained no landscapes, voices, or thoughts. Heartbeats imposed themselves as rhythm alone: quick, slow, arrhythmic, sleeping, laboring, frightened. Thousands overlapped until Issen's own pulse disappeared inside them. Hunger entered next, not as one emptiness but as pressures of different depth. A field worker's steady deficit. A fever patient refusing food. Children whose stomachs had learned not to demand breakfast. Soldiers digesting meat while distant bodies absorbed the heaviness.

Issen gripped the table edge. Their silver chain clicked against tile.

A right wrist broke.

The force bent Issen's hand backward. Bone did not part in the hidden kitchen, but pain arrived complete, carrying the clean instant of fracture and the swelling that followed. One child somewhere in the represented field had taken an injury too large for that small body. Issen knew childhood only from the scale of the pulse and the speed at which shock scattered breath. Nothing offered a name.

They tried to speak. Breath came with someone else's exhaustion.

Across the salt line, the cook reached for the brazier hood.

Rovan raised two fingers. "Wait."

The cook froze.

Issen watched him through tears. "End it."

"Can you distinguish the reaches?"

"A child."

"Anything else?"

"End the measure."

"The distinction matters."

Pain multiplied in the left thigh, beneath the ribs, around a rider's knee. Issen could not know which bodies originated those burdens and which received them. That uncertainty formed part of the design, not a weakness in their palate.

They hooked the lowest silver link around the cup and pulled. Ceramic struck tile. Broth spilled across the inner edge of the salt line. The personal portion broke contact, but the larger vessel continued to steam. Relief came incomplete.

"Smother it," Issen said to the cook, using the command form reserved for immediate contamination.

Her eyes lifted. Issen held them. Ceremony gave the office few powers, but trained kitchen staff still recognized that one.

She dropped the hood.

The northern flame vanished. Around it, the smaller cups dimmed. Recoil moved through the broth as a shudder in the oil. Issen's stomach cramped hard enough to bend them over the table, then the field of heartbeats withdrew.

Their own pulse returned, rapid and solitary.

Rovan regarded the covered brazier. "The test ended sooner than planned."

"It ended later than ordered."

"You identified both scope and an individual injury. That exceeds our smaller trials."

"A child's wrist broke while you measured reach."

"The injury did not originate here."

“Neither did the hunger. You still served it.”

He dismissed the attendants except the recorder and cook. When the door shut, he drew a stool to Issen’s side but did not touch them.

“The basin approaches another provisioning crisis,” he said. “River storehouses refuse assessments. Salt guilds set local advantage above common measure. Armies and villages already exchange consequences through seizure, blockade, and price. They merely do so blindly.”

Issen flexed their right hand. No fracture. Nerves continued to report one.

“You propose improving the blindness?”

“I propose ending it.”

“By hiding the seats from the person who tastes.”

“By establishing that distance need not protect one province from another’s condition.”

Rovan asked the recorder for the slate. He read Issen’s objection, then added a notation in his own hand. His writing leaned neither forward nor back.

“The public certification will state that the sample showed no toxic adulteration,” he said.

“I did not certify it.”

“You found no poison.”

“I found concealed weighting and involuntary reach.”

“Those belong to policy review, not food safety.”

The familiar division settled between them. Every dangerous measure acquired a room where one office lacked jurisdiction and another lacked a tongue.

Issen unhooked the broken tasting cup from their chain. “Then invite me to the policy review.”

Rovan smiled with genuine weariness. “I am inviting you now.”

“To approve?”

“To understand. The Equinox demonstrations begin soon. A First Taster who understands the instrument can keep panic from wasting its value.”

“You want a mouth for the Hall.”

“The Hall already has many. I want one trained to tell differences.”

He stood. At the door he paused beside the nameless cook. “Prepare a second baseline tomorrow. Half souring. No peripheral military burden.”

The cook inclined her head. Issen noticed that Rovan still had not asked whether the child’s wrist remained broken.

Two attendants escorted Issen to a recovery room on the upper kitchen level. Officially, tasters rested there after strong spices. A couch, washbasin, and covered

chamber pot furnished the space. No window offered a view of time.

They sent the attendants away and vomited into the basin.

The body did not respect ceremonial distinctions. Sweat chilled Issen's back. Their right hand curled protectively though the bones remained aligned, and a pulse of saddle fatigue tightened muscles they had not used. They tested each finger against the basin rim, then pressed the wrist from both sides. Actual swelling would persist under pressure; borrowed pain shifted with attention and returned when they released it. The examination gave them facts, not relief. No ritual prescribed what to do when another person's injury remained real after the taster's sensation faded.

Barley, fat, and black residue streaked the porcelain. Their wrist pain faded as nerves surrendered the distant instruction. Hunger lingered in layers. Issen drank water carefully, one measured mouthful at a time, and counted their own pulse until it no longer matched remembered rhythms.

Ceremonial doctrine called this recovery: identify what belonged to the sample, separate it from actual bodily condition, and return to public composure. The doctrine assumed every dangerous taste had an endpoint the office controlled.

Issen rinsed the basin. One black crystal remained caught beneath the rim, smaller than a lentil grain. It had not dissolved. Perhaps it had fallen from the cup when the ceramic broke, clung to their cuff, then dropped while they washed.

They lifted it on the tip of the silver spoon.

Ash shifted inside the crystal when held toward the lamp. One side carried a minute groove from bronze pincers. Evidence of an unregistered hearth instrument, if any examiner dared name it. Also a live fragment of whatever hierarchy had held one hundred signatures beneath the capital fire.

Footsteps stopped outside the recovery door.

Issen opened the clasp at the seventh link of their tasting chain. The hollow catch traditionally held a pinch of neutral salt for cleansing the tongue. They emptied the white grains into the washbasin, placed the black hearth-salt inside, and fastened the clasp at their throat.

When the attendant entered, Issen stood with the chain in order and the basin clean.

Chapter 4 — The Cold Seats

Vinegar ate the old dye from the hearth bricks while soldiers searched the street above.

Savra kept the pan below a boil. Too much heat would send white steam through the roof vents and announce that someone had relit the abandoned dyehouse kitchen. Too little would leave the seal's glaze closed. She fed the fire with one charcoal chip at a time, each taken from Dima's medicine brazier and scrubbed of ash before it entered the grate.

Across the cellar, Piri slept with his right wrist splinted against a paddle handle. Fever had not come. Swelling had. His sister Seli sat beside him, trimming linen into strips that no one presently needed because work kept her from listening to boots.

Dima watched the stair. "Third patrol since sunrise."

"Second patrol," Savra said. "The first came twice."

"That should comfort us."

Rain had ended during the night. Kelar's market lanes now carried sound cleanly: shutters raised under inspection, jar lids breaking, officials calling registration marks. The garrison had found two kitchens with mixed military ash and arrested their owners. Neither kitchen reported injuries. That meant the field tablewright still searched for the branch that had recoiled hard enough to disturb the cavalry meal.

Savra's palms made lifting the vinegar pan difficult. Blisters crossed both hands where heat had passed through wet cloth. Dima had dressed them in honey and linen, then wrapped the right more tightly because she refused to stop using it. The imperial hearthseal lay in a shallow clay dish beside the fire. Its copper eye had turned green around the edges.

She had washed all loose ash from it without scratching the glaze. Civilian pinpricks remained visible inside the company ring. The deeper notation stayed concealed. Hall seals often carried three levels: public authorization on the face, weighting under heat-softened glaze, and a custody instruction written in metal salts visible only through sour steam.

Veyra should not know that.

Dima came down two steps. "Someone's in the drain court."

Savra covered the vinegar with a board, killed the brazier flame under a sand cup, and drew her chipped knife. Dima lifted a dye paddle in both hands. Seli woke Piri without letting him cry out.

Water moved behind the cellar wall. A rusted grate shifted inward. Muddy fingers appeared through the gap, then a broad-shouldered man forced the grate

aside and entered bent nearly double. His coat carried canal slime to the chest. He favored his left foot.

A second man remained beyond the opening with a short spear.

The first raised empty hands. "I'm looking for Savra Kel."

"No one here by that name," Dima said.

The stranger's attention passed over the room. It stopped at Savra's left forearm, where her sleeve had ridden above the old oven scar. Then he looked at her knife. Not the face. Competent.

"My name is Teren Avo," he said. "Free Granary."

"Anyone can paint a blue sheaf."

"Mine showed when rain stripped the wagon."

"Then you're a poor smuggler."

"I'm a grain captain. Smuggling happens because the empire changed the noun."

Dima lowered the paddle a finger's width. Savra did not lower the knife.

Teren drew a folded toll invoice from inside his coat. The paper had stayed dry under two layers of waxed cloth. He set it on the floor rather than approach her. Rows of names and bodily injuries covered the back, followed by times and bell patterns.

"Ruva," he said. "Daret Ford. Iskar Fen. Different local fires, different breakfasts, one imperial district oath. They hurt when the Kelar garrison eats."

He placed a wrapped ceramic fragment beside the invoice. Its inner hook matched one of the marks on Savra's complete seal.

Dima stared at it. "More children?"

"Three in Ruva. Two at Daret. Iskar kept theirs from the morning pot after we warned them."

"Why come here?" Savra asked.

"Because eleven years ago Savra Kel wrote seven precautions against military grain oaths. Yesterday a market cook used salt lines to break a fighting table. Either I found her or I found someone she taught."

Savra had sent those precautions to six river mills after she deserted. She had signed no name, but a copyist could identify a hand by its measurements. Rován had taught that too.

"What was the fourth precaution?" she asked.

"Never cool official bread above a civic ember, because fat carries both signatures through the next heating."

"The fifth?"

"Grind oath grain with an unregistered measure."

“Wrong. Reweigh it. Grinding changes texture, not claim.”

Teren accepted the correction without embarrassment. “Then the copy reached us damaged.”

“Or you remembered badly.”

“Both can be true.”

The answer irritated her because it left no loose edge to pull. She sheathed the knife.

Dima opened the cellar door for Teren’s spearman, who introduced himself as Haro Sen. Haro stayed near the drain with a hand on his weapon and concern fixed on Teren’s ankle. These men had not entered to make arrests. They had also brought no grain. Savra distrusted causes that arrived empty-handed.

“We delivered what survived the road to a canal store,” Teren said when she asked. “Twenty-four sacks.”

“Kelar expected forty-two.”

“Six stayed with villages carrying other people’s wounds. Six bought us time at Iskar. Six remain hidden for those villages.”

“You count absence cleanly.”

“If I don’t, someone else pays it unnoticed.”

Savra looked at Piri’s swollen wrist. “Someone always pays.”

She relit the brazier. Teren crouched beside the hearth but kept outside arm’s reach. Haro took the stair from Dima, freeing the healer to check the boy again. No one suggested trust. They arranged labor around danger.

Savra poured vinegar back into the pan and added a strip of blue-dyed wool from the cellar floor. Old madder or indigo would have carried mineral contaminants. This wool released an alkaline blue that made metal salts stand darker against ceramic. She set the complete hearthseal on a pierced spoon above the steam.

“What do you expect?” Teren asked.

“Writing under the glaze.”

“Why hide it there?”

“So a ration clerk sees permission, a feastwright sees weight, and a commander can deny both.”

Teren opened the toll invoice. “Which mark means village?”

“None. Villages receive positions, not names.”

The first sheen appeared along the outer ring. Savra rotated the spoon with wrapped fingers. Vinegar steam condensed on the ceramic and ran toward the copper eye. Brown lines rose beneath the glaze, faint as old scars.

Four broad strokes divided the seal into serving groups. Cavalry occupied the

upper arc, with twelve authorized squad marks distributed equally. Lower arcs contained no public symbols, only tiny sockets punched through the glaze. The hidden writing connected each socket to a civilian grain-oath hook.

Teren counted. "Thirty-six."

"Thirty-six classes, not people. Each class may hold a household register or district issue."

"Kelar's west refugees?"

Savra pointed with a wooden splint. "This hooked well."

"And the open square?"

"Children without household registration."

Seli stopped cutting linen.

Piri's seat mark had no individual name. The empire had built a category large enough to catch him.

Steam thickened. A second layer emerged near the center, written in a feastwright's narrow ratio notation. Teren leaned closer. Savra put a hand against his chest before he crossed above the pan.

"Vinegar accelerates residue. If that copper still carries a live trace, breathing over it can join you."

"You're breathing over it."

"I know where not to stand."

He shifted back. "Show me the ratio."

Twelve cavalry marks shared a single shallow stroke. Civilian sockets descended in groups toward a deep central cut. The recipe gave every soldier one part burden across the table, then divided that part through the lower seats with a multiplier that changed by body class. Workers carried standard weight. Registered dependents carried half. Unregistered children carried double because official fractioning had been inverted in the hidden layer.

Teren's jaw set. "Yesterday the villages had adults hurt too."

"The hooks can overlap. A person belongs to a household, district, and relief class. If the seal does not exclude duplicate claims, one body may occupy several positions."

"How much can they take?"

"As much as their combined weighting directs until digestion ends or their bodies fail."

"Death?"

"Does not transfer. The burden stops with the dead seat and recoils across whoever remains."

Dima came to the pan. His hands carried honey from Piri's bandage. "You knew

this could be done.”

Savra kept the seal turning.

“I knew the notation existed.”

“That wasn’t my question.”

Before she answered, the copper eye clicked.

A thread no thicker than hair uncoiled from inside the seal. It had been wrapped around a ceramic spindle beneath the metal rim. Vinegar loosened the binding resin. Savra caught the thread on her splint and drew it free without touching skin.

Copper wire held three knots of blackened salt paste. Each knot aligned with a serving bell notation.

Teren set Ruva’s symptom record beside it. “Two-one. One-two-three.”

“Breakfast companies and midday order,” Savra said.

“Active, then.”

“Active yesterday. We need a heat response to prove it remains so.”

Dima’s expression hardened. “You’ve proved enough for Piri.”

“For a witness, yes. Not for a salt guild or a town council. They’ll say this came from an old campaign seal and the injuries followed panic.”

“They said that before?”

Savra heard the question he had not asked: Who said it, and where were you?

She took a chickpea crumb from yesterday’s ruined-cake basket. Dima caught her wrist.

“No more tasting.”

“I don’t need to swallow.”

She pressed the crumb against the seal’s outer ring and held it over steam. Official flour residue answered the grain oath. One black paste knot softened. Heat traveled along the copper thread toward the military arc. The civilian sockets darkened first.

Cold seats, Hall tablewrights called them. Not because the bodies felt no heat. Because they sat away from the visible hearth, unnamed and unable to touch the fire that governed them. Their distance made them useful reservoirs. A feastwright could drain fatigue, pain, or hunger toward those positions while declared diners experienced only the relief.

Teren spread the village record beside the steaming dish and sorted injuries by the seal’s four broad serving groups. Ruva’s spear pain clustered under the mounted-company arc. Daret’s dislocated jaw aligned with a smaller notch for cart crews, likely a driver struck by a lurching pole. Iskar’s saddle aches belonged under remount handlers. The match did not identify the soldiers, but it connected categories of military work to categories of civilian receipt.

"Could the seal send pain the other direction?" he asked.

"Yes. Weighting has direction, not morality."

"Could villagers make soldiers carry this back?"

"Not through a branch they don't control. A recipe at the origin governs flow."

"Then stealing the ledger won't stop tonight's meal."

"No. It tells us which ember entries sustain it and where the signatures came from. With those, we can break source seals instead of severing one kitchen at a time."

Dima took the charcoal copy and compared Piri's open-square mark with the complete seal. "If we break the source, where does his share go?"

Savra appreciated the question because it refused the easy shape of rescue. "Across every seat still active when the break happens. If we extinguish the cavalry origin during service, burdens recoil through soldiers and concealed civilians together. Some may receive less. Others may receive a last concentrated share."

"So you wait until no one is eating."

"If the table ever empties. Campaign kitchens overlap meals and keep ration bread in soldiers' mouths between bells. A sustained bond may run for days."

Teren tapped the midday pattern. "Change of company, not an empty hour."

"Probably."

He revised a note on the invoice. No safe severance assumed. Savra watched him underline it once. Most officers treated uncertainty as a gap to cross. He treated it as a weight added to the load, though she did not yet know whether that made him safer.

Seli laid her linen strips beside the seal. "What did the soldiers lose when Piri took the wrist?"

"Pain, swelling, and some loss of function spread away from the injured rider," Savra said. "The break itself remained where force made it unless enough of the bodily consequence shifted early. Piri received a matching break because his weighting carried too much at the instant of injury."

"Then two children can break from one soldier."

"Conservation prevents unlimited copies. Several bodies can carry fractions. A badly weighted small body may still fail under its fraction."

Seli returned to Piri without accepting the distinction as comfort.

Savra explained the remaining notation without using the Hall's euphemism until Teren stopped her.

"What do you call the positions?"

She looked at the tiny punched square for unregistered children. "Cold seats."

Seli crossed the room and stood beside her brother's litter. "Say what that means where he can hear it."

Piri's eyes had opened.

Savra forced herself to face him. "Soldiers ate from a table that sent their injuries into people they did not name. Your breakfast put you in one of those hidden places. You did nothing to cause it."

"Did I break the soldier's hand?"

"No. The soldier's injury broke yours."

"Does he still hurt?"

"Less than you."

The boy considered that answer. "Then he should know."

No Hall notation accounted for knowledge.

Boots scraped the street grate overhead. Haro raised one finger. Everyone went still.

An inspector outside asked a neighbor whether smoke had risen from the dyehouse. The neighbor complained for a long time about soldiers ruining her saffron inventory. Kellar's market people had learned to weaponize detail. After a minute, the boots moved on.

Savra lowered the pan. With cooling, the hidden lines began to fade.

Teren copied them onto the margin of his invoice, starting with the hooks and ratio strokes. His hand made a soldier's block letters, poor at curves. She corrected three marks, then took the charcoal from him and completed the diagram herself.

"You write it as though you've used it," he said.

Dima closed her eyes once.

Savra could lie. The steam would cool, soldiers would leave, and Teren would carry proof to whatever council still listened. Her knowledge could remain a useful accident. Yet they planned to challenge a live military table. A hidden cook endangered everyone beside the fire.

"I trained in the Hall of Measures," she said.

Teren did not move.

"I served as an imperial feastwright. Field tables, march provisions, ration bonds. Rovon Dast supervised my work."

"How long?"

"Long enough."

"That's not a number."

"Seven years in field design. I left ten years ago."

Dima's voice came quiet. "After the villages started waking hurt?"

"Yes."

"Before or after you believed them?"

Savra looked at her bandaged palms. "After."

Silence held no forgiveness. Good.

Teren finished one notation line before setting the charcoal down. "Did you make this seal?"

"No."

"Can you identify who did?"

"Not from ratio work. Hall hands copy one another by rule."

"Can you stop the source?"

"Not with a branch seal. The field kitchen keeps an ember-ledger for every active signature. Break the entry, kill the origin ember, or alter the recipe at service."

"Where?"

"Cavalry kitchens stay behind the east barracks while quartered. If the army moves, they use the old tileworks road."

Haro descended from the stair. "Army carts started leaving the east gate at dawn. Flour carriers went with them."

Teren opened a road map drawn on the front of his toll invoice. "Tileworks road crosses the canal three miles north. One field stop before Ember Bridge."

"Too exposed for an attack," Dima said.

"We don't attack," Teren replied. "We carry flour."

Savra studied him. Mud still dried on his coat from entering through the drains. His left ankle binding had bled damp through the leather, though he had not mentioned pain once. He counted risks as if naming them prevented concealment. The habit could become another way to command, but for now it offered a surface she could test.

"Field-kitchen carriers have clay permits," she said. "Meal officers check the thumbprint under hot oil."

"I have a printer who can lift one."

"Oven crews inventory workers by hand burns."

He looked at her wrapped palms. "You have fresh ones."

"They need two carriers."

"My shoulders can pass for flour work."

Dima stepped between them. "Yesterday a child's wrist broke. Today you mean to walk into the fire that did it."

"Today we know the fire can move," Savra said. "Tomorrow its ledger may be

beyond Kelar.”

She lifted the complete seal from the cooling spoon. Once dry, the hidden notation vanished beneath glaze again. Teren wrapped both it and the Iskar fragment in separate cloths. He placed them in the inner compartment of his document pouch, under the symptom record and above the road map.

Custody spoken aloud mattered when people did not trust one another.

“Teren Avo holds the complete seal and village fragment,” Savra said. “Dima Orr and Seli witnessed the opening. I copied the weighting.”

Teren repeated the statement exactly.

Piri shifted on the litter. “Bring back the soldier’s name.”

Savra could not promise that an ember-ledger listed diners. It would list units, hearths, weights, and service times. The boy wanted a person where the seal supplied only a category.

“I’ll bring back every name it has,” she said.

Above them, the east garrison sounded the wagon bell. Axles answered from the road, one cart after another leaving Kelar.

Teren tightened his left boot. Savra banked the brazier and poured the vinegar into a dye jar so no inspector would find a fresh forensic pan.

They had until the moving kitchen lit its next meal fire.

Chapter 5 — Smoke over Kelar Market

Inspectors nailed the east smoke shutter open before noon, turning the market lane into a chimney.

Every oven had been ordered hot. Bakers burned proof fires under white-clay cups while soldiers compared the rising ash to registry tablets. Smoke gathered beneath the awnings, escaped through the forced-open shutter, and marked each active hearth for the watchtower. No cook could bank a fire without attracting a spear butt against the door.

Savra walked through Kelar Market carrying a basket of spoiled onions. Teren followed six paces behind with a flour carrier's shoulder cloth and his document pouch sewn under one arm. Haro had gone ahead to collect forged permits from a printmaker near the canal. Dima, Seli, and Piri waited in the dyehouse with thirty refugees due to move when the afternoon inspection changed shifts.

That plan lasted until Savra saw Piri's door litter beside the ration scales.

Soldiers had emptied the dyehouse while she and Teren were gone. The refugees stood in two fenced lines between the chickpea sellers and spice row. Dima knelt with her hands laced behind her head. An inspector in a yellow Hall sash arranged stacks of official flatbread on the weighing table. Beside him, a caged brazier held one clean red coal.

Teren passed Savra without looking at her. "West awning. We count first."

She kept walking.

Forty-one detainees. Twelve soldiers. Two market exits barred, canal steps watched by one archer. The Hall inspector had three assistants, one tending the ember and two pressing bread against a fresh ration seal. Refugees who accepted a loaf received a clay discharge token. None had eaten yet. Dima had delayed service by demanding a healer examine Piri's splint.

The tokens created the trap's second wall. Anyone released without one could be arrested at the smoke shutters for refusing lawful relief. Anyone carrying one had to surrender it at sunset roll, proving that official bread had entered the assigned household. The Hall did not need soldiers inside every room. It made food and passage validate each other.

A widow at the front of the second line turned her loaf over three times. She could not read oil strokes, but distrust had taught her where officials placed danger. The assistant slapped her knuckles and ordered her to hold it flat. Behind her, two small children watched the bread with the still attention of hunger. If one bit before Savra reached the fire, both might enter through a household grain oath even if only one name appeared on the register.

Dima had arranged the detainees by vulnerability while pretending not to. Piri's litter blocked the first serving point. Three elders with weak lungs stood where

smoke blew least heavily. Adults able to run occupied the fence ends. Seli had hidden a water knife beneath the litter blanket, useful for rope and almost nothing else. The healer could build an evacuation from people and furniture as readily as she organized a kitchen.

Teren shifted to the onion stall's far side. His position gave him a straight line to the first fence joint and kept soldiers from seeing his injured ankle. Haro remained absent. No forged permit could matter now unless the trapped refugees left before the ration bond formed.

The yellow sash belonged to an oath registrar, not a trained feastwright. He could join grain and ember through an existing seal but could not alter weighting. The new seal on his table showed the same cavalry arc Savra had opened in vinegar steam.

Teren stopped at a smoked-onion stall and tested one as if price mattered. "Can it bind before swallowing?" he asked without turning.

"Food takes a seat at the first swallowed bite."

"Then we move them before that."

"Break both fences, twelve soldiers close the lane. Someone eats in panic."

"What do you need?"

"The live coal."

Teren weighed the distance to the brazier. "Sixteen paces."

"Seventeen."

"Your route?"

"Through the line."

A soldier pushed Dima's shoulder. "You asked for a healer. Here."

The registrar glanced at Piri's wrist and did not touch it. "Stable splint. Feed him."

"Tell me what table," Dima said.

"District relief."

"Name the seats."

The registrar's gaze moved from Dima to the waiting line. "All lawful recipients in good standing."

Piri spoke from the litter. "Am I good standing?"

A few market sellers laughed under their breath. The registrar heard contempt and responded with procedure.

"Give the child his portion first."

An assistant lifted a flatbread.

Savra set down the onion basket.

She entered the fenced lane at its open end, joining three women from the west quarter. A guard held out his hand for her issue mark.

"Kitchen loss," she said. "Morning register burned."

"Name?"

"Veyra."

The old answer came easily. It might still save her if she left the line, let Dima refuse until soldiers used force, and reached the tileworks before anyone connected the dyehouse seal to an imperial deserter. She could warn field kitchens later. She could not repair Piri's second break.

The assistant pressed bread into the boy's left hand.

Savra stepped over the fence rail.

"Don't swallow," she said.

The registrar turned. Recognition did not reach him, only annoyance at an unregistered cook interfering with service. "Return to your place."

She took the flatbread from Piri. Its underside carried a fresh oil mark divided into four serving groups. Heat from the caged coal had softened the seal paste. The bond waited in the crumb.

"Who authorized this weighting?"

Market noise changed. Bakers understood the question even if they could not answer it. Soldiers understood only that a detainee spoke as an official might.

The registrar straightened his sash. "District tables fall under the Hall of Measures."

"I asked for the authorizing feastwright."

"State your office."

Savra could feel Teren counting positions behind her. Dima looked up from the stones. Piri's left fingers closed on nothing.

She raised the bread so everyone could see the cavalry strokes in the oil.

"Savra Kel," she said. "Former master feastwright, western field provision."

Her true name crossed the lane in a murmur. An old baker repeated it. A spice porter shouted it toward the west gate. The registrar lost color, which meant the Hall had kept her description alive.

"Arrest her," he said.

Teren threw the smoked onion into the brazier cage.

Oil and skin flared. Two soldiers turned toward the fire. Savra broke the flatbread over the registrar's seal, forcing crumbs into the wet lines before any detainee swallowed. She seized the preserving-salt jar from the weighing table and emptied it across the four arcs.

Salt alone did not erase a seat. It hardened boundaries. She needed the origin

coal separated from the bread while the seal remained unfed.

A guard caught her bandaged right hand. Fresh blisters tore beneath the linen. Savra drove her forehead into his nose, pulled free, and overturned the bread stacks into the salt. The registrar reached for the seal. Dima surged up from her knees and locked both arms around the man's waist.

"Every seat aloud," Dima shouted.

No one answered.

Teren hit the first fence with the weighing-table bench. Thin wood split at its pegged joints. Refugees pushed through the gap. Soldiers could not lower spears without striking one another in the narrow lane.

Savra tore the caged brazier from its stand. The handle burned through her bandage. She dropped it onto the salted bread and kicked the cage door open.

The live coal rolled among crumbs.

Heat woke the seal.

For one breath, every oil stroke gleamed. Savra saw civilian hooks reaching toward mouths that had not yet eaten, a prepared structure seeking bodies. She drove her chipped knife through the soft center and twisted. Ceramic fractured. The incomplete bond discharged into bread, salt, and the registrar's own hand resting on the outer ring.

He screamed and collapsed with a rider's knee pain. No civilian had swallowed. The burden had nowhere else to go.

A soldier swung a spear shaft at Savra's head. Teren caught it on the broken bench, stepped inside the reach, and shoved the man into the weighing table. His left ankle buckled. He stayed upright by holding the spear.

"West awning," he said.

Dima lifted Piri's litter with Seli at the other end. Refugees scattered into spice row as bakers dropped their shutters, trapping smoke under the forced-open roof. Market sellers slashed awning ropes. Canvas descended across the lane in broad folds, hiding bodies and tangling soldiers.

Savra snatched the coal from the ruined bread with bronze sugar tongs. It still glowed. She pushed it into the onion basket, where Teren had lined the bottom with a small clay ember cup before their approach. Ash from the ration brazier clung to its red surface. A live signature from the active field kitchen could answer permit seals and help them trace the source.

She covered the cup with onion skins, leaving two vents.

"Move."

Fenugreek dust filled the west awning after a fleeing porter struck a spice bin. Smoke caught it and turned the air bitter enough to blind. Savra followed the sound of Piri's litter rather than sight. Her torn palms left damp prints on stall

boards. Behind her, the registrar called her name again, this time as a charge.

At the lane's end, Haro cut through an awning seam with his spear knife. "Permits are gone. Printer burned them when soldiers came."

"Then we lift new ones at the field stop," Teren said.

"You're limping."

"I was limping yesterday."

They crossed roofward through a ladder stall. Dima and the refugees continued at ground level beneath closing awnings while Haro led them toward Free Granary grain carts hidden in the old pottery yard. Savra climbed because the basket could not survive a crowd. Teren followed on his right leg and used both hands to spare the left ankle.

Tiles above Kelar retained rain in their hollows. Savra moved along ridge beams, jumped one alley, then slid beneath a laundry frame as an archer climbed from the market watch. Teren kicked a water jar behind them. It broke across the tiles and took the archer's feet away without sending him over the edge.

"No killing if delay works," Teren said.

"You issue that rule while running?"

"I issue it before people improvise."

At the spice merchants' court, they descended through a saffron loft. A widow opened her trapdoor, saw Savra's face, and said, "The Hall wants you alive."

"Unkind of them."

The widow pointed toward the canal wall. "Dyers' runoff gate. Haro paid me yesterday."

Teren handed her two silver halves anyway. His accounting included debts no one had invoiced.

They reached the runoff channel while bells sounded an arrest closure behind them. Gray water rose to Savra's knees. The ember cup hissed each time the basket dipped. She held it above her head and passed beneath the wall through a tunnel crusted with mineral blue.

Outside Kelar, Free Granary carts waited in a stand of pollarded willows. Only two carried grain. The others held people beneath reed mats. Dima had already loaded Piri and the injured refugees. Haro counted heads twice, finding forty-one on the second count because an old man had hidden under a cart to avoid slowing it.

Soldiers closed the canal gate.

Teren spread his road map on a wagon board. "The field kitchen stopped last night at the east tileworks. It moves north on the old kiln road, then serves before Ember Bridge. Flour carts join here." He touched a fork six miles ahead. "We approach on foot before dawn. The refugee wagons take the canal track to the

bridge.”

Dima looked at Savra’s torn hands. “You can’t carry flour.”

“The inspectors saw burns. The field crew expects them.”

“Piri asked for names.”

“I remember.”

He did not ask her to stay. That restraint cost him.

Savra removed the ember cup from the onion basket. The coal pulsed red beneath military ash, still alive after market smoke, rooftop rain, and canal water. Teren nested the cup inside a sand-filled transport jar, leaving the lid vented and the handle wrapped against accidental contact.

They tested the vent before moving. Too little air would kill the signature before dawn; too much could ignite the packing straw or let ash touch a wagon hearth. Savra set the jar inside an empty grain measure and wedged it with three wet clay tiles. Teren assigned no one else to carry it. If one of them fell, the other would take custody and speak the transfer aloud.

By sunset, Kellar’s walls stood behind them and the old kiln road opened north through abandoned clay pits.

Savra walked beside Teren with one live stolen ember between them.

Chapter 6 — The Ledger Under the Oven

Teren carried one hundred pounds of flour into the imperial field kitchen because ninety would have looked comfortable.

The sack rested across both shoulders, balanced behind his neck so its weight traveled down the straighter leg. His left ankle had stiffened overnight. Every fifth step sent a dull line upward through the shin, but field laborers did not arrive with clean boots or sympathetic joints. He kept pace with the six hired carriers ahead of him.

Savra walked two places behind, a sixty-pound sack on her back and linen wound around both palms. She had rubbed soot into the fresh bandages to make them look older. The sand-filled transport jar hung beneath her flour cloth, warm against her ribs. Their live stolen ember had breathed all night through a hole no wider than a grain stem.

Dawn had not cleared the clay pits. Red kiln walls rose around the field encampment, broken by ramps where carts once hauled roof tile. The cavalry kitchen occupied the largest firing yard. Four canvas roofs joined around a brick oven built against the old kiln face. Cookfires showed as low orange wounds under iron grates.

Teren counted fifty-six tents, three hundred tethered horses, fourteen ration carts, and at least two infantry companies camped beyond the north rim. Ember Bridge lay another eight miles along the road. Dima's refugee wagons had taken the canal track. If both groups maintained ordinary speed, Dima would reach the bridge near sunset. The army could reach it before midday.

A sergeant at the flour gate slapped each sack and checked each carrier's hands. Legitimate crews bore old burns across thumb webbing from lifting hot bread trays. Savra's damage passed easily. Teren had rope calluses and one crescent scar from a wagon brake, insufficient for oven work.

"Permit," the sergeant said.

Their printer's papers had burned in Kelar. Teren handed over a market transfer token Haro had taken from an abandoned grain cart. It authorized six measures of chickpea flour, not two unregistered people.

"This has no hand assignment."

"Market registrar said field kitchens had lost half their carriers," Teren replied.

"Market registrar doesn't staff my yard."

Behind them, another eight sacks approached. Delay would create witnesses. Savra shifted under her load and let a little air escape the hidden transport jar. Military ash warmed the token in Teren's hand. Its oil mark darkened as the stolen signature answered.

The sergeant saw a live seal response where no response should have existed. Bureaucracy supplied the explanation he preferred.

“Late validation,” he said. “Hold it closer next time.”

He pressed Teren’s right thumb into hot sesame oil and then onto the token. Pain cleared Teren’s face of any need to pretend. The sergeant inspected the print, saw no registry match because he had no comparison tablet, and waved them through.

“One meal only,” he said. “Return tokens at second bell.”

Teren lifted the sack again. The burned thumb found every coarse thread in the cloth.

Inside, labor followed a sequence more disciplined than many infantry drills. Flour entered the west roof. Sifters removed stone and husk. Kneaders mixed dough in troughs long enough for a body to lie down in. Bakers shaped ration loaves, pressed their undersides to oiled seals, and moved them through the brick oven on flat paddles. Finished bread cooled beneath the east roof, where meal clerks stacked it by company.

No one ate in the kitchen.

Savra had warned him. A feastwright who stood outside the declared table could work without receiving its heat or fatigue. Kitchen laborers often occupied no seat either. Their burdens stayed their own.

Teren dropped his flour onto the west inventory mat. A clerk marked one hundred pounds without weighing it, proving the disguise had chosen the right excess. Underloaded carriers invited suspicion. Overloaded ones invited lazy gratitude.

“Water team,” the clerk said. “Both of you.”

They joined a line passing clay jars from a cistern cart to the kneading troughs. The work gave them reason to cross the yard and let Teren measure the oven. Old tileworks bricks enclosed a new iron throat. A cooling flue ran into the kiln wall at knee height, barred by a grate. Ash workers cleared it after each service. Beneath the oven mouth, one brick showed a thin green stain.

Copper hidden nearby.

Savra saw it too. She tipped her water jar half an inch, an agreed signal to wait.

Meal bells sounded from the north rim: one long, two quick. Infantry lined up at the east roof. Cavalry riders came later, still tightening girths and fastening armor as they collected bread. Every loaf had cooled only minutes. Oil on the undersides remained bright.

Teren watched a young spearman limp toward the serving clerk. The man’s heel carried an open blister stained through his sandal. He accepted a loaf, broke it at the company line, and swallowed while standing.

Relief changed his posture before the second bite.

His shoulder settled. Weight returned to the injured foot. The red stain remained, but the muscles around it stopped guarding. He walked away without a limp.

Elsewhere, someone received that pain.

A cavalryman arrived breathing hard from a horse drill. Two mouthfuls slowed his chest. Sweat cooled along his temples. Another soldier rubbed a swollen wrist until he ate, then flexed it against the ground as if testing a repair. Skill had not moved. Wounds had not vanished. The table redistributed heat, pain, and muscular cost so efficiently that the camp looked rested.

Teren carried another water jar. Numbers imposed themselves. Three hundred riders. Perhaps four hundred infantry. If each sent only a quarter of daily fatigue outward, the receiving villages took the labor of one hundred seventy-five people without performing it. Add injuries and repeated meals, then multiply across a campaign. A province could feed an army grain and bodies without seeing either requisition entered in a ledger.

The cooling racks showed how the table avoided empty hours. Breakfast loaves carried a straight oil stroke and remained active until the soldiers digested them. Midday rounds already waited with a hooked stroke designed to overlap that duration. At dusk, sour broth would accelerate the evening share before the first bread released its hold. The kitchen did not need one permanent meal. It laid temporary bonds across one another like roof tiles so rain never found a gap.

That method cost grain. Teren counted racks, loaf size, and company stacks. The camp issued nearly a third more food than its visible head count required. Extra bread fed bond continuity rather than muscle. Free Granary scouts had reported imperial units requisitioning beyond appetite, and Teren had assumed officers were hoarding. Some likely did. Here, waste served timing. Stale end pieces remained under seal for night pickets, ensuring their seats stayed reachable even when the soldiers did not need calories.

He marked the implication for the bridge. A cavalry unit arriving already fed could carry its bond across the crossing without a cookfire on the causeway. Destroying the kitchen cart would not free civilians until digestion or origin severance. Any defense based on stopping meal service would begin hours too late.

At the far serving table, a soldier collapsed before eating. Two cooks dragged him behind a screen. No one used a healer's call. A feastwright in a clean brown apron brought broth from a lidded pot, checked a company seal, and spooned it between the man's lips. His trembling eased.

Savra set down her empty jar. "Origin pot," she murmured as Teren passed.

"Ledger under the green brick?"

"Likely custody tube. Oven flue opens after second service."

"When?"

"Forty minutes if they keep standard heat."

Teren looked toward the north road. Three cavalry units had begun striking tents. "We have twenty."

A rider in a captain's red-edged coat entered the kitchen yard. He carried his helmet under one arm and no visible injury. Men straightened around him without fear. Captain Orel Tas, according to the quartermaster's boards Teren had studied before the occupation. Tas had refused a winter order to burn Eren Ford's mill because the canal would have flooded three loyal districts. The same officer now commanded troops who stood upright on hidden civilians' pain.

Tas spoke to the brown-aproned feastwright. "The bridge company moves first. Keep them fed through crossing."

"Next loaves leave in thirty minutes."

"Make it fifteen."

"Oven heat won't answer command."

"Then issue what's cooled and send the rest by cart."

Not a sadist. Not ignorant of logistics. He simply treated unseen harm as one more ration source because the institution made it available.

Teren passed close enough to hear Tas lower his voice.

"Kelar reported a seal broken by Savra Kel. Does this table remain secure?"

The feastwright wiped his spoon. "The branch recoiled. Origin integrity held."

"Can she trace it?"

"Not without our ledger or ember."

Tas glanced across the working yard. "Inventory both."

Teren continued walking. His burned thumb left a wet mark on the jar handle.

Savra reached the cistern cart and stumbled deliberately. Her vessel fell against the wheel, cracking at the neck. Water spread beneath stacked jars. The clerk shouted. Savra caught the wheel rim with bandaged hands, tore linen loose, and showed fresh blood.

"Useless market hire," the sergeant said.

He ordered Teren to take her to the ash station for rewrapping, which moved them behind the oven.

"Inventory is coming," Teren said once the brickwork hid their mouths.

"I heard."

"Can we open the flue hot?"

"Not without pulling fire through it."

"Could that look like a fault?"

"It could become one."

They reached the ash station. An old laborer kept salve, linen, and three long rakes beside a trench of cooling cinders. Savra held out her hands for treatment while Teren inspected the flue grate. Iron pins held it at top and bottom. The lower pin had warped from heat, leaving a gap large enough for two fingers.

"Maintenance?" Teren asked the laborer.

"After the loaves."

"Clerk sent us now."

"Clerk can crawl in himself."

Savra hissed as salve touched her torn palm. "Smoke pulled west over the last batch. Feastwright wants the draw checked before bridge loaves."

The laborer looked toward the serving roof, where officers now demanded haste. He did not want responsibility for delayed bread.

"Five minutes," he said. "If you crack a brick, I never saw you."

He loosened the upper pin and went to fetch a smaller rake.

Teren pulled the grate. Oven breath struck his face, dry enough to close the throat. The flue ran under the baking chamber for six feet before turning upward into the old kiln. Its floor held warm ash and broken tiles. No person his size should fit. That did not change the space available.

Savra retied her bandages herself. "Copper tube sits beneath the oven lip, probably accessible from the turn. Keep your coat wet."

"What keeps the ledger from burning?"

"Air gap and clay sleeve."

"What marks the sleeve?"

"Green salts at the seam."

"Alarm?"

"Removing copper may interrupt the origin coil."

"May?"

"I did not build this oven."

Teren soaked his coat in the spilled cistern water, wrapped cloth across his mouth, and entered feet first so he could retreat faster. The left ankle objected when he folded it. He put the right leg under his weight and pulled himself inward on his elbows.

Heat erased distance. After two body lengths, the yard sounds flattened into knocks and scrapes carried through brick. Ash entered his sleeves. Each breath through wet cloth tasted of old bread and metal.

At the bend, the flue narrowed. Teren rolled onto his right side. The old ankle dragged behind him, boot scraping brick. He found the green seam where Savra predicted, beneath a lip supporting the oven floor. A clay sleeve had been

mortared into the cavity. Its cap faced away from the ash flow.

He tried to turn it. Heat had fixed the cap tight.

Outside, a rake struck the grate. The laborer had returned.

Savra said something too quiet to hear. The rake withdrew.

Teren braced his burned thumb against the cap and twisted with both hands. Skin stuck to hot clay. The sleeve opened a quarter turn, then stopped against grit. He took the narrow iron tally pick from his belt, inserted it along the seam, and worked the obstruction loose one grain at a time.

A bell rang above the oven.

Not a meal call. Inventory.

Teren freed the cap.

Inside lay a cylinder of rolled copper sheets around a black iron spindle. Fine wires ran from the outer sheet through holes in the clay sleeve toward the oven. Each wire carried an ember's ash signature to a scored ledger line. Removing the cylinder would break contact, though perhaps not immediately if heat sustained the last reading.

He could copy nothing in the flue. He pulled the iron spindle free.

The wires snapped in sequence.

Pain traveled through the brick as a sound. Soldiers above stamped or cried out. Burdens that had been held away returned by fractions as the origin coil lost its recorded routes. The table did not collapse because the active seal and food remained. It shuddered.

Teren shoved the cylinder inside his wet coat.

A hand seized his boot.

The old laborer pulled. Teren kicked free with his right foot and drove himself past the bend. His left ankle caught between bricks. For one second the joint took his full weight at the wrong angle. White pain narrowed the flue.

Then Savra's arm entered, bandages black with ash. She gripped his belt and pulled while he straightened the foot. Together they dragged him out beside the ash trench.

The brown-aproned feastwright stood ten paces away.

He held the stolen transport jar with its lid open. The red coal inside answered the oven's failing signature. At his feet lay flour cloth and onion skins.

"Savra," he said.

She rose without denying it. "Who wrote the child class?"

His face changed. "You opened the Kelar seal."

"Teren," she said.

They ran.

The feastwright shouted for the gate. Teren took the copper cylinder from his coat and passed it to Savra because his hands needed balance. They crossed the kneading roof, overturning no troughs and wasting no food. Workers moved aside once they saw soldiers coming.

Captain Tas stepped into their route with a drawn sword.

"Give me the ledger," he said.

"Ask where your blisters went," Teren answered.

Tas's gaze dropped to Teren's burned thumb, then shifted to soldiers behind him who had begun limping as distribution faltered. He did not lower the blade.

Savra threw the sand jar at the yard's proof brazier.

It struck iron and burst. Sand smothered the proof flame while the stolen coal rolled beneath a ration cart. Every permit token waiting for validation went dull. Carriers surged at the gate, waving unresponsive clay and demanding their pay. For three breaths, procedure blocked soldiers more effectively than a barricade.

Teren and Savra went over the low kiln wall.

They landed in powdered red clay. Teren's left foot folded, and he rolled down the pit slope rather than fight it. Savra slid after him with the ledger held above her head. Arrows struck the clay where they had crossed.

Old drainage trenches joined the pits below. They ran bent under banks cut by generations of rain. Savra chose north whenever paths divided. Teren tracked hoof noise above. Cavalry spread along the rim but could not descend without circling to the cart ramps.

At the third culvert, they stopped long enough to open the cylinder.

Copper sheets unrolled into concentric leaves, each punched with hearth hooks, location marks, active status, and service dates. Teren counted by columns while Savra read.

"Thirty-two western basin," she said. "Twenty river. Fifteen salt uplands. Eighteen terraces. Twelve capital approaches."

"Ninety-seven hearths."

"Prepared and keyed."

Teren found three blank channels on the iron spindle. "A hundred positions."

"Three entries still absent."

Along the sheet edge ran a sequence of sun marks and harvest cuts. One date had been crosshatched in black salt lacquer.

"Equinox," Savra said.

"That's twenty-nine days."

"Timing for simultaneous service. The ledger does not state purpose."

It stated scale. Ninety-seven prepared hearths could bind districts larger than

any field army. Three empty positions waited for signatures not yet entered. Teren looked for Kelar's hook but could not distinguish it among the crowded lines without clean steam and time.

Horns sounded above the clay pits.

A cavalry messenger rode north on the bridge road. Another followed, then a full squad. Tas had chosen the route they would protect first.

Savra rerolled the copper ember-ledger around its spindle and wrapped it in her blood-stained flour cloth. "The refugees."

"Eight miles ahead if Dima kept pace." Teren calculated rider speed, wagon speed, and the bridge's single stone causeway. "The army reaches them before noon."

They climbed from the drainage trench through scrub on the north side. Behind them, the field kitchen struck alarm bells. Ahead, dust rose where cavalry units moved to seal Ember Bridge.

Teren took the ledger from Savra so she could use both injured hands on the slope. They ran toward the bridge with ninety-seven hearths knocking against his ribs.

Chapter 7 — The Ember Bridge

The first cavalry arrow landed in a sack of rice and emptied breakfast across the bridge stones.

Savra dropped behind the wagon wheel as a second arrow struck the axle above her shoulder. Red grains rolled between paving joints and bounced into the gorge. Forty paces south, imperial riders formed two lines at the road bend. Their horses still carried tileworks dust.

“Not shooting to kill yet,” Teren said beside her.

“They want the wagons.”

“They want the ledger.”

“Both fit on a wagon.”

Ember Bridge crossed a volcanic cut where the basin’s eastern canal plunged through black rock. Three basalt arches carried a road broad enough for two grain carts abreast. The bridge had taken its name from fire-colored stone beneath each parapet, not from any hearth. At the northern end, a tollhouse barred the road with an iron-bound gate. Its keeper had locked it when Captain Orel Tas’s messenger arrived, trapping six Free Granary wagons, four refugee carts, and more than eighty people along the span.

The gate could open from either side if they broke its chain. Haro’s people worked beneath arrow cover with a grain hook and hammer. The chain had links thick as a thumb.

South of the bridge, Dima’s last cart stood sideways across the approach. Refugees crouched behind flour sacks and bundles of bedding. Piri lay under the cart, splinted right wrist protected against his chest. Seli had wrapped wet cloth around the wheel hubs in case soldiers used fire.

Savra counted distances. Road bend to first wagon, forty paces. First wagon to south parapet, twelve. Full bridge length, one hundred and sixty. Northern gate, another ten. Seven cookfires burned or smoldered among the carts: three enclosed braziers, two clay stoves, Dima’s medicine fire, and a baker’s charcoal pan. Different ash-signatures. Different foods. Enough for a table if joined deliberately.

Not enough time for a good one.

Captain Tas rode forward under a small square shield. “Savra Kel. Return the Hall ledger and the civilians cross unharmed.”

Teren looked at the refugees. “He may keep that promise.”

“Until their next meal.”

“I know.”

Tas stopped beyond spear reach. His soldiers appeared rested from bound rations, though sweat darkened the horses. “The bridge gate opens when I hold

the ledger.”

“Then order your keeper to open it first,” Teren called.

“I did not close the gate.”

“Your message did.”

The distinction sounded sincere. Savra disliked him more for making it.

A Free Granary escort named Varo crawled from the northern tollhouse. “Chain pin’s fixed inside the stone. Half an hour.”

Cavalry could take the wagons in five minutes.

Teren drew the copper ledger from beneath his coat. The field-kitchen alarm had gone ahead of them. Tas’s riders knew the theft; they might not know what the sheets contained. If Teren threw the cylinder into the gorge, the empire retained source copies or memories. The coalition would lose the only evidence that could persuade distant cities.

“We hold twenty minutes,” Teren said. “Haro breaks the gate. People cross by priority.”

“With which fighters?” Dima asked.

“Fourteen escorts. Eight market volunteers with poles.”

“Against sixty riders?”

“Road holds six abreast.”

“Six rested abreast.”

Savra studied the seven fires. A bridge table could spread hauling exertion across people not pulling, share impact pain between defenders and seated volunteers, and move body heat toward anyone going into shock. It could not give a potter spear skill. It could not prevent a blade from opening flesh. It could keep fourteen trained people on their feet long enough for eighty others to pass the gate.

It could also make every diner vulnerable to her weighting.

“I can build a table,” she said.

Dima’s expression closed. “From whom?”

“Only volunteers. Names spoken. Weights shown in salt. Duration until the seventh fire dies or the food releases. Severance by extinguishing each source, with recoil risk stated before anyone eats.”

“We have minutes.”

“Then I speak quickly.”

Teren looked south. Tas had withdrawn to his lines. Field cooks unloaded a lidded pot behind the riders. “Do it.”

Dima caught Teren’s coat. “You don’t command that answer.”

The rebuke stopped him.

Savra said, "No one commands it. We ask."

They pulled the middle grain wagon crosswise, creating a preparation wall. Dima shouted for seven people responsible for the fires. An Eren Ford baker brought canal rice crusts. Two Kelar women carried chickpea cakes saved from the previous night. Haro contributed dried lentils from a scout bag. Each food had cooked or would cook above its own live ember; mixing small portions through one broth could join the signatures.

Savra refused the imperial ration grain. It carried an oath they could not read.

"Local stores only," she said. "If you cannot name who milled it, keep it out."

A man offered smoked goat fat from Tal Jes. Another produced salt fish traded through Ulsor. Savra used the fat to carry heat evenly and refused the fish because its guild salt could divide the table unpredictably. Bitter fenugreek from Dima's medicine pouch entered the broth as a diagnostic. If any weight turned biased, its flavor would sharpen first.

Arrows struck the wagon wall. Tas's soldiers had begun testing range.

Dima set a broad copper pot over the central clay stove. "Seat list."

"First, jobs," Savra said. "Defenders carry impact and muscular load. Haulers move wagons and break the gate. Seated sharers take pain, fatigue, and heat while remaining behind cover. Cooks carry ordinary share plus any imbalance we fail to place."

"How many sharers?"

"As many as choose after hearing the cost."

Dima climbed onto the wagon tongue. "Listen. This meal may make your body hurt where nothing strikes it. It may weaken you while someone else lifts. If a defender suffers a wound, you can carry part of the pain, heat, bleeding pressure, or loss of strength. The cut itself stays with the body struck, but enough transferred consequence can injure you. You may refuse now. Once you eat, the safest release comes when every fire goes out together. Breaking one early can throw its share onto the rest."

No promise softened the words.

A cooper from the morning kitchen raised her hand. "My daughters go first through the gate. I'll sit."

"Name," Dima said.

"Ressa Min."

Seli stood. "Seli Var."

Piri called from beneath the cart, "Me too."

"No," Seli said.

"I already know how."

Savra crouched so he could see her. "Your right wrist is broken and your grain oath may still answer the imperial table. A second bond could overlap it. I will not seat you when we cannot measure that risk."

His face tightened. "You said people choose."

"Choice requires a limit the cook can safely offer. I cannot offer you this one."

Dima watched her answer, neither approving nor forgiving.

Volunteers gave names. Ressa Min. Seli Var. Old Nima from Ruva, still guarding his ribs. Eda the reedworker. Noro the axlewright. Three bakers, two canal hands, a dyer, four parents, Haro, and every Free Granary escort. Teren took a defender's seat despite his ankle. Savra listed herself among cooks.

Dima put her name last. "Double pain share."

Savra looked at his hands. "No."

"You told the boy the cook sets limits. Set one I can choose inside."

"Your hands do the healing afterward."

"My hands can take more than a child's."

"Size is not protection against concentrated nerve damage."

"We need the defenders able to keep their grips."

"Ordinary share."

"Double pain. Ordinary fatigue. No extra heat."

He had specified state and boundary as a trained organizer would. Savra could refuse him. Someone else would take the portion or the defenders would carry more. Refusal could become another way for the tablewright to preserve the person she considered useful.

"Double pain, ordinary fatigue, no extra heat," she repeated. "You sit beside the medicine fire. If your fingers lose position sense, you tell me immediately."

Dima held up both hands so witnesses saw them uninjured. "Agreed."

Savra divided preserving salt into seven shallow bowls and set one at each fire. Lines ran from each bowl toward the central pot, visible on dark bridge stone. She used no hidden under-stroke. Weights appeared as notches cut in chickpea dough: one notch ordinary, two for double, a crossed notch for cooks. Defenders' cakes carried one pain notch and two exertion notches. Haulers took the reverse. Seated sharers carried one pain and one fatigue unless they chose less.

The bridge wind complicated the geometry. A gust could scatter a salt line and separate one fire before the others, causing partial recoil. Noro cut seven channels into strips of damp clay and packed the salt inside them. Each channel ended at the central pot without touching another, preserving distinct source signatures. Dima assigned one keeper per line with a water cup for extinction and a dry cloth to shield the salt, then made each keeper repeat which fire they held.

Fuel also needed equal duration. The baker's charcoal pan could outlast the

medicine brazier by an hour, while one clay stove held only enough tamarisk for twenty minutes. Savra redistributed unlit fuel beside each source without moving live coals. She measured by burn rate, not by visual size: dense charcoal to the short stove, split brush to the slow pan, olive pits reserved for the central flame. All seven needed to survive the evacuation and die on the same count. A stronger fire offered no moral advantage if it trapped the other six inside its remaining bond.

Several volunteers chose less.

A pregnant woman named Osa took a quarter fatigue share and no pain. An elder with weak lungs accepted heat only. Two market porters chose double muscular exertion but refused injury consequence. Savra adjusted dough portions rather than shame them into symmetry. A table needed usable differences, not equal portions displayed for virtue.

Dima read every seat named from the list Teren wrote on the back of a grain invoice. Each person answered aloud. Haro stood at the edge and repeated the count: forty-six seats, including five cooks, fourteen defenders, nine haulers, and eighteen sheltered sharers. The seven fire keepers spoke their hearth sources. Savra announced duration, weighting, and severance again.

Captain Tas advanced his riders ten paces.

"You are binding civilians on a battlefield," he called.

Savra tasted the broth. Fenugreek remained bitter but balanced. "I am naming them where you can hear."

"Names do not stop arrows."

"No. People do."

She served the cooks first because a cook could not stand outside the burden. Dima drank from her medicine-fire cup. Savra swallowed her portion and felt forty-five other rhythms touch the edges of her own body. No thoughts. No loyalties. Only breath, hunger, fatigue, heat, and the small pains people already carried.

Teren ate next, then defenders, haulers, and sheltered sharers. Every diner held up the marked cake before biting so neighbors could verify the weight. No one received food by mistake.

The table settled across seven cookfires.

Savra felt the bridge through bodies. Teren's left ankle burned with old damage. Dima's shoulders carried years of kneading and lifting. Ressa had a cut beneath one heel. One escort trembled from fear, a state hearthbinding could spread as bodily rhythm but never turn into courage. Savra directed no emotion. She adjusted only declared states, using salt lines and portion marks already swallowed.

"Haulers," Teren called. "Gate wagon first."

Nine people leaned into the lead grain cart. Their muscular effort spread toward

the double-exertion porters and defenders. The wagon rolled as if pushed by more hands, because more bodies performed fractions of the work from behind cover. No one gained knowledge of harness or wheel. Noro still directed where to place the lever.

Haro's hammer struck the toll chain.

Imperial cavalry charged.

Six riders entered the southern approach abreast. Free Granary escorts braced poles between parapets. They had no room for a full spear wall, but wagon shafts lashed crosswise reduced the lane. Horses refused the first barrier. Two riders forced through and met hooked grain tools rather than swords.

Impact traveled across the table.

Savra's shoulder jolted though she stood at the pot. Dima grunted beside the medicine fire. Sheltered sharers cried out in scattered sequence. The defenders kept their grips because the force no longer belonged to their arms alone.

"First cart through," Teren shouted.

The gate chain lost one link. Haro and Noro dragged it from the stone socket. Refugees pushed the iron-bound leaves outward while the grain wagon squeezed through. Its hubs scraped both posts. Beyond lay open north road and a steep track toward river country.

Seli led children after the cart in pairs. Piri crossed on his door litter carried by two haulers. He kept his right arm against his chest and stared at the fighting until Dima ordered him to look north.

A rider thrust over the wagon-shaft barrier. The spear entered an escort below the left collarbone. Flesh opened; no table could move the hole. Pain and shock spread outward. Dima took twice the ordinary portion. His knees hit stone, but his hands remained around a bandage roll.

Savra shifted heat from the wounded escort toward three volunteers who had accepted it. She moved no blood. The man still needed pressure on the wound. Dima crawled to him and packed linen around the spearhead before defenders cut the shaft.

"Fingers?" Savra called.

"Working."

A second cavalry rank dismounted and came forward on foot, using horses as moving shields. Captain Tas had adjusted rather than spend animals against the barrier. His men pushed the first wagon sideways to open the approach.

Teren saw the change. "Oil the stones."

Two cooks poured smoked-onion oil from a ration jar across the south slope. They did not light it. Fire would trap refugees and damage the bridge. Boots slipped where hooves would have found purchase. Imperial soldiers advanced more slowly, shields touching.

The second and third wagons passed the gate.

With each load, haulers tired. Their fatigue flowed into seated volunteers in declared fractions. Ressa's head bowed. Nima vomited over the parapet, then drank water without leaving his marked place. Osa carried only a quarter share and remained steady enough to count children crossing.

Savra moved among the fires, tasting one spoon from each. Different foods revealed different stresses. Rice crust softened when exertion weighting rose. Lentils thickened as heat accumulated. Fenugreek sharpened near Dima's double pain line.

She added no new ingredients. Changing the recipe mid-service without re-declaring could conceal a weight. Instead she redistributed by moving the existing salt bowls where everyone could see, one finger width at a time, and called each adjustment aloud.

"North fire, pain reduced one quarter. Central fire, cook share increased one quarter."

Her own right hand flooded with the escort's spear pain. The wound did not appear, but burned skin split again as muscles clenched. She accepted the physical consequence because she had named the cook's share.

Tas's shield line reached the barrier.

Teren fought with a grain hook. He knew convoy spacing, not sword forms. The table gave him no martial skill. Haro shouted when to pull, and Teren followed. Together they caught a shield rim and dragged its bearer into the oil. An escort struck the soldier's helmet with a mallet, enough to stun without crushing his skull.

Imperial bread kept the attackers rested. Their field table drained exertion elsewhere as fast as Savra's bridge table spread it among volunteers. Two systems met across twelve paces of stone: one concealed its receivers, the other called names through smoke.

The fourth wagon jammed at the gate.

A rear wheel had swollen after canal water soaked its rim. Noro crawled beneath the axle with a hammer while arrows struck the tollhouse. Teren ordered sacks unloaded. Refugees formed a line and carried grain through by hand.

Captain Tas stepped behind his shields. "Your table cannot outlast our ration."

"It only needs to outlast the gate," Savra said.

A field cook beside him lifted a copper witness spoon from the lidded pot. He touched it to a company seal, then pointed toward the bridge. The stolen ledger no longer governed their oven, but the active ration table retained Kellar's branch notation from its last service.

Savra felt the imperial counter-bond before she saw its effect.

Cold pressure entered the southern fires. The enemy table was not joining the voluntary seats directly. It used overlapping grain oaths among refugees who had

eaten imperial relief, trying to reopen concealed positions and pull bridge burdens outward through them. Piri screamed beyond the gate. His splinted wrist jerked.

"Stop the children's line," Savra called. "No one with oath bread moves farther from the fires."

Panic rippled among the carts. Parents thought she meant to keep children on the battlefield.

"Distance does not sever them," she shouted. "I need the overlap held still."

She took the copper ember-ledger from Teren's pack. Copper leaves carried the broken field routes. The Kelar hook darkened against her palm as the enemy spoon reasserted it.

The safe response would extinguish all seven fires together. That would end their table and throw current shares back across active diners. Defenders might collapse before the gate cleared. The imperial branch would remain.

The ledger offered an established route: break the specific entry. Savra unrolled the copper until she found the western basin sheet and matched the hooked well, split roof, and open square from Kelar's seal. Three wires fed one punched channel.

"Dima, hold the central salt line."

"With what hand?"

"Both, if you have them."

He pressed his palms into salt at the medicine fire, physically maintaining its boundary while she worked. Pain weighting continued through him.

Savra used her chipped knife to sever the open-square wire.

Recoil struck every unregistered child who remained in the imperial table, including Piri. His body arched on the litter. The voluntary table caught only his declared absence, not his person; she had refused to seat him. Nothing she had built could receive his share.

Dima changed that with her body.

He broke his own marked cake in half and pressed one piece across the open-square wire while holding the medicine-fire salt. Food from the bridge table touched the imperial route. He had no authority to name Piri into a seat, but he could put his already declared double pain share in contact with the recoil.

The burden entered Dima's right hand.

His fingers folded inward. Knuckles struck the stone. A cavalry rider's crushed grip, Piri's fracture consequence, and the escort's spear pain converged through the line he held. Savra heard small bones or joints shift beneath his skin.

"Release it," she said.

"Cut the next wire."

"Dima."

“Cut.”

She severed the hooked-well entry. Adults near the west refugee class cried out, but their hidden connection collapsed before the counter-bond could deepen. The split-roof wire followed. Copper snapped under her blade.

Imperial pressure left the seven fires.

Dima lifted her left hand from the salt. Her right remained on the stone, fingers curled without control. The double-share line in his cake had gone dark.

Savra moved to him.

“Gate first,” he said. “My choice. Finish it.”

The fifth wagon cleared. Then the sixth. Haro and four escorts retreated one barrier at a time while refugees carried the last flour sacks through the tollhouse. Tas’s men pushed forward, but their own table had shuddered when three civilian routes broke. Fatigue returned to knees and shoulders. The shield line lost its single rhythm.

Teren saw the opening and ordered no charge. “Withdraw north.”

Defenders backed through the gate. Two carried the wounded escort. Savra and the cooks lifted each fire onto its cart hearth or, where vessels could not move, transferred the live coals into named ember cups held by their keepers. Source identity remained intact. Salt lines shortened visibly as the table crossed the threshold.

Only the central stove stayed on the bridge.

Savra stood beside it with Dima. His face had gone gray. She splinted his right hand flat against a bread board without trying to force the fingers straight. Fine control had already vanished. Whether it returned depended on damage no hearth could wish away.

Captain Tas reached the south end of the span. His sword stayed lowered.

“You have nowhere to take ninety-seven fires,” he said.

“Neither do you,” Savra answered.

Teren shouted from the north road. “All carts clear.”

Savra called the severance sequence. Seven keepers answered by fire name. Six transport cups stood north of the gate. The central stove remained seventh. Every active diner had crossed except Savra and Dima.

“Extinguish on three,” she said. “Recoil returns by current weight. Sit down.”

People sat or braced against wagons. Teren knelt to spare his ankle. Dima placed her left hand around the stove’s sand cup.

Savra counted.

Seven fires died together.

The table released in one hard wave. Haulers sagged under the exertion

returning to their own muscles. Defenders felt bruises gather where shared impacts had landed. Savra's burned palms throbbed with their actual injuries. Dima made no sound when pain settled fully into her damaged right hand.

No hidden seat took the remainder.

Haro pulled the gate closed. The broken chain could not lock, but two wagons backed against it while the refugees moved north. Tas's cavalry held the bridge without crossing. Perhaps he awaited infantry. Perhaps enough of his soldiers had felt their concealed supports fail to make another charge costly. The reason did not change the minutes gained.

On a rise beyond arrow range, Dima examined her hand. She could bend the wrist. The thumb moved slightly. Three fingers answered only with coarse flexion, and the index finger did not straighten. When she tried to pick up a needle, it slipped twice before she stopped.

"Dima's right hand needs a proper splint and cold water," Savra said.

"It needs work it can no longer do," he replied.

"You chose a declared share. I still set the table that carried it."

"Both statements stay true."

He would not absolve her by claiming ownership, nor surrender his choice so she could claim all blame. Savra wrapped the hand while the survivors gathered around.

Teren set the copper ledger on a grain cart. "They'll keep hunting this. People should know why."

Savra unrolled the leaves. Forty-six diners who had heard every seat named stood with refugees who had refused, children excluded for safety, and laborers who had moved them all. Smoke from the extinguished cookfires trailed north in seven separate lines.

She read the numbers aloud: ninety-seven prepared provincial hearths, three positions waiting, simultaneous service marked for Equinox. She explained what black salt hierarchy could do when a primary fire held the weighting. No sheet stated Rován's purpose in words. His method stated enough. A hundred distant fires, one controlling recipe, whole populations entered through grain oaths, burdens directed by whoever stood at the origin.

"This is Rován Dast's Hundred Fires plan," Savra said. "He means to make the basin eat from one table whether it knows the seats or not."

Behind her, Dima held her splinted right hand against her chest. Ahead, the refugee carts turned toward the salt road and Ulsor.

Part II

Chapter 8 — Salt City Without a Table

Ulsor measured strangers by the water they carried uphill.

At the first brine terrace, a guild clerk stopped the refugee carts and emptied every jar into marked basins. Fresh canal water went into blue clay. Brackish water went into green. Anything touched by an official Namarra measure entered black vessels for boiling before use. No amount disappeared, but ownership changed shape under inspection.

Teren stood beside the scales and counted while a line of eighty-three people waited in salt glare. Two children had joined them from a canal hamlet; one bridge volunteer had returned south to warn family. They brought six grain wagons, four carts, thirty-one sacks of rice, nineteen of barley, eight of chickpeas, and enough water for half a day if the heat held. Ulsor's gate rose another mile above them through terraces white with evaporation crust.

"Three jars short," Teren told the clerk.

The clerk checked her tablet. "One leaked on the north road. Two carried mixed ash and went to black."

"Black water still counts as water."

"After boiling."

"People thirst before your boil ends."

"Then they may drink their blue allotment first."

No insult entered her voice. Ulsor had survived imperial measurement by making its own rules more exact.

Terrace channels demonstrated the principle. Each brine pool received a numbered gate, but workers could close any one without draining its neighbors. Rakes, baskets, and evaporation dates belonged to separate crews; shared reservoirs fed them only through valves visible from the public path. Teren had expected a salt city to centralize what scarcity made valuable. Instead Ulsor multiplied boundaries so one bad measure could not spoil the whole season.

The arrangement sacrificed speed. Three clerks recorded water that one imperial assessor would have waved through. Seven vehicle lines occupied ground that could have held a warehouse. Yet no distant official could conceal a failed pool inside a provincial total. The city's inefficiency looked deliberate, purchased with labor against the cost of trusting one hand. Teren counted that labor too, because autonomy still required someone to lift every gate.

Dima sat on the front cart with her right hand bound flat to a splint. Swelling had darkened the knuckles. She could lift the arm and close three fingers coarsely, but

a water cup slipped unless Seli steadied it. Piri's wrist rested in a better splint made at a roadside mill. Neither complained while Teren argued over jars. That made the accounting more urgent, not less.

Savra waited apart beneath a reed shade. She had given Teren the copper ember-ledger for the climb because both palms remained open beneath their bandages. People along the terraces recognized her name before her face. News from Ember Bridge had outrun wagons through salt merchants. Some workers stared with gratitude. Others touched two fingers to the ground against bad weighting.

A second clerk brought seven shallow salt trays. "One per vehicle fire."

"Our fires are cold," Haro said.

"Then the trays remain clean."

Each wagon rolled across a white line poured between stone posts. Separate salt boundaries prevented accidental mingling of ash-signatures carried in hubs, cookpots, or spilled meal oil. Ulsor did not assume extinguished embers had forgotten where they came from.

Teren approved of the caution and disliked the delay. Both facts stayed true.

At the fourth terrace, Guildspeaker Mava Ul met them without escort. She wore a pale linen coat stiffened by salt at the cuffs and carried a hooked rake used to lift crust from brine pools. Her hair had gone white except for a dark band above one ear. Three guild seals hung from her belt, none resembling imperial measure marks.

"Teren Avo," she said. "Your Free Granary owes us twelve barge measures."

"Eight. Four burned at Vesk Ford under your contracted guard."

"The guard protected people, not rice."

"Then we owe eight measures and thanks."

Mava considered him. "Thanks take less warehouse space."

Her gaze moved to Savra and stopped. "Master Kel."

"Not master," Savra said.

"Rank does not vanish because the wearer dislikes its cost."

"No. It also does not survive desertion as authority."

Mava touched two fingers to the ground. Salt workers nearby repeated the warding gesture. "Keep her fire outside our lines."

Dima shifted on the cart. "She has no live fire."

"Then we agree easily."

Ulsor opened its gate for refugees, wagons, and grain after recording each name of origin. It did not open a common kitchen. Families received lodging tokens assigned among storehouse lofts, fish-curing sheds, and empty kiln rooms. Every

group got an unlit clay brazier stamped for its quarter. Guild law forbade one quarter from lending embers to another during first-night inspection.

Admission took the rest of the afternoon. Teren assigned Haro to the grain count and walked every lodging site himself. The fish sheds offered shade but retained salt in their floorboards, which would draw water from bare feet. Kiln rooms stayed cooler and had stone sleeping ledges, yet their vents opened toward brine pans where night insects gathered. Storehouse lofts kept bedding dry and placed too much weight above working warehouses. He distributed families by injury and mobility rather than by town, then changed the arrangement when Dima pointed out that separating witnesses from familiar caretakers would make every treatment slower.

Ulsor issued water at three measures per adult and two per child. Cooking took from the same allotment. Teren calculated barley at one and a quarter pounds per person for the first night, reduced for children, increased for terrace workers, then crossed out the whole figure because it treated people as standard mouths before any of them had accepted work. He asked each lodging group to name its own cook and report what grain its members could digest. The revised total differed by less than one sack. The process took an hour longer and prevented three old people from receiving barley they could not chew.

Dima established an infirmary in a disused weighing room. He directed splint work with his left hand and held bandage cloth under his right elbow while Seli cut it. When a guild healer offered to take over, Dima accepted examination but retained the patient list. "Help is not custody," he said. The healer nodded as if Ulsor had written the same rule for bodies that it used for salt.

At the grain yard, Haro found two sacks damp from the bridge. Ulsor clerks would not credit them at full measure. Teren opened both, spread rice across reed screens, and paid three terrace children in clean barley to turn the grain through sunset. Nothing in the bargain could depend on spoiled weight disguised by intact cloth.

The delegation meal took place on a roof above the civic brine tanks. Wind moved across water cut into rectangles, each pool at a different stage of concentration. Beyond the terraces, pale uplands climbed toward salt quarries. No city wall enclosed Ulsor. Any army approaching across the flats would see the guilds drain canals and ruin a season's harvest before surrendering it.

Servants brought pale barley, salt-baked river fish, sour plum paste, and brine herbs. Each delegate received separate bowls on an individual square of undyed cloth. No serving spoon passed between them. Mava's fish came from one oven, Teren's from another, Savra's from a third. Dima ate barley softened in goat milk from a broad bowl she could brace with her left hand.

"Is this hospitality or quarantine?" Teren asked.

"Yes," Mava said.

She sat with five guild assessors: brine, quarry, river trade, civic ovens, and oath disputes. Four seats remained empty for guilds that had declined to attend while Savra entered the city.

Teren ate before speaking. Refusing food would insult the shelter already given. Sharing carelessly would insult its boundaries. The fish flesh lifted cleanly from the bone, firm from salt packing and scented by herbs Savra identified as marsh rue.

"No table binds this meal," Mava said. "Our separate bowls carry separate fires. We may agree without pretending one stomach."

"That custom would improve half the Free Granary councils," Teren said.

"Only half?"

"The other half would argue over who gets the larger bowl."

Mava almost smiled.

Teren set his spoon down. "Rovan Dast has prepared ninety-seven provincial hearths for a simultaneous Equinox service. Three entries remain blank. We stole the working ledger from the army kitchen at Kelar."

A quarry assessor shrugged. "Namarra makes ambitious feast lists every year. Half serve prestige and half never serve."

"This one already moves soldiers' wounds into civilian grain districts."

"Your proof?"

Teren placed the document pouch on his cloth but did not open it until Mava provided a clean slate between them. Custody rules mattered more when evidence could bind through residue. He removed the complete Kelar seal with bronze tongs, then the Iskar fragment, village symptom record, bridge seat list, and copper ledger wrapped in flour cloth.

The civic-oven assessor leaned forward. "That cloth carries blood."

"Savra's hands," Teren said. "No one ate from it."

Mava assigned two witnesses to every object. A salt worker dusted the slate's edges so no hidden line crossed into a delegate's bowl. Only then did they unwrap the copper leaves.

Savra read the region columns without touching. "Thirty-two western basin. Twenty river. Fifteen upland. Eighteen terraces. Twelve capital approaches."

The river-trade assessor counted punches. "Ninety-seven."

"Look at active scoring," Mava said.

Copper darkened where field heat had sustained live signatures. Twelve entries showed repeated service polish. Seven had received repairs. The Kelar branches Savra cut remained ragged at their holes.

Mava did not accept appearance alone. She sent for two thumb-sized cakes of compressed salt, one from Ulsor's oldest civic line and one from a quarry fire never entered in imperial trade. The oath-dispute assessor placed each cake near the

copper without contact. The civic salt developed faint dampness beside three upland punches, evidence that old shared transactions had left compatible ash traces. Quarry salt remained dry. When she moved the civic cake toward a western-basin entry, its surface roughened as live residue tried to align.

“Prepared,” the assessor said. “Not merely listed.”

Savra asked for a sliver of sour plum skin. Mava gave it only after a witness cut the piece on a separate tile. Held above the Kelar punctures, its acid vapor darkened all three severed wires at once. The reaction matched the active overlap Savra described at Ember Bridge. No person ate, no live ember entered the roof, and each test item went afterward into a brine crock marked for destruction.

The quarry assessor remained skeptical. “A live route proves connection, not intent. A floodgate also connects towns.”

Teren answered with quantities. “The military arc receives one part across twelve declared squad marks. Civilian classes divide that burden under multipliers, including double weight for unregistered children. Connection does not require that ratio.”

“Could a civilian tablewright have altered it after issue?”

“Not beneath fired glaze,” Savra said. “The under-layer entered before the registrar stamps. A Hall kiln made the bias or accepted it.”

Mava required both statements copied: proof of prepared connection and inference of military intent. She would not let urgency promote an inference into a witnessed fact. Teren respected the distinction, though every lost hour enlarged the empire’s advantage.

Teren presented Ruva, Daret Ford, and Iskar Fen by time rather than accusation. Different breakfasts. Local fires. Shared district grain oath. Identical meal bells. Injuries matching cavalry work. He then described the tileworks kitchen: soldiers eating marked loaves, fatigue and blisters easing, origin coil routes breaking when he removed the spindle.

The oath-dispute assessor interrupted. “You observed relief. You did not observe the same pain entering those villages at that moment.”

“No,” Teren said. “Distance prevents a single witness.”

“Then cause remains inferred.”

“Add the seal.”

Savra explained the cold-seat classes under vinegar steam, civilian hooks beneath the cavalry arc, and inverted fractions for unregistered children. She used a charcoal copy rather than reopen the ceramic near food. Piri held up his splinted right wrist when the open-square mark came under discussion.

Mava asked him, “Did you eat imperial grain?”

“Chickpea cake from our kitchen.”

"Did you see a soldier break his wrist?"

"No."

"What did you feel?"

"A horse falling. Savra says I didn't see it in my head. My body guessed."

Savra had taught him the distinction. The boy repeated it without making the event cleaner.

Dima laid her splinted hand on the edge of her separate cloth. "At Ember Bridge, I took a declared double pain share. The imperial cook reopened Piri's hidden class through the field table. I contacted the recoil while holding our medicine-fire line."

"By choice?" Mava asked.

"Yes."

"Could you withdraw at that moment?"

"Not safely without shifting my share onto forty-five other named people."

"Then the first choice constrained the second."

Dima looked at her motionless index finger. "That belongs in every instruction we give afterward."

The civic-oven assessor examined his hand without touching it. She asked him to close each finger, oppose thumb to fingertips, and turn the wrist. Dima completed only the coarsest movements. No magic lingered. Damage had become bodily fact.

Mava listened to every witness before asking what Teren wanted.

"Shelter for the refugees through the hot month. Salt access for opening copied seals. A council of cooks and grain towns before Equinox. Permission to use one guild fire under your witnesses."

"What do you offer?"

"Eight owed barge measures delivered from Eren Ford stores. Four additional as shelter payment. Free Granary priority for Ulsor fish and salt on any northbound empty hull. Copies of every hearth location we can read."

"You do not control Eren Ford's stores alone."

"My sister keeps its communal oven. The river council holds the grain."

"Then you offer what other people must approve."

Teren felt the familiar urge to make the promise firm enough that approval would follow. "I offer to carry the proposal and bind no shipment without their vote."

"That has smaller weight."

"It is what I own."

Mava turned to the brine assessor. They calculated shelter need on clay tablets:

water per person, barley allotments, roof capacity, fuel, infirmary linen. Ulsor could absorb eighty-three people for twelve days without reducing salt workers' winter reserve. Longer shelter required grain deliveries or labor exchange.

Teren accepted those conditions. Refugees capable of work could choose terrace wages, but no labor would offset their food automatically. Ulsor had learned that debt meals became another seat list if left unnamed.

The bargain reached provisional agreement. The four empty guild seats remained empty.

Mava then pointed at Savra. "No fire."

Teren kept his hands on his own cloth. "You heard the evidence."

"I believe the danger. I do not accept her at an Ulsor hearth."

Savra said, "Those are separate judgments."

Mava's rake lay beside her seat. Salt scars crossed the wooden shaft. "At Selet Quarry, eleven years ago, workers woke with marching fractures. Forty-two could not return underground. My younger brother lost both knees while standing in a brine pan. Imperial records called it fever weakness."

No one ate.

"A captured ration seal carried nine salt divisions," Mava continued. "The Hall's army crossed the uplands without blisters while our villages bore them. We call it the Nine-Salt campaign because Namarra never gave us another name."

Savra's face emptied of every defense except attention.

Mava spoke her old title in full. "Master Feastwright Savra Kel, western march design. Your rank appears on the campaign provisioning orders."

Teren looked at Savra. At the dyehouse she had admitted field work and leaving after harmed villages. She had not named this table. The ledger between them seemed to gain physical weight.

"Were you present?" Mava asked.

"Yes."

"Did you make its recipe?"

Savra's burned hands rested palms down beside her untouched bowl. "I will answer in a hall where the harmed towns can send witnesses. Not in a closed meal with four guilds absent."

"That sounds like delay."

"It is a condition against private absolution."

"Do not presume anyone here offers it."

"I don't."

Mava considered her for a long time. "Until that answer, you do not touch a civic ember. You may cook over cold stone, clean vessels, and advise from outside the

salt line. If anyone calls you master, I fine them.”

Savra inclined her head. “Agreed.”

The decision frustrated Teren because they needed her work. It also preserved the very local authority he wanted Ulsor to exercise against the empire. He could not ask a city to resist one master table while demanding that it accept his preferred feastwright.

Mava brought an evidence chest made from salt-cured cedar. Two guild assessors checked its clean interior. Teren transferred the complete Kelar hearthseal, Iskar fragment, village record, bridge witness list, and copper ember-ledger one object at a time. Each custody statement entered the guild tablet. Mava locked the chest with three independent seals and gave no single assessor all keys.

“Ulsor holds the evidence,” she said. “Shelter begins tonight. Council invitations go out at dawn.”

“And fire?” Teren asked.

Mava looked across the roof at the distinct bowls and the empty guild cloths.

“Ulsor offers no shared fire until Savra answers for the Nine-Salt campaign.”

Chapter 9 — A Mouth for the Empire

Issen certified the famine bread while servants carried roast lamb behind a screen.

The public course consisted of nine thin slices, one for each day the capital's stores had failed twenty-eight years ago. Millet husk roughened the crumb. No oil softened it. A line of petitioners watched from the lower court while officials on the raised platform chewed in commemorative silence.

Behind them, concealed by embroidered linen, kitchen pages trimmed lamb fat into white curls for the private course that followed.

Issen swallowed the first slice. "Fit for the memorial measure."

The phrase entered the record. It did not say fit for a meal.

Their silver tasting chain lay cold against the throat except at the hollow seventh clasp. The stolen grain of black hearth-salt had remained there for eight days. Issen cleaned the chain each night without opening that link. During sleep, they sometimes felt a child's right wrist bend again, though no active bond remained. Ceremony trained a mouth to remember danger. Guilt needed no hearth.

Nine tables filled the Hall of Measures. Grain assessors sat nearest the dais, military provisioners next, then canal magistrates, guild delegates approved by Namarra, and foreign merchants whose gifts supplied the private kitchen. Empty benches along the walls represented districts unable to send delegates. The presiding herald named those absences as a sign of imperial reach: even those not present belonged to the common remembrance.

The petitioners entered by ration category. Widows of registered soldiers received clay markers for the lower court. Canal laborers stood behind a yellow cord. Displaced families occupied the outer arcade, where they could hear the herald but not see the tasting table. Their memorial bread came from the same batch, yet pages delivered it in different baskets so no recipient crossed into another administrative class.

Issen checked one basket from each line. The widows' slices weighed a full civic measure. Laborers lost a finger-width to "workhouse adjustment," on the assumption that their midday porridge supplemented the course. Displaced families received pieces cut by eye because many lacked current ration tablets. The Hall described all nine breads as common. Its knives disagreed.

They ordered the remaining loaves weighed before cutting. The distribution clerk protested that the memorial docket authorized ceremonial samples, not public allotment review. Issen invoked adulteration authority: unequal cuts changed the effective proportion of husk to crumb and therefore changed what each mouth tasted. The argument stretched law until it covered justice by a corner. It also delayed service seventeen minutes while hungry people watched

scales move.

Rovan noticed from the first table. He could have overruled the order. Instead he told the clerk to comply and required officials' slices reduced to fund the difference. By the fourth bread, every public line received equal weight. The private lamb continued roasting behind the screen.

That contradiction described him more accurately than any accusation Issen could have made. He corrected a visible inequality when its measure reached his hand. He did not question the screen that kept another inequality outside the ceremony's terms.

Issen tasted the second bread. Ground chickpea, too much ash, a bitter edge from old fenugreek. The flavor pulled Kelar close enough to disturb their breathing, although they knew no name for the distant child or kitchen. They kept their face still.

Grand Provisioner Rovan Dast sat at the first table without eating. His famine bowl held the same nine slices as everyone else's. No lamb fat touched his place. Whatever exemptions he permitted the court, he did not take that one.

The herald recited figures from the Nine-Day Famine: granaries closed, barges delayed, riots, households abandoned, bodies collected from market steps. Rovan had been a child then. The official account never named what he had eaten or whom he had watched starve.

At slice four, a canal magistrate drank wine beneath the table. Issen smelled anise on his breath when he leaned forward for certification. Memorial rules forbade any other food until all nine measures passed.

"Your cup," they said.

He covered it with one sleeve. "Medicinal."

"Then the court physician will have entered it."

The physician had not. A page removed the wine. The magistrate's expression promised a later complaint, but he ate the fifth slice dry like the petitioners below.

Small equalities made convincing theater because bodies felt them.

The sixth bread came from red millet. The seventh used canal rice pressed into a hard square. The eighth contained only barley and salt. Each course claimed a province through grain while withholding the province's ordinary preparation. Tal Jes millet arrived without pepper oil or goat curd. Eren Ford rice lacked lentils and pickled mustard. Ulsor barley carried standardized mine salt, not guild brine. The memorial joined ingredients by stripping away difference.

For the ninth measure, servants brought a shared basin of warm water. Every official dipped one piece of famine bread before eating. Rovan waited until the petitioners received their basin below. Only then did he swallow.

"Let no private store stand between one hunger and another," the herald declared.

Applause moved across the hall.

Issen certified the water and watched kitchen pages remove the screens. Roast lamb, honeyed roots, spiced fish, and white loaves entered for officials. Petitioners received one extra memorial slice at the doors.

Rovan joined Issen at the tasting table. "You object to the second service."

"I have not tasted it."

"You object before taste."

"The lamb did not wait through nine breads."

"Staff must prepare the next course while guests complete the first."

"Preparation has a smell."

"So does resentment."

His tone remained mild. Issen met his gaze. "Resentment did not roast the lamb."

A line appeared beside his mouth, almost amusement. "Come below after certification. The archive kitchen has the old famine menus. You asked to understand policy."

"I asked to see the seat list."

"Understanding may improve your questions."

The private courses required sixteen tastings. Issen found no poison. They rejected one honey glaze because fermented foam concealed a poppy tincture above court allowance. Rovani supported the refusal and ordered the full tray withheld, including his own portion. Sincere standards coexisted comfortably with concealed seats.

By midafternoon, Issen descended to the archive kitchen carrying their chain, tasting spoon, and an authorized slate. This room lay above the hidden test hearth but below the public ovens. No live fire burned. Heat came through pipes from a laundry boiler, keeping wax tablets soft enough to read without cracking.

Menus occupied cedar shelves organized by reign, campaign, civic festival, and emergency ration. Each consisted of two records. The public sheet named dishes and ingredients. The kitchen sheet named source stores, oven signatures, oath classes, expected bodily effects, and tasting sequence. Issen's office usually received only the first.

Archive rules treated food history as chain of custody. A kitchen sheet recorded who opened each grain jar, how many hours an ember had remained banked, which spoon touched the test cup, and where leftovers went after service. Discarded broth could retain a bond until it cooled or digestion ended in every diner, so waste carts carried extinction marks. Even grease scraped from a pan had a destination entry. The Hall knew how to follow matter when matter threatened its own kitchens.

Population reach received less precision. Oath classes appeared as hooks and initials rather than names. A source clerk might record twelve pounds of barley to the half-ounce while representing two thousand attached households with a single provincial cut. Accuracy contracted around what the Hall owned and expanded around bodies it governed.

Issen selected a menu from a flood-relief service and followed its two records. The public sheet promised warming rice for canal evacuees. The inner sheet expected excess heat to move toward dredging crews working in cold water. That transfer might have helped both groups if every diner knew. Nothing in the public text mentioned the crews, duration, or weighting. A useful outcome did not repair the omission; it merely made concealment easier to defend.

“Were the dredgers told?” Issen asked.

Rovan checked the service year. “The canal magistrate requested the arrangement.”

“That answers who ordered it.”

“Workers knew relief kitchens supported the flood effort.”

“That answers what they might have inferred.”

He closed the flood menu. “You want every administrative fact spoken before every meal.”

“Only the facts entering a body.”

Rovan waited beside a table holding the original famine ledger. He wore no ceremonial black bronze now. His gray robe smelled faintly of dry bread.

“The first day,” he said, opening a wax leaf. “Look at distribution.”

The menu listed millet cakes from South Canal Store Three. In the kitchen margin, two letters appeared beside a three-pronged hearth mark: SC. A second source carried NF for North Foundry. Day two added RW, River Weighhouse. By day nine, thirty-one initials crowded the margin.

“Storehouses,” Issen said.

“Originally.”

“Originally?”

“As ration oaths expanded, the notation moved from buildings to the populations attached to them. A hearth represents continuity better than a warehouse. Warehouses burn.”

“So do kitchens.”

“People rebuild them.”

He handed Issen a menu from the previous year’s canal festival. Provincial ingredients filled the public page. Its kitchen margin carried the same initials as several blackened ember cups beneath the Hall, plus marks Issen had not seen in the test room.

They touched none of the wax. "These menus contain seat reach."

"They contain provenance."

"Provenance ends where the ingredient enters this kitchen. These marks continue into households."

Rovan took time before answering. "A modern ration oath does both."

The distinction he offered functioned like a door painted on stone.

Issen compared the famine commemoration menu from that morning. Nine provincial grains, nine public sources. In the inner margin, forty-two hearth initials appeared under lines for expected hunger, digestive delay, and shared satiety. The banquet had not carried an active mass bond; no live provincial embers touched its bread. Yet the menu had been written to accept those signatures later without changing service order.

"A template," they said.

"A measure that can grow."

"Toward one hundred."

Rovan did not deny it. "The earlier test established reach. Equinox will establish a stable civic field."

"How many mouths?"

"Enough that provincial isolation stops deciding who bears scarcity."

Issen opened the authorized slate. "Name them."

"Names change daily."

"Name the hearths."

"You are looking at some."

"Why only some?"

"Because the instrument remains vulnerable to sabotage."

"By the people entered into it?"

"By officials and insurgents who profit from keeping burdens local."

Rovan walked to a shelf marked REBELLION YEARS. He removed a campaign menu bound in leather and set it beside the famine ledger.

"During the Vesk uprising, river towns withheld grain while upland districts starved," he said. "The river councils could afford rebellion because other provinces carried the army's requisitions. Their local prosperity financed refusal."

"Imperial assessments financed the army they refused."

"And when the army withdrew, Vesk merchants charged famine rates to the uplands. Local independence did not produce local mercy."

That much entered the historic record even outside Namarra. Issen had tasted Vesk memorial wine, deliberately sour to recall grain sold late.

Rovan opened the campaign menu. "Suppose the river councils had felt the upland deficit in their own stomachs. Suppose the uplands had felt the broken ribs of dockworkers beaten during seizure. Neither side could have called the other's condition distant."

"Feeling does not grant control over the barges."

"It alters the price of refusing them."

"Who sets the weights?"

"A central provision office with representation from every region."

"Under whose army?"

"Under a law built to outlast any army."

Issen saw the shape of his sincerity. Rovan had not invented hunger as an excuse for command. Hunger had taught him to fear any storehouse closed by a private hand. He wanted every closed door to hurt the person holding its key. He did not apply the same suspicion to the office governing all doors.

"What happens to rebellion under your stable field?" they asked.

"It loses the fiction of clean victory. Burn a granary, and your own children feel the hunger. Wound a soldier, and the cost reaches your household. Let soldiers wound a village, and the capital receives that pain."

"Equally?"

"According to population and capacity."

"Those are weights."

"Justice requires weights. An infant cannot carry an adult share."

At Kellar, a small body had carried more.

Issen kept that knowledge behind their teeth. "You call it peace through equal hunger."

"Equal hunger, equal consequence. Not identical portions."

"Then the phrase conceals its own correction."

Rovan's hand rested on the famine ledger. "I remember adults telling me the closed granary held enough. They treated my hunger as information about someone else. If its keeper had felt what I felt, the gate would have opened."

"Or he would have endured your pain and kept the key."

"No one endures a continent."

"You intend to prove that with bodies who did not choose the test."

"Consent cannot be gathered from every mouth before a canal is dug, a tax assessed, or an army raised. Government acts among people who disagree."

"A canal can be walked away from."

"Not by the town it floods."

He answered too well to become a simple monster. That made the room more dangerous.

Issen touched the seventh link of their chain. Black salt rested inside, evidence taken without lawful warrant. "Where does the First Taster sit?"

"At the capital measure."

"With what weight?"

"Representative."

"Can I sever my seat?"

"The supervising tablewright can sever any seat that fails."

"That gives me no severance."

"It gives you protection."

"From the person controlling the fire."

Rovan closed the campaign menu. "You mistake independent power for safety. Offices constrain one another."

"My office does not receive the inner menu."

"You receive it now."

"Because you want my mouth at Equinox."

"Yes."

The admission came without shame. He believed use and trust could occupy the same word.

A kitchen archivist entered to request the famine menus for resealing. Issen watched her inventory every sheet by title and shelf number. The inner menus carried no individual classification beyond their category. A tasting order could access them legally when comparing ingredient provenance. Copying the hearth initials would violate archive rules, not because they named people but because they exposed infrastructure.

Issen returned the authorized slate. "I need to compare today's bitter fenugreek against previous western-grain services. The memorial bread carried storage contamination."

Rovan had eaten the same bread. "How severe?"

"Below refusal. Strong enough to confuse a future hearth test."

"Take an archivist and examine five years."

He granted access because the tasting reason remained sound. Issen had not invented the bitterness.

Rovan Dast left for the afternoon grain council. The archivist, Pel Arit, brought menus from five famine commemorations and two western provincial festivals. She sat across from Issen while they compared ingredient marks.

Issen worked slowly enough to remain exact. Fenugreek source. Storage year. Oil carrier. Oven. Beneath those legitimate observations, they tracked hearth initials. SC repeated. NF. RW. Three western marks appeared only after the ration-oath expansion. Two matched regional cuts on the black-salt test apparatus. Four more occurred beside souring instructions designed for rapid reach.

They could not write the initials openly. Pel checked every mark made on Hall slate.

Instead Issen used their tasting chain.

The seven links bore tiny calibration scratches along the inner edge, used to measure spoon depth. During a wash break, they added one pinprick beside the first link for SC, two beside the second for NF, then combinations corresponding to the menu order. The marks alone meant nothing without a key.

For the key, they wrote a list of spice corrections on a permitted paper strip: sesame before fenugreek, mint after plum, rue omitted, cumin doubled. First letters and positions encoded the hearth sequence. A court cook would read only adjustments.

Pel returned with the final menu. "You're looking past ingredients."

Issen kept their voice courteous. "The office trained me to."

"Some things in these sheets do not belong to your certification."

"Then they should not alter what I taste."

Pel glanced toward the archive door. "Grand Provisioner says the new field will prevent another famine."

"Do you believe him?"

"I believe he remembers being hungry."

"That was not my question."

The archivist resealed the menus without answering. Before she carried them away, she turned the top kitchen sheet so Issen could see its lower corner. Three additional initials lay beneath the wax flap, places omitted from the public provenance line.

Issen memorized them.

That night, they resumed court duty at a reception for canal magistrates. They tasted wine, fish paste, and sugared nuts while officials praised the morning's shared austerity. No one asked whether nine slices had satisfied the petitioners.

In the recovery room afterward, Issen opened the hollow clasp. The black hearth-salt grain remained intact. They placed the coded spice strip beside it and copied the pinprick key onto a scrap hidden inside the chain's storage case.

Seventeen initials. Seventeen distant hearths, each attached to mouths Rovan called representation. None of those mouths could inspect Issen's list, yet the first honest record of them now existed outside the Hall's inner menu.

Issen folded the private list beneath the case lining and fastened the silver chain for tomorrow's service.

Chapter 10 — The Meal No One Bound

Savra had twelve baskets open on the brine-yard stones and no two of them agreed about supper.

One held pale barley polished until each grain looked like a clipped fingernail. Another leaked pepper oil through its reedwork. There were river onions cured in salt, a clay jar of sour plum, two gutted fish stiff beneath their crust, mustard stems from the canal country, meal made from red millet, and a sack of chickpeas that had crossed Ember Bridge in Teren's third wagon. Around the baskets stood twelve cooks who had agreed on only one fact: none intended to let Savra Kel put their food over her fire.

"Good," Savra said. "Then we have begun correctly."

Guildspeaker Mava Ul watched from beneath the shade cloth. Her mourning cords, gray for the relatives lost in the Nine-Salt campaign, lay against a robe white with blown salt. "We asked for proof that you can cook without control. Not proof that you enjoy being contradicted."

"I don't enjoy it." Savra pressed a thumb into the fish's belly. The flesh returned slowly. Fresh enough, if cooked before sunset. "I trust it."

The cook from the western pans, a narrow man named Hesh, pulled his basket farther from the chickpeas. "My fire takes no imperial grain."

"Those chickpeas came from Kellar refugees," Dima said. She held her right hand close to her apron, the fingers bent with the permanent stiffness Ember Bridge had left in them. Her left hand rested on the handle of an adapted cleaver. "If you mean to insult someone, count accurately."

Hesh's ears darkened. He did not return the basket.

Mava had arranged the test in the salt guild's dyeing yard, where twelve brick fire beds ran beside a channel carrying hot brine toward the settling pans. No hearthseal had been admitted through the gate. Two guild clerks had searched Savra's clothes, her knife roll, and the seams of her shoes. They had searched Dima as well. Teren had been ordered to remain outside with the Free Granary guards. The guilds wanted no soldier, no captain, and no hidden ember close enough to turn a meal into an argument made inside another person's body.

Savra understood the precaution. Understanding did not make the search easier to endure.

"Each of you keeps your own fire," she told the cooks. "Your own salt. Your own serving hand. We will produce one course from twelve vessels. Nothing crosses a flame. Nothing receives a common ash."

A woman in a reed hat lifted the sour-plum jar. "Then it isn't one course."

"It will reach one table at one time. That is enough."

“An emperor’s definition,” Hesh said.

Savra looked at his basket. Coarse barley, brine herbs, and an iron pan polished by generations of oil. “An emperor would tell you your pan had always belonged to him.”

A laugh escaped someone near the millet, brief and unwilling. Mava heard it. Her face did not change.

The guildspeaker pointed to the central paving, where twelve low tables stood apart in the Ulsori custom. “No common platter. Separate bowls. If your demonstration depends on breaking our hospitality to make a prettier symbol, it has already failed.”

“Keep the bowls,” Savra said. “Move the guests.”

That proposal bought her silence.

She assigned no recipe. Instead she asked each cook what their ingredient refused. River fish refused slow heat after salting. Millet refused too much water. The chickpeas refused haste. Pepper oil refused a wet spoon. Barley refused to share a pot with sour plum until its husk had opened. Their answers came as challenges, but answers still gave her timings.

Work began with the chickpeas because they needed the longest flame. Savra borrowed a broad pot from the yard, filled it at the brine channel’s freshwater inlet, and set it over a fire kindled by the Kellar cook, a round-faced girl named Nerin who had learned in the refugee kitchen. Savra did not touch Nerin’s fuel. She crouched near enough to judge the flame by the movement of steam at the pot’s lip.

“Skim now,” she said.

“I know foam.”

“Then why are you arguing with it?”

Nerin skimmed.

Across the yard Hesh toasted barley dry. The reed-hatted cook split sour plums with her thumbnail. A terrace cook heated pepper oil until one mustard seed gave a single jump, then pulled the pan aside. Dima worked through onions with her adapted knife, rocking the broad blade under her left palm while the curled fingers of her right hand steadied nothing. No one offered help. She had asked them not to unless the cut escaped her.

Savra moved among the fires without crossing the chalk arcs Mava’s clerks had drawn around each hearth. She called time by the brine drops from a cracked ceramic cup: fish after forty drops, onions after sixty, millet covered at ninety. At each fire she asked before touching a lid. Three cooks refused. Their food still had to arrive with the rest, so she altered the sequence around them rather than their work.

By the second hundred drops, rivalry had acquired practical consequences. Hesh’s barley needed the hot brine that the fish cook meant to throw away. The

terrace cook wanted onion skins to temper the bitterness in her oil. Nerin needed sour plum to keep the chickpeas from collapsing into paste, but the woman in the reed hat would not surrender her jar to a common ladle.

"No exchange across fires," Mava reminded them.

"Ingredients may cross before they touch flame," Savra said. "Only if their owners choose."

"Convenient."

"Necessary things often are. That doesn't make them innocent."

Hesh stared into his pan. "I'll take the fish brine if I can carry it myself."

The fish cook shrugged. "Take what I would spill."

No one praised them. Hesh carried a cup between the chalk arcs, poured it into his barley, and returned the cup to a basin for scalding. The terrace cook traded a spoon of pepper oil for onion skins. Nerin received three split plums on a shard of clean pottery, not the jar. Each exchange stayed visible. Each giver named the amount.

Savra felt something loosen in the yard, though no hearthbinding touched it. People adjusted because a pan demanded it, not because a seal made refusal painful.

The first vessel finished too early. The fish had drawn firm under salt and heat, its eye gone pearl-white while the barley still held a hard center. Savra asked the fish cook to lift the pan onto warm brick.

"You said forty drops."

"I judged a larger fish."

"So your timing failed."

"Yes."

Her answer moved through the cooks more sharply than an excuse would have. Imperial feastwrights did not admit mistakes before service. They buried them in garnish, changed the measure, or found a colder seat.

Dima slid the onions from her board. "What does the error cost?"

"Five minutes of resting. The skin may cling."

"And if it had cost the fish?"

"We would serve eleven vessels and name the missing one."

Nobody laughed this time.

When the barley opened, Hesh tasted it from his own spoon and signaled with two fingers. Nerin crushed chickpeas against the pot wall, leaving half whole. Dima divided smoked onion among twelve little dishes, her left hand quick despite the drag of her right. The pepper cook drizzled oil in measured drops. Sour plum remained on its own shard. Nothing met until the bowls reached the tables.

Mava's invited delegates entered at sunset: guild weighers, canal keepers, refugee elders, two Free Granary factors, and a potter whose kilns supplied half the city's seal clay. Twelve diners sat, one at each low table. Before them stood twelve bowls in twelve local forms. At Savra's signal each diner rose and moved one place clockwise, carrying nothing. After every bite they rose again. By the end, every person had eaten from every cook, but no fire, ash, vessel, or spoon had joined another.

At the sixth place, the canal keeper asked Hesh for more barley. Hesh pointed him toward the next table because giving an extra portion would disturb the count. At the eighth, the potter passed her untouched pepper oil to a refugee elder who wanted it. At the tenth, two delegates began comparing the fish brine to the mustard stems and called the fish cook over to settle whether the cure could preserve canal rice.

Conversation did what Savra could not have ordered. It crossed the spaces the bowls preserved.

She remained standing until Mava tapped an empty cushion beside the chickpea table.

"You cooked," the guildspeaker said.

"Nerin cooked."

"You corrected the fire."

"I asked her to."

Mava tapped the cushion again. "Sit where we can see what reaches you."

Savra sat. Nerin gave her the final portion, scraped from the pot's bottom where the chickpeas had browned. It carried smoke, sour fruit, and the sandy roughness of a pulse cooked almost, but not entirely, soft. No foreign ache followed the swallow. Her scar did not warm. No soldier's fatigue pressed behind her eyes. The food contained only what field, hands, fuel, and error had put into it.

"The meal no one bound," the potter said.

Mava glanced at her. "You make it sound ceremonial."

"I make seal jars. Everything sounds ceremonial after enough guild speeches."

A few delegates smiled. Savra did not. She had reached the part of the test no timing could improve.

Hesh set down his spoon. "Tell us what you did for the empire."

Savra folded her hands above her bowl. She spoke of training in the Hall of Measures, of field tables built to spread marching fatigue among named companies, and of notation that let a feastwright alter weights after the first bite. She said she had worked under Rován Dast. She said villages had suffered through an imperial campaign table she had helped make. She did not offer the design's formal name, and she did not pretend omission had kept her clean.

"How many villages?" the reed-hatted cook asked.

"I don't know."

"How many people?"

"I never learned the number."

Her next question cut deeper. "Did you stay to count?"

"No."

Brine water clicked through the yard channel. Dima watched Savra without rescue in her face.

Mava wiped plum from her thumb. "You want these cooks to learn from you."

"I want them to survive what Rovani is building."

"That was not my question."

Savra looked around the separate tables. "Yes. I want them to learn from me. Skill survives guilt. That makes skill dangerous, not useless."

"And trust?"

"Trust should not survive on command."

Mava let the answer stand. She turned to the twelve cooks. "You have seen her work without a seal. That proves she can coordinate supper. It proves nothing about what she will do with an ember."

Dima reached into her apron and placed two small salt cups on the paving. The guild clerks stiffened, but both cups had come from Mava's own stores. Dima added two charcoal embers in separate clay saucers, one from her camp fire and one from Nerin's refugee hearth.

"We can prove one more thing," Dima said. "Small enough to stop."

Savra studied the cups. "Who takes the paired share?"

"I do," Nerin said at once.

Dima shook her head. "Your fire is already named. We need someone who understands the right to end it." She looked at Hesh.

His mouth tightened. "You want Ulsor in a former imperial cook's table."

"I want you in your own."

The proposed bond used no blended embers. Two saucers heated two barley cakes made from the same dough, each cake marked with one name. A line of clean Ulsor salt separated the saucers. Savra would bridge them only with a spoon of onion oil, equal measure on both cakes. Dima named the burden: the warmth and sting of a hand held over steam for ten breaths. Equal weighting. Duration no longer than twenty minutes. Either diner could sever by overturning their salt cup and scattering its line.

"And the cook?" Mava asked.

Savra took a third pinch of dough.

Dima's brows lifted. "A pair has two."

"Then I do not bind it. Under our rule, the cook takes a seat."

Hesh studied her for a long moment. "Three equal shares. No hidden fourth."

"No hidden fourth."

They spoke all three names aloud. Savra touched no one's cup. Hesh marked the cakes with the blunt end of his own spoon. Nerin placed her ember. Dima counted ten breaths while each diner held a hand above steam, and pain gathered red across Savra's palm. When they ate, the heat divided. Her own sting diminished, then steadied as Hesh's and Nerin's joined it. Nothing vanished. Three palms carried the same modest burn.

At the seventh minute Hesh overturned his salt cup.

The line broke. Recoil returned his fraction across Savra and Nerin, a quick increase sharp enough to make Nerin gasp. Savra held her hand open so everyone could see the color deepen. Dima extinguished both embers, and digestion carried the remaining bond down toward silence.

Hesh flexed his fingers. "It obeyed me."

"No," Savra said. "We obeyed the limit you declared."

Mava rose. One by one, the other cooks stood with her. They did not swear to Savra, and no one asked them to. Each named the defensive work they would accept: finding concealed salt, breaking seals, measuring recoil, teaching diners to leave a table alive.

By full dark, twelve cooks had agreed to return at dawn. They carried their separate embers to twelve separate banks of ash, ready to learn severance rather than battle feasts. Savra stayed behind to scrub the three salt cups clean.

Chapter 11 — Grain for an Unwounded Army

Teren lay under a tamarisk bush with his bad ankle in canal mud and counted the imperial barge by the way its towrope moved.

Six men hauled from the north bank. Two more walked loose beside them, spear carriers by posture even in laborers' gray. The barge rode deep enough for twenty-eight tons if the hull followed Namarra's grain measure, but its stern sat lower than its bow by a hand. That meant guards or seal chests aft. A boy steered with a sweep longer than he stood. Three soldiers occupied the deck, each wearing boiled-leather shoulder pieces and the bored faces of men who expected the road to remain owned.

Behind Teren, reeds hid twenty-one Free Granary fighters, four guild archers, and two cooks carrying wet hides instead of weapons. Nobody had eaten a binding meal. Their strength belonged to their own legs, their fear to their own mouths.

The canal narrowed at a maintenance gate thirty paces ahead. Ulsor masons had removed one pin before dawn. When the barge entered the lock, two women beneath the downstream walkway would drive the gate shut with a timber ram. Teren's people would drop the towline, take the deck, and keep every flame away from the grain.

He raised one finger.

The first towman passed the painted stone. Sweat darkened his back from neck to belt. His bare heels had split against the bank, and every step pressed blood into dust. The second limped. The third had wrapped his palms in cloth gone brown at the center.

None of the soldiers showed a blister.

Teren lowered his hand before giving the signal. He watched the soldier nearest the bow. The man's boots lacked road dust above the ankle. His face had the gray looseness of fatigue, yet his shoulders stayed level beneath his armor. When the towmen strained around a root, all three soldiers drew breath together, not from effort but from something shared and distant.

"Captain?" whispered Saret beside him.

"Wait for the stern."

Four heartbeats later Teren saw the black ceramic cap fixed beneath the tiller bench. A seal. Small enough for a company table, large enough to keep a ration bond alive between meal bells.

He showed two fingers, then closed his fist.

The maintenance gate slammed across the canal. Water struck wood with a flat crack. Archers rose from reeds and sent blunt shafts at the tow guards before either man brought a spear around. Saret cut the rope. Six haulers fell backward

as tension vanished, while Teren and the boarders ran down the bank with hooked poles.

His left ankle caught in a washout. Pain climbed the old crush line and forced one short step, but he kept moving. A pole hooked the barge rail. Teren used both arms, swung across the water, and landed among spilled millet grains.

The nearest imperial soldier thrust low. Teren knocked the spear aside with the hook, drove its butt into the man's ribs, and saw the towman onshore fold around the same place before the soldier did. The bond carried impact away quickly enough to make the soldier's eyes widen without stopping his counterstroke.

"Don't strike them!" Teren shouted. "Pin the weapons."

His people adjusted because he had warned them before the ambush that any unexplained resilience meant hidden seats. Two hooked the spear shaft. Saret threw a net over the second soldier. The third drew a short sword and backed toward the stern seal, perhaps to break it, perhaps to increase its weight. Teren could not let either happen while the distant seats remained unknown.

He crossed behind a stack of sacks and shoved a wet hide over the ceramic cap. One of the cooks, Vei, followed. She packed mud around the seal's air holes, starving the ember without cracking the clay.

Transfer moved badly when a source fire died. The soldier with the sword staggered as his own fatigue returned. A blister rose beneath his thumb in the time it took him to grip the rail. The netted man vomited canal water though none had touched his mouth. Onshore, the towmen stopped gasping.

"Yield," Teren said. "The bond is dying, not broken. If you smash that cap, whatever remains may recoil."

The swordsman looked toward the haulers. His blade lowered by a finger.

Saret tightened the net around his companion. "He means it."

"Free Granary lies with an honest face," the soldier said.

"Then test my arithmetic. Three of you, six haulers, one sealed ember. You have been walking without sores while they bleed. If the seat list contains only nine names, your captain might survive breaking it. If it contains ninety, you may kill someone you have never seen."

That calculation reached him. He put the sword flat on deck.

The skirmish ended in less time than the lock took to fill. One archer had a cut across her left forearm. Two towmen carried bruises from falling. Teren's ankle throbbed. Nobody had died, and the barge still held its cargo.

By noon they had moored beneath a salt warehouse whose guild mark kept imperial patrols away. Teren ordered the prisoners given water before questioning, then began his inventory at the bow.

The first sacks held pale barley, forty imperial measures to a stack. Next came hard red wheat, river rice, chickpeas, and millet. Each sack bore two stamps: the

Hall of Measures weight and a ration-oath origin. The origin marks should have named crown fields or taxed estates. Instead Teren found village oven signs pressed beneath wax patches.

Vei heated a thin knife and lifted the patch from a wheat sack. Beneath it lay a three-reed mark.

"Dovet Bank," Teren said.

Saret leaned close. "That's south of the reed marshes. No crown land there."

"Forty families. Two ovens." Teren had bought rice from them three years earlier. "Write it."

The next patch concealed a hooked fish from Heron Cut. A barley sack carried the split wheel of Ashel Ferry. Thirty rice sacks bore the low-arch sign of Mere Varo. At the stern, under the deepest stack, they found red millet marked with the hand-and-spade of Orra Field.

Five civilian villages supplied the oath marks. Every one lay along a military road, and none had sold to the Free Granary since spring.

Saret ran a hand over the stacked food. "Requisition."

"More than that." Teren cut open one sack and found individually baked ration loaves packed upright between layers of husk. They looked like standard white army bread, dense enough to keep through wet weather. A black line crossed each crust. Not mold. Hearth-salt baked into the scoring.

He selected three loaves from separate layers and set them on an overturned crate. Vei brought the mud-smothered barge seal. Its ember had cooled to a dull red, but faint heat still moved under the cap.

One imperial soldier, the man who had surrendered his sword, watched from beneath guard. He gave his name as Captain Orel Tas, though his armor carried no field bars. His men called him captain without thinking.

"Those are breakfast rations," Orel said. "You'll learn nothing by wasting them."

Teren turned one loaf. The base carried five tiny cuts radiating from a central hole. "Who eats from the other seats?"

"Army provisioning does not publish routes to raiders."

"Routes are already on the sacks."

Orel's gaze moved to the exposed village marks. Surprise tightened one side of his mouth before discipline removed it.

That mattered. A man could participate in a system without knowing its full table. Ignorance did not restore the haulers' skin, but it changed how Teren should question him.

"Did you know civilian grain oaths remained active after requisition?" Teren asked.

"My company eats assigned bread."

"That is not an answer."

"It is what I know."

Vei broke a loaf. Steam no longer rose, yet the crumb smelled faintly of the last oven that had baked it: rice chaff, old mustard smoke, a little canal damp. She pinched off a piece but did not swallow.

"We test with hands," she said. "No eating while the full list remains concealed."

A shallow bowl received warm water and a measure of sour plum to accelerate transfer. Vei floated crumbs from the three loaves, set the barge seal beside the bowl, and named only the participants present: herself, Teren, and Orel. Without access to the concealed list, she could not exclude distant seats. She therefore used no fresh ember and no binding salt. The goal involved reading the old bond's residue, not waking it.

"Touch the water," she told Orel.

His manacled hand entered first. Teren followed, then Vei. For several breaths nothing happened. After the sixth, Teren felt pressure under his heel. After the eighth, a raw line opened across his right palm, mirroring no injury he carried. Orel's breathing eased as the sensation arrived.

Vei withdrew. "Enough."

Teren kept his fingers in the bowl for two more breaths to judge direction. The pain ran toward them from the seal, not from Orel directly. Behind it came the heavy drag of sleepless labor, a child's cramped calf, and heat trapped beneath someone's shoulder blade. No memory traveled with those states. No face or name. Only bodies paying fractions.

He pulled free. The palm looked unbroken, but the hurt remained until Vei buried the seal in wet salt and quenched its last coal.

Across the room Orel flexed his hand. The blister at his thumb had thickened since the bond weakened. Teren looked at the prisoners' feet. Their socks showed no blood. The towmen waiting in the courtyard had needed bandages before they could walk.

"Soldiers without blisters," Saret said quietly. "Marchers without swollen knees. While five villages limp for them."

Orel's face hardened. "My soldiers marched fourteen days. We bled at Ossen Ford."

"I believe you." Teren dried his hand. "The table did not erase your wounds. It kept sending portions elsewhere."

"No civilian sits in a company ration circle."

"Then help us open the manifest."

The captain looked again at the village marks. "If I assist you, my crew hangs."

"If you don't, these loaves go back into service and people who never enlisted

keep marching under your feet.”

Orel offered no answer. Teren did not press him toward a conversion that one inventory could not earn.

The manifest chest required two keys. One hung beneath the tiller bench. The barge master, captured downstream after trying to swim the lock, had swallowed the other. Dima would have proposed patience and oil. Saret proposed an axe. Teren chose the hinges.

They removed each bronze pin without striking the chest body, using sail grease and a wagon punch. Inside lay wax tablets listing allotments for six hundred troops over twenty days. The ration numbers matched. The seat annex did not name people, only the same five oven marks and a weighting column.

Dovet Bank carried twelve shares for every hundred soldiers. Heron Cut carried nine. Ashel Ferry bore seventeen. Mere Varo, the largest village, bore thirty-eight. Orra Field carried twenty-four. The numbers totaled one hundred civilian shares set against each company hundred. Imperial troops felt half of what happened to them. Villages received the rest according to grain contribution.

Saret looked pleased in the grim way of a man whose enemy had finally written down its crime. “We take the tablets to Mava. The grain feeds us through Halvek.”

Teren had already begun a different count. Twenty-eight tons on the barge. Three tons could support the twelve cooks and coalition guards through the next week. Twenty-five tons divided by the requisition weights could return something close to what each village had supplied. The tow route to all five would cost six days. Imperial pursuit would cost more.

“We return it,” he said.

Silence met the order.

Saret planted both hands on the crate. “We have nine days of grain if every town gives what it promised. Seven if the bridge refugees join us. You want to surrender twenty-five tons to villages that may be occupied before we arrive.”

“They already paid for this grain.”

“We are fighting the people who stole it.”

“With their food.”

Vei sat beside the quenched seal, rubbing stiffness from her wrist. “The loaves may keep the ration bond alive if villagers eat from the same oath grain.”

“Then every loaf gets destroyed or reworked unbound,” Teren said. “Whole grain goes back under local custody. The five villages decide how to bake it.”

Saret lowered his voice. “Captain, mercy is expensive.”

“So is recruitment.”

There it stood: the part of his thinking he trusted too readily. He could convert a moral debt into routes, days, and allies, then call the answer clean because the

columns balanced. Returning the grain remained right even if no village joined them. He needed to say that before his arithmetic made virtue look profitable.

"We return it if they close their gates to us," Teren said. "We return it if they curse us. Mark three tons for our crews because we captured the barge and must deliver the rest. Record every measure. If Mava calls that theft, I'll answer her."

The order changed the warehouse. Fighters stopped seeing provisions and started seeing five deliveries. Saret cursed once, then divided the wax tablets. Guild clerks brought clean seals without hearth-salt. The black-scored ration loaves went into soak pits, where water would ruin them before anyone could swallow an active mark. Nothing useful vanished: after the seal residue died, the mash would feed pigs.

Division took longer than seizure. Imperial sacks followed a forty-measure standard, but three had split during the boarding and seven carried damp along their lower seams. Teren would not let a village receive the rotten share merely because its allotment fell last. He ordered every damaged sack opened, the dry grain winnowed onto sailcloth, and the damp grain spread in the warehouse loft where brine heat could reach it without touching salt. Each of the five piles received the same proportion of loss. Saret kept the calculation on a wax tablet while two village factors watched his stylus.

At Dovet Bank's pile, a guild weigher found the imperial bronze measure shaved beneath its rim. What the manifest called forty measures amounted to thirty-eight and a little husk. Teren had seen dishonest merchant cups before, but this one carried the Hall stamp. He made them test all four official measures from the barge. Three cheated by the same amount.

"Count by weight," he said. "Use Ulsor stones."

"That delays us until midnight," Saret replied.

"It delayed those villages all winter. We can afford one night."

Teams lifted each sack onto a beam scale. Teren recorded tare weight for cloth, cord, wax, and the grain dust trapped in the seams. His ankle swelled while he stood at the table, so he moved to a low stool and kept counting. Nobody mistook sitting for rest. By the time darkness covered the canal, the promised twenty-five tons had diminished by spoilage and false measure to twenty-three tons, six hundredweight. He divided the shortfall across all five allotments, then assigned coalition grain from their three-ton share to make each village whole under the honest measure.

That choice left his own force with less than two tons.

Vei read the final columns. "You said three."

"I said they would receive what the tablets claimed the barge carried."

"You are correcting an imperial fraud with coalition food."

"Yes."

“Write that beside your name. Don’t let the numbers make it look accidental.”

Teren pressed his sign into the wax. The note named his decision and the precise grain removed from coalition stores. A future council could accuse him from an honest record. That felt better than leaving a clean column over a concealed theft.

Before sealing the village stacks, they added copies of the seat annex between paired clay tiles. Each copy named the weighting but excluded instructions for waking the bond. The villages needed proof, not a reusable weapon. Vei marked the tiles with vinegar so any later alteration would cloud the writing. One set remained with Mava, another with Teren, and five traveled with the restitution loads.

The captives received ordinary barley from an Ulsor oven whose oath had never entered the imperial seal. Orel smelled the bowl before he ate. Teren understood the hesitation: after learning what bread could conceal, even hunger needed evidence. Vei broke her own portion from the same loaf and swallowed first, without ember or declared seat.

Only then did Orel eat.

Orel watched the work. “You’ll lose Halvek before you reach it.”

“Maybe.”

“The Grand Provisioner will burn what you return.”

“Maybe.”

“You command by maybes?”

Teren tied Dovet Bank’s tablet to its first stack. “I command what we do, not what it guarantees.”

Before dusk, news of the capture had crossed the canal faster than the redistributed cargo. Two river-town boats arrived under unpainted sails. One came from Lorn Steps, the other from Vale Senn. Their elders had seen village children wake with marching cramps after army meal bells. Neither town had promised the coalition more than shelter.

Now Lorn Steps offered sixteen rowers and two shallow craft. Vale Senn offered its north granary key, provided no army table ever touched the stores.

Teren accepted both under written conditions. He did not call it victory.

The barge left Ulsor divided into five protected allotments, each under a local oven mark uncovered from imperial wax. Their coalition column followed with less than two tons instead of twenty-eight. Six days had disappeared from Teren’s campaign board. In exchange, two river towns rowed beside them, and Captain Orel Tas sat under guard watching soldiers’ bread travel back toward the bodies that had carried its cost.

Chapter 12 — Twelve Recipes for Refusal

Dima dropped the first ash-bread into the fire and made twelve cooks watch it burn.

The little barley cake blackened along its scored edge, curled, and opened a seam that breathed fenugreek smoke. Nobody reached for it. Each cook stood behind a separate salt line in the lower guild kitchen, where the ovens faced one another across a floor tiled with old brine marks. Savra had spent dawn inspecting those lines. Dima had spent it hiding mistakes in them.

“Why?” Hesh asked.

“Because you let me name the diners after I lit the ember,” Dima said.

“You named all twelve.”

“I named twelve people. I did not name myself.”

Nerin looked from the burning bread to Dima’s crooked right hand. “You weren’t going to eat.”

“I was going to teach.”

“That’s outside the bond.”

Dima smiled without warmth. “Then stop me.”

Hesh kicked salt across the nearest fire bed. The origin ember hissed under the spill. Nerin used a wet cloth to lift the cake without breaking it, preserving the seal long enough for Savra to inspect. A third cook opened the flue so smoke drew away from the group.

“Correct result,” Savra said. “Poor order. If the cake had reached a mouth, which action would have severed first?”

“The salt,” Hesh answered.

“The ember,” said Nerin.

“Neither,” Dima said. “You prepare an open share before disturbing a live table. Otherwise recoil chooses for you.”

Savra lifted the cake with iron tongs. Dima had scored thirteen tiny seats into the crust, twelve in a ring and one beneath the fold where the dough had curled. The hidden mark belonged to no name. In an imperial field kitchen, a clerk could fill it later from an oath list.

Training had begun the morning after the unbound meal. Mava permitted two days, four guild kitchens, and enough black salt for six demonstrations. She issued none of it to Savra directly. Two clerks measured each pinch into Dima’s left palm, recorded the use, and collected the ash. Twelve cooks attended: Hesh of the western pans; Nerin from Kelar; three Ulsori fish and barley cooks; a canal-rice baker; two Free Granary camp cooks; a terrace-oil keeper from Tal Jes; a potter

who fired seal clay; a refugee elder who knew chickpea ovens; and Dima herself.

Savra occupied the thirteenth work place. Under the rule they were building, the cook takes a seat. Instruction did not excuse her.

“Start again,” she said.

This time Hesh read the list before fuel touched tinder. Thirteen named seats. Equal weight. Heat burden from one hand held above steam for five breaths. Duration ten minutes after the first swallowed bite. Severance by scattering an individual salt line, followed by transfer into a declared open cup. Source ember from Hesh’s household pan, ash witnessed by Mava’s clerk. Food: barley ash-bread, one cake divided into thirteen visible pieces.

Dima interrupted him twice. “Whose hand?”

“Mine.”

“Which hand?”

“Left.”

“Say it.”

He did. A diner could not weigh a cost if the cook hid its shape behind a general word.

Savra watched the dough rather than Hesh’s face. He had mixed it too dry from fear that softer bread would blur the score marks. She added no water. Correction belonged to the person carrying the fire. When the cake came off the tile, its edge cracked and two portions threatened to split.

Hesh swore.

“Name the change,” Savra told him.

“Two pieces smaller. I can remake it.”

“Or alter the weight before anyone eats.”

He recalculated aloud. The two smaller portions would receive no special burden because food quantity did not determine magical weighting once the seat marks and salt line had been fixed. Yet smaller bites digested sooner, shortening those diners’ exposure. Hesh extended the dough with two unbound crumbs baked on cold tile, equalizing digestion without changing the table.

Thirteen people ate. Warmth divided across their left palms, mild and undeniable. At the fourth minute the canal-rice baker scattered her salt.

Nerin slid an empty cup into the gap before the last crystals separated. Recoil entered the open seat as heat without a body. The cup’s water steamed. No diner felt the departing share.

“That cup cannot suffer,” Mava said from the doorway.

“No,” Savra replied. “It can hold heat briefly. Not wounds. Not hunger. Not exhaustion beyond what water or clay can embody.”

“So it does not solve your war.”

“It solves one hand leaving one small lesson.”

Mava nodded once. She had no patience for promises enlarged beyond their vessel.

The second exercise used salt-baked river fish. It failed more dangerously.

Reed-hatted Pava built the table from six diners instead of thirteen. Her fish carried an Ulsor ember; sour-plum broth accelerated transfer; a skin of sesame oil should have delayed onset until every diner finished the first mouthful. She named stomach warmth as the shared state, equal weight, fifteen-minute duration. Dima sat at her right. Savra watched from the opposite seat after adding her own name to the list.

Pava poured the oil too early. It clung to the hot bowl rather than spreading over the cooling broth. The first serving carried almost none. The last held a shining layer.

Savra saw it but did not stop the service. The declared burden remained small, and Pava needed to feel what uneven onset did before she trusted a written rule.

Hesh swallowed first. Nothing moved. Nerin swallowed second. Still nothing. By the time the sixth diner lifted her spoon, Pava’s face flushed and Hesh’s lips had gone pale.

“Unequal,” Nerin said.

“Source?” Dima asked.

“Pava’s stomach warmth.”

“Wrong. Look at Hesh.”

The oil delay had reversed across the bowl. Hesh’s nearly oil-free portion woke the souring immediately, drawing warmth out of him before Pava’s heavy-oil serving joined the table. Conservation held, but timing turned equal weights into a temporary theft.

Pava reached for the seal.

Dima caught her wrist with her left hand. Her right could not close firmly enough. “Prepare the landing before you cut the rope.”

Three cooks moved. Nerin placed warm stones inside two open clay cups. Hesh named his seat for severance. Savra stirred the remaining oily broth to distribute its delay and swallowed one measured spoon, not to add a new rule but to bring the late portion awake. Only then did Dima score through Hesh’s salt line with the blunt back of her adapted knife.

Heat jumped into the stones. Pava’s flush eased. Hesh bent over the table, breathing until his own warmth returned to his hands.

“What failed?” Savra asked.

“My pour,” Pava said.

“More exactly.”

“I treated equal weight as equal timing.”

“Write that into your recipe.”

Pava wiped her mouth. “We don’t write recipes for mistakes.”

“Then you write instructions that create them.”

By midday the kitchen wall held twelve clay tablets, each beginning with a refusal. Pava’s read: No fish table begins until the oil has covered every serving. Hesh’s read: No ash-bread enters flame before the cook’s name enters the list. Nerin’s required each hidden fold to be broken open in front of diners. The potter’s required seals to carry a maker’s countermark visible under vinegar steam. Dima’s required a prepared landing vessel before any severance.

Savra added no tablet of her own. Her rules had governed too many people from walls they never saw.

After the failed fish table, they moved to the largest oven room for nested tables. Three local circles took shape on the floor: four Ulsori cooks behind white salt, four river cooks behind gray canal salt, and four camp cooks behind coarse red salt from Tal Jes. Each circle held a separate ember and separate food. Barley porridge carried warmth in Ulsor. Rice cakes carried fatigue in the river circle. Pepper-oil chickpeas carried the ache of holding a squat in the camp circle.

A broad outer line enclosed all three. It did not merge them. Its purpose allowed a declared share to move between circles only when both sending and receiving cooks opened matching gates in their salt.

“Nested tables,” Nerin said. “Small fires inside one boundary.”

“Not one authority,” Savra corrected. “Three authorities agreeing on one passage.”

Dima took the Ulsor cook’s seat. Savra sat inside the river circle. Hesh joined the camp cooks. Each group read its list independently. Nobody in the outer ring gained power to rename an inner seat.

The first transfer moved warmth. Ulsor opened one gate; the river circle opened its matching place. Heat left Dima’s palm and entered Savra’s, distributed among four rice-cake diners. The camp circle felt nothing.

Next came fatigue. Savra had held a grain sack at shoulder height for twelve breaths before eating. The river cook opened outward, but Hesh kept the camp gate closed.

“I refuse it,” he said.

No magical pressure forced his salt apart. Fatigue remained among the four river diners, Savra included. Her shoulders trembled under a weight no longer present.

“Reason?” asked the camp cook.

"Our people need steady legs for tonight's watch."

"That is enough," Savra said.

A refusal did not need moral grandeur. It needed effect.

On the third transfer both gates opened. The squat ache moved from the camp circle into Ulsor warmth, one burden crossing each direction under measured weights. Dima's injured right hand received no special exemption; they had listed only thigh ache and palm warmth, so her old damage stayed hers. Hearthbinding could not infer kindness. A recipe either named a state or left it alone.

Mava's clerks tested the outer line with vinegar brushes. No concealed crossing appeared. Then Dima struck the side of a salt jar with her knife.

The jar broke. Black grains spilled under the outer line from a channel hidden in its base.

Three cooks moved toward their seals. Four moved toward the fires. Nerin froze.

"Name what you know," Savra said.

"Unknown source salt," Nerin answered. "Crossing beneath all circles. No seat marks visible."

"First action?"

"Stop eating. Keep embers alive. Prepare open weights."

Her voice steadied as the sequence gave fear work to do.

This hidden-seal drill carried no live burden beyond the states already declared. Still, abrupt destruction could have thrown those states across remaining diners. The cooks set warmed water for heat, weighted hanging slings for muscular exertion, and three volunteers for fatigue. Every volunteer named a limit. Dima tested the black grains with sour plum; imperial wax rose purple around them, revealing a buried line aimed at the Ulsor circle.

Pava cut the buried channel at two places instead of breaking the central seal. Hesh closed the camp gate. Savra and the river cooks widened their declared fatigue share for three breaths while Dima lifted the compromised Ulsor ember into a tray of its own ash. The hidden route died in sections. Recoil arrived as a manageable pulse: hot palms, shaking thighs, one wave of sleepiness.

Nerin remained still until it passed. Shame tightened her face.

"You stopped," Dima said.

"I failed."

"You named the hazard while the rest of us reached for tools. Next time your hands will follow your mouth."

Dima held out the adapted knife. Nerin took it and practiced the two cuts on cold salt until the motion belonged to her muscles. No table could transfer that skill. Repetition had to do the work.

During the final afternoon, each cook revised a local dish for defensive use.

Hesh made barley wafers that showed hidden scoring when snapped. Pava's fish broth separated suspect oil into visible rings. Nerin baked chickpea cakes around removable personal salt cups. The canal baker used mustard pickle to reveal imperial wax. Terrace pepper oil made unauthorized crossings sting the tongue before bodily transfer deepened. Dima designed a one-handed severance board with grooves that held a seal steady beneath a broad knife.

Testing the recipes required more than tasting. The potter, Sela Vorn, fired six false seals from the same clay and mixed iron filings into two. When heated, ordinary clay expanded evenly; filings made a seal grip its wax lining and resist a clean break. Her refusal tablet required diners to strike every seal cold against a bronze tuning plate. Pure clay answered with a high ring. Tampered clay gave a short, dead note. No magic carried the warning. Material craft did.

Canal baker Omin worked beside her with three jars of mustard stems. He warmed imperial wax under vinegar steam, then brushed each jar's pickle liquor across the softened surface. Two seals showed their written seats in purple threads. The third stayed blank.

"Safe?" Omin asked.

Savra smelled the brush. The blank wax held too much oil. "No. The oil kept the vinegar out."

He changed the order, dusting the wax with barley ash before brushing it. Ash drank the surface oil; purple script rose beneath. Omin added the step to his tablet and crossed out the word clear. A seal that revealed nothing had not proved innocence.

The refugee elder, Arda Men, distrusted personal salt cups because thin clay shattered during travel. She formed hers from chickpea dough baked hard around a pinch of salt. A diner could crush the edible cup underfoot, but rain or hungry children might damage it before a table began. Nerin suggested enclosing each one in a pierced nutshell. Arda refused because Kelar kitchens could not depend on imported nuts. She stitched little holders from reed and marked each with the diner's name in flour paste.

Their argument lasted through two batches. Neither woman softened her standard. The final design used materials a refugee line already possessed: reed, dough, salt, and flour. Savra wrote nothing for them. Local disagreement had produced a better tool than her intervention would have.

At the camp table, Vei tested a lentil paste meant to slow repeated ration bonds. Oil delayed transfer, but soldiers might eat another stamped loaf before the first bond died. She added coarse husk that lengthened digestion and bitter fenugreek that changed under biased weighting. The herb grew metallic when one hidden practice seat received twice the fatigue of the others. Every cook tasted the shift.

"Warning, not protection," Vei said.

"Good," Savra replied. "Call it what it can do."

Hesh objected to any recipe that depended on a trained palate. He crumbled one of his barley wafers over the paste. A concealed line caused the fragments to draw into a wet clump around the weighted seat mark. The effect could be seen by a child who had never tasted fenugreek. Vei altered her tablet to use both signs where barley remained available and the herb alone where it did not.

Dima's board received the harshest trial. Mava ordered a live goat-blood heat bag set beyond the wall, carrying warmth as an embodied state without placing an animal inside their eating circle. The cooks woke a six-seat practice bond, then locked the seal into Dima's wooden grooves. With her left hand she turned the broad knife. Her right palm held the board through a leather strap rather than finger grip. The first cut stopped short because the blade met grit.

Pain rose in all six palms as the delayed heat gathered. Dima reversed the board, used its second groove, and finished two sectional cuts before anyone touched the origin ember. Prepared cups took the first recoil. The remaining heat spread across declared diners for three breaths, then ended when Hesh buried the ember in its own ash.

Dima examined the nick in her blade. "A field knife dulls. Add two cutting grooves and require a second edge."

Sela burned that correction into the board itself. A tool used under panic could not depend on a tablet staying close.

By late afternoon, the floor had become a map of practical limits. Dry regions could not rely on open water cups. Canal settlements could. Refugee lines needed disposable seals because custody changed every hour. River barges needed weighted jars that would not spill during recoil. Terrace kitchens needed oil measures narrow enough to show delay. Twelve solutions remained separate because twelve conditions truly differed.

The twelve recipes shared no flavor, vessel, or fuel. They shared disclosure: source, names, weights, duration, severance, recoil provision, and the cook inside the list.

A rider reached the guild gate before the tablets had dried. His mule carried foam under its harness, and white grain dust covered his sandals. Teren's mark closed the message tube.

Savra read standing beside the ash oven. Imperial columns had turned toward the Halvek granaries. Storehouse guards reported army ovens traveling in advance. If Halvek fell, the coalition would lose the largest grain reserve west of Namarra. If it held, the empire's southern road would starve.

"How long?" Mava asked.

"Three days before their main force. Less for the ovens."

Hesh looked at the tablets. "You trained us to refuse tables. Now you want us at a battle."

"I want you where seals will be hidden," Savra said. "Whether you go belongs to you."

Pava wrapped her fish tablet in oilcloth. Nerin packed the severance cups. One after another, the cooks named where they would serve: gate kitchen, field tents, refugee line, granary yard, river landing. None offered to build a table that made fighters stronger.

At sunset they left Ulsor by separate roads, carrying twelve recipes for refusal under identical rules. Savra traveled toward Halvek with Dima and the unlit seal tray between them. Behind the city wall, thirteen places in the training kitchen stood empty, each salt line broken by the person who had sat inside it.

Chapter 13 — The Battle of Empty Bowls

Teren measured the Halvek granaries against sunrise and found twenty minutes in which an army might still behave like thieves instead of executioners.

The town occupied a shelf above three irrigation channels. Mud-brick walls enclosed the houses, while the grain compound stood outside the eastern gate behind its own low stone barrier. Twelve domed storehouses rose from the yard, each limewashed against insects and capped with a clay vent. Enough winter barley, millet, and rice waited inside to feed the western coalition for five months. Enough also to keep Rován's southern columns marching until Equinox.

Imperial troops had reached Halvek two days before Teren. They held the east gate, two watchtowers, and the granary roofs. Their cookfires smoked behind the northern wall where townspeople could not see them. No siege engines had arrived. Captain Orel Tas estimated three hundred soldiers, perhaps another hundred levy spears.

"Estimate?" Teren asked him in the predawn ditch.

Orel's wrists remained tied, though the rope ran long enough for him to crouch beside the map. "The road carries ten companies. They would leave three at the stores and divide the rest between crossings."

"You captains all count alike?"

"We eat from the same allotment tables." Orel looked toward the unseen smoke. "Or we did."

Teren had not offered him freedom for information. Orel had not asked. The captured officer understood that testimony might keep bodies alive without clearing his own place in the system.

Savra knelt opposite them with a bowl of damp ash. She drew the compound as a cook saw it: fires, ventilation, food routes, possible seal chambers. "If their ovens stand here, behind the north wall, smoke will cross the town before it reaches soldiers on the east roofs."

"Does that matter?" Saret asked.

"It tells me the ovens were placed for fuel shelter, not fast service. Rations came out last night. Any bond they carry may remain active until midday."

Teren shifted weight off his left ankle. Six days spent returning grain had cost him the first approach to Halvek, but two river towns now supplied shallow boats for the lower channel. His force held four hundred fighters, eighty town levies who had slipped out before imperial closure, twelve cooks distributed among aid stations, and thirty-seven wagons with less than a week of grain. He needed the stores. Need did not alter the rules they had just taught.

The plan avoided the houses. River crews would enter through the middle

irrigation channel, lift the compound's south gate from inside, and admit Teren's main force. Archers would suppress the granary roofs with padded shafts and smoke pots. Nobody would loose flame above grain. Savra's cooks would inspect captured ovens before any soldier ate. Halvek levies would open the town gate only after the store yard had fallen.

"Civilians remain in three refuge halls," said Naro, the Halvek miller commanding the local levies. He marked them on Teren's board: bathhouse, southern shrine, old press yard. "The empire told families they would be safer together."

Savra's head lifted. "Together near food?"

"The halls have communal kitchens."

"How many ate last night?"

"All of them. The soldiers issued barley."

Cold moved through Teren before the air had changed. "Marked loaves?"

Naro shook his head. "Porridge from town pots."

"That can still carry oath grain," Savra said. "We cannot assume a table without evidence."

Neither could they wait. Imperial reinforcements would reach the northern road by noon.

Teren ordered one change: no stabbing blows against roof soldiers until Savra inspected the first captured ration. Hooks, nets, shields, and surrender calls first. Saret disliked the restriction. He repeated it down the line anyway.

At sunrise the channel boats began moving beneath reed mats.

Water reached Teren's waist when he entered with the second group. Cold tightened his ankle and made the old crushed bones feel packed with grit. Ahead, rowers used hands against the channel wall to guide their boats without splashing. The granary barrier rose twelve feet above them. Its drain grille had lost two bars during the night to Halvek children carrying files under their shirts.

The first boat passed through. Then the second. Teren followed Saret into a culvert that smelled of wet grain and rat dung. Someone above called the dawn measure. Bronze clappers sounded from the store yard, three slow strikes.

Army meal bells answered from behind the town wall.

A shudder ran through Orel, who came under guard at the rear. "They renewed the ration table."

The culvert opened beneath a stone trough. Teren climbed out and saw imperial soldiers eating on the roofs. Each held half a white loaf. Black scoring divided the crust.

"Now," he said.

The south gate rose. Coalition fighters poured into the yard behind hide shields.

Archers sent padded arrows upward. One roof guard toppled from surprise rather than injury. A smoke pot burst against limewash, covering the western dome in bitter gray.

Teren ran toward the gate winch. His first task involved access, not enemies. He cut the retaining cord, put six people on the wheel, and watched the heavy doors spread wide enough for the main force. Saret's units entered in four columns, each turning toward its assigned storehouse.

Imperial resistance stiffened at the central scales. Soldiers formed behind grain carts with short spears. A lieutenant shouted that Halvek stores belonged to the Hall of Measures. Naro answered by holding up the town's granary key.

No one heard the next words. Shields met. Hooks dragged at spear shafts. Teren struck a soldier's wrist with the flat of his blade.

A scream rose behind the town wall.

It came faintly through mud brick, one high voice cut short. Teren froze long enough for the soldier to hit his shoulder. The blow spun him against a cart.

Saret drove a shield between them. "Move."

Teren recovered and looked toward Savra. She had heard it. Her face carried the stillness she used when a pot changed taste before anyone else noticed.

Another coalition fighter hooked a soldier's knee. The man fell hard on the stones. Beyond the wall, several people cried out together.

"Stop striking!" Savra shouted.

The order traveled poorly in battle. Metal and wood filled the yard with their own language. On the eastern roof, an imperial archer shot into Teren's third column. A Free Granary woman took the arrow through her upper arm. Her brother loosed a pointed shaft back. It entered the archer's thigh.

From the refuge halls came a surge of screams.

Teren climbed onto a grain cart. "Shields only! Pin them. No wounds."

His nearest units obeyed. Farther east, two people had already reached the roof ladder. A soldier kicked one in the face. The other drove a knife up under his boot. Every injury produced its answer inside town: a child's shriek, an old man bellowing, women calling names through walls.

Imperial soldiers heard it too. Some looked toward the houses with confusion. Others used the advantage. The lieutenant pushed forward, knowing Teren's people had stopped cutting.

Savra reached the nearest dead cookfire, a shallow iron tray beside the scales. She scraped ash into her palm, smelled it, and spat into the dust. "No source ember. Service point only."

"North wall," Teren said.

Getting there required crossing the central yard while refusing the ordinary

means of battle. Teren ordered two shield lines locked into a wedge. They advanced by pressure, crowding spear points upward and forcing soldiers back without piercing. Every step cost bodies. A shield edge broke Saret's lip. Teren's bad ankle turned on loose millet and sent pain up his calf. He stayed upright by gripping a cart rail.

At the third granary, Naro's levies opened a side lane. Civilians appeared atop the inner wall, waving cloths. One woman held a wooden bowl above her head. Empty.

"Don't hit them!" she screamed. "Whatever you do, don't hit them."

Teren saw blood on her cheek with no cut in her skin.

The wedge reached the north passage. Behind it, built into a disused oil house, six imperial ovens burned beneath copper hoods. Army bakers worked under guard. Ration loaves moved from cooling boards into wicker hampers while a seal clerk pressed black lines into each crust.

Dima's trainees entered behind Savra. Hesh closed the passage with a shield team. Nerin seized the nearest hamper and broke one loaf over her barley wafer. The crumbs clumped around five marks hidden inside the central score.

"Civil seats," she said.

Savra cut a loaf into its layers. "More than five. Those marks branch."

A baker tried to run. Dima tripped him with the end of her severance board and pinned his sleeve beneath her left knee. "How many halls?"

"I bake what they stamp."

"Which grain?"

"Halvek barley."

Orel stepped into the oven house under guard. The imperial lieutenant saw him and called him traitor.

"Answer the healer," Orel said to the baker.

"Three refuge halls," the man gasped. "Every household bowl. We were told the distribution would prevent panic."

Savra found the live seal beneath the largest oven. It had been mortared into the floor, a black ceramic cylinder surrounded by nine salt channels. Three channels ran west toward the refuge halls. Six ran east and south toward soldier companies. The civilian lines carried no names, only household bowl marks copied from Halvek's grain register.

"The town ate porridge from registered bowls," Savra said. "That placed them inside the seal. Soldiers eat the ration loaves. Wounds move west."

"How much?" Teren asked.

She brushed sour plum over the exposed channels. Purple weights surfaced. "Four civilian shares to one military share."

The number struck harder than any spear. Every wound inflicted on a soldier divided mostly among families behind the wall. Four parts carried west, one stayed with the body wearing armor.

Saret wiped blood from his mouth. "Sever it."

"If I cut the town lines, recoil returns their accumulated share across the soldiers," Savra said. "That might end the fight. It might also kill everyone holding a burden already."

"Then extinguish the ember."

"Same danger, less control."

Teren looked through the oven-house doorway. His people held nine of twelve granaries. Imperial defenders had fallen back to three roofs and the east wall. By any field count, victory stood close. Another push would secure the stores. Another push would injure Halvek through every body his fighters struck.

"How long until digestion ends it?"

"Last porridge may bind the households six hours. Ration loaves keep the soldiers active until midday if they eat only once."

"They can eat again."

"Yes."

From outside came the sound of wood breaking. An imperial squad had overturned a scale cart into the shield line. Teren heard three impacts, then cries within the town.

Naro gripped the oven door. "My wife and sons are in the bathhouse."

"Can you evacuate them without feeding anyone?" Teren asked.

"The gates are barred from inside. Imperial guards hold the streets."

Saret's eyes stayed on Teren. "We can take the east gate in ten minutes."

"At what cost?"

"Less than leaving these stores to Rován."

That answer used Teren's own language. He had turned people into necessary columns often enough to recognize the sound.

Captain Orel approached the seal without crossing its salt. "Order the town to empty the bowls."

Savra looked at him.

"Company procedure," he said. "A registered vessel carries the household seat while the oath grain remains in digestion. Break the bowl and you weaken the encoded identity. Not enough to sever, but enough to reduce the precision."

"You knew that?" Teren asked.

"I knew soldiers were told to protect registered bowls during occupation. I did not know why."

Savra considered the seal. "He may be right. The household mark anchors through the vessel pattern. Breaking bowls would blur individual routes into the hall's common line. Burden still reaches civilians, but spread wider."

Teren gave Naro the order. Halvek levies along the wall began shouting toward the refuge halls: empty every bowl, smash the registered pottery, eat nothing from army grain.

At first no answer came. Then clay broke inside the town.

One impact, another, a scatter of hard cracks. The sound spread from the bathhouse to the shrine and press yard. Families smashed cooking bowls, storage bowls, cups stamped for tax measures, dishes inherited through marriages. Imperial administration had made each vessel an address. Halvek destroyed its own kitchens to become harder to wound.

The change reached the oven seal. Purple lines blurred beneath Savra's plum wash. A soldier stumbled outside after taking a shield blow. Instead of one distant scream, a low groan moved across many voices.

"Reduced," Savra said. "Not ended."

Teren climbed the oil-house step and looked over the yard. Nine granaries in coalition hands. The south gate open. His standards above the scales. Imperial troops compressed against the eastern quarter.

"Signal withdrawal," he said.

Saret stared at him. "We have the compound."

"We cannot hold it without fighting soldiers tied to the town."

"We came for five months of grain."

"And we leave before victory turns every sack into a reason to keep hitting them."

Saret's jaw worked. He raised the red withdrawal pennant.

Horn calls sounded across the compound: two low, one high. Confusion answered. Fighters on the roofs had to abandon positions they had bled to gain. Wagon crews who had reached the store doors began shouting that the grain stood open. One unit refused to move until Teren crossed the yard and gave the order himself.

The eastern granary roof posed the first problem. Nine coalition archers occupied it behind a lime parapet, and the ladder below had splintered during the assault. Imperial soldiers held the stairs inside. Teren sent a rope team along the roofline while Saret formed shields beneath them. Each archer descended with bow unstrung and wounded arm strapped before the next person moved. Padded enemy shafts struck the shields. A pointed arrow would have pierced the formation, but Captain Varo had not yet changed ammunition. Teren wondered whether restraint or shortage had made that decision and found he did not care which kept people alive.

At the scales, three Halvek levies refused to abandon the town key. Naro had to take it from his cousin's hand. The bronze teeth carried their fathers' tool marks, older than Namarra's occupation. Leaving the lock open felt to them like surrendering the stores by choice.

"We take the key," Naro said. "They keep a door without a town."

His cousin struck the grain cart once with an open palm, then joined the withdrawal.

A wounded imperial soldier lay between the shield lines with a crushed pelvis. Every attempt to lift him sent a corresponding cry from the southern shrine. Dima crouched beside him, assessed the angle, and ordered a door pulled from the oil house. Coalition bearers carried him flat. The decision slowed the center column by forty breaths and saved at least one hidden civilian from repeated movement pain.

"Why take him?" asked the young fighter beside Teren.

"Because leaving him for his comrades to drag still hurts the town," Teren said. "And because he is wounded."

Those reasons did not need to compete.

Storehouse crews began closing vents as they left. If imperial troops fired the grain, sealed domes might slow flame. Saret ordered them onward, then countermanded himself when he saw oil jars beside the doors. Four people rolled the jars into the central trough and cracked them under water. Another team scattered oven wood beyond the compound wall. They could not remove every means of burning, but they did not have to make destruction easy.

Near the south gate, a Free Granary standard had caught on the winch. Its bearer climbed back for it. Teren shouted him down.

"They'll display it as captured."

"Let them. Cloth costs less than your body."

The bearer cut the pole instead. Red fabric fell into trampled barley and disappeared beneath retreating feet.

Only then did Teren understand how the phrase would sound outside his own mouth: retreat before victory. Rivals would call it weakness. Hungry fighters would call it theft of what they had won. Halvek families might call it too late because the first blows had already reached them. None of those judgments changed the order. Command meant carrying the consequence after the horn, not pretending one clean reason had produced it.

"Carry wounded, not sacks," he told them.

A young fighter had already filled her cloak with barley. She looked at him as if he had betrayed the dead. "We won this."

"Put it down."

"My village has three days."

“So does Halvek.”

Her hands opened. Grain ran between her boots.

Withdrawal under an enemy’s gaze demanded more discipline than advance. Teren assigned the freshest shields to the rear and sent wounded through the channel gate first. Archers used smoke to hide movement without setting roofs alight. Naro’s levies remained long enough to relay bowl-breaking orders, then climbed ropes down the outer wall.

Imperial soldiers realized what was happening. Their lieutenant ordered a charge.

Orel stepped onto the passage threshold. “Captain Varo! Hold your line.”

The lieutenant faltered at hearing a superior officer among the enemy.

“You are a prisoner,” he called.

“Yes. You are still responsible for the civilians carrying your wounds. Hold.”

Varo could have ignored him. Instead he looked toward the town, where smashed pottery continued to ring. Perhaps he had not known. Perhaps he knew and understood that charging men who refused to strike would make the arrangement visible even to his own companies. He lowered his spear.

The pause bought four minutes.

At the south gate a frightened mule overturned an aid cart. Teren tried to lift the shaft and his left ankle failed beneath him. Pain drove him to one knee. Saret and Vei raised the cart while Dima pulled a wounded archer free. Teren stood again by locking his boot against a stone, but the joint had begun to swell beyond the leather.

“Get on the boat,” Saret said.

“Last unit first.”

“You can’t walk the culvert.”

“I can crawl it.”

He stayed until the final shield team reached the gate. Savra came after them, carrying no imperial seal. She had scored the exposed channels with vinegar and ash so any later investigator could read them, but breaking the cylinder remained too dangerous while civilians digested the porridge.

“What happens when the bond ends?” Teren asked.

“The soldiers keep their own wounds. Civilians retain whatever reached them. Nothing reverses simply because the table goes cold.”

No magic returned payment after the meal.

They entered the channel as imperial drums began above. Teren crawled through the grille with his left leg dragging. Behind him, Halvek’s compound remained intact. The twelve white domes stood against the noon sky, full of food they had chosen not to hold through civilian pain.

Coalition forces withdrew two miles to the reed flats. Their casualty count reached thirty-one wounded, four dead. Halvek's toll remained unknown. Runners from the refuge halls reported crushed fingers, spear cuts appearing on unbroken skin, two fractured legs, and one child who had stopped breathing after a roof guard fell. Dima sent healers back under white cloths.

The first healer returned with her white sleeve torn away. Imperial guards had admitted her to the bathhouse but barred her from the shrine. Halvek families accepted bandages and refused coalition food, afraid every loaf carried another seat. Dima ordered sacks opened in public, grain poured loose, and clay seals smashed before cooking. She tasted from each unbound pot with her own name written on a scrap beside it. Only six families accepted portions.

Naro came back carrying the dead child's registered bowl in two pieces. The fracture crossed a blue heron painted inside the rim. He placed both pieces before Teren without accusation.

"His mother wants to know which soldier fell," Naro said.

Teren could not answer. The battlefield gave him locations and units, not a line between one rooftop body and one child behind a wall. Hearthbinding conserved injury but erased accountability by dividing it across hidden routes.

"Then write that you do not know," Naro said. "Do not write battle loss."

Teren took a wax tablet from Saret. He recorded the child as an unnamed Halvek boy, death linked to an unidentified roof fall through the civilian table. The words lacked a name because nobody had yet given him one, not because the death belonged in a remainder column. Naro watched until the stylus stopped.

Teren lay beside the irrigation bank while Vei cut his swollen boot away. No bone had broken. The old injury had torn something deep along the outer ankle. He could stand with a staff, but not run.

Across the flat, fighters filled cooking lines without talking. They had expected grain porridge from captured stores. Their cooks boiled the last river rice instead. When portions were counted, several pots came up short. People sat holding empty bowls because nobody wanted to take a share from the wounded.

Smoke rose over Halvek near sunset.

At first Teren thought the imperial ovens had renewed. Then flame broke through the first granary vent. A second dome darkened. Fire traveled too quickly for accident, moving storehouse to storehouse along oil poured at the doors.

"They're burning it," Saret said.

The coalition watched five months of food become columns of sparks. Halvek townspeople formed bucket lines at the wall, but imperial guards kept the compound gate closed. Heat split limewash from the domes. Grain roared inside like dry rain.

Naro made no sound. His empty bowl rested upside down before him.

Teren understood the choice Rován's commanders had made. If the coalition would not seize grain through civilian wounds, the empire would deny it to everyone. The fire also destroyed the most visible evidence beneath the oven floor. By dawn only scorched channels and testimony would remain.

A signal rider arrived after dark carrying sheets printed in Halvek itself. Imperial presses had begun before the granaries burned. The proclamation named the day the Battle of Empty Bowls. It claimed Free Granary raiders attacked protected stores, wounded households through unlawful hearthbinding, and fled after loyal troops saved the town. Rován Dast promised emergency grain to every family that renewed its oath.

Saret crumpled one sheet. "They prepared the lie before we came."

"They prepared the table," Teren said. "The lie followed the same route."

He wanted to answer with numbers: nine granaries taken, thirty-one wounded, four dead, three refuge halls used as sinks. Numbers could prove sequence. They could not make Halvek families forget which army had arrived under Teren's standards when pain entered their bodies.

By midnight, refugees began leaving through the south gate. Some came to the coalition aid fires. More turned west without looking at them. Each carried food in cloth or bare hands because their registered vessels lay smashed.

Teren sat with his injured ankle bound to a willow splint and watched Dima distribute the last rice. No one rang a meal bell. Across the flats, hundreds of empty bowls reflected the granary fire until soot covered them. The coalition had retreated before victory, lost the Halvek granaries, and left Rován holding the story of who had struck first.

Chapter 14 — The List of Distant Hearths

Issen tasted Halvek at noon from a porcelain spoon painted with victorious wheat.

The first course held clarified chicken broth, white barley, and three drops of saffron oil. Court menus named it Granaries Preserved. Forty ministers watched Issen lift the spoon beneath the bronze scales of the Hall of Measures. Rován Dast sat at the long table's head, his hands folded beside an empty bread plate.

Safety required Issen to note bitterness, fever, rot, poison, and unlawful hearth residue. Ceremony required them to smile before speaking.

They swallowed.

Smoke touched the back of the tongue first. Not cooking smoke. Granary fire, dry and mineral, carried through barley that had never been close to Halvek. Under it came the bodily residue the cooks had failed to clarify away: bruised shoulders, a cut without a blade, one small chest struggling after impact. The sensations had thinned through distance and repeated service, but First Taster training made thin things legible.

"The course is safe," Issen said.

Applause moved around the table.

Their mouth had certified the absence of poison. Everyone present heard the presence of justice.

A minister from the southern roads raised his cup. "To loyal Halvek, defended against Free Granary violence."

Rován drank water. He had not eaten the broth.

The second course contained twelve little white loaves, each scored to resemble a closed granary. Issen broke one. Black hearth-salt marked no active bond, only a decorative line added after baking. The kitchen had learned restraint in presentation while the empire's proclamations did not.

"Does victory taste peaceful?" Rován asked when attendants moved between them.

Issen kept their answer inside ceremonial bounds. "It tastes of smoke and displaced injury, Grand Provisioner."

"Battle leaves both."

"Displacement leaves a direction."

His expression remained patient. "You are paid to identify hazards, Issen. Not to infer policy from seasoning."

"The body does not separate them for me."

"That limitation once made you useful."

Attendants removed the bread before Issen could examine the scoring again. At

the far service door, old Rel caught their eye. Rel had dressed tasting tables since before Issen entered the Hall at fourteen. The attendant's face showed no warning, only the careful vacancy of someone who had heard a dangerous exchange and intended to survive it.

After the banquet, Issen returned the silver tasting spoon, washed their mouth with salt water, and signed the public record. They wrote no poison detected. In the private residue column, accessible only to the First Taster and Grand Provisioner, they wrote smoke; transferred blunt trauma; divided laceration; juvenile breath distress. The stylus paused over source.

Officially, the source read Halvek rebel attack.

Issen wrote concealed seat structure likely and sealed the tablet before caution corrected them.

For eleven days they had copied provincial hearth initials from tasting menus. Menus did not publish seat lists, but imperial courses named ingredient origins in a code of prestige. River rice from one district appeared beside salt from another, while a black-salt notation in the margin indicated ash compatibility. Issen had learned to read absences: a province whose oil appeared without its grain had contributed a burden seat rather than flavor.

Their private list held eighty-nine names. The copper ledger stolen by Savra's coalition, if court reports spoke true, held ninety-seven. Rovan's clerks had moved the remaining information after the field-kitchen breach.

The Hall archives occupied three rooms below the public tasting chamber. Issen possessed access to the first, where menus and poison records slept in cedar boxes. The second held ration formulations. The third, called the Quiet Measure, admitted only the Grand Provisioner, chief sealwright, and archive attendant on duty.

Rel kept the keys that afternoon.

Issen waited until the victory table had demanded a fourth course. Bells summoned every senior attendant upstairs to carry sugared fruits shaped like Halvek bowls. Issen entered the menu archive, closed the door, and opened their tasting chain at its seventeenth link. The link contained the grain of black hearth-salt they had taken from the forbidden sample on Day 1.

Salt did not open locks. It rewrote nested arrangements when carried by a First Hearth. Here, without that ember, the grain offered only its ash signature. Issen pressed it into warm wax on the day's menu box, then compared the mark to wax residue along the locked door of the Quiet Measure.

Both carried the same capital ash.

The lock still required a key. Ceremony supplied one indirectly. Each First Taster's silver chain included a small fork for opening sealed poison packets. Issen filed its narrow tine against the sandstone beneath the washbasin, inserted it beside the top ward, and listened through their fingertips. Skills came from years

of opening delicate containers, not from the salt. After four attempts the first ward lifted. The second resisted until Issen used the tasting spoon's handle as tension. The door opened on air smelling of cedar, cold ash, and mouse droppings.

No alarm sounded. That frightened them more than a bell.

The Quiet Measure held shelves of ceramic cylinders. Each cylinder carried a provincial oven mark and a knotted cord showing current status. Issen recognized the ninety-seven marks the field ledger must have named. At the back stood three new cylinders painted with capital signs: North Public Oven, River Gate Bakery, and the Hall Charity Hearth. Those completed the count of one hundred fires, but not the list of distant sinks. Capital ovens served as sources and relay points.

Arrangement supplied part of the missing evidence. The cylinders did not stand alphabetically or by road. Clerks had grouped them according to bodily capacity. Blue cords indicated settlements expected to absorb cold and fatigue. Red cords marked pain and muscular injury. Yellow carried hunger. A cord braided from all three colors hung from Kelar's cylinder, though Issen had not yet read its label.

They worked shelf by shelf. Ulsor's official guild hearth did not appear, but two salt-pan labor ovens did. Eren Ford carried the communal-oven mark of a river town and a red cord tied with three extra receiving knots. Tal Jes occupied four terrace cylinders, each bound for heat as well as hunger. Halvek's three refuge halls had been added under one town index, the ink recent enough to shine.

Every entry implied preparation beyond the ceramic itself. Grain-oath samples had to be collected. Bowl patterns had to enter civic registers. Ash signatures had to travel to Namarra without going cold. Rován's plan did not depend on one ingenious supper. It depended on years of tax clerks, ration bakers, potters, road officers, and cooks performing ordinary duties without seeing the table those duties assembled.

Issen copied not only the hearth name but its cord colors and knot count. Their rice paper filled. They turned it sideways and wrote into the margins, reducing each settlement to initials only after copying the full name once. A mistaken letter could send a warning to the wrong oven and leave another village inside the bond.

At the forty-third cylinder, voices passed the archive door. Issen stopped breathing and held the paper against their inner wrist. Two clerks argued about fruit invoices, paused near the lock, then moved away. The interruption cost less than a minute but changed their hand. The next three names leaned left. Issen recopied them so no one in Ulsor would mistake haste for a different code.

The eighty-sixth cylinder came from an unnamed military colony whose public menu name had changed twice. Issen matched its oven mark to the old version in their private notes. The ninety-fourth belonged to a canal hospice. They made themselves copy that word in full. Calling it a civic hearth would have hidden who lay in its seats.

A bronze index plate hung above the shelf. Its columns read hearth,

contribution, receiving weight, final correction.

Issen copied quickly onto rice paper hidden inside their sleeve. Ninety-seven provincial names. Three capital civic ovens. Beside twelve hearths, a small hooked mark indicated heavy receiving weight. Beside one, the correction column held nine black dots and no upper limit.

The row read: Kelar Market Relief Oven, south refugee kitchen.

Issen knew that kitchen from casualty menus after the market sweep. Bitter fenugreek. Chickpea flour. A minor ration station, officially temporary. Yet the index made Kelar's refugee kitchen the final correction point for an entire continent's unresolved burden.

They checked the mark twice. Nine dots indicated progressive weighting. No upper line meant the system would keep routing imbalance there until bodies, digestion, or fire failed. Rován had not chosen Kelar because it possessed capacity. He had chosen people without secure household registers, people easy to count as a kitchen and difficult to count as deaths.

Issen's hand shook against the paper.

"You put the fork back crooked," Rel said from the doorway.

The old attendant held no guard bell. Their narrow shoulders blocked the exit more effectively than armor would have.

Issen folded the paper once. "How long have you known?"

"Known what?"

"That tasting certifies only the mouth they permit me to see."

Rel closed the door behind them. "Since before you wore the chain."

Anger arrived hot enough to taste as copper. "You trained me."

"I trained you not to die at fourteen."

"You taught me to bow after swallowing other people's injuries."

"I taught you where to stand so Rován saw an instrument, not a witness."

Issen looked at the shelf. "And what did you do with the years that bought?"

Rel's face changed then. Weariness entered it without performance. "Carried menus. Moved keys. Warned two tasters before you. One fled and vanished. One accused the Hall in public and recanted after her family ate from a locked table."

"That explains your fear."

"It does not excuse it."

The answer denied Issen the clean shape of condemnation. Rel had participated, survived, and named no virtue in either.

Footsteps crossed the outer archive.

Rel held out a hand. "Give me the salt grain. They inventory forbidden ash after every victory service."

Issen closed their fist around the chain link. "No."

"Then they will find its impression in the wax."

"They will find that anyway."

"Not if the wax box burns."

Rel moved past them, took the victory menu box from the first room, and set its corner to a lamp. Cedar caught slowly. Smoke would bring guards within moments.

Flame crept along the lid before taking the papers. Rel sorted two boxes away from it: childhood poison cases and the register of attendant injuries. Even while destroying evidence, they preserved records that might keep future workers from repeating a dosage error. Issen recognized the habit. Complicity did not erase care; care did not erase complicity.

"If the list reaches Ulsor, what will they do?" Rel asked.

"Warn the named kitchens. Break oath vessels. Stop eating registered grain if they can."

"And if panic starves them before Equinox?"

"Then the warning must carry methods, not only fear." Issen thought of the menu initials already sent, the potters who understood kiln flaws, and cooks they had never met. "They need to know which lines receive pain, hunger, cold, or fatigue. They need the weights."

Rel pushed the index copy toward the fire, then withdrew it. "Take the cord colors too."

"I have them."

For the first time, relief showed plainly in the attendant's face. It lasted one breath. Then Rel dropped the copy into flame and began coughing loudly enough to summon witnesses.

"South pottery court," the attendant said. "The Hall sends measure jars to Ulsor tomorrow. Blue cord means kiln breakage. Put your paper where inspectors expect shards."

"Why help now?"

"Because you wrote in the private column today." Rel fed another box to the flame. "A witness who remains private serves the archive. You made yourself expensive."

Issen left through the poison-sample corridor while Rel called the alarm.

The pottery court covered half an acre behind the Hall kitchens. Rows of storage jars stood under woven mats, each calibrated to Namarra's standard grain measure. Ulsor had ordered two hundred after discovering shaved imperial cups on a captured barge. The irony had passed through six administrative desks without injury.

Issen could not place raw paper inside a jar. Inspectors tapped every vessel and

checked each interior. Instead they went to the glazing shed, where apprentices painted calibration rings around unfired lids.

First Taster authority opened the door. "Victory-service contamination," Issen told the night apprentice. "I must inspect clay absorbency."

The apprentice bowed and retreated outside.

Issen ground the rice paper in a mortar with gum water until the writing disappeared into gray pulp. Destroying the visible list felt like repeating the Hall's crime, but the names remained as counted fibers. They divided the pulp into one hundred small strokes along the inner rims of ten lids, ten marks per lid. Each mark's position corresponded to a numbered column in the standard potters' glaze chart used across Ulsor.

Names required a second code. On the underside, Issen painted ordinary kiln tally strokes in groups matching the archive shelf order. The hooked heavy-receiver sign became a flaw mark. Kelar's nine dots entered the glaze as nine pinpricks around one lid's center.

Before the lids dried, Issen tested the code from the other side of the shed. They covered their rice-paper notes, selected the fourth lid, and read only glaze position, tally strokes, and flaw marks. The pattern yielded hearths thirty-one through forty. Two reversed because Issen had painted from the inside rim while imagining an outside view. They washed all ten strokes away and began that lid again.

Time narrowed with every correction. Night kiln workers crossed the court carrying wood. A watch clerk rang the water measure. Somewhere inside the Hall, the archive fire had brought coughing attendants into the corridors. Issen kept their brush slow. A code that reached Ulsor quickly but reconstructed falsely could condemn a hearth through warning the cooks did not need or silence where they did.

The second reading produced ten correct index positions. They tested the Kelar lid last. Nine pinpricks, progressive receiving. Hook mark, heavy correction. Shelf position ninety-seven among the provinces, followed by three capital relays. The result matched the destroyed paper.

Packing presented another problem. Standard measure lids nested face to face in straw sleeves, so wet gum marks could transfer. Issen dried them above a cooling kiln, keeping the heat below the point that would warp unfired clay. They placed each coded lid in a different sleeve and marked the sleeve cords with tiny knots showing reconstruction order. Ordinary inspectors would read the knots as packer counts. A Ulsori potter would read them as sequence.

One lid developed a hairline crack while cooling. It carried hearths sixty-one through seventy, including the Halvek refuge index. Issen could not remake the clay without an apprentice noticing. They painted the same code onto a rejected calibration ring and packed the ring among kiln spacers. The redundancy added weight that a careful clerk might detect, but omission would remove ten names.

They accepted the measurable risk.

No single lid carried a readable list. Together with the publicly available chart and the private menu initials Issen had already sent in harmless trade notes, the ceramic shipment would reconstruct all hundred intended hearths.

The Kelar lid needed protection from casual breakage. Issen wrapped it in wool and placed it among rejected shards at the base of crate seven. Blue cord marked the crate for kiln claims. A guild potter would open it before customs. Issen added a tasting-chain pattern in chalk beneath the slat, the sign Ulsori seal makers had begun watching for since reports of the hidden barge marks.

Wagon crews arrived before dawn. Issen remained in the shadow of the calibration kiln while teamsters checked axles, counted crates, and cursed the Hall's insistence on paired inventories. Rel did not appear.

At sunrise a clerk discovered that crate seven weighed three ounces more than its tablet claimed. He ordered it opened.

Issen stepped forward in full tasting robes. "Ceramic dust from that crate entered a victory sample. Opening it inside the court risks contamination of every vessel."

"What contamination?"

"Unknown until assay. That is why it travels sealed to the salt guilds."

The clerk did not want responsibility for poisoning imperial measure jars. He added a red caution mark beside the blue cord and waved the wagon through.

Ten lids passed beneath the Hall gate. The ceramic shipment turned west toward Ulsor with the list hidden inside its glaze.

Issen returned to their chamber and found the silver tasting chain laid straight across the desk. They had been wearing it when they left the pottery court.

Only then did they touch their throat. The chain there belonged to a ceremonial copy, lighter by one link. Someone had entered, exchanged it, and taken the black salt grain.

On the desk beside the chain rested the bronze index plate's hook-shaped receiving marker. No message accompanied it. None was needed.

The archive theft had been detected. The list had already left Namarra, and Issen remained inside the Hall with every door politely open. Beyond the chamber, measured footsteps stopped, waited through one full breath, and continued down the corridor.

Part III

Chapter 15 — What Savra Fed the War

Savra recognized her own correction marks in the glaze before the Ulsori potter finished laying out the ten lids.

A shallow hook meant increased receiving weight. Three pinpricks meant a progressive share. Nine meant the cook had expected the line to take whatever imbalance remained. Issen Mar had copied the Hall's notation into flaws an inspector would ignore, but the hand behind the original system belonged to Savra.

The open guild hall held no doors. Salt wind moved between its columns and lifted the blue cords from the ceramic shipment. Mava UI sat at the central table with Teren, Dima, twelve trained cooks, river-town elders, and six refugees from Halvek. More people filled the steps. Nobody had been searched for hearthseals because no food entered the gathering.

Sela Vorn turned the Kelar lid beneath the light. "Ninety-seven provincial marks. Three Namarra relays. This one carries final correction."

"Kelar Market Relief Oven," Nerin read from the decoded chart. Her voice thinned. "South refugee kitchen."

Someone behind Savra began to cry.

Dima did not look around. Her adapted knife lay sheathed at her belt, the broad handle built for a right hand that could no longer close properly. She watched Savra instead.

Teren rested his injured left ankle on a low stool. Halvek had put gray beneath his eyes. "You know the mark."

"Yes."

"How?"

Savra could have answered with technical language. Progressive correction, differential receiving weight, reserve capacity. Every phrase would make the design sound as if it had emerged from a cylinder rather than a person.

"I invented it," she said.

The wind pressed a lid cord against the table. Mava caught it with two fingers.

Savra stepped into the open center before anyone ordered her there. She had prepared explanations for ten years, each meant for a smaller room. None survived the sight of Halvek's refugees holding food in cloth because their bowls had become weapons.

"The system began eleven years ago," she said. "The empire's western army could not cross the Saltback road without losing half its marching days to heat,

blisters, and water sickness. Rován asked me to design a field table that spread those burdens across nine military columns. I called it the Nine-Salt March Table."

Mava's hand tightened on the cord.

Savra continued. "Each column carried its own ember and salt line. A tenth line corrected imbalance when one company climbed steeper ground or fought longer. I designed that correction to take no more than a soldier's declared double share. I required the reserve seats to rotate."

"Required where?" Hesh asked.

"In the master recipe."

"Could the soldiers read it?"

"No."

"Could the villages?"

"I was told there were no villages in it."

Hesh leaned back. "There is the sentence."

Savra let the contempt reach her. "Yes. That is where I usually place the lie I told myself."

No one interrupted again.

The army first used the table on the Nine-Salt campaign road. Savra traveled with the central oven for six weeks. She measured sweat, fever, joint pain, and sleep loss. Reports showed the correction line taking more than its cap. Rován's clerks blamed damaged salt. Savra altered the recipe twice to stabilize it. Both alterations made the hidden line more efficient.

She named the towns from memory. "Seven Wells. Orro Vale. Pel Reed. The hamlets along the north brine cut. Three caravan shelters whose names never entered Hall records."

A man from the back steps asked to speak. He had carried a kiln worker's badge into the hall, though half its clay rim had broken away. Mava recognized him as Jori Ul from Seven Wells and gave him the center without asking Savra's permission.

"My father woke with both feet raw," Jori said. "He had spent that week repairing roofs. No march. No boots. The Hall physician wrote salt fever and charged us for salve. My aunt took a mule's kick to the ribs while every mule in town stood tethered."

Savra remembered both entries. The annex had called them minor extremity abrasion and distributed blunt load. She said the names the records had omitted. "Peren Ul. Sava Deth."

Jori stared at her. "You know them?"

"I know the claims your town sent to the field office. The clerk copied injuries without people. I learned the names later from market rolls."

"Why?"

"I thought memory counted as witness."

"Did anyone hear it?"

"No."

He put the broken badge on the floor between them. "Then you made a private graveyard and called it work."

Savra bent, picked up nothing, and let the badge remain where he had placed it.

A woman from Pel Reed spoke next. During the campaign her milk had dried in three days because a cavalry unit's hunger entered the village ovens. Two infants were sent south to relatives. One survived. An old caravan cook described men waking drunk after an officer banquet, though their shelter had no wine. Each testimony attached a household to one of Savra's clean receiving columns.

The hall did not ask her to respond after every account. Silence now served listening rather than concealment, a distinction no one owed her credit for.

Mava stood. "My mother's people lived at Seven Wells."

"I know that now."

"When did you learn?"

"Near the end of the campaign. A child came to the field hospital with marching sores and no road dust. Then an old man arrived with a spear wound that had no opening in his skin. I opened the clerk's annex. The correction seats used village grain oaths."

"How many?"

"Fourteen registered ovens. More shelters through shared flour."

"And you broke the table?"

"No."

The word crossed the hall without shelter.

Savra had broken one relay line. Recoil hit two companies and three villages at once. Twenty-seven soldiers collapsed; the annex later listed eighty civilian injuries. She stopped because further severance without open capacity might have killed people already carrying shares. Rován took the master seal from her. The army completed the campaign using a revised copy.

"What did you do?" Dima asked.

"I left."

"Not that night."

"No. That night I stabilized the table."

"You kept the march alive."

"Yes."

Dima's right fingers moved against the knife sheath and failed to close. She

looked down at them, then back at Savra. "Did you tell the villages what had been done?"

"No."

"Did you publish the annex?"

"No."

"Did you name Rován?"

"No."

Savra's reasons arrived anyway. Guards at the ovens. Threats against assistants. The danger of recoil. Rován's promise to remove civilian grain. Her belief that she could correct the design from inside. Each reason held some truth. Together they had kept her useful until the conquest ended.

"I waited eleven days," she said. "Then I stole my knives and deserted. I hid for ten years. I cooked in kitchens where no one knew my rank. I told myself I was preventing the empire from using my skill again. Silence also prevented the harmed towns from using my testimony."

A Halvek woman on the steps held up two pieces of a blue-heron bowl. "Were our bowls in your first recipe?"

"No. Rován's cooks extended the method."

"But he learned the extension from you."

"Yes."

There lay the line Savra had refused to draw. Rován had chosen the seats. Clerks had hidden them. Officers had eaten. Yet the machinery of correction came from her hands, built to keep an army moving by making imbalance disappear from command's sight.

Teren asked, "Is the Hundred Fires index your notation?"

"The receiving marks are descended from mine. The capital relays are new. The final-correction structure follows the Nine-Salt reserve, enlarged beyond any cap."

"Can you stop it?"

"I can read parts of it. I don't know enough yet to promise more."

Mava left her seat and came into the center. "Seven Wells carried fever for an imperial column. My mother lost two brothers during that season. They were called salt-sick because no battle had crossed the town."

Savra met her gaze. "The annex recorded fifty-three civilian seats at Seven Wells."

"You memorized the number."

"Yes."

"Did that help them?"

"No."

Mava's palm struck Savra's face.

The blow snapped her head sideways. Nobody moved to restrain the guildspeaker. Savra tasted blood from the inside of her cheek and did not mistake receiving pain for repair.

Mava lowered her hand. "I should not have done that."

Savra looked back at her. "No."

The answer startled the room more than the blow. Mava had not granted Savra permission to turn punishment into balance. One struck face could not redistribute a decade.

Dima rose next. "At Ember Bridge I chose a double share. Savra read every seat. She warned me about my hand."

A murmur moved through the steps.

"That does not clear her," Dima said. "It tells us she changed her procedure when people could see her. We need procedures that survive when she wants to hide."

Savra's cheek burned. "Yes."

"Stop agreeing as if agreement costs you."

"What would cost enough?"

Dima's expression hardened. "Nothing. That is the problem. There is no meal where you swallow the right pain and make the account close."

The guild hall began its vote at midday. Mava framed three separate questions so nobody could bury one inside another. Should Savra retain command over coalition kitchens? Should she continue teaching hearthbinding? Should she remain present as a technical reader of Issen's list?

The first answer came quickly. No district supported her command.

Votes entered three separate salt bowls, white stones for yes and black for no. Mava required delegates to place each stone in public and name the district whose authority they carried. Savra stood close enough to hear every refusal. Seven Wells voted first. Halvek followed. Kellar's refugee delegation divided its voice, then chose no because dependence on her skill could not justify command over their kitchen.

When the twelfth black stone fell, Mava counted twice and invited Hesh to count again. The result needed no interpretation: zero support, twelve refusals. Savra's former office ended without a ceremonial removal because the coalition had never granted it in the first place.

The second divided the hall. Five of twelve cooks wanted her removed from instruction entirely. Four accepted instruction only with two witnesses and no custody of seals. Three abstained because their towns needed knowledge before they could decide.

The third question lasted longest.

Halvek's refugees wanted the list read before Rován could activate it. River towns wanted Savra confined after she explained the marks. Nerin argued that no other coalition cook understood progressive correction. Hesh answered that dependence on one guilty expert repeated the Hall's structure. Both spoke truly.

Teren did not defend Savra. He asked what limits could let the coalition use knowledge without restoring office.

Mava wrote the terms in charcoal on a white tile. Savra would hold no ember, seal, black salt, ration ledger, or seat registry alone. She could not order a bound meal. Two trained cooks had to witness every technical reading. Her instruction would be copied and challenged. Any local kitchen could refuse her presence. The arrangement lasted only until the Hundred Fires threat ended or the coalition voted again.

"Do you accept?" Mava asked.

"Yes."

"Do not answer yet. What do you surrender?"

Savra understood. She unrolled the leather case at her belt.

Savra's knives had followed her from the Hall through desertion, refugee kitchens, and Ember Bridge. The narrow boning blade carried a notch from the Nine-Salt road. The broad vegetable knife had been sharpened asymmetrically for her fast leftward draw. A small seal knife bore no decoration except the imperial balance mark ground almost away.

She laid all three on the white tile.

Mava wrapped them without touching the handles. Custody would remain with the salt guild. Savra's empty knife roll stayed open on the floor.

The final vote allowed her to remain under the written limits. It did not restore trust. Several Halvek delegates left before the count. Mava refused to call the decision mercy.

"There will be no absolution in this hall," the guildspeaker said. "Only work whose boundaries we can see."

After sunset, the decoded lids remained on the central table. Savra sat three paces away with Nerin on one side and Hesh on the other as required witnesses. She read the correction marks aloud while both copied.

When they reached Eren Ford, Teren's hand stopped above the chart. He said nothing. Savra did not follow his gaze toward the communal-oven sign.

Her cheek had swollen. Her belt felt wrong without weight. Beyond the columns, Mava carried the wrapped knives into the guild vault. Savra remained at the open table because the threat still required her knowledge, not because anyone had forgiven what that knowledge had fed.

Chapter 16 — The Villages in the Seal

Teren found his sister's oven by the three cuts she put beneath every official mark.

The decoded hearth chart covered Mava's council floor in glazed lids, charcoal copies, and river maps weighted flat with salt cups. Issen's shelf order placed Eren Ford in the red receiving column. Its public sign showed two arches over water. Beneath the sign, nearly too small for the copied glaze, ran three short strokes.

Lale Avo cut those strokes into oven paddles, rice bins, and tax tablets. Their father had used two. Lale added the third after taking custody of the communal oven, saying an official mark should admit which hand kept it honest.

Teren lowered himself beside the map. His left ankle still required the willow splint from Halvek. Swelling had receded enough to fit a loose boot, but kneeling pulled the torn tissue against old crushed bone.

Savra sat across from him between Nerin and Hesh, her required witnesses. The bruise along her cheek had yellowed. No knives hung from her empty belt.

"What do the red knots mean?" Teren asked.

"Pain and muscular injury," Savra said.

"Three extra receiving knots?"

"A weighting above the ordinary provincial share. I cannot tell how high without the master index."

"Kelar had nine."

"Kelar carried final correction. Eren Ford may carry three fixed increments, or a progression capped at three. Issen's code records the knot, not every underlying line."

Teren pressed a finger beside the oven mark. Forty-two households used Lale's ovens in dry season. During canal planting, another sixty laborers ate the midday rice there. The empire's grain oath registered each household bowl for tax portions. A hundred people could enter a table through one hearth before anyone noticed a soldier's pain.

Mava's clerk read the next names. Dovet Bank. Mere Varo. Seven Wells. Pel Reed. Halvek. Ninety-seven settlements, each reduced in the Hall archive to bodily capacity and receiving weight.

"They're not villages in a seal," Teren said. "They're people."

Savra's gaze stayed on the map. "Then put people back into it."

He disliked the instruction because it sounded correct in her voice.

A messenger reached the hall before noon. She wore Eren Ford's mustard-yellow scarf and had canal mud dried to her knees. Teren knew her as Pellu, one of Lale's oven apprentices, though the girl who used to steal charred rice from his mother's

pan had become a woman with two missing front teeth.

Pellu did not embrace him. She placed a sealed rice-paper packet on the map and said, "Your sister told me to make you read before you command."

Lale's letter held no greeting.

One hundred sixteen regular eaters. Forty-seven children. Nine people too old or sick to walk the north towpath. Two imperial ration officers arrived Day 21 with replacement bowls and ordered every household to renew its grain mark. We refused the bowls. Soldiers then closed the west ferry. Our old vessels remain registered. We have four mule carts, three river boats, and grain for five days if divided honestly. Do not send fighters who bring army bread.

Below that, Lale had drawn the communal oven's current seal. Three red receiving lines entered from the capital route. A fourth line, incomplete, pointed toward the barracks on the southern bank.

Pellu unpacked what Lale had sent around the letter. A twist of oven ash showed the hearth still burning clean. A shard from one replacement bowl carried imperial wax beneath its glaze, proof that the officers had tried to renew the household register without visible scoring. Last came a mustard stem wrapped in cloth. Its cut end had browned on one side only.

"Lale held this in her left hand when the officer was kicked," Pellu said. "The bruise came before the stem fell. She marked the side so your cooks could compare."

Savra asked Hesh to move the objects within her view. Under the witness restriction, she touched only after Pellu named each item and Nerin recorded custody. Vinegar raised three fine lines from the bowl shard. They matched the red knots in Issen's chart. The fourth line stopped at a patch of unglazed clay.

"Incomplete because the bowl never entered an oven," Savra said. "If households accept the replacements and heat food in them, the barracks route closes."

Pellu nodded. "Lale broke the first six in front of the officers. They brought sixty more."

Teren pictured the communal oven yard: canal water along the west wall, rice mats on roofs, his sister standing with a firing paddle while soldiers stacked polite gifts at her feet. Eren Ford did not need to understand the whole Great Table to recognize an unwanted vessel.

They added population marks to the river map. Forty-seven children became small white stones. Nine nonwalkers became black. Lale, Pellu, and seven oven workers received clay markers because custody made them likely anchors. Seventy imperial soldiers occupied the ferry; Teren placed bronze counters south of the water.

Four mule carts could carry the nine nonwalkers, eighteen smallest children,

water, and two days of grain. That left twenty-nine children and seventy-eight adults on foot. At the pace of an injured elder, the first canal bridge lay nine hours away. The north towpath offered no shade for five miles.

"They leave after sunset," Teren said. "Carts carry water on the outward leg. Boats shadow them from the canal with more."

"The soldiers search boats," Pellu replied.

"Then water travels in fishing baskets under wet net."

"They stab baskets."

"Float sealed jars beneath the hull."

Pellu considered that. "Eren potters make jars with tow eyes."

The route became local because she corrected it. Teren marked two reed islands where boats could transfer supplies without landing. He wanted to send armed rowers. Lale's instruction barred army bread, not weapons, but Pellu's expression reminded him that seventy soldiers at the ferry would treat any Free Granary escort as an attack.

"Has anyone felt transferred injury?" Teren asked.

Pellu touched the gap where her teeth had been. "A horse kicked an imperial officer yesterday. Lale fell against the oven wall at the same moment. Bruise on her left shoulder. No mark on the officer after an hour."

"Your teeth?"

"Boat hook last year. Mine."

"How many soldiers?"

"Seventy at the ferry. More coming downriver."

Teren counted routes. The north towpath could take walkers to Ulsor in four days, three if carts carried children and water. Boats could move thirty per trip but the west ferry closure put them under bow range. South led toward imperial columns. East crossed shallow marsh unsuitable for carts.

"We evacuate north tonight," he said.

Pellu did not touch the letter. "Lale said you would answer before reading the last line."

He looked down.

If leaving us sends our share into another village, I will not call that rescue. Find where the weight goes.

Teren folded the paper. "She knows too much about tables."

"She listens when cooks explain."

Savra reached for the seal drawing, then stopped before touching it. Hesh moved the paper to her side under the witness rule.

"The fourth line matters," she said. "It may provide the replacement route."

"Soldier barracks."

"Possibly. Or a relay ember stored there."

"Can we cut Eren Ford out?"

"Not from a copy."

"If we reach the oven?"

Savra studied Lale's marks. "We can break local vessel anchors, extinguish the oven ember, and stop eating oath grain. Those actions weaken the route. If Rován's capital fire has already claimed the hearth, local removal creates recoil."

"Back into the soldiers."

"Across every remaining seat according to the master weighting. That includes other villages."

His patience failed. "You designed correction. Tell me how to correct it."

Nerin shifted. Hesh's attention sharpened, both witnesses now part of the quarrel whether Teren wanted them or not.

Savra answered slowly. "A share can leave a seat only by entering another embodied seat, a compatible temporary vessel for a compatible state, or by returning across those already bound. Eren Ford may be carrying pain, fatigue, hunger, heat, and cold. No pot can hold all of that. If you remove one hundred sixteen people at once without replacement, the table sends their current burden somewhere."

"So we leave them."

"I did not say that."

"You describe every choice until action sounds criminal."

"Action can be criminal."

"Easy to say after ten years hiding from yours."

The words struck. Savra's expression did not ask him to withdraw them.

Teren pushed himself upright with his staff. "My sister has soldiers at her ferry and an imperial line entering her oven. I need a plan, not a confession shaped like caution."

Savra stood too. "Then count what your plan moves."

"I always count."

"No. You count what you can see. Halvek showed you the rest."

Teren looked at her empty belt. "And Nine-Salt showed you. You still kept it running."

Mava's hall had heard that truth yesterday. Repeating it did not make his argument stronger, only crueler. He knew and used it anyway.

Savra went pale around the mouth. "Yes. Do you want my shame to authorize your speed?"

"I want your skill to protect Eren Ford."

"Then stop asking me to promise conservation will spare your family."

Pellu stepped between the map and both of them. "Lale asked where the weight goes."

Her plain sentence ended the quarrel.

They built a recoil test in the lower training kitchen. It could not reproduce Hundred Fires or prove Eren Ford's exact line. Its purpose involved showing Teren the shape of removal with known seats.

Four diners joined: Teren, Savra, Dima, and Hesh. Nerin cooked barley cakes over a Ulsor ember and took the fifth seat. Equal weighting. Declared states: palm heat from five breaths over steam and shoulder fatigue from holding a water jar for twenty breaths. Duration fifteen minutes. Five personal salt cups stood inside separate lines. Two open vessels waited, one filled with warm water for heat and one rigged with a weighted leather sling for muscular effort.

Everyone read the terms aloud. Teren's participation remained voluntary. He resented the need to state it while thinking of Lale's registered bowl.

They ate.

Heat evened first. Shoulder fatigue followed after sour-plum paste woke the table. Teren felt Dima's weakness in his right fingers only as present exertion from her jar, not her permanent injury. Hearthbinding followed named states, not resemblance.

Nerin pointed to Hesh. "Remove one seat without landing vessels."

Hesh overturned his salt cup.

His fifth share returned among four diners. Teren's palm heated. The water jar seemed to regain weight against his shoulder though his hands no longer held it. Savra's breath shortened. Nothing reached Hesh after separation.

"Recoil," Nerin said. "A departed burden does not depart the table."

They reset. This time warm water and the sling accepted Hesh's compatible shares before the salt line broke. Recoil diminished to a mild pulse.

"Now remove two seats," Savra said.

Dima and Hesh severed together. The open water steamed hard enough to crack its cup. The sling dropped as its leather strap tore. Unheld shares returned across Teren, Savra, and Nerin. Teren's knees bent. Nerin lost her grip on the spoon. Savra caught the table edge.

The scale mattered. Prepared vessels failed when burden exceeded their physical capacity.

For the third test, all five diners remained. Nerin opened a sixth line with a piece

of cake and no named person.

"An open seat?" Teren asked.

"An available route, not a body," Savra said. "Until someone eats it, it can hold only what the food and vessel embody. It cannot carry a wound."

Teren took the sixth piece himself. The moment he swallowed, the line gained a body. Heat and fatigue spread across six instead of five.

"A replacement can enter before removal," he said.

"Yes."

"If soldiers took the departing shares, villages could leave."

"If they entered knowingly, with declared weights and enough bodies."

"How many?"

"For Eren Ford alone, perhaps one company. For all listed villages, an army."

They both understood what resource lay closest to the empire's tables.

After the test, Teren apologized for using Nine-Salt as a blade against Savra. He did not apologize for demanding an evacuation plan.

She accepted the distinction without warmth. "Lale should begin moving people before any local severance. Distance does not end the bond, but it removes them from soldiers who can force another meal."

They designed the operation on the council floor. Pellu would return by the marsh path with orders in Lale's authority, not Teren's. Children, sick people, and registered bowl keepers would move first. Nobody would eat army grain. Old vessels would remain intact until Dima's cooks prepared sectional cuts and mapped where recoil traveled. River towns would send unbound food north. Coalition fighters would avoid the ferry unless Lale requested them.

Dima joined them with a list of what two cooks could carry: vinegar powder, barley ash, four personal salt cups, one severance board, three broad knives, and clean clay for copying line impressions. No black salt left Ulsor. If Eren Ford's seal required First Hearth authority, the cooks would observe and withdraw rather than improvise.

Food demanded another column. Unmarked grain did not mean safe grain unless its oath origin remained outside the capital archive. Mava released barley from two salt-guild terraces that had never accepted Hall measures. Lorn Steps promised dried fish. Nerin baked chickpea cakes without any shared ember, scoring each only with batch number and date. Every sack received a plain reed tag stating source, hands, and absence of binding.

"People will still be afraid to eat," Pellu said.

"Let them watch the cooks eat first," Dima answered. "No ceremonial taster. Same pot, same ladle, same ground."

Evacuation order required care. Moving registered bowl keepers first might

weaken local vessel routes unevenly. Savra proposed three groups, each mixing anchors with unregistered laborers. The oven ember would remain live until the final group reached the north bridge. Lale would continue baking from unregistered guild barley so no imperial clerk noticed a sudden cold hearth and tightened the barracks line early.

Teren objected. "That keeps her beside the seal longest."

"She holds local custody," Pellu said. "She already chose last."

He started to overrule his sister from four days away. The command reached his mouth and stopped there. Eren Ford belonged to the people leaving it, not to his fear. He wrote Lale determines final departure on the operation tile.

Signals used no meal bells. One shutter lamp meant carts loaded. Two meant first walkers clear. A covered red lamp from the northern reed island meant imperial boats had moved. If soldiers blocked the towpath, people would divide into household groups and enter the mustard fields rather than form one visible column. Reassembly would happen at the old lime kiln, not the bridge.

Mava read every line back. "What ends the operation?"

"All one hundred sixteen regular eaters north of the first canal bridge," Teren said.

"And the oven?"

"Still live, under Lale's decision, until the cooks know whether severance exports the share."

The answer left his home exposed after its people moved. An oven could be rebuilt. Teren wrote that into no column because Lale did not need him to explain the value of her own hearth.

The plan risked moving Eren Ford's share into other hearths if the capital bond woke fully. Teren chose evacuation anyway. Leaving people concentrated beside an imperial barracks guaranteed repeated exposure.

Mava required the decision entered into the public ledger. Teren signed beneath Lale's question: We do not yet know where every displaced weight goes.

At dusk, Pellu departed with two cooks and no soldiers.

Teren remained in the map room after witnesses carried Issen's lids back to the vault. He took out his private copy of the captured barge annex. Five company marks survived on it, each tied to ration loaves imperial soldiers had already eaten. A company could become a replacement circle if a new recipe reversed the weighting.

He drew a line from Eren Ford to the nearest company mark.

Volunteers first, he wrote. Declared shares. Officers included.

Below that he calculated what happened if too few volunteered. One company held a hundred bodies. Five companies could cover the five most endangered

villages. Soldiers had chosen the army, he told himself. They already benefited from civilian seats. Returning burden to them differed from imposing it on strangers.

The arithmetic grew easier once he stopped writing the word consent.

Teren folded the contingency inside his boot lining, beneath the splint strap. The wax tablet pressed against the swollen outside of his ankle whenever he stood, turning secrecy into a small physical irritation. He could have removed it by showing the plan to Mava. Instead he adjusted the strap until he could walk without limping more visibly.

He told no one, not Savra, Mava, Dima, or Lale. Before dawn he sent evacuation orders north and requisitioned enough unmarked grain to feed Eren Ford on the road. The first sacks left under plain reed tags at dawn while Ulsor's ovens remained cold, denying the convoy even the appearance of a common fire.

Chapter 17 — The Grand Provisioner's Offer

Savra entered the white-tile kitchen with no knife, no ember, and two witnesses who had been ordered to wait outside.

The customs house stood at a disused crossing where salt caravans once paid Namarra by the wheel. Mava had accepted Rován's request for parley only after both sides named the ground neutral and permitted inspection. Nerin searched the stove. Hesh tested the floor grout with vinegar. Imperial attendants opened every cupboard, lifted every drain cover, and broke the wax seals on three water jars. No live ash appeared. No salt line crossed the room.

Then Rován's guards required Nerin and Hesh to remain in the outer passage.

Savra objected. "My terms require witnesses."

Rován Dast stood beside an empty preparation table, wearing the plain brown robe of his office rather than court white. Age had narrowed his shoulders since she last saw him, but his hands looked unchanged: broad fingertips, two old oil burns, nails cut too short for dough work.

"They can see through the grille," he said. "They cannot hear every word. You may leave."

That choice formed the first dish he served her. Accept privacy or lose information.

Savra looked through the iron grille. Nerin held up two fingers, then pointed at her own eyes. Two witnesses watching. Not enough under Mava's rule, but enough to record whether Savra touched a seal or left with contraband.

"I stay for one hour," Savra said.

"Always a timer."

"Always a man who resents one."

Rován almost smiled.

Servants cooked in the courtyard beyond the west wall. Their work reached the room as sound and heat: knife on board, pestle against stone, oil answering a hot pan. A square hatch admitted finished dishes. The people who prepared them never entered. Rován had arranged a meal with labor outside the conversation, just as he arranged tables with burden outside command.

Savra opened the first dish before he could. Salt-baked fish, pale barley, sour plum, Ulsori herbs. He had chosen the food of the city that judged her. Two separate bowls stood on the tray. No scoring marked the flatbreads.

She tested barley against the inside of her wrist, smelled the fish cavity, and dragged a damp finger around each bowl's foot. No ash. No hearth-salt.

"You taught me to test from vessel outward," she said.

"I taught you to notice the table before admiring the food."

"You taught me many useful things."

His eyes settled on her empty belt. "They took your knives."

"I surrendered them."

"Institutions prefer that verb."

"People harmed by my work voted in the open."

"And now you require permission to cut an onion."

"Now no one mistakes access to a blade for authority."

Rovan sat. His bowl remained untouched. "Eat. Nothing here carries a bond."

"You first."

He took fish from his own bowl. Savra watched him swallow before tasting hers. The flesh held too much salt near the spine. Whoever cooked outside had rushed the cure or received poor instruction. Rovan noticed her pause.

"Still correcting servants in your head?"

"Still serving their errors under your name?"

A louder knock came from the courtyard. The hatch opened. A young attendant's hands removed the tray and set down lentils with smoked onion. The wrists carried shallow red bands from lifting hot pots. Savra had time to see them before the hatch closed.

She crossed to the hatch and opened it again. Three servants worked around a charcoal range built too low for standing comfort. One stirred lentils. Another scraped burned barley from a pot while the youngest held both forearms under cool water. An imperial guard occupied the courtyard door, not to protect the cooks from intruders but to prevent their leaving before service ended.

"Names," Savra said.

The guard stepped forward. "They are Hall staff."

"That describes custody."

Rovan spoke from the table. "Eda Sen, Mol Varo, and Tath."

The youngest looked startled that he knew. Savra asked who had chosen the menu, measured salt, assigned fuel, and decided servants would eat later. Rovan answered each question. His steward chose the dishes. A customs clerk issued salt. The guard released fuel from a locked shed. Rovan had ordered delayed staff service because the parley required privacy.

"There," he said. "Every hand visible. Does that satisfy the new faith?"

"No. Visibility without power gives a cleaner account of command."

Eda Sen pulled the burned pot from the range. "If you want to improve our power, let us finish before the lentils seize."

Savra closed the hatch. The rebuke belonged to the cook, not to either feastwright's argument. She returned to her bowl knowing she had made labor pause so she could prove she noticed labor.

Rovan waited until the scraping resumed. "Your coalition will discover that scrutiny also consumes people."

"Then they must be able to tell us to move."

"A kitchen cannot vote on every ladle."

"It can refuse the table that claims its body."

"Do they eat what we eat?" she asked.

"After service."

"From which fire?"

"The courtyard hearth."

"Are their names on any list?"

"There is no binding here."

"You answered the smaller question."

Rovan folded his napkin once. "You came to discuss one hundred hearths, not kitchen wages."

"They are the same discussion if the person controlling service treats labor as scenery."

"Still exact. Still exhausting."

Once, in the Hall of Measures, praise had arrived in that tone. Rovan called her exhausting after she found a false tare weight or corrected his salt ratio before senior feastwrights. She had treasured the word because it meant he considered her difficult enough to respect.

He used it now to open the old room between them.

"I mourned you," he said.

"You sent riders."

"To find you."

"To arrest me."

"To bring you home before frightened officials made your departure treason."

"You signed the treason order."

"After you stole the master knives and burned a relay."

Savra tasted the lentils. Smoke, onion, no residue. "I did too little and too late."

"Yes." His agreement held no triumph. "But leaving did not undo the work. It only removed the person most capable of governing it."

There came the offer, not yet named.

Rovan pushed his bowl aside. "Hundred Fires activates at Equinox. Ninety-seven provincial hearths are prepared. Three capital ovens close the relay. Every registered diner will feel a weighted share of hunger, fatigue, pain, and bodily heat from the whole table."

He drew a folded cloth from his sleeve and opened it between the bowls. A hundred small circles had been embroidered in nine colors. No settlement names appeared, only numbered routes and receiving bands. Kelar occupied the lower edge as a circle stitched over itself until the cloth puckered.

"Not a seal," Rovan said when Savra leaned closer. "A planning diagram. You may inspect it."

She kept her hands away. Nine major routes corresponded to the old March Table. Each divided into provincial branches, then returned through three capital relays. The design did not copy Nine-Salt line for line. Rovan had spent a decade testing how to hide its moral structure inside administrative complexity.

"Where are the individual exits?" she asked.

"Local hearths maintain ordinary severance."

"Ordinary severance produces recoil into the remaining table."

"Which discourages selfish withdrawal during shared crisis."

"You call a trapped seat local authority."

"I call it mutual obligation."

Savra followed the embroidered routes without touching. Ulsor's branches remained thinner than its population warranted because the guilds had resisted grain oaths. Eren Ford carried a heavy red strand. Halvek's route entered after a recent knot, improvised during occupation. Rovan's universal language concealed a table assembled through different degrees of force.

"Why show me this?"

"Because you can still distinguish correction from punishment."

"Your diagram distinguishes only what you intend to measure."

"Then add what I missed."

He offered a charcoal pencil. Savra did not take that either.

The proposal expanded in practical terms. She would receive the title Master of the First Hearth, authority over provincial weights, access to census records, and power to suspend any local cook. Twelve coalition instructors could enter Hall service without prosecution. Mava would gain an advisory seat. Teren's Free Granary forces would receive amnesty if they surrendered captured seals and grain routes.

Every concession converted opposition into a department beneath Rovan.

"What if Mava advises you to extinguish the table?" Savra asked.

"Advice does not dissolve imperial obligation."

"What if I order it?"

"You would command weighting, not state policy."

The offered command ended exactly where refusal began.

"Not every share equally."

"Equality without weighting would kill children and the sick. Capacity must govern distribution."

"Who defines capacity?"

"The Hall holds census, labor, ration, and health records."

"The Hall defined Halvek refuge halls as capacity."

"Halvek became a battlefield because Teren Avo attacked a protected store."

"You built the civilians into soldiers' wounds before he arrived."

Rovan's calm tightened, a nearly invisible movement at the jaw. "I built a consequence for violence. Once an army knows its blows return to households, it must consider the cost."

"Your soldiers kept striking because other households took most of their injuries."

"That deployment failed its ethical purpose."

"It fulfilled its weighting."

He looked toward the grille, where Nerin and Hesh remained visible. "You have taught them to speak in accusations."

"They arrived with their own."

Rovan leaned back. "Command the Great Table."

The words sounded smaller than the room prepared for them.

"You designed the correction method," he continued. "You understand progressive receiving better than any living feastwright. Take the Hall kitchen. Name the caps. Audit the records. Put yourself inside whatever line satisfies your coalition. Without you, lesser cooks will enact the system with crude weights. With you, no province need carry more than its capacity."

Savra felt the old reflex wake. Ask for the master chart. Demand the current recipe. Correct the obvious fault, then the next. Authority offered itself as the chance to reduce harm already guaranteed by someone else.

"What happens to a hearth that refuses?"

"Refusal from one region shifts its burdens onto neighbors. No province owns the right to export hunger."

"What happens to a diner who refuses?"

"Grain oaths carry civic obligations."

"That means no."

"It means their body already participates in systems of roads, granaries, defense, and famine relief."

"You convert receiving grain into consent to receive wounds."

"I reject the fiction that private appetite has no public cost."

Savra placed her spoon down. "And who sits outside?"

"Administrators require clarity during crisis."

"Who sits outside, Rován?"

He did not answer.

The courtyard knife continued its steady chop. An attendant coughed in smoke. In the white room, two former feastwrights debated equality over food cooked by people excluded from the terms.

Rován tried another route. "The Nine-Salt March Table ended the western war in one season. Fewer soldiers died. Fewer villages burned under prolonged requisition."

"Villages carried marching sores, spear wounds, fever, and hunger they did not agree to take."

"Because clerks corrupted the reserve list."

"You kept using the design after you learned."

"As did you."

The sentence landed cleanly because it remained true.

Savra did not defend herself. "Yes."

"Then do not pretend our difference lies in innocence."

"It lies in what we do after knowledge."

"You deserted."

"And you scaled it."

Rován's hand flattened on the tile table. "I studied why your correction line succeeded. Nine military tables stayed stable because imbalance had somewhere to go. Every bounded system requires a final receiver. You proved that. Hundred Fires extends the lesson until no burden can hide outside the public body."

"Except the people who write the recipe."

"Governance cannot function while fevered, starving, or in shock."

"Then governance assigns itself the first exemption."

"Not exemption. Operational necessity."

Savra heard Teren in the phrase, though Teren would have hated the comparison. Arithmetic made private command feel like duty when the person counting included every cost except the authority to choose.

She turned her spoon in the lentils. A narrow silver bowl, worn dark near the

handle. Three notches crossed its underside. A witness spoon did not create a recipe. It copied the weighting of broth tested against a known table. This spoon carried old black salt in its scratches.

Rovan watched her notice it.

"The first utensil you ever calibrated," he said. "I kept it."

"You kept everything useful."

"I kept what you abandoned."

He lifted the spoon and dipped it into his bowl. For a moment black residue showed within the lowest notch, then oil covered it.

"The Great Table has a master seal?" Savra asked.

"One hundred seals."

"That cannot maintain correction. Separate hearths drift during digestion."

"The First Hearth aligns them."

She kept her face still. "The capital brazier is ceremonial."

"Ceremony is continuity with guards around it. The ember has remained live for six hundred years. Black salt lets its weighting overwrite subsidiary arrangements."

Established physics, enlarged by custody. The First Hearth could rewrite nested topology because every capital grain oath recognized its ash. Rovan had not built one enormous seal. He meant to use the brazier as authority over a hundred local tables.

"Where does final imbalance go?" she asked, though Issen's list had already answered.

Rovan cut a piece of flatbread. "Kelar can absorb variation that registered towns cannot."

"Refugees are not capacity."

"They are a population already fed across mixed civic lines. Their hearth accepts grain from every province. That makes it resilient."

"It makes their deaths hard to assign."

"The kitchen will receive food, healers, and evacuation support."

"After you route a continent through it."

"If you command, you can cap the receiving line."

The bait showed its hook. To protect Kelar, Savra must accept the table, then govern everyone else's coercion more gently.

"No," she said.

Rovan's face aged in a single small release around the eyes. "You would leave the weighting to men you consider monsters?"

"I would break the authority that lets one cook hold it."

"Then burdens return chaotically. Provinces starve alone. Armies hide wounds. Merchants hoard while children eat husks."

"Those crimes do not make your control consent."

"Consent does not feed a city."

"Neither does pain."

Outside, Hesh raised one hand. Half the hour had passed.

Rovan drew the witness spoon through his lentils, then set it beside Savra's bowl. "Take it. Test what I built. You will find the weighting more humane than your allies' improvisations."

An offered artifact could carry tracking ash or become proof of agreement. Savra did not take it.

She asked for fresh dough from the courtyard.

Rovan's brows lifted. "Hungry?"

"The flatbread is stale."

He signaled. The hatch opened, and an attendant placed a ball of raw barley dough on a saucer. Savra tore it in half. She pressed one piece against the base of her bowl as if checking its foot for grit. With the other, she wiped lentil oil from her fingers.

Rovan spoke about provincial caps while she listened. His proposal granted Ulsor an elected auditor, Halvek reconstruction grain, and amnesty for twelve cooks. Every concession assumed the Great Table would exist.

When he looked toward the grille, Savra pressed the dough beneath the witness spoon for one breath. The three underside notches left their impression. Old black-salt residue entered the soft surface as gray dust. She folded the dough inward and held it beneath her tongue, where no guard search could distinguish it from food.

The act did not copy the full recipe. It preserved the spoon's weighting geometry and ash signature, enough to test how the First Hearth addressed nested lines.

Savra stood before the hour ended.

"You will return," Rovan said. "When your villages begin severing and recoil moves into children elsewhere, you will need a table large enough to hold the consequence."

"I need tables small enough to leave."

He looked genuinely sorry. That made him more dangerous, not less.

Nerin and Hesh inspected Savra in the passage. She opened her mouth and placed the folded dough on Nerin's clean tile. Hesh recorded its custody. Neither praised the theft.

They tested the packet before carrying it toward Ulsor. Nerin divided the outer dough from the impressed center with a reed splinter because Savra had no knife. Hesh placed each portion in a separate clay cup and sealed both with his own salt, unbound. The outer piece showed only barley and lentil oil. Across the center, three gray arcs matched the spoon's underside.

"Could he have wanted you to take this?" Hesh asked.

"Yes," Savra said.

"Then we treat it as offered evidence, not a clever victory."

Nerin wrapped the cup in plain cloth. "And no experiment until Mava names the room, witnesses, and stopping conditions."

Savra accepted both corrections. Possessing a stolen pattern did not grant her the right to wake it. The sealed cup traveled in Nerin's hands, while Hesh walked close enough to break it if pursuit turned custody into capture.

Behind the grille, Rován remained alone in the white-tile kitchen while servants cleared food he had not finished. Savra left understanding the mechanism he had tried to make irresistible: the First Hearth could overwrite table topology. If one authority could force a hundred fires into one arrangement, another arrangement might keep each fire's right to break away.

Chapter 18 — A Hundred Independent Fires

The first stew failed before anyone swallowed it.

Twelve cooks stood around the kiln kitchen's central cauldron, each holding a bowl made in their own district. Mava kept the witness-spoon impression locked inside a pierced clay box at her feet. Nerin held the key. Hesh held the inventory tablet. Savra possessed nothing except a reed stylus and permission to speak.

They had mixed twelve broths without mixing twelve embers. Ulsor fish stock met Eren Ford lentil liquor, Kellar chickpea water, Tal Jes pepper oil, and eight smaller bases. Each cook heated a portion over local ash, then poured it into the common vessel. Separate ladles touched separate salt rests. No seal joined them.

Still, when Dima brushed vinegar around the cauldron, one gray line appeared where steam had carried ash residue across the rim.

"Whose?" Mava asked.

Sela Vorn tapped each ladle against bronze. Eleven rang clean. Pava's fish ladle answered dull. A hairline crack in its handle had trapped Ulsor ash, then released it into the common stew.

Pava swore and reached for the cauldron hook.

"Stop," Savra said. "Name what removing it changes."

"Nobody ate."

"That means no embodied seats. It does not mean no arrangement."

The spoon impression had been pressed into a cold wax tile beneath the cauldron. Three gray arcs copied Rován's weighting geometry without any First Hearth ember to activate it. Even cold, the pattern ordered ash signatures toward one center. Pulling the fish ladle could smear the route across the others.

Dima secured the cauldron with her severance board. Her right hand rested inside a leather loop, providing pressure without finger grip. With her left, she scored a circle around the gray line. Nerin packed clean salt into the cut. Pava lifted the ladle only after the contaminated segment stood isolated.

The gray route ended in salt.

"What did we prove?" Hesh asked.

"That your stew tastes of indecision," Mava said.

Several cooks smiled. Savra did not rescue the experiment with humor.

"We proved a central vessel turns accidental contact into central authority," she said. "Rován's geometry pulls every compatible line toward one correction point. If we wake this cauldron, separate recipes become one table whether we intended it or not."

"Then destroy the impression," said Omin, the canal baker.

"That prevents us learning how it addresses local seals," Nerin replied.

Hesh looked at Savra. "And learning lets us imitate it."

"Yes," Savra said.

Distrust belonged inside the room, not outside the door.

Mava ordered the stew discarded into twelve waste jars, one for each contributing broth. It could feed no person because ash contact remained uncertain. After the jars cooled, they would pour it into separate compost trenches. Food lost through unsafe design counted among the experiment's burdens.

The second arrangement removed the cauldron.

Twelve low hearths formed a circle on the kiln floor. Each cook kept their own ember, food, bowl, ladle, and salt. A broad outer ring of unlit clay tiles connected the work places without touching inner lines. At the center, the spoon impression rested under glass. Thin channels ran from its three arcs toward the clay ring, stopping a finger's width before every local salt boundary.

"No route crosses unless a local cook completes it," Savra said.

"Who authorizes the outer ring?" Pava asked.

"Nobody. It carries no food, ember, or seat list."

"Then why have it?"

"To make requested transfers visible and to let the First Hearth address all circles at once."

Mava crossed her arms. "That last phrase contains the danger."

Savra changed the drawing. She turned every inward channel sideways before it reached the local line. The geometry no longer pointed from center to hearth. It pointed along the outer ring and presented an open end to each cook.

"The capital can announce a route," she said. "A local circle decides whether to close its own gap."

"Unless black salt overwrites the gap," Hesh said.

"That is what we test."

They could not reproduce full First Hearth authority. Mava permitted one grain of black salt from guild custody and an ember carrying Ulsor's oldest continuously kept guild ash. The ember lacked Namarra's continent-wide recognition but could act across the twelve Ulsori practice seals prepared for training.

Nerin weighed the grain. Hesh recorded it. Dima crushed it into the wax impression with the flat of her broad knife.

The first live test used heat only. Twelve cooks held palms over their own steam pots for three breaths, then ate one bite from their local dish. Every circle named its diners, source ember, equal local weighting, ten-minute duration, personal salt-cup severance, and prepared open water.

Savra took a seat in Nerin's Kelar circle. Mava sat with Pava's fish table. Dima occupied her own two-person healer circle and read the terms with Hesh.

At Savra's signal, Nerin opened her local channel toward the outer ring. Pava kept hers closed. Dima opened halfway, leaving a salt bridge narrow enough to limit flow.

Black salt darkened in the center.

Heat moved from Nerin's circle into the outer clay, then stopped at eleven local gaps. Dima's narrow bridge admitted a small portion. Pava's circle received nothing. The Ulsor ember could announce the route but could not cross intact separate salt lines without the local opening.

"Measure," Savra said.

Dima dipped three fingers of her left hand into a calibrated water cup. Its rise in temperature matched the fraction allowed by her bridge. Nerin's diners cooled by the same amount. Conservation held across the accepted transfer.

Pava touched her steam-reddened palm. "I kept mine."

"You kept both burden and authority," Mava said.

"Until someone with the real brazier overwrites my line."

The question remained.

For the second test, Dima closed her bridge while transfer continued. Her one-handed seal mattered because a cook had to act under bodily load. She locked the local seal into her board, turned the broad blade with her left hand, and drew salt across the channel using the leather-bound heel of her right palm.

Her circle separated. Its accepted heat did not vanish. The share already embodied among Dima and Hesh remained until digestion. Transfer stopped at the closed line. No recoil struck the other circles because their local portion had an open water cup prepared beside the gap.

Steam rose from that cup.

"Revocable," Nerin said.

"At practice scale," Savra answered.

They expanded from heat to fatigue. Each circle chose one diner to hold a grain measure at shoulder height for twelve breaths. Oil delayed half the dishes, souring accelerated others. Timing differences created a ragged onset. The outer ring carried requests only after every local cook signaled readiness with a raised spoon.

One circle refused because its oldest diner's breathing had become shallow. Another accepted a quarter share. A third opened for five breaths, then closed. Fatigue traveled according to those local choices and nowhere else.

The arrangement did not equalize sensation. Some tables carried more because they chose more. One carried none. Yet every share had a named source and receiving circle.

“Rovan will call this hoarding,” Omin said.

“Rovan calls compelled access solidarity,” Mava replied.

A harder problem emerged when a diner wanted to leave while their local circle remained open. Arda Men crushed her chickpea-dough salt cup. Her personal line broke. Prepared water could not receive shoulder fatigue. The burden recoiled across the three diners remaining in her circle, not across all twelve fires.

They reset with an open seat: one portion of ash-bread placed beside a named empty cushion, its salt cup intact, food uneaten.

“Open seats cannot carry fatigue without bodies,” Hesh reminded them.

“No,” Savra said. “But they can preserve an available route for someone who chooses to enter before another leaves.”

Nerin volunteered. She moved from the Kelar circle to Arda’s refugee table only after severing her first seat, waiting for its heat share to settle, hearing the new terms, and eating the open portion. Once her body entered, Arda broke her cup. Fatigue spread across the replacement circle without reaching unrelated tables.

“No one may fill that seat by name alone,” Dima said. “The diner must hear, eat, and remain able to break their cup.”

Magic required no metaphysical consent. Their compact would.

The third test introduced pain. Mava permitted only a pinprick made by each diner on their own left thumb. No cook could assign another person’s source injury. Circles chose independently whether to open. Seven refused. Five accepted fractions no greater than one extra pinprick distributed among their local seats.

Savra felt five tiny points gather into pressure beneath her skin. The sensation hurt without breaking her thumb again. Across the room, Pava chose to close her fish circle after two breaths. Dima’s board cut its route. Open warm-clay cups could receive none of the pain, so Pava’s accepted fraction stayed among her diners until the bond digested.

Nobody called the result painless. That mattered.

When the tests ended, every diner scattered their own salt. Cooks extinguished local embers in local ash. Dima isolated the central impression before Nerin lifted the blackened wax into its pierced custody box. Hesh weighed the remaining grain residue. Nothing left Savra’s hands because nothing had entered them except food.

The coalition debate began before the floor cooled.

Hesh argued that any outer ring recreated a master table in waiting. Pava wanted no Namarra ember near Ulsor, even for a counter-design. Omin pointed out that villages already sat inside Rovan’s routes; purity offered them no severance method. Nerin insisted that local circles could not protect themselves if each recipe remained secret from neighbors.

Teren attended from a bench near the wall, his left ankle braced. He spoke only

when Mava asked about scale. "Twelve fires require twelve cooks watching. One hundred require messengers, timings, guards, fuel, and food that reaches every table before the first bond changes."

"Central command?" Hesh asked.

"Coordination," Teren said.

Savra heard the edge between the words. His hidden calculations remained hidden from her, but the difference mattered more after Halvek.

Mava placed a blank white tile in the center. "No master recipe until we define who may refuse it."

They drafted a provisional compact as kitchen procedure rather than law.

First: every fire kept its own ash signature and separate salt lines.

Second: local cooks alone opened routes from their circle to the outer arrangement.

Third: seat lists named actual diners, not households, professions, villages, or future replacements.

Fourth: each diner received a personal salt cup and could break it. Local recoil had to be explained before eating.

Fifth: open seats remained visible, unfilled, and incapable of assignment by a distant cook. Entry required hearing the terms and eating locally.

Sixth: no central cook altered local weights. The outer recipe could request a share, never compel one.

Seventh: every cook took a seat inside the circle they bound.

Eighth: custody of the aligning ember, witness pattern, salt records, and timing signals remained separate. No person held two.

Ninth: any local circle could extinguish its ember and leave, accepting only recoil already declared within that circle.

Tenth: the compact expired after the Equinox threat unless every participating kitchen renewed it.

The written clauses did not settle the difficult cases. A cook from a small salt-pan camp asked what happened when only one trained person remained and that cook fell ill. Hesh proposed automatic closure. Omin objected that closure during an active bond could recoil into children. They amended the compact: every circle named two noncooking severance witnesses before service, each trained to close the local line without altering weights.

Pava raised famine. "If one circle has full bowls and its neighbor has none, refusal protects hoarding."

Mava set two bowls on the tile, one filled with barley and one empty. "The compact controls bodily transfer. It does not forbid taking grain across the floor."

"People with grain may refuse that too."

“Yes. Then we confront ownership, requisition, trade, or theft in public. We do not solve unequal stores by hiding hunger inside another person.”

Teren shifted on the wall bench. “A convoy cannot debate while raiders cut harness.”

“Then convoy councils set emergency food rules before departure,” Mava said. “Urgency needs prior limits more than peace does.”

His mouth tightened. He entered the clause on his own copy.

Sela asked about children too young to understand a salt cup. No answer satisfied everyone. Some cooks wanted guardians to speak. Dima refused any guardian authority to assign pain. Savra proposed that children eat only unbound food during a counter-feast, but Nerin pointed out that many already sat inside imperial grain oaths. Excluding them locally would not remove those old routes.

They drafted a narrow rule: no coalition cook could add a child to a new burden share. Existing imperial ties could be severed only with a prepared landing plan and two local guardians witnessing for protection, not consenting to burden. The distinction felt imperfect because the situation remained unjust. The compact recorded the imperfection instead of calling it solved.

Next came soldiers. Teren spoke carefully. “Can a military circle volunteer for village recoil?”

Savra looked at him. The question followed directly from Eren Ford, yet something in his stillness suggested calculations already made.

“Yes, if each soldier enters as a named diner under the same terms,” she said. “An officer cannot volunteer a company.”

“What if refusal by ten people overloads ninety?”

“Then the cook reduces the requested transfer or leaves the route closed.”

“That may leave a village bound.”

“It may.”

Teren wrote without answering. Savra could not read the lines from across the room.

Dima tested custody by pretending collapse. She released her left hand from the severance knife, let the blade fall inside the board groove, and stepped away. The two designated witnesses approached. One stabilized the seal. The other read the current weights from Hesh’s tablet. Neither touched the center impression. Together they closed Dima’s local line and directed remaining heat into its prepared cup.

Then Mava changed one number on the tablet without telling them. The witnesses compared the written weight to the water measure, detected the mismatch, and stopped. Procedure had to survive false records as well as failed bodies. They added independent measurement before severance whenever time allowed, and a marked emergency cut when it did not.

A final edge case involved destruction of the central pattern. Sela lifted a kiln hammer over the pierced box. If she smashed it during transfer, the outer ring would lose the address carrying requests. Local tables should continue independently rather than collapse.

Nerin closed three practice gaps. Pava kept hers open. Sela struck a blank duplicate box beside the real one. At the sound, every cook followed local procedure instead of reaching toward the center. Open routes ceased receiving new shares because the request signal ended. Accepted burdens remained inside their circles until digestion. No recoil crossed between fires.

"That is independence," Hesh said. "The center can fail without taking the edges."

Savra added the test result beneath the clauses. Rovan's Great Table made provincial survival depend on one center. Their arrangement would treat the center as a courier whose death ended messages, not kitchens.

Only after those disputes did Mava open signing. Each cook received a separate tile rather than adding names beneath one master copy. The clauses had to exist in every local custody, and any difference introduced during copying had to be read aloud before fire. Sela prepared twelve wet tiles. Cooks impressed their own hearth marks, then exchanged tablets for comparison.

Tenth remained unchanged: the compact expired after the Equinox threat unless every participating kitchen renewed it.

"Revocable local circles," Dima said after Mava read the clauses. "Not one good table."

"A hundred independent fires," Nerin replied.

Savra looked at the spoon impression beneath its pierced lid. "Independent does not mean isolated. The outer line lets them answer one another."

"Answer," Hesh said. "Not obey."

They changed the tile to use his word.

Opposition did not disappear. Three cooks refused to sign even the provisional test. Pava signed only for Ulsor fish kitchens and reserved the right to withdraw before any capital ember arrived. Eren Ford's absent place remained open for Lale's decision. Halvek delegates demanded that no household vessel ever substitute for a person's name.

Mava accepted every limit into the text. A compact that erased objections for elegance would reproduce the cauldron they had discarded.

Scaling remained unsolved. The old guild ember had addressed twelve practice seals because all recognized Ulsor ash. It could not speak to Eren Ford, Tal Jes, Kelar, or the other intended hearths. The witness impression carried Rovan's geometry but no authority beyond compatible local embers.

Only one material source already existed inside every capital-recognized route:

the blackened bronze brazier in Namarra.

“The First Hearth ember,” Nerin said.

“We need the physical brazier or a live coal from it,” Savra replied. “An impression alone cannot scale this.”

Teren looked toward the western road, where imperial checkpoints stood between them and the Hall of Measures. “Then we steal it.”

“No,” Mava said. “We decide who can reach it, what they are allowed to carry, and who holds custody after. The sentence comes after those answers.”

Savra had once mistaken being the only person who could solve a design for permission to own it. She remained silent while the cooks named conditions.

By midnight, the compact tile held nine signatures, three refusals, and one open place for Eren Ford. Twelve separate salt lines remained visible on the floor. At their center sat no flame, only the boxed impression and an empty bronze stand shaped for an ember they did not possess.

Chapter 19 — The Convoy of Stolen Embers

Issen tasted the ash before the guards permitted them to see the fire.

Two attendants held a white linen screen across the eastern service court of the Hall of Measures. Behind it, bronze feet scraped stone. The sound came in four careful movements, each followed by the grunt of men carrying more weight than ceremony admitted. Dust had already begun to blow over Namarra's roofs, a thin ochre veil from the northern road. It gritted between Issen's teeth and spoiled the official fiction that anything inside the Hall could remain pure.

"First Taster." Warden Pel held out a shallow silver dish. "Certify the convoy ember."

For six days he had addressed Issen by office only. Their rooms stood locked at night. Two clerks watched their meals, and a guard followed them even to the washing court. Yet the Equinox ceremonies required a mouth that the city recognized. Suspicion could confine a person; ritual still needed the shape of their obedience.

Issen touched one finger to the ash. The dish held three grains of black hearth-salt, powdered barley husk, and a smear of oil from the brazier's inner rim. They placed the finger on their tongue.

Warmth moved first, not as heat but as the remembered labor of a public oven: shoulders lifting kneaded loaves, palms burned on stone, bellies waiting through lean years for civic bread. The sensation belonged to bodies linked through old grain oaths. Beneath it lay a newer pressure, narrow and deliberate. Provincial embers strained toward the capital. Somewhere an old woman's empty stomach contracted. Somewhere else a soldier breathed without feeling the blister beneath his heel.

The sample carried no poison. It carried a design.

"Sound," Issen said.

Warden Pel watched their throat. "Swallow."

They did. Refusal now would change nothing except the hour of their arrest.

The attendants lowered the screen. The First Hearth brazier stood in a cedar litter banded with bronze. Soot had blackened its bowl and three of its lion-shaped feet. A hood of pierced copper enclosed the coals, keeping sparks from the procession cloth. No flame showed, but an ember glowed through each hole like a watchful eye. Four Hall bearers gripped the litter poles. Six soldiers surrounded them, and two feastwrights walked behind with sealed jars of oil and fresh charcoal.

Small enough to steal, Issen thought. Heavy enough to make theft ridiculous.

Grand Provisioner Rován had moved the brazier from the Hall's inner kitchen to

the Equinox pavilion every year since Issen took office. The route normally crossed a colonnade and one guarded square. This year he had ordered a dust procession through five wards, a public display meant to show Namarra that the oldest civic ember still traveled unharmed while rebels burned granaries.

It also placed the brazier among crowds.

Pel lifted Issen's silver tasting chain from an attendant's tray. Each linked spoon represented a province whose dishes they had certified. The chain felt heavier than it had at dawn, though its weight had not changed. Pel fastened it across their chest himself.

"You will walk beside the left pole," he said. "At the spice arch, the fish gate, and the pavilion stair, you will taste the carrier oil. Any deviation, and the convoy returns."

"Any deviation?"

"Any."

Formal courtesy gave Issen room to bow. "Then I hope your bearers have eaten."

The nearest man looked away.

At the court gate, drums began a pace fit for men carrying fire. Outside, thousands waited behind rope lines. Bakers had dusted the road with flour patterns that vanished beneath the first sandals. Children on roof ledges waved strips of red cloth. Market elders cast pinches of grain toward the litter and shouted blessings older than the empire's measures.

Issen walked at the left pole and counted mouths.

A sesame seller near the first turning wore a blue cord around her thumb. A water carrier had tied the same blue beneath his leather wrist guard. On a balcony above the dyers' lane, three women shook rugs in a dust wind that needed no rugs shaken. Merchant allies, the ceramic message had promised. Not soldiers. Not tablewrights. People who moved sacks, jars, invoices, and rumors past gates because cities starved without them.

The drums carried the convoy into the dust procession.

Wind thickened along the Avenue of Kilns. Powdered clay curled around ankles and entered every fold of cloth. The brazier bearers coughed. Soldiers wrapped scarves over their mouths. Issen kept their face uncovered. A taster who feared dust would never have survived Namarra's public kitchens.

At the spice arch, Pel broke the wax on the first oil jar. Issen sampled a drop. Sesame, old smoke, a trace of bitter orange. Harmless. They declared it so, and the feastwright poured the oil through a narrow pipe in the copper hood.

The ember brightened. Warmth touched Issen's molars.

On the second route, beside the coppersmiths' court, a mule broke its traces exactly when the water carrier crossed behind it. Clay jars struck the paving.

Guards shoved spectators backward. The convoy tightened around the brazier and continued. No one reached for the litter. The disturbance merely taught Pel to expect interruption.

At the fish gate, the sesame seller stumbled under a basket. Silver anchovies spread across the road like spilled coin. One bearer slipped, recovered, and cursed. Again the guards closed ranks. Again nothing happened.

Issen tasted the second oil. Pepper leaf, rendered goat fat, fenugreek browned past bitterness. Beneath those flavors waited a resin that numbed the tongue but did not poison it. A forged burn required pain, not injury. The merchant cooks had measured well.

They let the oil touch the inside of their lower lip.

Numbness came first. Then heat sharpened along the gum where Issen had cut it that morning with the edge of a tasting spoon. They drew breath through their teeth and dropped the dish.

“Stop the ember.”

The words carried farther than a shout because the drums ceased at once.

Pel seized their wrist. “What did you taste?”

“Copper bloom. Hot resin. The carrier jar has taken a kiln taint.” Issen pressed two fingers to their mouth. Blood made the lie visible. “If poured, it may force the oldest ember into a false ash signature.”

One feastwright went pale. Such a corruption had never occurred, which made its consequences impossible to disprove quickly.

“Return to the Hall,” Pel ordered.

“Through this crowd?” Issen asked. “With a suspect carrier open?”

Protocol offered the alternative before Pel could invent another. An origin ember under suspected taint had to be screened from public offerings and tested against an unbound flame. The nearest licensed inspection kitchen occupied the House of Pepper Weights, thirty paces into a side court.

Pel swore softly. “Move.”

The guards turned the litter beneath a lintel too low for the ceremonial banners. Cloth tangled on spearheads. Dust followed them into the passage. Behind, the crowd pushed to see why the First Hearth had vanished from its promised route.

The inspection court held three roofed ovens, stacks of amphorae, and no public exit. Issen had walked it twice in earlier years. It also had a charcoal hatch opening into an alley broad enough for a handcart.

Pel stationed four soldiers at the street arch and two beside the hatch. “Test it.”

A licensed pepper cook waited by the center oven, hands shaking over an unbound charcoal flame. Issen did not know his name. They knew the blue thread sewn beneath his collar.

He poured clear oil into a black cup. "First Taster."

Issen knelt by the brazier. Their chain clicked against the bronze litter band. Through the hood's perforations, the old coals gave off a dense heat that smelled of barley crust and generations of scraped ovens. Issen had no black hearth-salt left. Hall searchers had taken the grain from their chamber after the archive theft. Even if they had kept it, one grain could only make the First Hearth recognize copied weighting. It could not make four bearers forget the load, nor convince eight armed men to surrender it.

People had to perform the theft.

Issen held the cup over the unbound flame. The pepper cook counted seven breaths, then tipped in the suspect oil. It flared green from copper powder planted in the jar.

"Down," Issen said.

The cook overturned a basket of ground pepper into the oven.

Flame struck powder. A red cloud punched across the court. Men screamed, coughed, and clawed at their eyes. The soldiers at the hatch turned away. Through the cloud came the crack of wood: the sesame seller and water carrier had rammed a loaded handcart through the charcoal doors.

Issen found the litter pole by touch. "Set it on the cart."

One bearer obeyed from training before he understood. A second released his end to cover his face. The litter tilted. Bronze rang against stone.

Warden Pel caught Issen by the silver chain. "You."

His astonishment hurt more than the links cutting their neck. Issen twisted, not away but toward him, and unhooked the chain at the shoulder clasp. Pel staggered backward with the whole bright burden in his fist.

"Keep the office," Issen told him.

The tasting chain fell among pepper, anchovy scales, and trampling feet.

Merchant hands heaved the brazier onto the cart. A wet felt cloth covered the copper hood without smothering its vents. The water carrier kicked loose a clay stop under the cart bed, revealing a cradle packed with sand. They lowered the First Hearth brazier into it and rolled through the broken hatch.

Issen followed into the alley as an imperial horn sounded behind them.

Namarra's service lanes had been built for food, not fugitives. The cart struck baskets of coriander root, squeezed between olive presses, and scattered chickens through a vinegar yard. Ahead, a woman in flour-gray clothes raised a shutter. The allies shoved the cart inside a bakery and dropped the door as soldiers entered the lane.

"Upper oven," she said. "Move the fire, leave the litter."

The cedar litter bore the Hall's stamp and added most of the bulk. Four bakers

lifted the bronze bowl by hooked rods while Issen unlatched the hood. The First Hearth came free with a groan of metal. Its three feet fitted into a round bread tray prepared with sand and broken tiles.

No one bowed to it. That helped.

The bakery master covered the tray with a wicker dome used for cooling loaves. "Roof stair."

Before they could lift it, the wounded pepper cook stumbled in from the alley carrying the Hall's first oil jar. He poured its remainder into the bakery's waste crock, then pressed the wax seal against a lump of warm dough. The imprint came away clean.

"Why copy it?" Issen asked.

"Because by sunset every loyal kitchen will be ordered to refuse unstamped carrier oil." He wrapped the dough in flour cloth. "By sunset we will need oil that appears loyal."

His answer disclosed the scale of what these people risked. An official could defect once and imagine the act complete. A baker who helped them still had to open tomorrow. The sesame seller still had accounts, kin, creditors, and a stall that guards knew how to find. Each ordinary obligation gave the Hall another cord to pull.

Issen took the copied seal from him. "No. Put it in the sour bin."

The pepper cook stared.

"If you use the stamp, Pel will compare the oil ledgers. He will find every kitchen that bought the same pressing. Let him believe we carried one prepared jar." They crushed the dough impression between finger and thumb, breaking the circle. "Change the route instead of multiplying the evidence."

The bakery master gave one clipped nod. Two younger workers overturned a rack of cooling loaves, not to block the door but to make the room look robbed in haste. Another scraped the blue thread from the pepper cook's collar and dropped it into the oven mouth. Nobody asked Issen to certify these choices. Their knowledge could reduce the danger; it could no longer command the people taking it.

A spear struck the shutter below as they climbed.

Flat roofs joined much of the ovens' quarter. Families dried figs there, restaurants kept herb boxes, and kitchen workers carried hot pans between buildings when alleys flooded. Dust turned the tiles treacherous. Two porters took the hooked rods and ran with the brazier suspended between them. Issen followed, their mouth bleeding, their ceremonial robe bright enough to guide every archer in Namarra.

On the second roof, they tore off the red outer layer and shoved it into a bread oven chimney. Underneath they wore a porter's undyed tunic. The badge of office

remained stitched at the throat. Issen cut it free with a baker's paring knife.

"Left," called the sesame seller, whose name Issen still did not know.

A roof kitchen opened around a clay stove where six women fried lentil wafers. They did not stop cooking. One pulled a pan aside. Another cast a cup of water on the embers, making steam. The porters carried the First Hearth through the cloud and across a plank to the next house.

Soldiers reached the bakery roof behind them.

"First Taster!" Pel's voice rose through dust. "In the name of the Hall, stop."

Issen almost did. Twenty years of training lay inside that command: stop before crossing a kitchen threshold, stop before tasting, stop before contradicting a measure certified above one's rank. Their body slowed while their judgment continued forward.

The sesame seller caught their elbow. "Are you coming?"

"My name is Issen Mar," they said, partly to her and partly to the man behind them.

"Then come, Issen Mar."

They crossed the plank. A soldier stepped onto it before the porter behind Issen could pull it away. The sesame seller tipped a jar of frying oil across the boards. He slipped to one knee but clung on.

The next kitchen belonged to a public lodging house. Forty bowls of millet porridge stood ready for noon laborers. The cook had drawn a salt line around his stove and listed eight kitchen workers on a wax board. No concealed seats showed in the seal. He held up a ladle.

"Runner share," he said. "Declared: heat and leg fatigue, eight of us to four of you, equal weights, until the coals go dark. Refuse by passing the bowl."

The porters drank. The sesame seller drank. Issen passed it on.

The cook frowned but did not argue. Consent meant accepting refusal when haste made refusal inconvenient.

Warmth entered the runners' limbs. The kitchen workers sagged at their stations, each taking a visible fraction of the porters' exertion. No strength appeared from nowhere. The porters gained what those workers agreed to carry, nothing more.

They crossed three roofs before the soldiers regained the distance.

At the copper-dome kitchen, the planned route broke. Imperial archers had taken the grain exchange roof ahead. Below, mounted guards flooded the west alley. The road south toward Tal Jes began beyond both.

The water carrier leaned over the parapet. "Lower it through the date warehouse."

"Too narrow," one porter said.

Issen measured the brazier with their hands, then the roof vent. Bronze projections at the feet made it wider by two fingers. "Turn it on its side."

"You'll spill the ember."

"Not if the ash bed stays packed. Oil the inner lip. Rotate slowly toward the unblackened foot." The old civic fire had accrued uneven ash. They had seen the residue during every annual inspection and never imagined the knowledge would matter outside ritual.

Kitchen workers brought hooks and a fish net. Together they wrapped the brazier, tipped it, and fed it through the vent. Issen descended first. Hot ash sifted through the hood and burned their forearm, but no coal escaped. Below, dates lay stacked in sealed jars. They guided the bowl past them one handspan at a time.

An arrow struck the roof tiles.

The last porter came down bleeding from the scalp. Issen tasted iron in the air, their own blood and his, and had to separate them by sight. He could still focus. He took the rear hook.

They emerged onto a lane where three grain carts waited under awnings. Each held sacks stamped for a different provincial kitchen. A gray-haired merchant stood beside the middle team.

"East gate closed," he said. "South road watched. We have two wagons and one fire worth an empire."

"Tal Jes," Issen said.

"Riders can take the direct road by dusk."

"The canal road forks at the lime pits. Send one wagon south with the empty litter cloth. Take the brazier west under millet."

"That road also leads to Tal Jes, eventually."

"Eventually will have to suffice."

They bedded the bronze bowl among sacks, keeping the pierced hood clear. The wounded porter climbed in beside it with a water skin to damp the packing. Issen took the driver's bench. Behind them, the sesame seller cut the blue cord from her thumb and tied it around the wagon brake.

"What should I call you?" Issen asked.

"Veyra Sen. Oil factor, when anyone believes invoices." She slapped the wagon side. "Today, an accomplice."

At the western gate, dust had swallowed the sun. Guards searched carts entering Namarra, not those leaving toward lime country. The wagon passed beneath the arch while alarm bells rang from the Hall of Measures.

Beyond the walls, the road divided around a dry shrine. The decoy took the southern branch in a storm of mule bells. Issen steered west, where the land folded into ochre gullies before turning toward Tal Jes.

From the ridge behind came the flash of imperial spearheads. Far ahead, riders appeared on the western road, dark points against the dust.

Veyra looked from one pursuit to the other. "Which office tells us what to do now?"

Issen felt the bare place at their throat. The chain no longer pulled their posture straight. Beneath the millet sacks, the oldest civic ember of Namarra breathed through its copper hood.

"No office," they said. "Take the gully."

The wagon left the road.

Chapter 20 — The Red Millet Terraces

Teren sent the first irrigation gate down before sunrise, and three hundred fields began to drown.

Water left the upper channels in a broad brown sheet. It ran over embankments, filled the footpaths between plots, and turned loose volcanic soil into mud deep enough to seize a cavalry horse at the fetlock. Farmers watched from the stone stairs with their mouths set hard. The crop stood two weeks from cutting. Every stalk of red millet bent beneath the flood that might keep imperial riders from Tal Jes.

“How much survives?” asked the terrace waterkeeper.

“West of the fourth spillway, half.” Teren kept his eyes on the measuring stakes. “East, less.”

“You said a third last night.”

“Last night their scouts had no fire carts.”

Below the lowest terraces, imperial columns moved through dawn haze. Four thousand infantry by Teren’s count. Six hundred mounted soldiers. Twelve ox carts carried clay jars under wet hides, which meant lamp oil or pitch. Behind them rolled portable field ovens with bronze seals nailed above their mouths. The army intended to fight unburned, unblistered, and fed by pain taken from people whose names would never reach this hillside.

Tal Jes had eleven hundred defenders. Three hundred could hold spear lines. The rest served as slingers, water crews, litter bearers, cooks, and farmers who knew every retaining wall. Free Granary wagons had brought grain for two days. The city cisterns could supply five. Issen and the First Hearth had not come.

A signal mirror flashed from the northern watch.

One flash, pause, two. Riders on the gorge road.

Teren’s pulse lifted. “Ours?”

The watcher looked again. “Too much dust. Can’t tell.”

He marked the report on his wax slate. Every column had a quantity. Every route had a time. Uncertainty ought to narrow as scouts returned. Instead, the missing brazier sat in the center of his calculations like a hole cut through the board.

His left ankle had swollen overnight inside its boot. The old crush injury protested each stair, so he distributed his weight through a cut-down spear used as a staff. Pain had once seemed useful to him because it reported damage honestly. Since learning what imperial tables could hide, he trusted pain less and the absence of it not at all.

Lale came up from the communal ovens carrying two flat loaves wrapped in

cloth. Flour marked her forearms. Eren Ford's evacuation had put two hundred river people in Tal Jes, along with the banked ember from her oven and every child she could fit aboard the barges. She had not forgiven Teren for making the decision without asking them. She had still brought breakfast.

"Eat," she said.

"Bound?"

Her expression tightened. "Red millet, goat curd, pepper oil. No seal. No table. I watched the kneading."

He took a loaf. The hot pepper reached his nose before he bit. "Any word from the hospital?"

"Dima needs clean linen. Twenty-six patients from yesterday's skirmish, nine too fevered to move."

"Put litters beside the west road."

"She already did." Lale looked toward the flooding plots. "You have drowned people's winter grain."

"I know the count."

"That isn't what I said."

A horn sounded below. Imperial skirmishers entered the first drowned field.

Teren handed back half the loaf. "Keep the ovens ready."

"For food?"

He did not answer quickly enough.

Lale caught the omission. "Teren."

"For food," he said, and watched her go knowing the statement held only the part of his plan she had asked about.

The contingency lay inside a grain chest beneath the command awning. He had prepared it after finding Eren Ford among the hundred cold seats. Removal without replacement caused recoil. If evacuation stripped civilians from Rován's design, a replacement table might force the burden onto soldiers who had chosen to fight. That had been the arithmetic he wrote alone. Savra would have called the words might and chosen weak joints, places where command disguised a seat nobody had named.

He had hidden the seal anyway.

At first light, Teren's ration master had cooked two cauldrons of red millet with charred goat curd. One fed the lower spear companies. The other stood near the allied field hospital, officially reserved for litter crews and defenders rotating off the line. Both burned over mixed embers: Tal Jes terraces, Ulsor salt ovens, Eren Ford, and six Free Granary wagon hearths. The ash signatures gave the food reach. A pair of bronze plates inside Teren's chest gave it direction.

The plates came from an imperial field-kitchen seal captured on the canal. Savra

had shown the cooks how to break its hidden weighting. Teren had copied the arrangement before it was destroyed, replacing five village marks with the hospital grain oath and weighting the fighting companies light.

He told himself he would use it only if the wall failed.

The first wall failed before the sun cleared the eastern ridge.

Imperial sappers pushed wicker screens through the flooded millet and reached a retaining bank. Under sling stones, they drove iron hooks into the dry-set masonry. Oxen pulled from firmer ground. The bank opened like a split sack. Mud, stones, and water crashed into the terrace below, carrying six defenders with it. Imperial infantry entered the breach behind tall shields.

Teren sent forty spears down the west stair and ordered the next irrigation gate broken rather than lowered. Released water took the flank of the advancing column. Men fell. Their shields clogged the spillway. More soldiers climbed over them.

Fire arrows rose from the oil carts.

They came high and slow, points wrapped in burning cloth, hundreds against the paling sky. Terrace crews had soaked roof mats and covered the grain stores, but the millet itself stood dry above the flooded lower plots. Flame landed among seed heads. Wind pulled it uphill.

"Cut three fields," Teren ordered. "Throw the green stalks into the fire lanes. Move the eastern reserve to the second wall."

A runner hesitated. "The reserve hasn't eaten."

"Give them the lower cauldron."

That order activated nothing. Not yet.

The defenders consumed millet from the first pot and returned to the walls. They carried ordinary fatigue, ordinary fear, ordinary burns. Teren watched one man drop his spear after an arrow scorched his palm. Another vomited behind the wall and went back to the line. The empire pressed uphill with soldiers whose gait remained impossibly even.

By midmorning, Tal Jes had lost two terraces and eighty-three defenders from the line. The hospital sent word that every floor space had filled. Dima asked for twenty more water carriers. Teren could spare six.

A second mirror signal flashed from the north. Riders had entered the gorge. Still no colors.

"If it's Issen, they need the city standing," said the waterkeeper.

"If it's imperial cavalry, we need the city standing."

"How?"

Teren looked down at the breach. One more wall gave access to the terrace road. Once the oil carts reached that grade, they could burn the ovens, the

hospital, and every gathered ember before the First Hearth arrived.

He went to the command awning.

The seal plates felt cold despite the day's heat. One carried the fighting companies as twelve shallow notches. The other hid the hospital grain oath beneath the mark for litter crews. The arrangement promised a four-to-one weighting: fighters would keep one share of heat and pain while the concealed seats carried three. Conservation remained absolute. There would be no unwounded army, only wounded people placed where the attackers could not see them.

Teren pressed the plates into clay and sent the fresh seal to the lower cauldron.

"Stamp the bowls for the second-wall companies," he told the runner. "Serve everyone who comes off rotation."

"Seat declaration?"

"Fighting companies and support crews, four measures to one."

It sounded almost true. Support crews included the hospital under the stolen notation. He did not say so.

"Where does command sit?" the runner asked.

Teren took a bowl. "Here."

He ate first because he had learned at least that much from Savra.

Red millet stuck to his teeth. Pepper oil burned the cut at the corner of his mouth. The bond settled through his limbs when the origin embers caught the seal's shape. Fatigue lifted from his shoulders, not vanishing but flowing along the table. Farther down the hill, someone else received the heaviness.

He felt the same easing pass through the defenders. Backs straightened. Burned hands closed around spear shafts. Men who had limped to the cauldron walked away with pain thinned to a manageable line.

The counterattack began.

The lower channel offered room for only twelve people abreast. Teren divided the reserve into groups of ten and assigned one terrace farmer to each, because soldiers could read an enemy line while farmers could read water. The first group crossed behind a curtain of spray from the broken gate. The second carried clay lids as shields against burning oil. A third rolled wet wool around the handles of orchard hooks and used them to drag wicker screens apart.

From above, the movement looked too small to alter a battle. At ground level, every body occupied exactly the width required. Farmers opened side sluices after the groups passed, cutting off pursuit. Sling crews received stones in shallow grain baskets rather than sacks so runners could count ammunition by basket and know when a position had five volleys left. Teren shifted twelve water carriers from the eastern cistern, then shifted four back when he saw defenders drinking from flooded plots. Bad water could win an hour and lose a company by nightfall.

A terrace boy reached the awning with an arrow through the loose flesh above his hip. He had carried three bundles of green millet to the fire lane before noticing it. Under an ordinary body's report he should have collapsed in the first field. The battle-table had spread his pain so widely that he mistook damage for permission.

"Hospital," Teren told the litter crew.

The boy gripped Teren's sleeve. "I can carry again."

"No."

"My group needs the stalks."

"They need you not bleeding into a channel."

As the litter left, Teren felt a needle of pain at his own hip. The share vanished almost at once into the concealed support weights. He knew where the remainder went. Knowledge did not stop him from sending the next group forward.

Teren sent two companies along an irrigation ditch hidden by tall millet. Slingers struck the imperial screen crews from above. Terrace farmers rolled millstones down narrow stairs, breaking shields and forcing men into flooded plots. At the breached wall, defenders locked spears and pushed.

Imperial fire landed among them.

A jar shattered on the parapet. Burning oil covered three people. They screamed, but the sound broke off with unnatural speed. One rolled beneath a wet mat and rose with red skin that should have blistered deeper. Another kept fighting while flame still clung to his sleeve.

Heat entered Teren's own arm as a broad sting, then dispersed.

He had taken a command share, lighter than the lower seats but real. That fact tried to serve as proof of fairness. It proved only that he had included himself in a wrong done to others.

"Advance the reserve," he said.

Tal Jes retook the broken wall before noon.

Below, imperial soldiers began to falter. Their own burden-table had too many injuries to export cleanly after three linked villages evacuated. The imperial front ranks showed blisters and exhaustion. Men stumbled in mud. The difference appeared tactical, almost righteous. Teren could see victory taking shape through quantities: another hour, perhaps two; one push down the terrace road; fire carts captured; route held for Issen.

Then a hospital bell rang without stopping.

The sound came from the upper fig court, where the allied field hospital occupied three wine sheds. One continuous iron note meant fire. Two meant bond injury. The bell struck without pattern because whoever held the rope had lost the strength to count.

Dima appeared at the head of the stair. Her right hand curled against her apron,

fingers unable to grip, while her left held a blackened bowl.

“Teren Avo!”

Her voice crossed the command terrace. Runners stopped. The waterkeeper turned from the channel maps.

Dima threw the bowl at Teren’s feet. It broke, showing the copper-red stamp impressed beneath its base.

“Whose seal?” she asked.

Teren dismissed nobody. Privacy would repeat the act. “Mine.”

“Name the seats.”

“Lower companies. Litter crews. Command.”

She stepped close enough for him to see a fresh burn climbing from her left wrist beneath the sleeve. Not her injured hand. A new wound.

“Name all of them.”

Around them, fire arrows continued to fall. A horn signaled imperial retreat from the second wall. Teren heard the opening and hated himself for hearing it as an opening.

“The allied field hospital,” he said.

The waterkeeper made a sound like breath punched from the chest.

Dima pointed uphill. “Twenty-six old patients. Nine fevered. Thirty-one new wounds. Four cooks, seven healers, sixteen litter workers. They ate from the support cauldron because your stamped bowls named them. Their burns appeared while your companies kept their skin.”

“I weighted the hospital across all support seats.”

“You hid them.”

“I needed one hour.”

“A patient with a splinted leg has burns inside her mouth. She never went near flame.”

Teren looked toward the fig court. Smoke rose there, but not from burning roofs. Cooks had extinguished the hospital hearth. The origin ember still lived in the lower cauldron, keeping the bond active through every swallowed bowl.

“Break the seal,” he said.

Dima’s face did not soften. “Abrupt severance throws every share back across the companies. Half of them stand above a drop.”

He had known that. The knowledge had occupied a column in his plan, under risks acceptable if the city fell.

“Bring them down by rotations,” Teren said. “Two companies at a time. Sit them before extinguishing.”

"The empire is withdrawing," said the waterkeeper. "If we pull back now, they keep the lower terraces."

"Then they keep them."

A terrace captain came running from the wall, helmet split along one side. "We can take their oil carts. Give me the eastern reserve."

"No."

"We have them."

"No pursuit. All companies return by marked stairs. Anyone who ate from the sealed cauldron sits inside the lower salt court."

The captain stared at the broken bowl. Understanding traveled across his face. He spat beside Teren's boot and went to relay the command.

Withdrawal from victory proved harder than retreat under defeat. Defenders saw imperial backs and wanted payment for burned fields. Farmers shouted that the lower terraces could still be saved. Teren sent runners with the same order until his voice roughened: return, sit, do not eat, do not cross the salt court.

He descended with the last command group. His ankle failed halfway down. Pain flared through the old crushed joint, no longer thinned because the hospital cooks had cut one origin ember. He caught the wall and continued.

Inside the salt court, four hundred defenders sat shoulder to shoulder. Some carried burns they had not felt until leaving the line. Others looked untouched. Dima's assistants moved among them, recording injuries before severance so no cost could disappear into confusion.

Lale stood at the cauldron with a splitting maul. "Where are the plates?"

Teren took them from his coat.

She read the visible notches, then turned the second plate toward the light. Eren Ford's old seal craft used river curls around communal marks. She found the hidden hospital oath immediately.

"You copied our oven mark."

"I used the evacuated oath to redirect Rován's recoil away from Eren Ford."

"Into sick people."

"Into the seats closest to the defense."

Her eyes met his. "Sick people."

No quantity changed the noun.

Dima established three temporary salt lines across the court. Fighters with open burns sat nearest the extinguishing crew. Uninjured diners moved to the outer ring. Teren took a place in the center, where the hidden weighting had assigned command its protected fraction.

"You move to the hospital share," Dima said.

Lale looked at her. "Can the seal be changed while active?"

"Not safely without the First Hearth. We can crack his command notch and let recoil find him by the ordinary seat list."

"Do it," Teren said.

Dima used the heel of her broad-handled knife. Her right hand could not hold the plate steady, so Lale pinned it to the stone. One strike flattened the command notch. A second split it through.

Pain arrived like a door kicked inward.

Heat covered Teren's left arm, chest, and face. His mouth filled with the taste of scorched cloth. His ankle took the weight of men who had run uphill on torn ligaments. Breath shortened under many fractions of panic. None of those states belonged solely to him. He could not identify lives or memories, only embodied burdens redistributed by his recipe.

Across the court, defenders cried out as their shares returned. Dima's crews held them seated. Water waited in measured jars. Nobody promised the pain would vanish.

Lale swung the maul into the clay seal on the cauldron. It cracked. Dima cut the mixed ash with plain salt, dividing the table into smaller rings. Cooks smothered each origin ember in a planned order: wagon hearths first, then Ulsor, then Eren Ford, leaving Tal Jes for last so the nearest diners carried the final recoil.

At the hospital, bells found a count again. Two strokes. Pause. Two.

When the Tal Jes ember went dark, Teren vomited red millet onto the court stones.

The bond ended. Injuries remained where conservation had left them. Some defenders now bore the burns they had escaped during battle. Hospital patients kept damage already taken before severance. A healer had lost skin along both palms. The woman with the splinted leg could not swallow water without pain.

Tal Jes had held. Its people had paid once in fields, once in battle, and once through Teren's hidden arithmetic.

Dima made him walk through the hospital before anyone discussed command.

The wine sheds had low doors and floors sloped for washing casks. Patients lay on reed mats between drainage grooves. A man admitted yesterday with a broken collarbone now carried a fire stripe across his back, although he had spent the battle under a tiled roof. Two fevered children from an evacuated terrace house shivered in the heat after sharing the defenders' sudden cold when wet clothes met mountain wind. The table had not moved disease, but it had laid battlefield states over bodies already laboring to survive their own conditions.

At each mat, Dima asked Teren to read the injury board aloud. She held the boards in her left hand. Her right fingers could steady only the lower edge.

"Transferred heat burn, shoulder and spine," he read. "Origin uncertain. Support

weighting, three shares.”

“Again.”

“Exertion collapse. Breath rhythm recovered. Two shares, possibly more.”

“Again.”

The woman with the splinted leg turned her head toward him. Blisters lined the inside of her lips. Her name, Eda Tel, had appeared on the morning hospital list. Teren had seen it as one entry among twenty-six old patients.

“Her name,” Dima said.

“Eda Tel.”

“Her seat?”

“Hidden under litter support.”

“Her choice?”

“None.”

Eda could not speak. She lifted two fingers, then pointed toward the terrace wall. Teren did not know whether she meant two sons fighting, two burns, or two times she had been used. Hearthbinding carried no explanation with pain. He had created a system in which the person harmed could not even know whose survival had entered her mouth.

Outside the last shed, a cook sifted spoiled millet from the extinguished support cauldron. Nobody could eat the remainder; the cracked seal and mixed ash made its weighting unsafe. Two full baskets went into the burial trench. Tal Jes had defended grain by ruining fields, then wasted cooked grain to end the hidden table. The quantity belonged on Teren’s account along with bodies.

Guildspeaker Mava Ul arrived from the upper council house as the wounded were being sorted. Salt dust streaked her robe. She listened to Dima’s account without looking at Teren. Around them, terrace captains reported that the empire had withdrawn beyond sling range and begun making camp. The city possessed a few hours, not victory.

Mava held out her hand. “Command tally.”

Teren removed the knotted cord from his belt. Each bead marked a company, wagon group, water crew, or allied kitchen under his orders. He had carried it since the Free Granary convoys left the river road.

“Teren yields command,” he said, making the declaration loud enough for the court recorders. “I activated a concealed weighting against the allied field hospital. I named support seats falsely. I relinquish field authority and submit the act to coalition judgment.”

Mava accepted the cord. “You will retain no operational command. You may answer questions of route and supply when asked. The terrace captains’ council holds the walls until we vote a replacement.”

"Yes."

"Do not make me ask twice for a seal you have hidden."

"There are no others."

Mava turned to Dima. "Verify that."

Dima nodded once.

The command awning came down before afternoon. Its maps moved to the council house. Teren sat outside the field hospital with his boot cut open around the swollen left ankle. He could still count the litters entering: sixty-one from the battle, thirty-eight injuries worsened by the table, eleven healers or workers burned. Numbers mattered because each person needed water, linen, fat for dressings, and a place out of the wind. They could not make the decision clean.

Lale washed soot from her arms at a basin nearby. Her own burden amounted to a blister across one shoulder, transferred from a defender through the hospital seat. She had received it while tending an oven she believed unbound.

"I thought the city would fall," Teren said.

"I know."

"If it fell, the hospital would have burned."

"I know that too."

"We held long enough for the gorge road." He stopped. The sentence sought the word necessary before he spoke it.

Lale dried her arms. "Say what you did. Don't ask the outcome to rename it."

He looked down at the cut boot. "I used them."

"Yes."

"I sat in the table."

"That did not ask them."

"I stopped it."

"After Dima found it."

Every answer remained accurate. None balanced the account.

Teren pressed both palms against the bench until the transferred burning steadied. "Will you testify?"

"At your judgment."

"For me?"

"For what happened." Lale lifted the basin. "You are my brother. That does not turn your act into a necessity."

She carried the dirty water toward the dressing yard.

From the northern watch came three mirror flashes, then one: a wagon in the gorge, imperial riders behind. No signal confirmed who drove it.

Teren's body rose before authority remembered it no longer belonged to him. Mava's new runner crossed the court without waiting for his order. Terrace crews moved toward the gorge under the council's command.

He remained beside the hospital as the red millet terraces smoked below.

Chapter 21 — The First Hearth in Exile

The left wheel struck a buried stone and threw the First Hearth against its bed of millet sacks.

Issen heard bronze grind under the wicker dome. Veyra pulled the mules hard toward the gorge wall while the wounded porter braced both boots against the wagon bed. A red coal showed through the brazier hood, bright as a cut. If the ash bed cracked, they could lose the old ember without any soldier touching it.

“Slower,” Issen called.

“Riders behind,” Veyra said.

“Dead fire moves at no speed.”

The wagon slowed enough for Issen to climb over the sacks. Dust coated their mouth, filling the cut along the lower gum. They pressed folded wool between the brazier’s nearest foot and the wagon side, then drove a wedge of broken tile under the sand cradle. Heat reached through the cloth. The ash burn on their forearm had begun to blister, but the coal remained nested.

Behind them, imperial horns answered from both ridges.

The gully narrowed toward Tal Jes. Red volcanic walls rose above a track made for goats and terrace carts, not a loaded grain wagon. Three mounted soldiers followed at bow range. More traveled on the southern road, visible only when spear points crossed gaps in the rock. Veyra’s decoy had bought half a day. It had not bought the city.

The wounded porter, Jorin, lifted his head from the wagon rail. Blood had dried through his hair. “Smoke ahead.”

Issen smelled it before they saw it: millet straw, wet fig wood, and pepper oil spilled onto hot clay. Not battlefield smoke. Kitchen smoke, made thick on purpose.

A pale column rose from the next bend. Another appeared higher on the gorge wall. Then five more fires answered from ledges where no sensible cook would build an oven.

Veyra narrowed her eyes. “Friends?”

“Someone knows the ash signals,” Issen said.

An arrow struck the wagon gate behind them.

The mules bolted. Veyra fought the reins while Issen threw their weight across the brazier hood. The left wheel rode the slope, lifting high enough to show daylight beneath it. Jorin grabbed the rear brace with one hand. The wagon slammed level and entered smoke.

Figures moved inside the cloud. A broad-shouldered woman caught the lead mule’s bridle. Her right hand hung stiff near her waist; she controlled the animal with her left.

"Dima Orr?" Issen asked.

"You know my hand. That saves introductions." Dima dragged the team toward a cut in the wall concealed by smoke. "Get down. The wagon continues."

"With what?" Veyra asked.

"Millet, your blood on the bench, and a brazier-shaped basket full of hot tiles."

Four terrace merchants swarmed the wagon. Two unpinned the wicker dome. Another cut the lashings around the sand cradle. A fourth shoved an identical covered basket beneath the sacks. Their movements carried the speed of rehearsal and none of the silence of coercion; each called the task before doing it.

A lean cook stood inside the rock cut, scar crossing her left forearm. Savra Kel did not wear the black robe shown in Hall mosaics. She wore a smoke-stained apron and carried no knives.

"Keep the hood upright," Savra said. "The north foot has less ash beneath it."

"You know the First Hearth?"

"I know how Rovon neglects a brazier while polishing its litter." Her gaze took in Issen's forearm burn, Jorin's head wound, and Veyra's cramped hands. "Who ate from a table?"

"The roof runners. Not us."

"Good. Then nobody here carries a delayed share we cannot see." Savra pointed into the cut. "Bring it through."

The passage opened into an abandoned quarry bowl. Twelve people waited around three cookfires. Every fire burned ordinary millet straw mixed with one visible coalition ember. Names had been written in charcoal on flat roof tiles. Beside each name sat a measure: one cup, two cups, or half. No marks hid beneath clay.

Issen read all twelve. "What are you binding?"

"Runners only," Dima said. "Heat and leg fatigue. No pain, no wound share. First group carries the brazier to the fig ledge. Second takes it down the terrace stair. Third draws the riders after empty fire baskets."

"Who takes the weight?"

"Everyone who eats, including cooks. Four resting carriers hold two shares each. Eight runners hold one. Duration ends when we drown each straw fire at its marked cistern."

A boy no older than sixteen stood beside the upper fire.

Issen looked at Dima.

"He carries a smoke basket, not bronze," she said. "His mother is beside him, and both volunteered after hearing the weights. If either passes the bowl, the route keeps the gap."

No hurried replacement. No office declaring that the design required every seat.

Outside the quarry, Veyra cracked the reins. The decoy wagon rolled deeper into the smoke with three merchants hidden under its cloth. Imperial riders shouted and followed.

Savra lifted a bowl of thin millet drink. "Issen Mar. You are injured and have been driving. You do not run."

"The brazier answers to my tasting office."

"Your office stayed in Namarra. Does your body have strength for a share?"

Issen's ceremonial reflex searched for the answer expected by rank. Savra waited without offering one.

"No," Issen said. "Not safely."

"Then witness the list."

Dima read every name aloud. Each person answered with weight, route, and right to pass. Two chose half shares after reporting blisters from yesterday's battle. The resting carriers sat on reed mats and accepted the doubled fatigue of the runners. Savra drank from the first bowl. Dima took the second. The cooks had seats.

Only then did the others eat.

The voluntary runner table engaged through the three straw fires. No light marked it. Shoulders lowered among the resting carriers as exertion began to reach them from people already lifting the bronze bowl. A runner's breathing steadied. Another flexed a cramped calf and took position at the forward hook.

"First team," Savra said.

They carried the First Hearth brazier from the quarry.

Issen went beside it without touching. Their task consisted of watching the hood, smelling for spilled ash, and tasting any residue that escaped. It felt almost insultingly small after the office had trained them to stand above whole kitchens. Small work proved exacting. At the fig ledge, a coal shifted toward the hood. Issen stopped the carriers, used a wet reed to press the ash inward, and checked the smoke for copper taint.

Imperial riders entered the quarry behind them.

The decoy fires had been abandoned with bowls left beside false footprints leading west. One group of pursuers took the trail. Others found the brazier tracks in loose dust and turned toward the ledge.

"Second team," Dima called.

The first carriers lowered the bowl onto a stone cradle. They sat immediately. Four new runners took the hooks. Nobody praised those leaving the weight; the table had promised relief at a marked point, and relief required no gratitude.

The terrace stair descended along the outside of the gorge wall. Tal Jes spread below, its red millet terraces striped with black from yesterday's battle. Smoke

rose from wet fields. Imperial camps occupied the lower road. The city itself clung to the volcanic slope through retaining walls, ovens, cisterns, and narrow plots of figs.

Between the stair and the nearest gate lay open ground.

A rider appeared above. He loosed an arrow at the carriers.

Dima struck it aside with a clay smoke lid held in her left hand. The impact spun her against the wall. Her right fingers could not close around the edge, but she trapped the lid beneath her forearm and kept it up.

"Move."

The second team ran.

Heat and fatigue shifted through the declared seats. On the quarry ledge, resting carriers took the climb into their own legs. Savra's breath shortened beside Issen. She had eaten as a cook, so the table did not leave her clean while others moved her design.

Two more arrows hit stone. A third entered a runner's thigh.

He fell without releasing the rear hook. The brazier tilted toward the drop.

Issen seized the rod. Pain from the runner did not transfer because the recipe excluded wounds. His injury remained his. His share of heat and fatigue still moved until he severed or the fire died.

"Pass," Dima told him.

"I can hold."

"Pass the bowl or keep it. You cannot keep the route."

The man dragged his personal salt cup from his belt and smashed it on the stair.

His bond ended. Recoil returned his exertion among the remaining named runners and resting carriers, distributed across the open half-share left for route loss. Savra staggered. One carrier cursed. Nobody inherited the arrow wound.

Issen and a reserve runner lifted the hook together. They crossed the open ground under slinger cover from Tal Jes. Stone shot drove the imperial archers behind the ridge. At the first city cistern, Dima kicked over the marked water jar. Far above, the corresponding straw fire hissed out.

Half the table released.

Runners bent over, taking back the ordinary ownership of their breath. The remaining fire carried the final team through the gate and into a roofed grain court. When the bronze feet touched its prepared sand bed, Savra extinguished the last origin ember with brine.

The First Hearth's own coal continued to glow beneath its hood. Separate fire. Separate custody. The rescue bond ended cleanly around it.

Dima leaned against the wall. "That is how we get a brazier into a city without putting the city in the bowl."

Issen looked at the injured runner being carried toward the hospital. "He broke his cup."

"He knew it would hurt us."

"And you left room."

"We learned." Her glance went toward the burned terraces. "Not quickly enough."

Tal Jes's allied field hospital occupied old wine sheds above the grain court. Issen entered behind the brazier and found rows of people injured in places they had never fought. A woman with a splinted leg had blisters inside her mouth. Healers wore fresh dressings on their hands. Dima's new burn disappeared under the sleeve of her left wrist while the ruined fine grip of her right hand remained what she had chosen at Ember Bridge.

Teren sat outside beneath a fig tree with his left boot cut open. No command tally hung at his belt.

Before Issen reached him, Dima brought them to the hospital's support kitchen. The broken bowl seal lay in a tray beside the hearth, separated into six pieces. Its visible face named litter crews with four ordinary notches. Under the base, a river curl enclosed the hospital oath.

Issen turned the largest fragment with a wooden pick. "This cut comes from the Hall's sixth campaign alphabet. The clerk reads it as provisions retained near the fighting line."

"Can you prove what it means?" Mava asked from the doorway.

"In the ration archive, yes. Here, I can show the copying error." Issen indicated a hooked stroke where the clay had spread. "An original sixth-alphabet support mark bends inward. This one bends toward the Eren Ford curl because whoever copied it worked from a reversed bronze plate."

Dima's mouth hardened. "Teren had plates."

"Then preserve every fragment. Wrap them separately in unbound cloth. Do not fit them together over live ash."

A kitchen assistant reached for linen, paused, and asked, "Why unbound?"

"Because the clay still carries mixed ash. It cannot activate without food, origin embers, and swallowed seats, but evidence should not share signatures before judgment." Issen heard how easily instruction returned to their voice. "That is a recommendation, not an order."

Mava nodded to the assistant. "Do it."

At the wash bench, Dima showed Issen the morning serving boards. Twenty-six old patients had been written by name. The hidden seal had not erased those names; it had placed a second meaning beneath the category that joined them. Concealment did not always require missing records. Sometimes it survived by making the truthful list answer the wrong question.

"I tasted support broths for years," Issen said. "We were trained to ask whether litter crews could continue carrying. Nobody asked if the people on the litters had entered through the same oath."

"You could have asked," Dima said.

"Yes."

"Did any rule forbid it?"

"No. The rule made the question seem incompetent."

Dima used her left hand to scrub millet from a pot. Her damaged right hand held the rim against the bench with the heel of the palm. "Then when you speak in the public kitchen, name the questions too. Crimes like this survive on what respectable people learn not to ask."

Issen memorized the sentence without claiming it as their own.

They passed the dressing shed again on the way out. Eda Tel slept with her splinted leg raised and her burned mouth open to cooler air. Beside her, a young assistant measured water in spoonfuls because swallowing a cup caused too much pain. Issen could identify the carrier oil used in the Hall eleven years ago by residue alone. That skill could not tell Eda which defender's fire had reached her. The meal had moved sensation without memory, context, or consent, leaving the injured person with burden stripped even of explanation.

Only then did Issen approach the fig tree.

Teren rose when Issen approached, then steadied himself on the bench. "You reached us."

"So did your riders."

"Not mine anymore."

Mava Ul came from the shed. "Teren yielded command yesterday. He used a concealed seal against this hospital."

No courteous phrase could make the sight easier to receive. Issen looked from Teren to the patients. "Under support notation?"

His face changed. "Yes."

"The Hall files hospital oaths under litter provision. I certified three campaigns where that column appeared." Issen had called the meals safe because no poison entered the officers' bowls. "I never asked whom support meant."

Teren sat again. "You came to testify against Rován."

"I came to stop pretending the testimony ends with him."

By afternoon, the First Hearth stood in the largest public kitchen of Tal Jes. Guards remained outside at Savra's insistence. Inside waited the twelve Ulsor cooks, Dima, Lale, Mava, terrace witnesses, Teren without authority, and every merchant ally who had survived the convoy. Veyra arrived last after abandoning the decoy wagon in an irrigation ravine.

Issen asked for a stool, then removed the remaining insignia from their tunic. The cut badge at the throat had left stitches and a pale square. They laid it beside the brazier.

"My office certified safety by tasting the portion prepared for power," they said. "I swallowed first and allowed the order to imply that distant mouths would receive the same meal."

Nobody interrupted.

"I certified ration oil during the Qar campaign when village cold seats carried soldiers' fever heat. I certified the Hall banquet after the Seln Canal seizures while imprisoned millers received the guests' hunger. At Halvek, I tasted the victory course after civilians had already taken the wounds. I did not write those seat lists. I made their concealment look safe."

Issen named each ceremony they remembered. Twelve in full. Seven more with dates but uncertain kitchens. They identified which tasting phrases had concealed absent ledgers: no harmful residue, balanced according to measure, fit for common service. Every phrase had described the food placed before them, never the system carrying its cost.

Veyra listened with her arms folded. Mava's recorder filled two wax tablets. Savra did not offer forgiveness. She asked for the name of one carrier oil used eleven years ago, and Issen gave it.

When the account ended, their mouth had gone dry.

Mava said, "Will you sign this before public witnesses?"

"Yes."

"Will you submit to judgment after Equinox?"

"Yes."

No title protected the answers.

Savra approached the brazier. "Open it."

Issen unlatched the pierced copper hood. The hinges resisted from years of soot. Beneath lay a packed bed of pale ash surrounding seven coals. Six glowed red. The seventh had darkened along one edge during flight but still carried heat at its center.

Savra held Rován's witness spoon impression above the bowl without touching it. Black hearth-salt clung in copied grooves. The old ember responded with a faint blue line around the spoon's shadow.

"The topology is still writable," she said.

Dima exhaled. Lale set a clean clay ring around the bronze feet. Each cook laid a separate line of provincial salt outside it, not yet joined.

Issen looked at the blackened bowl on a terrace city's worktable. "What do we call it now?"

"The First Hearth in exile," said Mava. "Until a public council decides whose hearth it can be."

A bell keeper entered from the western tower, face streaked with soot. "The capital signal fires have changed. Equinox provisioning began at noon."

Savra counted on her fingers, not ceremonially but like a cook measuring what remained. "Three days."

"Three days until the Feast?" Veyra asked.

"Three days to make a recipe no single fire can own." Savra lowered the hood but left the latch open.

Around the brazier, the provincial salt lines remained separate. Outside, crews carried the Tal Jes wounded past the kitchen door one named person at a time, while recorders marked each injury and declared share on fresh clay.

Part IV

Chapter 22 — A Recipe with Open Seats

Savra rolled dough across the Tal Jes worktable until it covered a map of the basin.

The dough contained no live ash, only red millet flour, water, and enough oil to keep it from cracking. She pressed one hundred chickpeas into it where Issen's list placed the intended hearths. Three clustered in Namarra. The last sat in Kelar, marked by a bitter fenugreek seed.

Around the map stood twelve coalition cooks, Mava Ul, Issen, Dima, Lale, and four merchant route planners. The First Hearth rested on a sand bed behind Savra. Its hood remained open. Seven coals breathed under pale ash.

"Show us why the circles from yesterday cannot scale," Mava said.

Savra drew separate salt lines around four chickpeas. "A local table can disclose its own seats, weights, duration, and severance. We proved that. The First Hearth can hold the circles in one topology without mixing their lists. We proved that too."

She set Rován's witness spoon impression at the center. It carried the copied grooves of a master weighting, black hearth-salt packed into each line.

"When a person leaves one circle, recoil returns to that circle. At twelve seats, we leave a planned share unfilled and spread the return among people who agreed. At one hundred hearths, thousands may sever at once. No local cook can reserve enough bodies for an event in another province."

"Then do not connect them," said a fish cook from Ulsor.

"If we do not connect them, Rován's weighting enters first and joins every provincial ember to his hidden wards. The counter-recipe must overwrite that topology at activation." Savra pressed a ring around all one hundred markers, then cut the ring into local arcs. "Connected enough to refuse him. Separate enough to refuse us."

Dima leaned her right forearm on the table. Her fingers could not pinch salt, so she used a broad-handled scoop held against her palm. "Yesterday's runner table had an open half-share."

"For twelve people."

"Make the open share travel."

Savra looked at the dough. An open seat could receive recoil if the recipe named its function and left capacity for it. In the experiments at Ulsor, they had kept such seats local, visible, and small. A traveling opening across nested circles needed the First Hearth to recognize it without turning into Rován's universal sink.

"Not travel," she said. "Remain common."

Nobody answered immediately.

She cut a hole in the dough map's center.

Lale saw it first. "One seat outside the local arcs but inside the outer topology."

"Named," Savra said. "Weighted openly. Attached to every severance line, never to ordinary burden."

"A person?" Issen asked.

"A body. The magic cannot seat a principle."

Mava's face gave away nothing. "Whose?"

Savra placed her left thumb into the hole. The oven scar crossed its rim. "We test before we answer that."

The first trial used eight diners, four local tables, and four cookfires set along the courtyard wall. Each pair received a different preparation of millet: sour paste to accelerate heat transfer, oil-rich cakes to delay it, plain porridge for immediate equal weighting, and steamed grain held behind a separate salt line. The First Hearth contributed one coal no larger than a pea, carried to the center brazier in an iron cup.

Dima had made personal salt cups from thin clay. Each bore the diner's name on the outside and chosen weight inside. Smashing a cup would break that seat's salt connection. It would not erase the diner's existing injury or hunger. It could only stop further sharing and return unsettled burden according to the topology.

Savra read the list. No one answered for another person. One merchant refused after learning that sour millet might return pain quickly. The refusal left a gap; nobody filled it.

For controlled pain, Dima heated a bronze tasting pin over an unbound lamp. "One touch to my left forearm. No broken skin. Pain share only. No heat transfer after three breaths."

Her right hand already carried the permanent cost of Ember Bridge. She offered the left because the test could not turn history into an inexhaustible resource.

"Local table one," Savra said. "Dima source, Veyra partner, equal weight. Cook Savra seated at one quarter through the central witness. Tables two through four receive nothing."

They ate.

Dima pressed the warm pin to her arm. Pain entered Savra as a bright coin beneath the skin. Veyra hissed. Dima's face eased as their bodies carried the declared fractions. Across the courtyard, the other diners felt nothing.

"Break," Dima told Veyra.

Veyra smashed her salt cup.

Recoil returned. Dima doubled over as Veyra's unsettled share came back through the local line. Savra took a smaller fraction through the cook's seat. The other circles remained untouched.

"That kills a person if a thousand cups break," Lale said.

"It kills many local sources," Savra answered. "Again, with the center open."

Mava caught her wrist. "You said test before answer. State the seat."

Savra had spent ten years refusing any table large enough to require her. Refusal had protected others from her control. It had also let her imagine that absence carried no weight.

"The central function takes only severance recoil," she said. "No ordinary hunger, wound, fatigue, or heat enters it while local cups remain whole. Every participant sees the function on their list. Every local cook may refuse the whole topology. The person in the center may sever, but doing so returns recoil to the local circles unless another named volunteer takes the place."

"And you volunteer," Mava said.

"Yes."

"That is not penance."

"No." Savra kept her thumb inside the dough's central hole. "Penance cannot serve as a weighting rule."

Dima set down the tasting pin. "Call it what it does."

"Always-open balancing seat."

Issen repeated the phrase while looking at the witness spoon grooves. "Open to return, not open to unnamed diners."

"Exactly. One named body. No hidden replacement."

Mava released Savra's wrist. "Write yourself into the test. Not the final feast. We decide that after results."

They rebuilt the four local salt lines. Savra mixed a pinch of black hearth-salt into dough at the center and pressed the witness spoon impression across it. The First Hearth coal glowed blue at the edge. Each local cook copied only the line connecting their circle to the central opening. No cook received another circle's seat names.

Savra ate from a plain bowl marked with her full name and central function. The millet tasted of mineral ash and old ovens. It carried no power until the others swallowed.

Dima touched the pin to her left forearm again.

Pain divided locally. Veyra broke a fresh cup.

This time the released share struck Savra alone.

Her arm jerked. The sensation carried Dima's pain without the heat that caused it, exact in state and stripped of origin story. Dima still retained her source share. Veyra kept whatever pain had entered before she severed. Conservation held.

At the second table, a terrace farmer held his hand over steaming water for two

breaths, sharing heat with a baker. The baker smashed her cup. Scalding warmth entered Savra's palm while the farmer's hand cooled only by the amount distributed. At the third, two runners climbed the courtyard stairs until their legs shook. One severed. Savra's thighs filled with the returned exertion. The fourth table delayed hunger through oil-rich cakes, then broke both cups together.

That recoil put Savra on her knees.

The courtyard stones came close. Her empty stomach contracted with the hunger of two people who had fasted since dawn for the test. Their local cook kept a declared fraction. Savra took the unsettled return. Nothing came from the other tables except recoil released by choice.

Dima crouched beside her. "Can you continue?"

"Yes."

"That answer belongs to the seat, not the recipe designer. Do you continue?"

Savra checked her hands. Steady enough. Breath fast but regular. No wound had entered. "I continue for one more break."

At Mava's signal, nobody broke another cup. The distinction mattered. A balancing seat did not give the room permission to spend the person inside it merely because capacity remained.

They extinguished the local fires in reverse order. The First Hearth coal returned to its bronze bowl. Savra's hunger persisted until digestion settled the table, but no delayed share escaped into an unlisted body.

The cooks spent the next four hours trying to break the design.

They removed a local ember before a salt cup broke. Recoil found Savra through the central line. They soured one table and oiled another. Timing changed, conservation did not. They left a diner's cup unbroken while the diner walked beyond the city gate. Distance made no difference after swallowing, as expected. They placed two people with the same name in different circles and discovered that the cup marks needed hearth identifiers as well as personal names.

Savra corrected the dough map with a barley awn beside every name: hearth, person, weight.

Issen tested the spoken declaration. "If a Namarra baker hears only their local list, how do they know the center exists?"

"Every list begins with it," Savra said. "Name of balancing volunteer, current weight, severance consequence. Then the local seats."

"So the one common fact is who pays for departure."

"Yes."

Lale stood opposite Savra. "If ten thousand people break cups, you die."

"Possibly before ten thousand."

"Then local circles inherit whatever remains."

"If the central seat fails without severing, the topology loses its route. Recoil returns along the local salt lines. The cups still let people leave before that happens."

"You cannot promise safety."

"No."

"What do you promise?"

"That nobody enters hidden. Nobody stays because a replacement has been coerced. Every burden remains real."

Lale looked toward the hospital roof. "Teren could have said the last sentence."

"He could have. Visibility does not make a decision just." Savra pressed the central dough flat. "It makes the person deciding answerable to those who can see the cost."

Mava called the political review after sunset. The cooks sat in a circle without bound food. Each held a copy of their local test list. Nobody held the whole design except in memory and in the dough map, which would be cooked and eaten unbound when they finished.

The Ulsor fish cook objected to one central body. "You are rebuilding a master seat."

"A master sends weight outward," Dima said. "This one receives only what diners reject."

"Savra still becomes indispensable."

Savra answered before anyone defended her. "Then name successors before activation. A chain of volunteers, each able to refuse before taking the seat. If no one takes it, the table remains local and Rován's bond may enter where we fail."

Mava added the succession disclosure. Dima volunteered second, subject to a limit because of her right hand and hospital duties. Veyra volunteered third. Six others added names with stated conditions. Nobody praised them.

Teren attended from outside the circle. Mava had invited his logistical advice, not his vote. "One central kitchen cannot reach one hundred hearths in time," he said.

"It does not need to," Savra replied. "We need enough entry fires inside Namarra to overwrite the capital's three ovens when Rován activates them."

"How many?"

"Twenty-four gives us the routes Issen identified. Fewer may work. We do not pretend to know the threshold."

"Then plan for twenty-four and expect losses."

Mava's gaze hardened.

Teren corrected himself. "Plan twenty-four routes. Leave every missing kitchen as a deliberate gap. Do not replace it without council agreement."

The revision cost him. Savra saw that and did not call it redemption.

Twenty-four merchant kitchens assembled before midnight. Some belonged to the twelve trained cooks; others paired a trained tablewright with a baker, oil factor, caravan cook, or public-oven keeper who knew Namarra's wards. Each team memorized one local arc and the common opening declaration. Route planners assigned festival gates, grain carts, service alleys, and lighting times.

No written master copy would travel.

Savra divided the recipe into spoken passes. First: source ember, local fire, food, names. Second: hearth-person-weight marks inside every salt cup. Third: central volunteer declared before local seats. Fourth: witness-spoon line copied in black salt but kept outside each circle until imperial activation. Fifth: any smashed cup severs its owner and sends unsettled recoil to the always-open balancing seat.

Teams recited until another kitchen could correct them. Issen introduced small errors on purpose: a missing cook's seat, an unnamed successor, oil added before souring, a central line drawn through rather than beside local salt. Every error had to be identified by someone who did not belong to that kitchen.

Memorizing words did not prove that hands could reproduce the recipe. Savra sent the teams to separate corners of Tal Jes with equal packets of millet flour, black salt, plain salt, and oil. Each had to build its arc on a cold hearth while a witness from another route watched without helping. The fish cooks drew salt by pinching from the bowl. Dima poured hers through a narrow horn because her right fingers could not hold a pinch. A caravan baker used the squared edge of a flour board. Different hands produced different lines; only placement and declared meaning had to match.

The seventh team failed when its oil factor put the central line beneath the local ring. In a live hearth, the arrangement would have made the balancing volunteer a source for ordinary local burden rather than a recipient of severance recoil. Savra scraped the whole diagram away.

"Correct the line," the oil factor said.

"Build the kitchen again."

"We know the error."

"You know this error. Fatigue will make another." Savra returned the packet unopened. "If a witness catches a central-line fault, extinguish, discard the food, and start with cold vessels. Nobody repairs topology over a live ember."

The delay cost them two hours and one measure of flour. Teren, observing for the route council, noted the loss without asking her to accept a quicker correction.

At the northern cistern, the fourteenth team discovered that spoken declarations changed meaning across provincial dialects. An Ulsor phrase for an unused bowl sounded in Tal Jes like a diner who had not yet eaten. Issen replaced it with physical terms: cup whole, cup broken, seat receiving, seat closed. Each team had

to point while speaking. Translation could vary; the visible state could not.

Veyra tested route memory by moving markers on the ground. “Your festival gate closes. Your assigned oven has imperial guards. Your second cook does not arrive. What remains?”

The teams answered separately.

“Route closes, kitchen stays dark.”

“No substitute cook from the street.”

“Carry the ember onward only if the next named kitchen accepts it.”

“Leave a deliberate gap.”

One public-oven keeper offered to split her team if another disappeared. Mava refused the proposal. Splitting would create a twenty-fifth kitchen that had never rehearsed its local arc and might use half-heard names. The network’s strength had to include the ability to remain incomplete.

Near midnight, Dima placed a broken practice cup before each group. “Tell me what the person who breaks this owes you.”

Several answers came quickly: warning, reason, time to brace. Dima shook her head.

“They owe none of that. If they can warn us, warning helps. If they cannot speak, the break still counts. You volunteered for recoil with open eyes. Do not turn your preparation into their obligation.”

Savra watched the correction settle uneasily. A recipe could disclose a right and still grow a custom that punished its use. No salt line could prevent that. The witnesses would have to.

At dawn, all twenty-four teams recited without correction.

Savra put the dough map into the largest unbound oven. Heat swelled it around the chickpeas, then cracked the central hole. People ate the bread with lentils and no seal.

Only the witness spoon impression remained as a portable master. Savra placed it on the hearthstone.

Mava said, “Once broken, we cannot copy the topology again.”

“Twenty-four kitchens can.”

“People forget.”

“Then no object should let one person correct them from above.”

Dima held the impression steady with the heel of her right palm. Savra used a borrowed cleaver. Her own knives remained in Mava’s custody.

One blow split the copied spoon bowl. A second broke the handle grooves. They distributed the fragments among four cold salt jars, where no live ash could answer them.

Behind Savra, the First Hearth burned under civic guard. Before her, twenty-four merchant kitchens carried the recipe in separate memories, each with a route and the authority to leave a gap.

Savra washed the borrowed cleaver. Hunger from the test tightened through her again, a delayed wave from the oil-rich cakes. She gripped the edge of the basin until it passed.

Mava laid the final volunteer list beside her hand. "You occupy the first balancing seat if the kitchens affirm at Namarra."

"If they affirm."

"No command title. No restored office."

"No."

Outside, merchant teams began loading flour, salt cups, oil jars, and twenty-four covered ember pots for the road. Each pot carried one visible route mark and no authority beyond its named kitchen.

Chapter 23 — The Man Who Called Hunger Peace

Rovan tested the west public oven by laying his palm against its outer brick.

Heat entered evenly from the firebox. No cold seam marked a cracked flue. Inside, two hundred white loaves rose in standardized pans, each stamped with the measure of Namarra and the grain oath of its ward. Bakers moved around him with lowered eyes. Their work continued because cities expected bread even when officials brought soldiers into kitchens.

“Open the fourth damper,” Rovan said.

The oven master obeyed. Flame drew harder beneath the stone deck.

“The Equinox batch will scorch at that draft,” she said.

“It will carry three provincial oils. The added fat slows the crust.”

“The old recipe used the First Hearth to settle them.”

Rovan removed his hand. Soot marked his palm in a gray square. “The old recipe has changed.”

He had known for four days that the brazier had vanished from the Hall. Warden Pel’s report described pepper dust, a forged burn, merchant accomplices, and the First Taster’s tasting chain left on the inspection-court floor. Riders had recovered the cedar litter and a decoy basket. They had not recovered Issen Mar.

At dawn, a signal from Tal Jes confirmed that a covered bronze fire had entered the terrace city. Rovan no longer had the comfort of imagining the thieves had extinguished what they stole.

He walked around the west oven while clerks read the revised preparation. Ninety-seven provincial hearths still carried sealed imperial embers. Three capital civic ovens supplied the missing anchors, making one hundred target fires. Under the intended design, the First Hearth would have overwritten differences in their nested weightings and made the whole table answer one central recipe. Without it, the three Namarra ovens had to force a common current through standardized loaves and simultaneous lighting.

The bond would engage roughly. Some provinces would receive burden before others. Recoil would rise wherever local embers resisted. The hidden wards had sufficient capacity if the activation did not lose more than eight hearths.

“Seven,” corrected the clerk beside him.

Rovan looked at the wax calculation. “You have not counted Kelar.”

“The refugee seal remains active.”

“Issen carried the list. Assume Savra knows its purpose.”

The clerk changed the figure to eight.

A design that required optimism had already failed. Rovan did not call the new

plan elegant. Elegance belonged to demonstrations and commemorative feasts. States survived through what remained functional after theft.

"Proceed with all three ovens," he said. "Move first lighting forward by one watch. The provincial kitchens will follow the capital signal."

The oven master's hands stopped over a tray. "The festival gates will still be admitting merchants."

"Then the gates will close."

Rovan left before she could turn concern into objection.

The west ward had kept one old famine wall behind its public granary. New plaster ended at a jagged vertical line, exposing mud brick darkened by cooking smoke. As a boy, Rovan had waited against that wall with a clay ration disk clenched in both hands. The disk promised one cup of millet. The granary held grain. The official measure said the ward had enough for everyone if distribution remained equal.

By the sixth day, private courtyards had begun baking at night.

He remembered the smell more clearly than faces. Sesame oil warmed behind closed shutters. Barley crust charred on a household stone. A family three doors away fed its servants while the public line received half cups because reserve figures had changed. Hunger made every hidden meal an accusation. People struck one another at the pumps, then at the granary doors, then over a dead mule before its blood cooled.

His mother kept two handfuls of lentils sewn into a cushion. She opened it on the seventh night. Rovan watched her divide the lentils between him and his younger cousin while an old aunt turned her face toward the wall. Nobody called the division cruel. It preserved the children most likely to live.

The cousin died anyway after drinking canal water.

On the ninth day, soldiers opened a merchant cellar and found enough grain to feed the ward for three days. The merchant had kept it dry behind false brick while public measures reported nothing. A crowd beat him to death before the first sack reached the street.

No account of Rovan's childhood famine recorded what the grain tasted like when it finally came. He remembered weevils crushed into meal, smoke from the merchant's house, and the shame of chewing while bodies remained beside the cellar door.

He had drawn the wrong lesson with perfect conviction: private sensation made private morality. If every full stomach carried a fraction of every empty one, no household could close its shutters. If every province felt the wound it permitted elsewhere, war would cease before a spear moved.

Later study taught him that hearthbinding could enact the conclusion. Government taught him that nobody surrendered private advantage voluntarily at

continental scale. Someone had to set the weights.

The boy at the famine wall had not imagined becoming that someone. The man crossing Namarra's ward square considered the distinction sentimental.

His carriage waited by the old granary. Rován chose to walk. Festival workers hung red canopies across the avenue. Potters stacked thousands of thin salt cups at public tables, believing them ceremonial vessels for the Equinox toast. Hall agents would fill those cups after activation so no one could break a seat before the bond settled. The design protected the table from panic.

It also protected Rován from refusal.

He entered the northern infirmary through its laundry court. The public wards occupied the sunward rooms. His inspectors took him down two levels, beyond storerooms of vinegar, linen, and burial salt. A bronze seal closed the lowest passage.

"Capacity?" Rován asked.

"Six hundred twelve bodies fed and marked," said the ward superintendent. "Another eighty expected from debt court tonight."

"Condition?"

"Stable enough for transfer. We excluded the dying."

The hidden sink wards smelled of boiled barley and damp stone. Beds stood in rows beneath low vaults. Some held debt prisoners, some army invalids, some people collected from streets under fever ordinances. All had eaten grain-oath porridge for three days. Clay tags at their beds listed categories rather than names: reserve breath, heat sink, hunger depth, pain dispersal.

Rován stopped at a woman whose left leg ended below the knee. "Why pain dispersal?"

The superintendent consulted his board. "Old cavalry wound. High tolerance. No family petitioner."

"Tolerance does not increase capacity. It delays reporting."

"I can move her to heat."

"Move her to ordinary hunger. She has less tissue to carry thermal injury."

The woman watched them as if they discussed a vessel. Rován met her gaze.

"You will receive hunger from the southern wards," he said. "Your own meals continue."

"Can I say no?"

The superintendent shifted.

Rován did not lie. "No."

"Then why tell me?"

"Because concealment adds no mercy."

She laughed once. "You built this room under the laundry."

Her answer followed him to the next row.

The ward superintendent had arranged the rooms by bodily state. Hunger reserves received thin barley porridge at dawn and a measured lentil meal at dusk, enough to keep them stable while preserving capacity to carry the festival's expected want. Heat sinks slept under damp linen with braziers removed. Breath reserves occupied the driest vault, where attendants counted respirations through glass timers. Pain dispersal took the largest chamber and the highest dose of poppy milk, although intoxication itself could pass through an active table if the seal admitted it.

Rovan stopped an attendant before she poured a second cup for a man tagged pain dispersal. "One dose only after first lighting. If he enters dulled, the table will spread the drug state as well as pain."

"He has been crying since morning."

"Then sit with him."

"I have forty beds."

"Assign another attendant."

The superintendent consulted her tally. "We have no reserve staff below."

Rovan looked along the row. Administrative design had reached its physical edge: one pair of hands, forty beds, a rule that required an unavailable second person. He could transfer an attendant from the public ward, reducing care there; bring a guard down, though guards were not trained for the work; or let the man cry.

"Move two record clerks from intake," he said. "Boards wait. Bodies do not."

The superintendent marked the order. It would improve the night for perhaps eight people. Rovan accepted the improvement without mistaking it for structural change. In his own account, this honesty distinguished him from officials who called every local mercy justice.

A service corridor connected the wards to an underground kitchen. Three cauldrons held barley at different thicknesses. Kitchen workers weighed salt on Hall scales and pressed each bowl onto the appropriate bed tag. The system needed food to carry ash signatures and grain oaths; labels alone could bind nothing. Rovan checked the storage jars and found enough grain for two more days.

"What happens on the third?" he asked.

"Great Table distributions should reduce capital stores needed by then," said the kitchen overseer.

"Should."

"The provisioning plan assumes provincial equalization."

Rovan opened a lentil jar. Weevils moved beneath the top layer. "Sift these. Increase oil by one finger in the hunger ward after activation. If the southern provinces carry less scarcity than projected, reduce the ward weight before reducing food."

A sink ward could not create hunger. It could only receive contractions, weakness, nausea, and the bodily timing of deprivation from joined diners. Feeding its occupants did not nullify incoming state, but starving them first would reduce their ability to survive the transfer. The cruelty had to remain provisioned in order to function.

In the breath chamber, a prisoner raised his hand. "My tag says two measures. The board at intake said one."

Rovan took the clay tag. A fresh groove crossed the back, doubling the weight.

"Who changed this?"

No attendant answered.

The superintendent found the intake board. One measure remained written beside the man's number. A lower clerk had increased tags to meet capacity after sixty army invalids were marked for removal.

Rovan snapped the tag in two. "Restore every intake weight. Find the clerk who changed them."

"For discipline?"

"For testimony. Then reduce the activation ceiling by the missing capacity."

The prisoner watched him. "You think keeping the first wrong makes you clean of the second."

"No," Rovan said. "I think unmeasured changes make any system indistinguishable from appetite."

"And measured ones?"

"Can be stopped at a limit."

The man looked at the locked door. Rovan continued before the obvious answer became speech.

At the kitchen exit, he found a stack of blank bed tags already cut. Enough for three hundred more bodies. He had authorized reserve material for emergency displacement, not intake. The superintendent said debt court expected only eighty.

"Burn the blanks," he said.

"Provisioner?"

"If the activation runs short, an empty tag will become an invitation to fill it."

"You ordered the gates locked. There will be arrests."

"Arrest does not create a sink seat without my seal."

Rovan signed the destruction order and watched a clerk carry the tags toward

the kitchen fire. He did not notice that he had framed restraint as the persistence of his personal control. He saw only a boundary held against lesser officials.

Official plans called these wards balancing reserves. Savra had called them cold seats when she first discovered their use in the Nine-Salt campaign. The older term had spread among rebels because it described what the notation tried to remove: living bodies kept outside the visible warmth of the meal.

Rovan had ordered names preserved in sealed ledgers. He had mandated minimum rations, medical inspection, and exclusion of children after the first trials. Each reform reduced arbitrary harm. None changed the absence of choice.

"Grand Provisioner." The superintendent pointed to a boy on a lower cot.

Not a child, Rovan saw after looking twice. A small adult with scarred cheeks and a baker's burn along one forearm.

"Tam Vesso," the superintendent said. "Festival cook from the south ward. Arrested copying oven schedules for merchants. Execution set at dusk."

Tam sat up. "You moved it from tomorrow."

"Gate security," said the superintendent.

Rovan examined the burn. Old, cleanly healed. "You worked a public oven."

"Third south."

"Your team?"

"Arrested or gone."

"You know its damper faults."

Tam looked at him with the deliberate blankness of someone refusing to offer useful fear.

"The south oven must carry sour millet at first lighting," Rovan said. "Its rear deck runs cool. You will supervise the corrected draft."

"And after?"

"Your execution will be stayed pending review."

The superintendent said, "Provisioner, the charge carries no review."

"It does now."

Tam's mouth tightened. "You need a cook, so you call the rope a review."

"I need thousands fed through an oven you know. You need time in which outcomes may change. Neither need requires us to decorate the exchange."

"If I refuse?"

"The sentence proceeds."

Coercion stated plainly remained coercion. Rovan knew that. He also knew Tam possessed a choice between two real conditions, while the bodies around them possessed none. Degrees mattered in provisioning even when moral language

preferred clean divisions.

Tam swung his feet to the floor. "I supervise the oven. No binding my old crew through my oath."

"Agreed. Their marks are already void under arrest."

"I taste the first batch."

"The Hall supplies a taster."

"I taste it or hang."

Rovan considered. Tam might poison the batch, but tasting first would make that difficult. "Accepted."

The superintendent cut the bed cord.

Rovan paused at the last ward, where sixty soldiers slept after receiving wounds at Halvek without visible cuts. Their bodies had carried exported pain after the Halvek field table faltered. The empire's own system had made them evidence against its claim of controlled distribution.

"Move these soldiers aboveground," he said.

"They add four hundred pain shares."

"They have already carried assigned burden. Use the debt intake."

One act of limit did not cleanse the ward. It reflected Rovan's preference for accounts that could still distinguish service from seizure. He left before the soldiers woke.

At the Hall of Measures, the festival security council waited around a map weighted with grain scoops. Reports placed merchant convoys at all six gates. Twenty-four unusual kitchen licenses had appeared in the previous two days, though some might represent duplicated names or ordinary festival growth. Issen's route knowledge made every service entrance suspect.

"Close the festival gates at sunset," Rovan said. "Inspect all live embers against Hall registries. Detain unlicensed tablewrights. Ordinary cooks continue service under guard."

A commander touched the north gate marker. "Closing traps thirty thousand visitors inside."

"It also traps any coalition kitchens."

"If the crowd panics?"

"Feed them. The bond will equalize hunger after first lighting."

"Until then?"

Rovan moved three reserve wagons to the public squares. "Open these stores at gate closure. Standard half ration, no hearthseal before the Equinox batch."

The council recorded the order. He did not call soldiers to clear the tables. A festival remained useful only while people believed they attended a feast.

Night gathered over Namarra as workers prepared the Hall pavilion. The Great Table curved around a central cauldron broad enough for six cooks to stir at once. One hundred narrow salt channels ran outward across the floor toward symbolic provincial settings. Beneath those channels, hidden bronze conductors joined the real oven seals.

Rovan inspected his place.

A high-backed chair stood on a stone dais, with writing surface, signal levers, and a speaking horn connected to the oven courtyards. Its front legs touched the outer salt ring. Its rear legs did not.

"Move it back one handspan," he told an attendant.

The attendant obeyed. Now the entire chair stood outside the salt line.

From there Rovan could monitor weighting changes without receiving the Great Table's hunger, heat, wounds, or panic. Feastwrights had argued that command required an unburdened body. He had accepted the logic because a hand on the measures needed steadiness.

Tam Vesso, brought under guard to inspect the south-oven signal, looked at the chair. "Equal hunger?"

"Equal distribution among the joined provinces."

"Not to you."

"The person adjusting the weights cannot be impaired by them."

Tam gave him the same laugh as the woman in the buried ward. "Convenient work."

Rovan rested one hand on the chair back. He could have ordered the cook removed. Instead, he looked along the salt channels toward one hundred empty settings. Tomorrow those lines would carry enough shared pain to make invasion irrational, rebellion physically costly, and hidden plenty impossible.

His own exemption appeared temporary against that scale, a technical necessity rather than private advantage. The explanation fit every measure he trusted.

"Take him to the south oven," Rovan said.

Guards led Tam away. In the squares beyond the Hall, gate bells began to ring. Iron leaves closed one by one across the festival roads, sealing merchants, cooks, pilgrims, and coalition agents inside Namarra.

Rovan sat beyond the salt and ordered the first oil warmed. An attendant set a plain cup of water at his right hand, outside every channel. He drank while bakers below turned loaves meant to join thousands of bodies. No borrowed hunger tightened his stomach. No sink prisoner's breath entered his chest. The steadiness he had reserved for command felt, to him, like evidence that the system still possessed a mind.

Chapter 24 — Merchants at the Festival Gates

Teren's grain cart reached Namarra after the gates had closed.

Iron leaves met across the southern arch, studded with bronze bosses and guarded by two ranks of soldiers. Outside waited six hundred festival merchants whose licenses had become worthless between one mile marker and the next. Goats bawled inside wicker pens. Oil jars warmed under noon sun. Drivers argued that fruit would rot, fish would sour, and pilgrims would riot if the city kept its own feast beyond locked walls.

Teren stood on his bad ankle beside thirty sacks of red millet and did not look at the covered ember pot beneath the driver's bench.

Twenty-four kitchens approached Namarra by six roads. None carried a complete list of the others. Teren knew their planned gates, staging wards, courier phrases, and latest acceptable arrival. Mava's route council had granted him coordination because he could count carts and travel time. It had not restored command. Every merchant cook retained the right to turn back.

At the arch, a Hall inspector raised a speaking trumpet. "Only contracted provisions enter. Present manifests by ward seal. Unlicensed live fire will be confiscated."

Veyra stood at the front of Teren's convoy in a clean oil factor's robe. Dust had turned its hem the color of old blood. "My contract supplies the Hall's west tables," she called. "Your city owes spoilage if you refuse delivery."

"Present the tablet."

She held up a clay manifest fired three months earlier. The contract had once covered two jars of sesame oil. Merchant hands had altered none of its letters. Behind it, however, waited legitimate supplemental orders purchased from bakers who feared the lockdown would empty their stores. The coalition had not forged every fact. It had used the city's appetite to make facts arrive in a dangerous arrangement.

The gate opened one person's width.

Inspectors searched the lead cart. They pierced oil-jar seals, dug rods into flour sacks, and checked every axle box. One soldier found the packet of thin clay salt cups.

"Festival ware?"

"Twenty dozen," Veyra said. "West Hall annex."

He picked up a cup. The outside carried no name yet. Hearth-person-weight marks would be made only when local diners chose seats. "Why so thin?"

"Because thick cups cost more to break."

The soldier smiled despite himself and put it back.

A second inspector rolled a registry table into the lane. On it stood shallow dishes of ash labeled by licensed public ovens. Every incoming live fire had to be touched with vinegar steam and compared for color, clumping, and oil residue. The method could identify an unregistered hearth signature. It could not detect a cold pot wrapped beneath grain unless guards uncovered it.

Two carts ahead, a caravan cook declared a lawful brazier used to warm infant food. Her registry matched a canal tollhouse, not any Namarra oven. The inspector confiscated the coal and returned the empty bronze cup. She accepted the loss without looking toward Teren. Her coalition pot traveled separately inside a bale of felt on another team's contracted wagon; the declared brazier had existed only to satisfy the expectation that a caravan carried fire.

Teren had opposed the sacrifice during planning. One additional live coal seemed useful. The cook had asked whether usefulness gave him custody of her tollhouse ember. He had answered no and still disliked the subtraction. Watching her reclaim the cold cup reminded him that a plan could include loss chosen by the owner rather than loss he ordered for everyone.

At the gate scale, soldiers weighed Veyra's oil wagon. The axle came up nine measures heavier than its manifest. The hidden salt cups accounted for only two.

"Unload it," the officer said.

Veyra climbed down. "Your scale pan holds rainwater."

The day had not seen rain.

"Unload."

She removed the first jar and set it on the paving. Oil factors behind her began calling prices and spoilage clauses. Fish merchants joined them. Noise tightened the inspection lane until the officer ordered spears lowered.

Teren studied the balance frame. One rear foot rested on a wedge of broken pottery, tilting the crossbeam toward the wagon side. Whether accident or extortion, the false weight could be proved without exposing any cargo.

"Lift the rear foot," he said.

The officer turned. "Who spoke?"

Teren pointed with an open hand. "Your frame stands on a shard. Remove it or charge the city nine measures on every cart."

A gate clerk crouched, pulled out the pottery, and reset the pan. The wagon balanced within one measure. Merchants laughed with the cruelty of people briefly spared a search.

The officer waved Veyra through but marked her manifest with a red slash for inspection at the west annex. The coalition's bakery transfer now had to occur before a second inspection, under workers whose names the Hall could trace.

Teren's cart came third. Its grain sacks contained grain. Concealment depended on placement rather than false contents. Two sacks rested across a shallow

wooden frame under which lay the coalition's covered ember pot, black salt wrapped in waxed cloth, and a broad mixing bowl. An inspector would find them by unloading the cart. The gate line had more than a hundred contracted wagons and three hours before heat spoiled the fish.

"Open six," the inspector ordered.

Teren cut the ties on the six sacks marked with blue millet stems. Real grain poured into the sampling bowls. He had placed those sacks where an efficient search would choose them: corners, center, one near the axle.

The inspector plunged a hand into the fifth. "Tal Jes millet."

"Yes."

"Rebel city."

"Also a city that sells grain. The Hall's standard does not forbid profit."

"You sound educated for a carter."

"I count loads."

A horn sounded inside the arch. Soldiers dragged two bakers from a handcart entering through the pedestrian channel. One had live ash in a stoppered cup. Inspectors converged on them.

Teren kept his hands visible.

The gate officer stamped Veyra's manifest. "West annex, direct route. Any diversion voids entry."

"Then clear your festival pilgrims from my road," she said.

Their carts entered Namarra.

Inside the walls, closure had made the avenues denser rather than empty. Visitors already admitted could not leave. Public squares filled with people demanding food from reserve wagons. Soldiers stood at intersections checking kitchen licenses. Festival banners hung above ordinary panic, red cloth snapping over arguments about half rations.

Veyra led the convoy west for two streets, then stopped beside a contracted bakery. Workers rolled out replacement carts carrying white flour to the Hall. Under awnings, loads changed without any wagon standing empty long enough to invite suspicion.

The ember pot from Teren's cart went into a baker's cooling basket. Salt cups entered crates of festival pottery. Black salt passed inside a sealed jar labeled burnt cumin. The red millet continued to the west annex as the manifest promised. Every concealed item moved through hands already assigned to one kitchen.

Teren took a flour cart north with no visible weapon. His old left ankle caught on a paving stone. Pain rose through the joint, cleanly his own. At Tal Jes he had let other bodies carry what he chose to hide. Namarra required him to walk without such relief and without calling endurance proof of anything.

The first staging court occupied an inn kitchen near the dyers' ward. Five route couriers waited beside cold ovens. Each wore a strip of uncolored cloth tied differently: wrist, throat, basket handle, sandal. The signs reported arrivals, not orders.

Teren laid wooden counters on a flour board. "South gate: kitchens one, four, and nine entered. Kitchen seventeen turned east after inspection closed its manifest lane. No confirmation from fourteen."

A courier placed counters for the canal gate. Another reported three teams through the north cattle arch before closure. Nobody asked whether seventeen should return. Its cook would decide from the alternate route plan.

Lale entered carrying a basket of pickled mustard stems.

Teren knew her gait before he saw her face. She had entered through the river postern with an Eren Ford oven contract and spent four hours waiting under guard while inspectors matched her communal seal to imperial records.

"You got through," he said.

"So did the ember." She set the basket down. "Team six has a cellar oven in the rope ward. The owner accepted the local list and refused the successor position."

"Then the successor line passes to eight."

"Already recorded."

Their old working language returned without warmth. At Eren Ford, they had coordinated flood harvests this way: one reported a fact, the other changed the tally. Teren had once mistaken efficiency between siblings for permission that extended everywhere.

"How is your shoulder?" he asked.

"Blister closed."

"I have dressing fat."

"The kitchen has it." Lale looked at the counters. "Mava said you coordinate arrivals only."

"Yes."

"Then do that."

He moved no team marker without a courier phrase. The limit felt like a rope around his hand. It also kept twenty-four separate kitchens from becoming the extension of his fear.

By midafternoon, twenty-one teams had entered. Kitchen seventeen arrived through an undertaker's provisions lane after its original gate refused live ember. The cook sent the prescribed message: route changed, list unchanged. Kitchen fourteen remained silent.

Issen came to the inn kitchen wearing a laundry worker's gray tunic. The tasting-chain scar still crossed their neck, a red line rubbed raw by dust.

"The Hall's service court admits washing carts until evening," they said. "Rovan has moved first lighting ahead one watch. South and west ovens already warm carrier oil."

"How close can you get?" Lale asked.

"To the Hall cauldron if Pel has not changed the lower stair guard."

"And if he has?" Teren asked.

"I remain outside it."

No brave promise. No replacement plan requiring another body.

Issen carried no live ember. Their route passed through the Hall because they knew tasting signals and sink-ward notation, not because the final table needed them at any magical seat. Dima's kitchen would establish the First Hearth in a spice warehouse two courts away. Savra remained there with the balancing-seat bowl under civic witnesses.

Teren checked the sun. "Laundry carts leave in twelve minutes."

Issen took one pickled mustard stem from Lale's basket and ate it. "Unbound?"

"Everything in this room," Lale said.

"Good." They bowed, not as First Taster but in thanks, and went.

The twenty-two confirmed kitchens separated before the late bells. No procession connected them. Teams left in pairs carrying ordinary goods: lentil flour, fish baskets, oil jars, festival cups, charcoal, folded awnings. Couriers took different alleys and never carried more than one route report.

Teren walked the outer circuit with Veyra, checking only physical placement. At the pottery ward, an ember pot rested behind a kiln whose own fire would disguise its heat. In the canal quarter, a cook stored black salt inside a brine crock above flood level. Near the old famine wall, a public baker had placed salt cups among drinking vessels and posted the local seat declaration beneath a price list.

The baker had written nine names. An earlier plan listed eleven.

"Two refused after the gates shut," she said before Teren asked. "They have children outside the walls. They will not take a burden that may keep them from the gate when it opens."

"Does the kitchen still activate?"

"With nine. Weight remains equal. Central line unchanged."

Veyra checked the dough measure against the smaller list. "Reduce the batch. Food left over after first service stays unsealed."

The baker crossed out two bowl marks but did not scrape away the names. She wrote refused before eating beside each, preserving the decision rather than making the smaller table look as though it had always been intended.

In a rope-maker's cellar, kitchen six had an opposite problem. Four inn workers asked to join after learning the plan. Lale had refused them because the team had

not rehearsed their names or weights. The workers now carried water, knowing they could support the kitchen without entering its magic.

“Could the local cook add them safely?” Teren asked.

Lale answered, “Possibly.”

“Then why not?”

“Because possible under a locked gate is how a seat becomes necessary before anyone admits it.”

He recorded no disagreement. Her judgment controlled the kitchen.

At the eleventh site, a cracked oven flue forced the team to move from a sesame shop to a courtyard laundry. The local tablewright drew the same salt arc on a portable clay hearth, then waited while each diner inspected it. A change of location did not change the seat list. A change of origin ember would have, so they carried the shop coal in a lidded pan and left the laundry fire unbound.

The sixteenth site had no private room. Its cooks worked at a festival stall between two imperial ration tables. They hid nothing except the black salt packet, which remained sealed until activation. Their declared diners stood in the same public line as everyone else but would receive marked cups and stamped chickpea cakes. Proximity would not bind the crowd. Swallowed food and the named seat list would.

Teren checked firewood at each stop. Twenty-three kitchens required enough dry fuel to stay lit through first service and long enough for digestion to settle, perhaps six hours under festival conditions. Teams had cached wood in oven yards, but the gate closure increased ordinary demand. At current burn, seven sites would run short before midnight.

He gave the quantity to Veyra, not an order.

She rerouted two legitimate charcoal deliveries and asked three kitchens whether they would accept fig wood, which burned cooler and needed wider dampers. One refused because its recipe depended on rapid souring over steady heat. The refusal remained. The other two changed fuel and reheated test water before accepting the delivery.

No central bond moved those decisions. Couriers, questions, and time carried them.

Each kitchen had selected diners from its own workers and merchant allies. Festival crowds had not consented and were not listed. The counter-recipe could enter Rovan’s topology through twenty-four fires without binding everyone nearby. Food carried the table only to people who swallowed from those kitchens.

At the eighteenth placement, a courier ran up with no cloth visible. She had torn it away, the signal for compromised route.

“Kitchen fourteen reached the bronze-workers’ court,” she said. “Pot placed in the south wall oven. Before the cook drew the salt line, Hall agents entered. Four

arrested."

"Ember seized?" Veyra asked.

"Not found yet. Hidden behind the damper brick."

"Can another team light it?" Teren asked.

The courier looked at him. "No other team knows fourteen's local arc."

He knew the answer. His mind still produced alternatives: send half of kitchen thirteen, combine lists, pull a trained cook from the First Hearth warehouse, teach someone from memory. Every option treated preparation as transferable authority.

"The fire remains dark," he said.

Veyra removed the fourteenth counter from her board and left its square empty. "Deliberate gap."

"Can we get the cooks out?"

"Separate operation," she said. "No promise before activation."

Teren accepted both limits.

A pottery wagon brought confirmation from kitchens twenty-three and twenty-four near dusk. All planned ember pots now lay inside Namarra: twenty-three in accessible kitchens, one hidden behind the damper of an arrested team. Placement did not equal activation. The coalition possessed twenty-three hands able to draw their own salt lines.

They regrouped in the spice warehouse after dark. The First Hearth sat inside a ring of cold provincial salts. Savra knelt at a workbench shaping the central bowl. Dima checked crates of personal cups using the heel of her right hand to hold each stack while her left counted.

Mava's civic witnesses recorded the route board. Teren reported without interpretation.

"Twenty-four fires placed. Twenty-three kitchens active. Team fourteen arrested before drawing its line. Ember pot remains hidden and dark."

Mava asked, "Recommendation?"

"Leave the gap."

"Rescue?"

"After the bond breaks or if the local council detaches people who were never assigned to a kitchen fire."

Lale stood across the table. She did not praise the answer. She marked the empty square on her copy.

A knock sounded from the courtyard: two, pause, one. Issen's signal. They had entered the Hall of Measures.

Savra looked at the route board. "Rovan moved the lighting."

"How early?" Teren asked.

“One watch, perhaps more.”

The cold kitchen had no command tally. Twenty-three cooks stated their readiness in turn. Each could still refuse at the final declaration. The fourteenth square remained bare.

Teren counted the replies because counting had been assigned to him. When the last kitchen answered, he set aside one counter rather than pretending the board held twenty-four.

Beyond the shuttered warehouse, the festival gates locked another night’s worth of hungry people inside Namarra. Kitchen couriers went back into those streets carrying no central command, only twenty-three separate confirmations and one openly empty square. Teren watched them leave in different directions. His work ended where each local list began. He could count the fires that remained; he could not spend a missing team by assigning somebody else to become it.

Chapter 25 — The Night Before the Great Table

Savra found a hairline crack in the seventeenth salt cup and broke it before anyone could mistake it for a choice.

The thin clay split between her thumbs. Dima swept the pieces into a discard bowl with her left hand. Her right palm held the next stack against the worktable while she tapped each rim with a wooden spoon. Sound separated whole cups from flawed ones: a clear note for sound clay, a dull click for hidden fracture.

The spice warehouse kitchen had gone cold. No live ember remained except the First Hearth under its copper hood in the adjoining court, surrounded by civic witnesses. Twenty-three merchant kitchens waited across Namarra. Their fires stayed banked, their black salt sealed, and their local food unbound.

“How many spare?” Savra asked.

“Forty-one sound,” Dima said. “Eleven rejected. We distribute two per kitchen and keep none here beyond our list.”

“One each leaves eighteen.”

“I know what subtraction does.” Dima tapped another cup. Clear. “Two each. A cup broken by accident before eating should not force a diner to leave because we planned exactly.”

Savra accepted the correction. Planning spare vessels did not create replacement seats. It gave the same person another chance to mark a choice.

At the long flour table, Mava conducted the final conference. Couriers represented kitchens that could not risk sending cooks. Each carried a cold clay tile showing only local readiness, not names. The actual lists remained at each fire.

Mava called the routes by number.

“Kitchen one?”

“Ten seats, cook included. Two conditional successors for the central function. West grain annex.”

“Kitchen two?”

“Seven seats. One refusal recorded. Canal laundry.”

The answers continued. Some teams had fewer diners than at Tal Jes. One had changed fuel. Three had reduced batches because locked gates cut ingredient deliveries. Kitchen fourteen received no call. Mava left a full breath of silence at its place and moved to fifteen.

No one offered to fill the gap.

Savra listened for the errors fatigue encouraged. One courier said when the cup breaks rather than if. She made him repeat the declaration until departure remained possible, not expected. Another reported the balancing seat after local

names. Issen corrected the order through a message smuggled from the Hall: central cost must be declared first.

Every kitchen affirmed three choices separately. The cook accepted a seat in their own local table. Each diner knew that a smashed cup would sever them and route unsettled burden toward the named central volunteer. The team accepted darkness if its own line failed.

Then Mava asked the fourth question. "If Savra Kel cannot continue, does your kitchen accept the first successor named on its list?"

Twenty-three answers returned. Two said no and chose local severance instead. One accepted Dima but no further successor. The others accepted the sequence with different limits.

A universal table would have called those differences defects. Their plan depended on keeping them.

Dima finished the last cup and flexed her right fingers. Nothing moved except the thumb. "All sound."

"You should not take second position," Savra said quietly.

"Because of my hand?"

"Because you have spent two days treating Tal Jes and crossed Namarra under guard. Fatigue enters the seat."

"It enters yours too."

"I am first."

"That is sequence, not capacity." Dima set the spoon down. "My condition remains: if recoil interferes with my ability to manage severance, I break my cup. Veyra chooses whether to take third. You do not preserve me by revising what I volunteered after the lists left."

Savra looked at the broad-handled knife in Dima's apron. "Agreed."

The word did not ease her.

They packed the sound cups in chaff and divided them by kitchen. Each pair received one marked cloth: white for a cup broken before eating, red for a deliberate severance after swallowing. The cloth did not carry magic. It let a local witness record why a vessel disappeared without demanding an explanation from the diner.

At kitchen eight, the courier reported that imperial inspectors had ordered all festival pottery moved to public tables. Dima replaced their cups with thin lamp bowls from the dye quarter. She struck each one, discarded four with dull notes, and showed the courier how to write the hearth-person-weight marks around the wick groove.

"Will breaking a lamp bowl count?" he asked.

"The salt line recognizes the named vessel, not its trade," Savra said. "But the

diner must see which bowl holds the seat. No swapping after service.”

Kitchen nineteen had only thick drinking cups that would not shatter under an injured hand. Dima wrapped one in cloth and pushed it from the table with her right palm. It hit the floor, rolled, and stayed whole.

“Unacceptable,” she said.

“We can score the clay,” suggested the courier.

“A score may split while serving.” Dima took two of the spare thin cups. “These go to nineteen. Their local list has six diners, so one spare remains here.”

Savra noticed Dima had kept count without moving her lips. Injury had changed her work, not erased it. The broad-handled scoop, rim tapping, and table-edge grip all cost time. Their plan had to include that time rather than praise adaptation while scheduling as though her right hand still pinched and turned.

A runner from kitchen three arrived breathless. One diner wanted to revise from a full share to half after hearing the Hall had moved first lighting.

“Has she eaten?” Mava asked.

“No.”

“Then the local cook redraws the weight in her cup and reads the whole list again. Nobody votes on her reduction.”

“What if the others object?”

“They may refuse their own seats.”

The runner left with no permission slip because local authority already covered the change.

Savra went to the route board. Twenty-three separate squares carried charcoal marks. Kitchen fourteen’s square held only the word dark. She ran one finger beside it without filling the blank.

“What happens to their hidden pot after?” she asked.

Mava answered, “Civic evidence if we survive. Extinguished by its owners if they are released. It does not become coalition property because they were arrested.”

“Good.”

“You expected another answer?”

“I expected myself to want the ember.”

“Wanting it does not change custody.”

The exchange closed one more place where urgency could have become appetite.

After the couriers departed, Teren waited in the flour room. He had removed his grain-merchant coat and wore plain Free Granary clothes without a command tally. His left ankle had swollen above the boot. On the table between them lay a roll of gray knife cloth.

Savra knew the pattern of the knots. She had tied them in Ulsor before giving her tools to Mava.

"Guildspeaker authorized their return," Teren said.

"Why are you carrying them?"

"I asked to."

"That sounds like authority borrowed for a gesture."

"It may be." He considered the accusation instead of denying it. "Mava said you could refuse the messenger as well as the knives."

Savra untied the cloth. Savra's knives lay inside: the cleaver sharpened asymmetrically for fast joint work, the herb knife, and the narrow seal cutter. No imperial marks remained on the three handles. Mava's salt guild had wrapped a plain copper wire around each grip to show civic custody ended by recorded release.

"These do not make you master feastwright," Teren said.

"No."

"They do not mean Tal Jes trusts you."

"No."

"They mean the kitchen assigned to the balancing seat needs tools you know."

Savra tested the cleaver's edge against her thumbnail. "And you wanted to return what I surrendered after confessing what I did."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because I used the same argument at Tal Jes. Different scale, same hidden seat. I thought knowing the need let me decide who carried it."

She rolled the knives closed again. "That does not put us on equal sides of an account. Nine-Salt lasted a campaign. Villages carried it for months."

"I know."

"You know a sentence about it."

Teren looked toward the cold oven. "Yes."

The answer left no argument to defeat.

Savra lifted the roll. "I will use them. You do not get forgiveness for bringing them."

"I did not come for it."

"People often come for things they know better than to name."

"Then judge the work after." He shifted weight off his left ankle. "If there is an after."

No embrace followed. They returned to the kitchen conference with a workable

loyalty and damage that remained named.

Lale had prepared the private unbound meal in a storeroom without salt channels. The phrase sounded grander than the food: red lentils, canal rice, pickled mustard stems, leftover chickpea cakes, and one bowl of pepper oil. She had cooked over charcoal scraped clean of coalition ash. No hearthseal touched the pots.

Savra sat with Teren, Dima, Lale, Mava, Veyra, and an empty place for Issen, who remained inside the Hall. Nobody took the head because the room had no head chair.

Lale served the rice. "Say it."

"Unbound," Savra said.

"Source fire?" Dima asked.

"New charcoal from the dyers' yard. No civic ember."

"Seat list?"

"None."

"Then eat."

The private unbound meal moved nothing between them except dishes. Savra's hunger stayed hers. Teren's ankle pain did not enter another body. Dima's right hand remained difficult, so Lale steadied the rice bowl while Dima served with her left. Assistance crossed the table without magic and without pretending all burdens had become equal.

Teren asked Lale for the mustard stems. She passed them without looking away from her plate.

"After tomorrow," he said, "if there is a hearing about Tal Jes, I will not ask you to speak privately first."

"You already asked whether I would testify."

"I asked from the hospital bench. I meant whether you would defend me."

"I know what you meant."

"I am withdrawing the request."

Lale set the mustard dish beside him. "You cannot withdraw pressure I already carried. You can stop adding to it."

"Yes."

Their exchange ended there. The meal provided no ritual through which a brother could consume a sister's anger or spread it until neither had enough to name.

Veyra divided the last chickpea cake into seven unequal pieces because it crumbled under the knife. She put the largest beside Dima, who had skipped the afternoon ration while inspecting cups.

"Not equal," Dima observed.

"Not hidden," Veyra said. "You need food. I want the crust."

She took the smallest, darkest piece. Ordinary distribution could account for difference through speech, adjustment, and refusal. It did not need equal sensation to become legible.

Savra ate pepper oil with rice and felt sweat collect under her collar. Soon a table might send thousands of bodily states toward her. For this final quiet hour, heat came from the food she had chosen, and nobody else had to carry it.

Mava ate quickly. "At first signal, twenty-three kitchens open black salt. Second signal, they draw local lines. They do not feed until Savra confirms the First Hearth has taken the central topology."

"How does she confirm?" Teren asked.

"Blue edge along all common grooves," Savra said. "If fewer than twelve answer, we abort the overwrite and tell kitchens to keep their fires local."

"If twelve to twenty-two?"

"Proceed with whatever answers. Gaps remain gaps."

Veyra tore a chickpea cake. "And if Rován lights before the couriers reach us?"

"We feel it," Savra said. "His current will enter the provincial ash carried in our pots. The First Hearth may answer through the spice court."

"May."

"Yes."

The meal did not invite vows, but silence made room for truth.

Savra looked at each person. "The balancing seat may kill me before the universal bond breaks. If I lose speech, Dima decides whether I remain capable. If I smash my cup, recoil returns local. No one holds my hands closed."

Dima nodded. "My right hand cannot. My left will break it if you ask."

"If I cannot ask?"

"Then I use the limits written at Tal Jes: failed breath count, loss of posture, inability to swallow. Not courage. Not usefulness."

Mava said, "Recorded."

Teren did not object that the plan needed Savra alive. Lale did not call the choice noble. They ate until the bowls emptied.

Afterward Savra washed her own plate. She dried the three knives and placed them beside the central bowl. Around the warehouse, runners settled in shifts while cooks checked dampers. Namarra's Equinox bells remained hours away.

A blue line flared under the First Hearth's copper hood.

No coalition cook had opened black salt.

Savra dropped the cloth. Heat entered her scarred left forearm, followed by the distant contraction of an empty stomach. The imperial current had reached the stolen brazier through ash signatures already joined elsewhere.

From the Hall, a signal horn sounded one long note.

“Rovan lit the first ember early,” Teren said.

Savra took up her knives. “Wake every kitchen.”

The cold warehouse filled with moving feet before the official night bell struck.

Chapter 26 — The Feast of a Hundred Fires

The first imperial bite reached Savra through the stolen brazier before her own porridge had boiled.

Hunger closed around her stomach. A second body's heat pressed behind her eyes. Then came the split sensation of a blister opening under a heel, distant but exact enough to make her lift one foot from the warehouse floor.

Under the First Hearth hood, blue fire raced around seven coals.

"Rovan's current," she said. "Open black salt."

Dima cut the waxed packet with her broad-handled knife. Mava's witnesses drew back as Savra poured salt into the common groove around the brazier. In twenty-three kitchens across Namarra, couriers would be carrying the same order. Some would arrive late. A universal system enjoyed speed because it did not pause for answers.

The central bowl waited beside Savra's knives. Plain red millet, thin enough to swallow under pain, had cooked over a Tal Jes ember nested beside the First Hearth. Around its rim, Dima had written Savra's name, hearth mark, chosen weight, and function.

Mava read the declaration. "Always-open balancing seat: Savra Kel. Receives unsettled severance recoil only. No ordinary local burden. First successor Dima Orr under stated capacity. Every local table may refuse the common topology."

"I affirm," Savra said.

"Body condition?"

"Hunger not mine. Heat behind eyes. Blister pain at right heel. Breath steady."

Dima recorded the entry.

Savra ate.

The millet carried black hearth-salt and old ash. It tasted of burned crust scraped from civic ovens, bitter enough to make her jaw tighten. Connection settled through the left forearm scar first. The imperial current pressed toward the First Hearth, trying to flatten every provincial signature into Rovan's weighting. Savra laid both hands beside the common groove and looked for the blue edges of answering fires.

One appeared. Then four. Nine.

At twelve she gave the proceed signal.

Teren's couriers struck roof pans in the sequence the route council had approved. Twenty-three local cooks opened their pots, drew separate salt lines, and began feeding only their named seats. No signal compelled them. Three kitchens remained dark after the first call. One answered late. Another sent refusal because soldiers had entered its court.

Seventeen blue edges held.

"Enough to enter," Savra said. "Not enough to hold."

Rovan's first course strengthened.

Across the city, standardized white loaves had gone out from public ovens before the official bell. People ate because the locked gates had reduced half rations and because bread still looked like bread. The imperial seat lists reached them through old grain oaths. Hunger began moving out of soldiers, officials, and favored wards toward the hidden chambers under Namarra. Pain followed. Heat left bakers standing at overfired ovens and entered people lying beneath damp stone.

Savra felt only the current crossing the First Hearth, not memories or names. Hearthbinding could carry an empty stomach's contraction. It could not tell her who had gone without eating.

"Kitchen five active," called a courier. "Kitchen eleven active. Kitchen twenty reports arrested witness, cook proceeding with six seats."

Blue fire reached twenty.

At each merchant kitchen, named diners swallowed a sour first bite to enter their local arc. Cooks then carried trays into festival squares and announced the choice available: eat a marked portion, inspect a personal cup, hear the central cost, join the local table, or pass. People already trapped inside Rovan's bond could redirect their own seat through the black-salt topology only by eating from one of those fires. The coalition had food for hundreds, not the whole capital.

Hundreds could make openings through which local hearth signatures reasserted themselves.

The first salt cup broke near the canal ward.

Recoil struck Savra under the ribs. One diner had joined, felt a hospital patient's breathlessness passing through Rovan's current, and left before a second bite. The cup's clay connection snapped. Burden already received remained in that body. The unsettled share came to Savra.

"Breath shortened," she reported. "Posture sound."

Dima counted. "One."

More cups broke.

Not everyone left. A woman at the west annex kept hers after learning that her hunger would remain shared with eight neighbors at equal local weight. Two porters smashed theirs when imperial wounds entered the arc. A public baker held his cup in both hands and waited through one full transfer before choosing to stay. Choice produced no single moral shape.

Salt cups breaking sounded across Namarra like pottery stalls collapsing one vessel at a time.

Courier reports arrived faster than Mava's witnesses could press them into wax.

At the canal laundry, imperial soldiers ordered the local diners away from the fire. The cook did not defend the hearth with their bodies. They carried the marked pot into the washing room, where steam hid the salt line from the courtyard, and asked every diner to affirm again because the conditions had changed. Three broke cups without eating a second portion. Four stayed. The cook reduced the sour paste rather than forcing the smaller group to carry the original timing.

Kitchen six in the rope-maker's cellar received thirty frightened neighbors asking for protection from the imperial bond. Its list named seven. Lale stood in the doorway and explained that entering an unrehearsed person could misroute recoil into the others. She offered unbound rice and shelter instead. Some neighbors accused her of hoarding safety. She kept the line closed.

At the pottery ward, a woman who had joined the local table held her whole cup above the paving but did not release it. Her son had smashed his after a soldier's burn entered his chest. The mother stayed because her own hunger had begun easing through a circle she trusted. Nobody required family members to make one choice.

Veyra's west-annex kitchen sent out trays with the declaration written on flour boards. An imperial clerk read the central cost, took a marked cake, then broke his cup at the first transferred wound. He continued helping people read their options while carrying the pain already received. Severance removed no history from his body.

The relay itself had no magical speed. Runners crossed alleys. Bakers struck shutters. Oil sellers passed phrases over market walls. When a patrol blocked one street, kitchens waited without inventing a distant order. Rovan's system moved through seals established over years; the coalition answered through feet already tired from one day.

A Hall signal changed from one long horn to two short. Issen's prearranged code reported hidden-ward weighting increased. Teren sent no command to accelerate service. He gave the code to each courier and let local cooks decide whether their diners needed to hear it before the next bite. All twenty-one active kitchens chose to repeat their lists.

The repetition cost time while the imperial current deepened. It also meant that a person joining after the horn heard a changed risk rather than yesterday's promise.

Savra took each return.

Hunger arrived in waves from people who had swallowed oil-delayed loaves hours apart. Heat striped her arms. Exertion filled her thighs with the climb of runners she could not see. A fraction of panic tightened her throat, embodied timing without thought. Dima kept the list of states and watched Savra's breath.

"Twenty-one fires," Mava said.

“Which absent?”

“Fourteen, fixed gap. Seven under search. Twenty-two silent.”

The topology pulled unevenly toward the south wall. Kitchen fourteen’s hidden pot carried an ember but no salt line, food, or swallowed seats. Rován’s current found that unopposed ash signature and drove through it like water through a missing gate.

The First Hearth flared white.

Savra’s central bowl cracked along its rim. Recoil from three local circles reached her at once. She fell against the worktable, knives jumping in their cloth.

“Break?” Dima asked.

“Not my cup.”

“Your choice, not mine.”

“Continue.” Savra forced her back straight. “Move fourteen’s arc outside the common groove. Do not close the gap.”

No witness spoon remained to copy the correction. Twenty-three kitchens held the recipe in memory, and kitchen fourteen held nothing active. Savra could alter only the First Hearth’s central groove, making space around the missing signature rather than supplying it.

She used the narrow seal cutter to lift black salt from one segment. Her hand shook. One grain fell inward.

“Stop,” Dima said.

Savra stopped. Dima could not pinch the grain with her right fingers. She dampened a broad spoon, lifted it with her left, and removed the misplaced salt. Mava’s witness scraped the contaminated section clean. They redrew the gap together.

Blue fire divided around an empty span.

The collapse eased. Kitchen seven returned under guard pressure with four diners rather than nine. Kitchen twenty-two sent a dark signal; its owner had withdrawn access to the oven. The cooks extinguished their pot and left. The common topology held twenty-one active fires and two deliberate absences beyond fourteen.

“Proceed with twenty-one,” Savra said.

No one went to replace them.

At the Hall, Rován increased hunger weighting.

Savra knew because her stomach contracted until she retched onto the floor. Nothing came up but red millet water. Dima held her shoulders from behind without taking any magical share. Veyra opened the warehouse door, where three runners waited for the order to move the First Hearth.

Mava said, “The local arcs are established. Why risk the brazier?”

“Rovan still controls the three capital ovens. From here I can cut his provincial reach, not the sink wards beneath his own hearth.”

“You may not reach the Hall.”

“Then the local tables survive while Namarra’s hidden seats carry the capital.” Savra wiped her mouth. “Issen entered to open the service court. The plan includes movement.”

Mava looked to each civic witness. They affirmed the recorded route. She did not grant permission as though the brazier belonged to her alone.

The runners lifted the First Hearth by iron hooks. Savra carried the central bowl. Dima carried Savra’s cup in her left hand, wrapped but accessible. Veyra went ahead with a flour sack. Teren waited in the alley with route-council authority for movement only.

“East lane closed,” he said. “Hall guards at the dyers’ arch. The laundry court remains open according to Issen’s last signal.”

“How many escorts?” Mava asked.

“Six volunteers. No table.”

“Who chose the route?”

“The runners after hearing both.”

They moved.

Namarra had become a city of crossed hungers. People staggered in streets after imperial pain entered them. Others stood abruptly straighter because wounds moved away. At a public table, a soldier dropped his loaf and stared at blood appearing under an old woman’s bandage. The bond gave neither person the other’s memory. He knew only that his spear cut had eased while her side opened.

Merchant cooks shouted local declarations above the Hall bells. Some listeners accepted marked chickpea cakes. Others overturned the trays, believing every bound meal imperial. A cook let the food fall and did not force it between anyone’s teeth.

An imperial patrol reached the west kitchen as Savra’s group passed the next alley. Soldiers kicked through the salt line. The local cook smashed the origin ember pot. Recoil returned to six diners and the central seat.

Savra’s knees buckled.

The runners kept the First Hearth level while she leaned on Dima. Burn pain crossed her chest, followed by a runner’s exhausted breath and the cold of somebody lying on infirmity stone.

“Posture failed,” Dima said. “One condition.”

“Recovered.”

“Recorded, not erased.”

At the laundry court, gray-clothed workers opened a coal hatch. Issen waited

inside with blood on one sleeve that did not belong to them. They had freed Tam Vesso from his oven guard; the festival cook stood beside them holding a long paddle.

“Rovan started the second course,” Issen said. “He is sending public-oven heat to the northern hidden sink wards. Pain goes below the infirmary. Hunger goes to debt intake.”

“How do you know?” Savra asked.

“The Hall control bowls carry colored oil. I tasted the ladles.”

“Did you swallow?”

“Spit, rinsed, no seat mark. I remain unbound.”

Tam lifted a ring of keys. “South oven crew closed their damper. Rovan has two capital fires.”

A local refusal had removed one imperial anchor. Savra felt the topology sag, then pull harder through the remaining ovens.

They entered the Hall through the washing passage.

Above, the pavilion roared with voices. The Feast of a Hundred Fires had begun before guests took ceremonial places. Hall attendants tried to seat officials while bodies across the city carried one another’s states without explanation. The great fired-clay cauldron stood in a bronze cradle over three joined fire channels. White broth churned inside, thick with standardized grain, provincial oils, and black salt.

Rovan sat beyond the outer salt line with one hand on signal levers. His chair remained untouched by the currents crossing the floor. A small command cup rested beside him, half empty.

Savra smelled bitter fenugreek in the steam.

Kelar.

The refugee kitchen’s ash signature carried the final balancing sink. Rovan had put the bitter herb into the control broth so a feastwright could taste whether that route remained open. The flavor sharpened under biased weighting exactly as it had when children took cavalry wounds.

Rovan saw the brazier. Grief crossed his face before calculation covered it.

“You kept it alive,” he said.

“People did.”

“Put it beside the cauldron. We can still stabilize this.”

“Name the wards under the infirmary.”

His hand stayed on the levers. “Balancing reserves prevent chaotic recoil.”

“Name them.”

Issen stepped onto the pavilion platform and turned the speaking horn toward the public gallery. “Six hundred twelve marked before debt intake. Hunger, heat,

breath, and pain categories. Names sealed from diners. Refusal unavailable."

Rovan's attendants tried to close the horn shutter. Issen braced it open with the tasting-chain clasp Pel had left on the control table, recovered from the inspection court and kept as evidence. Silver bent under the hinge.

"You have given a number without its balance," Rovan said. His voice carried through the second horn at his chair. "Those wards prevent random recoil into children, crowded markets, and field hospitals. Every body there receives food and medical watch. If the reserves close now, the Great Table throws its unsettled weight wherever capacity remains."

Savra heard the persuasive part because it contained a physical truth. Abrupt severance could scatter burden. He had arranged the topology so his chosen victims appeared to protect everyone else from chaos created by the arrangement.

"Then open their names and let them break cups," she said.

"The wards cannot sustain individual severance under activation."

"Because you gave them bed tags, not cups."

"I gave the continent a design that survives panic."

"You designed away every answer except yours."

A control clerk pulled the pain lever halfway back. Rovan caught the motion and returned it to its marked stop. "Do not improvise."

The clerk stared at a wax tablet where ward reports arrived through runners. "Breath reserve is over measure. Two attendants collapsed."

"Transfer one share to public infirmary staff."

"Named?" Issen asked through the horn.

Rovan did not answer them. He ordered the clerk to use the emergency category, another label broad enough to conceal whoever happened to be working upstairs.

Savra tasted bitter fenugreek again as the Kelar sink opened wider. The flavor sharpened past bitterness into metal. Rovan had chosen the refugee kitchen because ration oaths there changed quickly; displaced people arrived, ate, and left without officials updating names. Administrative instability became magical capacity.

"Kelar is refusing," Mava called from the stair. A courier had arrived from the west signal post. "Their seal went dark."

The corresponding line on the Hall floor flickered. Rovan pushed more oil into the west public oven to compensate. The act drove heat toward the northern ward and made three attendants cry out behind the control screens.

"Your balancing reserve is failing," Savra said.

"Because you are cutting it without carrying its share."

"I am carrying every departure people choose from our tables." Her body shook

hard enough to make the knife strike the cauldron rim. "You still have not entered yours."

Guards moved toward them. Tam swung his paddle into the nearest oil channel. Hot carrier oil spilled across the stone, cutting one signal groove. Dima threw plain salt over it. Steam burst upward.

Teren did not order the escort. The six volunteers chose positions around the runners, blocking guards without drawing blades. Mava held up the civic witness tablets and shouted the names of Tal Jes hospital victims. Confusion slowed the pavilion long enough for Savra to reach the cauldron.

Rovan pulled the hunger lever.

The command bowl beside him trembled. He had eaten from it. Its seal named him as a witness seat with zero burden, allowing his body to sense activation timing without receiving the states. A zero weight still created a seat.

Savra set the First Hearth into the empty fire channel.

Blue flame climbed the cauldron.

She poured her central bowl into Rovan's broth. The Many-Table topology entered through twenty active merchant kitchens now, then nineteen as another local fire went dark. Each kept its own salt line. Their shared groove named only the balancing function and the visible right to sever.

Rovan looked down at the blue flame. "You have built one sink and put yourself in it."

"I built a seat people can see and leave."

"They will spend you."

"Some will. Others will keep their cups. You never let them answer."

He pushed the pain lever toward the northern wards.

Issen seized the speaking horn. "Break or keep your cup by your own condition. No witness may stop you."

Couriers repeated the call outside. Across Namarra, pottery began to shatter again.

Recoil hit Savra with enough force to drive her hands into the cauldron rim. Hunger folded her. Heat burned without flame. A hundred small injuries arrived as bodily fact: bruised ribs, cut palms, split lips, overworked calves. No skill came with them, no loyalty, no memory of how they happened.

Dima stood at Savra's left with the cup ready.

"Breath count failing," she said.

"Not yet."

"Two conditions."

Savra could no longer feel her feet. "Hold until local lines divide."

Rovan's chair remained outside the salt line.

Savra used the seal cutter on the blue groove connecting his command cup to the cauldron. She did not add a new person. She changed the zero weighting on a seat he had already entered by swallowing.

"Rovan Dast," she said. "Witness seat. Command cup. Existing mark."

He understood. His hand left the lever.

"You cannot set a weight without the witness impression."

"Twenty kitchens remember what you taught one object."

The First Hearth answered their distributed lines. Blue light reached Rovan's cup.

He knocked it from the table. The cup struck carpet and did not break.

Issen kicked the chair forward. Its rear legs crossed the outer groove. Tam's paddle swept plain salt behind it, closing the ring. Physical geometry joined the rewritten witness seat.

Rovan inside the salt line received his first ordinary share.

Hunger took his voice. He bent over the command table, one arm across his stomach. Heat from public ovens flushed his skin. Pain from the wards returned through the controls he had set. Not all of it, not punishment equal to every harm, only the conserved fraction assigned to a visible participant.

"Now," Savra told Issen. "Read the local choice."

Issen spoke through the horn. "Your hearth. Your name. Your weight. Cup whole or cup broken. No hidden replacement."

The phrase traveled through couriers and kitchen shouts. People kept cups. People broke them. Some local tables lost every diner and went dark. Others held with two or twenty. Rovan's universal ring fractured at each separate salt line.

The missing kitchen fourteen remained missing. No pain rushed into an invented substitute. Its provincial signature fell back to its own hearth as the common groove split around it.

Beneath the infirmary, hidden sink seals cracked under recoil. The bodies there kept injuries already received. New transfers stopped as local tables severed their route. One public oven retained a neighborhood bond because its diners had not broken it. Another went dark when Tam's crew flooded the firebox.

The Great Table ceased to have one weight.

Rovan reached for the central lever again. Teren caught his wrist, then looked to Mava rather than deciding the end alone.

"Detain him," Mava said under civic seal.

The escort pulled Rovan from the chair. He remained conscious. Issen took the command cup as evidence.

Savra's sight narrowed around the cauldron. The First Hearth burned too hot beneath wet broth. Dima shouted that her posture had failed again. Savra tried to answer and could not swallow.

"Limit reached," Dima said.

She struck Savra's salt cup against the bronze cradle.

It broke.

The central seat severed after the universal groove had already fractured. Recoil returned along surviving local lines, each carrying only its own unsettled share. Diners cried out but no hidden ward received it. Dima refused the successor position because Savra's incapacity had come after separation; taking the seat would reconnect what no longer needed a center.

Tam opened the cold-brine cistern above the Hall fire channels. Brine flooded the overheated cradle. The great cauldron's glazed clay lining contracted around boiling broth.

A crack ran from rim to base.

White porridge poured across the salt channels, washing black salt into harmless mud. Attendants dragged the First Hearth clear before the bronze cradle shifted. Its seven coals stayed alive.

Savra lay among broken cups. Hunger remained after severance, not as continuing transfer but as damage from too many contradictory bodily timings. Her stomach cramped as if it had not eaten for weeks, eased, then cramped again. Thousands of delayed oil-weighted shares had crossed her in minutes. The table had ended. Her body did not know when fullness belonged.

Dima brought unbound barley water and touched one drop to Savra's tongue. Her swallowing muscles contracted before the liquid reached the throat. She turned her head and coughed it out.

"No hearth food," Dima told the attendants. "Nothing stamped, no ration oath, no shared-cup broth. Her body has carried too many seat timings. We do not test whether another table settles them."

A Hall healer offered poppy milk. Dima smelled it, checked its vessel for ash residue, and refused until someone produced a sealed unbound jar. Pain relief could not be allowed to create another route into Savra while active embers still burned in the city.

Savra tried to say that hunger had returned. Dima already had two fingers at her throat, counting the dry swallow that never completed.

Dima checked her breathing. "Savra. Swallow."

Water touched her mouth. She could not.

Around them, guards lowered weapons as the pavilion floor lost every imperial signal line. Rován sat under watch beside the cracked cauldron, alive and shaking. Outside, separate kitchen bells answered one another across Namarra without

falling into a single rhythm.

Savra heard them as she lost consciousness, nineteen fires still burning apart. None matched the others, and no single hand could close them all.

Chapter 27 — After the Cauldron Broke

At dawn, Teren counted seventeen granary locks and three thousand people outside them.

The crowd filled Measure Square from the imperial storehouse to the Hall steps. Some carried broken salt cups. Others carried bowls, sacks, or nothing. Namarra's public ovens had gone dark after the Great Table split, and nobody trusted the stamped white loaves left on their racks. Hunger had returned to the bodies that owned it. It had also remained as transferred injury in people who had never agreed to carry anyone else.

Teren stood on the granary stair without a command tally.

Mava's provisional council had asked him to count stores, routes, and daily need. The request gave him a task, not authority over the square. He wore a clay token marked inventory witness. Two Namarra grain clerks held matching tokens. Lale represented public-oven workers. A terrace merchant recorded damaged wagons.

"North granary," Teren called. "Seventeen thousand white-grain measures, sealed dry. West cellar, four thousand barley, two thousand spoiled by flood. Hall reserve, unverified."

A man in a burned imperial coat shouted, "Those stores fed the army while our children carried wounds."

"Open all of them!" somebody answered.

Hands struck the first door. The bronze lock held.

Teren's body wanted to put guards across the stair, form lanes, appoint distributors, and make the crowd obey a plan before fear consumed the stores. Tal Jes had taught him what that instinct could hide inside the word need.

He turned to Mava. "Recommendation: open north first under four ward witnesses. Issue one measure per six people. Keep the west cellar closed until spoilage is separated."

"Who chooses distributors?" she asked.

"Each ward sends two. Granary clerks retain measure control. Kitchen council witnesses the seals."

"Army?"

"Same queue. No separate ration."

Mava faced the square. "You heard the proposal. Ward kitchens answer."

The argument lasted while hungry people waited. Three wards demanded two measures. The south ward refused Hall clerks because those clerks had certified hidden sink stores. Public-oven workers insisted on inspecting grain oaths before any sack entered a hearth. None of those disputes could be solved by opening a

door and calling the contents free.

A stone struck the granary façade.

Then another.

At the north street, sixty imperial soldiers appeared in shield order. Their commander carried an order board bearing Rován's seal. The crowd turned from the locks.

"This store remains under Hall custody," she called. "Disperse."

Mava descended one stair. "Grand Provisioner Dast is under arrest. His seal carries no force."

"My soldiers have eaten half rations for two days. If that door opens without guard, the store is gone by noon."

"Then guard the distribution."

The commander looked at Teren. "Free Granary wants imperial grain."

"People want grain," he said. "Your soldiers count among them."

"They held the city."

"So did bakers, laundry workers, sink-ward attendants, and people who broke tables. Nobody gets a service weight."

A group from the river quarter pushed toward the soldiers. One carried a torch despite full daylight. "Burn their barracks. Take what they took."

Teren stepped down before he could ask permission. He stopped at the last stair and turned back to Mava.

"May I address routes?"

"Yes."

He pointed toward the imperial barracks. "Their stores contain lamp oil, bow cases, and two days of military grain. Burn them and you lose food plus the wagons needed to move this grain. Seize them without inventory and officers hide what remains."

"Then kill the officers first," the torchbearer said.

"No." The answer left Teren too quickly, carrying command's old edge. He lowered his voice. "Rován survives for judgment. So do the people who served him unless a hearing finds a crime. Revenge looting gives every keeper reason to burn a ledger before surrendering it."

"Easy mercy from a captain."

"I used patients at Tal Jes. My hearing begins today."

The admission moved through the crowd. Some knew already. Others cursed him by a name he had not heard since Eren Ford. He stayed on the stair.

The imperial commander lowered her order board. "You submitted?"

“Yes.”

“Before whom?”

“Tal Jes witnesses, sink-ward representatives, coalition kitchens, and this city if it joins the council.”

She studied the crowd behind him. “My soldiers guard the north store if they receive the same ration in a separate line.”

“No separate line,” Lale said from the witness table. “Same line, weapons stacked under their own watch.”

The commander objected. Two ward delegates objected to any armed guard. Mava negotiated the physical terms: soldiers stacked spears inside a rope square; six remained shielded at the doors; six unarmed ward workers stood beside them. The grain clerks broke the first imperial seal in public.

When the doors opened, cool dry air rolled into the square carrying the smell of wheat husks.

Nobody rushed immediately. The argument had built lanes people recognized as their own, imperfectly. Ward distributors entered with empty measures. Clerks read sack stamps. Public-oven workers marked any grain oath linked to a dangerous seal and sent those sacks to unbound milling only.

The imperial granaries opened one by one over the next six hours.

Breaking seals proved faster than moving food. North granary’s stairs admitted one sack at a time, and its loading yard faced an alley too narrow for two wagons to pass. Teren proposed a one-way circuit through the old parade ground. Ward drivers walked it before accepting, measuring corners with their own axle poles. Two turns had to be widened by removing festival stalls. The stall owners recorded every plank taken and which kitchen would return it.

Measure disputes began at the first issue table. Imperial cups held one twentieth more grain than Ulsor guild cups and one twelfth less than an Eren Ford household scoop. Standardization had helped the Hall collect tax while letting public kitchens use local vessels that made rations appear generous or mean. Issen brought the bronze master measure from the Hall under two witnesses. Each ward marked a temporary clay cup against it, then kept its own cup rather than surrendering all distribution to the master object.

At the barracks store, soldiers refused to release mule teams unless their wounded received grain first. Sink-ward delegates objected that many soldiers had eaten full rations while civilians carried their injuries. The dispute stopped six wagons.

Teren counted travel time and said nothing until Mava asked for a route consequence.

“Without those mules, the north infirmary receives grain after dark. With them, every listed patient receives a midday share. That includes soldiers upstairs and

sink occupants below.”

The commander asked, “Equal amount?”

“Set by each ward kitchen after medical need is read publicly. Not by rank.”

A former breath-reserve prisoner lifted his intake tag. “I want the soldier who held my door to carry my sack.”

One guard stepped forward. The commander allowed eight more. They moved grain under ward supervision without calling the labor payment for what the ward had done to the prisoner. Restitution began as transport and could not end there.

Near the east store, looters found oil jars marked for military lamps. A kitchen worker tried to seize them for frying. Another person wanted them poured into the street so the army could not use them. Teren identified two jars tainted with pitch, unfit for food, and six containing clean sesame oil. Witnesses sent the pitch to guarded civic stores and the sesame oil to three unbound kitchens. Destruction would have felt decisive. Separation fed people.

Teren counted without deciding who deserved food. North store supplied ward kitchens. Barracks grain went to field kitchens around the infirmary. The Hall reserve contained black-salt contamination and stayed closed under joint seal. West barley required sifting and went first to people able to boil it outside bound ovens.

At midday, a group broke into the Grand Provisioner’s private store. They found dried figs, fine rice, and eight jars of old lentils. Mava had the goods carried to the same measured lanes. Rován’s household did not receive protection from evidence, but neither did the crowd get trophies.

His arrest became public at the second bell.

Mava stood on the Hall stair with Issen, two Namarra magistrates, and witnesses from the hidden wards. Rován appeared behind them without ceremonial robe. His hands remained unbound because guards surrounded him and because public humiliation could not substitute for custody. He still looked like a provisioner inspecting a delay.

Issen read the charges: concealed seat lists, coerced ration oaths, unauthorized bodily transfers, false safety certification, unlawful imprisonment for sink capacity, and activation of the Great Table after loss of the First Hearth. Their own name followed among officials submitting testimony.

A woman from the northern ward shouted for Rován to be put in a pain table.

“No,” Dima said through the speaking horn. “We do not prove hidden punishment wrong by building a public one.”

The crowd did not become peaceful. Rotten fruit struck the steps. Guards lifted shields around Rován. He flinched once and remained standing.

Teren watched from the grain lanes. Survival preserved the possibility that records would be opened, subordinates questioned, and provincial harms traced. It

also required people harmed by him to see him fed under guard. Justice had logistics too, none emotionally clean.

Captain Orel Tas, held under coalition guard since Halvek, transferred with the witness files to a Halvek civic panel. He surrendered his field-kitchen orders and sought no immunity; the panel kept him in custody until every concealed household list could be recovered.

Lale and Dima built emergency field kitchens in five squares. The first served unbound barley with onions and no seal. The second offered a voluntary fatigue share for water carriers: names on a board, equal weights, two-hour duration, cooks seated, cups thin enough for Dima's right palm to break against a table edge. The remaining three stayed unbound because no trained witness could supervise them.

Nobody called the unbound pots wasted magic.

By Day 35, the queues shortened. By Day 36, provincial delegates occupied the Hall kitchens instead of its banquet rooms. They slept beside ledgers and opened sink-ward records name by name. The First Hearth rested in a public court under four rotating civic seals. No single seal opened its gate.

Teren's Tal Jes judgment began in the old flour exchange.

Mava chaired only the procedure. Eda Tel, whose mouth had burned while her leg lay splinted, sat among the hospital witnesses. Dima presented the cracked seal fragments. Issen explained the reversed sixth-campaign notation. Lale gave the sequence of Teren's evacuation decision, hidden plate, false support declaration, and later request that she defend him.

Teren stood without advocate by his own choice until Eda objected.

"You choosing no help does not help us," she said carefully through scarred lips. "It makes your punishment another plan you control."

The council appointed a record advocate whose task involved testing facts, not excusing them. Teren accepted.

He described the red millet terraces from first gate release to final severance. He gave quantities where he knew them and said I do not know where pain shares had erased origin. He did not use the word necessary.

"Did you believe the city would fall?" asked a terrace witness.

"Yes."

"Do you still believe it might have fallen without the seal?"

"Yes."

"Then why call the act wrong?"

"Because I made the hospital carry my uncertainty without naming them. The danger did not give me their answer."

Dima asked, "Would you activate it again?"

“No.”

“If refusing meant losing Tal Jes?”

Teren looked at Eda. “I would give the choice to the people carrying it. If there were no time, I would not use them.”

The words cost more than claiming a changed heart. They admitted that command might have to endure defeat rather than convert another body into a resource.

The provisional ruling removed Teren from military or hearth authority until a full interprovincial judgment. He would work only under elected kitchen councils, disclose all copied seals and route contingencies, and provide restitution labor to Tal Jes and the hospital. The council reserved further penalty after patient testimony and damage accounts. Lale voted with Eren Ford to accept the provisional ruling. She did not ask for lenience.

Outside the exchange, Teren handed over his remaining private route notebooks. One contained nothing incriminating, only bridge weights and canal depths. Surrendering harmless pages felt foolish. Partial surrender would have let him decide which knowledge others could inspect.

On Day 38, the federation vote began.

Ulsor proposed that every burden-table require a local kitchen council, published names, weights, duration, a cook’s seat, and breakable personal cups. Tal Jes added independent injury records. Eren Ford required that no regional council could activate another hearth without its local vote. Namarra sink-ward delegates demanded a law against category seats that concealed names.

Arguments lasted two days. Some provinces wanted the First Hearth destroyed. Others feared imperial remnants would seize provincial seals if no common defense remained. Mava proposed civic custody with four rotating keys and no authority to approve a table. Any multihearth action would require local councils to opt in separately.

The key question consumed a full afternoon. If all four seals belonged to provinces that regularly traded together, they could become a smaller empire by habit. If one belonged permanently to Namarra, old authority survived under a new title. The delegates settled on rotation by lot every sixty days, with no two keys held by adjacent provinces and one reserved for a council that had declined the previous multihearth action.

“Reward refusal?” asked a river delegate.

“Give refusal custody of the thing it refused,” said a sink-ward witness. “Otherwise only agreeing provinces ever touch the lock.”

Eren Ford proposed that each local seat list remain posted for one digestion cycle after severance, long enough for injuries to be recorded. Ulsor wanted permanent copies. Tal Jes objected that permanent public names could expose

prisoners, fugitives, or people hiding from violent households. They compromised on names held by local auditors and public counts showing seats, weights, injuries, and reasons for withheld identity.

Issen refused the title First Auditor when three delegates offered it. “No office should certify a table alone,” they said. “Elect at least three, and let any one stop service for missing disclosure. Approval requires the local council.”

The delegates revised the article.

Teren sat behind the Eren Ford table as a logistics witness. He could answer how many carts a rule required, how long notices took to reach canal towns, or how much clay one hundred personal cups consumed. He did not vote. When a delegate quoted his convoy work as proof that one coordinator should hold emergency authority, Lale answered before him.

“His work proves routes need a practiced counter. Tal Jes proves a practiced counter cannot choose hidden seats.”

The emergency article assigned temporary route coordination but barred the coordinator from changing lists, weights, cooks, or local fire status. Teren copied the limits into his notebook under public eyes.

The provisional federation passed by twenty-seven delegations, with six abstentions and three refusals. Refusing provinces retained trade access and control of their fires. No bond enforced the vote.

Savra remained unconscious through all of it.

Dima fed her drops of unbound barley water, then spoonfuls, recording every hunger wave. Some came minutes after food. Others struck while Savra’s stomach remained full. No live ash entered the room. Her body had kept the injury after the table ended.

On Day 40, Savra wakes became the phrase runners carried badly through the Hall, as if waking erased what waited afterward.

Teren reached the infirmary after Lale and found Savra sitting against rolled blankets. Her face had thinned. Savra’s knives lay on a tray beyond reach.

“Can you eat?” he asked.

“Sometimes.” Her voice scraped. “Not from a bound hearth.”

Dima stood beside the bed. “Not now. Likely not again. Any table may give her body another timing it cannot separate.”

Savra looked at the tray. “Give me the herb knife.”

“No,” Dima said.

“I am not asking to join a table.”

“You cannot stand.”

“Then bring the board here.”

Lale set a chopping board across Savra’s knees and placed one smoked onion

on it. Dima gave her the small knife handle first, watching whether the hand held steady. Savra cut the onion into uneven slices. The first hunger wave doubled her over. She waited, breathing through it, then finished the second half.

No one called the work recovery. She could not taste from a bound pot, verify a shared burden, or occupy the cook's required seat. Under the new rules, that barred her from designing any hearth table alone.

It did not bar her from cooking food that moved no pain.

Teren carried the sliced onion to the infirmary's unbound cauldron because Savra could not yet walk. She corrected the amount of oil from the bed, and Lale ignored one correction until she tested the pan herself.

Outside, twenty-seven delegations posted the provisional kitchen laws. Inside, Savra listened to ordinary onions strike hot oil, every body keeping its own hunger until the meal was served. Dima marked the pot unbound in charcoal, not because anyone doubted it, but because the new practice began where witnesses could still see the cook. Teren took bowls to the corridor under Lale's direction. Savra stayed at the bed with the knife washed beside her. When the first bowl returned empty, she asked who needed the next one and did not ask who deserved it.

Chapter 28 — The Festival of Many Tables

One year later, Issen waited in Kelar Market while a twelve-year-old auditor rejected a feastwright's salt cup.

"The name mark crosses the weight," the girl said.

The feastwright, a river man three times her age, turned the cup in his hands. On its outside, wet clay carried his name and the Eren Ford hearth curl. Inside, a half-share line ran too close to the final letter.

"I know what it says," he replied.

"You know because you wrote it. The diner who breaks it should not have to."

Around them, the morning audit continued. Kitchen councils had built temporary tables beneath the spice awnings where Savra once fled imperial inspectors. Each hearth displayed source ember, food, seat names, weights, duration, severance method, cook's seat, and two elected witnesses. Diners handled their own cups before any grain entered a pot.

The feastwright scraped his mark away and began again.

Issen pressed a small notch into their audit tablet: defect found locally, corrected before service. They no longer wore silver across the chest. Three auditors worked the Kelar festival, elected from different councils. Any one could halt a kitchen for missing disclosure. None could approve it alone.

The girl's name, Pava, appeared on the council slate beside Issen's and an elderly Ulsor brine keeper's. Her age had provoked objections until she read six deliberately flawed seat lists faster than every senior clerk. Election did not make her infallible. It gave her objections a recorded route.

"Cup clear," Pava said after the correction.

The Ulsor auditor checked the cook's seat. Issen verified the origin ember against the custody jar. Three separate marks opened service.

Across Kelar, ninety-six visiting hearths had sent cooks or witnesses. Four had declined: two because harvest was late, one because its council opposed multihearth festivals, and one because fever closed its road. Their absences remained on the public board. Nobody carried substitute embers.

Local Kelar fires brought the visible count to one hundred, though no recipe joined them all.

The first tables began after the sun cleared the cloth roofs. Ulsor served pale barley and salt-baked fish in separate bowls, joining only six water carriers who had chosen to share leg fatigue for the afternoon's work. An Eren Ford table used red lentils and pickled mustard stems to distribute oven heat among bakers. Tal Jes offered peppered millet to a small group of terrace veterans who chose equal pain shares during a scar-treatment session supervised by Dima.

No table served as the festival's center.

The audit rules required inspectors to search for concealment beneath accurate words. A table could list every diner and still hide a second weight under a category, as Teren had done at Tal Jes. Issen asked cooks to lift bowls, turn cups, steam seals with vinegar, and explain every notch to someone from another province.

At kitchen thirty-one, a Namarra bread guild had listed oven support beneath five named bakers. The phrase carried no additional names, but its old Hall meaning could absorb anyone fed through the guild oath.

"Who does support include?" Pava asked.

"Only the five above," said the guild cook.

"Then erase the category."

"It explains their work."

"Their names explain their seats. Their work can go on the public board."

The cook appealed to Issen. A year earlier the office of First Taster might have resolved the dispute from precedent. Issen declined. The three auditors halted service and sent the question to the local kitchen council. The council removed the category before the ember was opened.

At a Kelar chickpea table, one diner tested her cup against the paving before eating. It broke. The cook marked vessel failure, no seat entered, gave her a spare, and read the full list again. Later the same woman swallowed two bites, felt a neighbor's oven heat, and chose to break the second cup. That break severed an active seat. Two similar pieces of clay carried different records because the body's condition had changed between them.

A visiting council from the salt uplands brought no bound table at all. Its members opposed redistributing pain but wanted to trade seed and attend the common course. Festival organizers gave them an awning equal in size to the hearth kitchens. Absence of magic did not reduce their civic standing.

The four declining provinces appeared on every count board. Their blank positions kept auditors from announcing universal participation. Children asked why the board held spaces for fires that never arrived. Cooks answered with weather, harvest, disagreement, and illness rather than calling the spaces failures.

Issen moved from one to the next, tasting only unbound inspection portions prepared before seals touched food. Their palate still found what official kitchens tried to hide: old oil under fresh spice, souring delayed by a warm jar, black salt clinging to a spoon groove. The work no longer let a mouth certify safety for unseen bodies. Taste began questions. Lists and witnesses answered some. Diners answered the rest.

At the Tal Jes awning, Dima cut goat curd with a knife whose handle had been widened to fill her right palm. A leather loop fixed the blade against her hand. Her

wrist and shoulder supplied pressure that fingers once provided. She worked slower than before Ember Bridge, and the service schedule included the difference.

A young cook reached to finish the cuts for her.

"I'll ask when I need you," Dima said.

He withdrew.

She divided curd into eight portions, then checked the scar-treatment list. "Two pain shares withdrew this morning. Reduce the sour millet or the transfer enters too fast."

The local cook adjusted the pot. The two withdrawn names remained posted with the notation refused before service. Dima did not call them weak. The people staying did not receive praise for courage.

"Your knife loop passed inspection," Issen said.

"My knife does not need your approval."

"The food board does."

"That one can have it after Pava reads the weights."

Dima's mouth bent at one corner. Time had not made her gentle about offices. Issen valued that more than admiration.

Near the old refugee kitchen, Teren unloaded sacks under the supervision of Kelar's elected kitchen council. He wore a route worker's red cord and carried no weapon. His left ankle still stiffened after long roads, so a younger driver handled the upper stacks. Teren counted measures at ground level.

"Thirty-two chickpea, eighteen barley, seven lentil," he reported.

Councilor Pava's mother checked the receipt. "Your route slate says eight lentil."

"One split in the north wagon. Spoiled by ditch water. Loss witnessed at the bridge."

"Compensation?"

"Free Granary route fund, subject to your claim."

He did not promise replacement from another town's allotment. The council signed for what arrived.

Teren saw Issen and lifted two fingers in greeting. A line of petitioners waited beside him: Tal Jes hospital representatives reviewing his third restitution route, Free Granary drivers contesting axle schedules, Eren Ford delegates asking for canal estimates. His knowledge remained useful. His decisions did not travel without other signatures.

Lale supervised the communal oven across the lane. She and Teren spoke over a flour board, close enough to hear, far enough that neither could pretend the year had restored an earlier ease. Their sibling bond had learned procedure because affection alone had once carried too much unspoken pressure.

At the public notice wall, a bell announced the annual judgments.

People gathered beneath the awnings. Issen joined Mava on the low platform while recorders unrolled the provincial findings. Rován Dast's case occupied three linked scrolls. Every participating court had heard sink-ward survivors, ration clerks, soldiers, cooks, cold-seat villages, and the accused.

Mava read the joint sentence.

"Rován Dast is permanently removed from all grain, hearth, custody, teaching, and public office. He remains in civic confinement subject to provincial witness access. He must answer archive inquiries and identify concealed seat systems, but no testimony reduces sentence or controls restitution. He receives the ordinary public ration and may not be entered into a burden-table for punishment, labor, or demonstration. Provincial claims for specific injuries continue independently."

No execution. No hidden torment. No return to private life.

A Halvek delegate shouted that he deserved every wound from the granary battle. A woman once held in the Namarra heat ward answered, "I will not share a table with him to make you feel balanced."

The argument continued after the formal reading. The sentence did not heal burns, restore Dima's hand, or return years to villages that carried marching armies. It preserved Rován as a source of evidence without making testimony a route to forgiveness.

The archive work had already changed three judgments. Rován identified a ration-oath index hidden inside bridge-maintenance accounts, leading auditors to two villages whose residents still carried unexplained campaign injuries. He also refused to name one retired feastwright, claiming the person had followed his direct order. The courts treated the refusal as obstruction, not loyalty, and extended witness restrictions. Useful evidence did not buy him control over the record.

A Tal Jes delegate asked whether ordinary public rations amounted to mercy. Mava answered by reading the confinement ledger: the same grain measure as the ward where he remained, medical care under two witnesses, no private stores, no command over cooks, and no salt cup because he could not be entered into a table. Keeping him alive cost food. Killing him would also have been a distribution chosen by power.

The heat-ward woman spoke again. "Do not call my refusal to torture him forgiveness."

Nobody did.

Restitution reports followed the sentence. Seized Hall stipends funded dressing oil at Tal Jes, rebuilding at Halvek, and new communal ovens in seven cold-seat villages. The amounts did not equal the injuries. Several councils refused coin until imperial land records were corrected. Others took grain first and reserved further claims. A common verdict did not require common remedies.

Eda Tel had sent a written statement from Tal Jes. Scarring in her mouth still made travel painful. Her statement asked that every future table record not only names and weights but the ordinary reason a person happened to be available: patient, prisoner, worker, traveler, child. Categories could not define seats, yet social conditions still explained why the same bodies were repeatedly asked.

Pava added the proposal to the next council agenda rather than announcing it as law. Endings, Issen had learned, required minutes.

Issen's own judgment followed. They had received no confinement. The courts barred them from sole tasting certification or lifetime office, required annual public testimony, and assigned five years of paid restitution work funded from seized Hall stipends. Some sink survivors considered that too little. Issen had no rebuttal that could weigh it into adequacy.

They read their acceptance aloud.

After noon, the festival tables began severing in their own times. Ulsor's water-carrier fire went dark when the cistern work ended. Eren Ford kept its baker table through the last oven batch. Tal Jes ended early after one veteran's cup cracked accidentally; the cook discarded the affected food and severed all eight seats rather than guess whether the break carried intent.

At each site, auditors posted final injuries and unsettled shares. Named records went to the local council. Public boards showed counts and any identity withheld for protection. The law allowed no hidden seats: every magical participant had a recorded name accessible to independent auditors, while public anonymity could protect the vulnerable without turning them into a category sink.

By late afternoon, all bound fires had ended.

Ending required more than letting flames die. Each cook checked the last swallowed time, waited through the promised duration, and extinguished the origin ember in its own vessel. Auditors counted whole cups, broken cups, and cups lost before service. They compared injuries against the opening boards. Where one diner's fatigue persisted beyond the expected interval, the local table stayed under observation rather than being declared closed for the schedule's convenience.

Ash from bound fires went into labeled cold jars. It could be returned to its home hearth, buried, or kept as evidence according to local decision. None entered the common ovens. Water used to wash salt lines drained into settling pits instead of kitchen cisterns because black hearth-salt residue could cling to grease. Ordinary sanitation became part of magical severance.

At the Eren Ford oven, one coal resisted extinction beneath a crust of ash. Lale found it before the unbound flour arrived. She lifted the coal into the correct custody pot and washed the oven deck again. A year earlier, a rushed cook might have called the glow too small to matter. The accidental Kelar bond had begun with mixed embers nobody intended to join.

Pava walked the market ringing a handbell only after all three auditors signed

the separation board. The bell did not proclaim safety forever. It reported a completed inspection at one hour on one day.

Kelar cooks swept salt lines from the market stones. They washed tables, changed ladles, and brought out vessels that had never touched live ash. The next course belonged to everyone who wanted food without a seat.

Savra directed it from the old refugee kitchen.

She wore no feastwright robe. Her knives hung from a plain belt. A year had returned weight to her face but not regular hunger. Some mornings she woke ravenous after eating before bed. Some afternoons a full bowl could not convince her body that food had arrived. Dima's standing rule remained absolute: no bound bite, no tasting over live ash, no cook's seat.

That kept Savra outside every hearth table under the laws she had helped establish.

It did not keep her outside the kitchen.

She had designed the unbound common course: chickpea cakes browned on iron plates, smoked onions folded through lentils, flatbread from mixed provincial flours, Ulsor sour plum served separately, Tal Jes pepper oil passed by hand. Each ingredient kept enough distinction to be recognized. The course promised no equal sensation. People could take pepper or refuse it, eat more bread, trade a plum for onions, or leave.

Dima handled the slicing station beside her. Her loop knife chopped mustard stems. Pava carried audit boards away because an unbound course required no magical approval, only ordinary food inspection.

"Oil," Savra said.

Lale checked the pan before adding it. "Not yet."

Savra waited. Authority over heat belonged to the person at the stove, even when another cook had designed the meal.

Issen approached the service table with an empty bowl.

Savra looked at the audit tablet. "Finished?"

"All tables severed. Three injuries retained. No missing records. Four refusals before service, nine cups broken after eating, one accidental break that closed its local table."

"No hidden transfers?"

"None found. That is not the same as none possible."

"Good."

Certainty had once served empire better than safety.

Savra filled Issen's bowl from the lentil pot. Her own portion waited in a blue dish at the end of the table. Dima had marked it unbound in charcoal despite everyone knowing. Repetition made practice visible.

When service slowed, Savra sat at the market's long common board. Teren occupied one end beside route workers. Lale sat with Eren Ford bakers. Mava argued about key rotation with two refusing provinces. Dima lowered herself beside Savra, keeping the adapted knife on the table rather than hiding her hand.

Nobody shared a magical seat.

Savra tasted alone. The first bite brought smoked onion, lentil, and a late edge of fenugreek from the Kelar pan. Her stomach tightened with a hunger wave that belonged to the injury she carried, not to any stranger presently connected. She set the spoon down until the contraction passed.

Dima continued eating. She did not ask whether Savra needed the burden shared. Teren did not watch from across the table. The people nearest made space without turning attention into ceremony.

Savra lifted the spoon again.

A child from the salt uplands approached with a plate containing only flatbread. "My council did not bring a table," he said. "Can I take onions?"

"If you want them." Savra held out the serving spoon, then stopped. "Do you want me to serve or do you?"

He took the spoon and chose three pieces. Nobody checked a hearth mark. His council's refusal had not excluded him from the unbound food.

At the other end of the board, a Tal Jes veteran set down a whole salt cup kept from the afternoon table. She had stayed through its full pain share. For the common course the cup carried no function, so she used it to hold plum stones. A tool of severance did not need to become a sacred badge.

Issen closed their audit tablet before eating. No signature certified the board. Ordinary food law still applied: clean water, sound grain, declared allergens, fair measure. Hearth authority did not.

As dusk came, cooks relit small festival lamps from their own hearths. One hundred fires rose around Kelar Market, some blue at the base from mineral salt, some orange from fig wood, some pale over charcoal. Salt lines did not connect them. No central cauldron waited. The First Hearth remained locked in Namarra under four rotating keys and could authorize nothing by itself.

Children carried unbound flatbread between tables. Auditors closed their tablets. People who had refused every bound dish ate from the common course beside people who had kept their cups whole.

Issen stood to see the market from end to end. A hundred separate flames illuminated different bowls, different hands, and every seat that had existed written where witnesses could find it. Darkness remained between the fires. No cook rushed to erase it.

Together they gave enough light for the meal.